DOMINIONS 6 KNOWLEDGE LIBRARY

Core Rules and Strategy

Rulesets, turn structure, economy, Pretenders, battle, magic, and campaign conduct.

Progress Edition 28 companion reader
30 August 2026

Unmodded 6.36 baseline. DE and Divinitus remain separately labelled.

Contents

This volume contains the Reader's Guide and Foundation Books I-VI. The standalone field reference, nation compendium, and technical volume remain separate downloads. Book and section names stay unchanged so references remain compatible with the omnibus and website.

DOCUMENT 1 OF 7

Reader's Guide and Concordance

The retrieval layer

The Knowledge Library is large enough that most players will not read it from front to back. Its fourteen books answer different questions, and one game situation can easily touch several of them. A failed battle might begin with an interface mistake or an economic shortage, then run through unit classes, scripting, fatigue, and conditions before becoming a wider campaign problem. A Pretender design might begin with scales, but its value can depend on the chosen form, research timing, mage recruitment, the patch that established the current rule, and the likely date of the first war.

This guide joins those subjects together without explaining them a second time. Every entry points to the chapter that owns the full rule or method, and definitions here stay short for that reason. If a summary appears to disagree with the linked chapter, the chapter takes priority.

The guide serves five purposes:

1. give a new player a controlled route through the library;
2. let an experienced player move directly from a live problem to the relevant rule;
3. provide an alphabetical concordance and expanded glossary;
4. define the content model used for website publication;
5. separate research that can be resolved from reliable sources from questions that still require engine evidence.

How the links behave

Every major heading now has a stable destination. The identifiers are shared by the PDF bookmarks, the website index, and the machine-readable export. A heading can move to a different page in a later edition without breaking a link, provided its subject and destination identifier remain the same.

The linked table of contents remains the complete structural map. The concordance is the practical one: it begins with the question at hand, not the order in which the books were written.

Part I: Reading Paths

Path A: The first complete game

This route supplies enough structure to play a full game without demanding mastery of every spell, special ability, or diplomatic edge case. The order is intentional: timing and economy come before Pretender theory because a design cannot be judged without knowing what a turn and a province can actually produce.

Stage	Read	What should be understood before moving on
1. Operate	Book X - ruleset and local continuity, creating the world, and the main interface	The correct game is installed, the essential screens are legible, and orders can be submitted safely.

Stage	Read	What should be understood before moving on
2. Ruleset	Book I - baseline and evidence	Which patch and mods govern the game, and how confirmed rules differ from doctrine or pending tests.
3. Turn	Book I - six-phase hosting model and the complete 63-step sequence	Orders are simultaneous when submitted but sequential when resolved.
4. Province	Book II - the economic model, income, and recruitment constraints	Gold, resources, Recruitment Points, infrastructure, and time are separate constraints.
5. Read a unit	Book XI - unit-reading method, unit classes, and ability register	Classes, leadership, movement, abilities, experience, and conditions are read as one current state.
6. Expansion army	Book IV - what a battle decides, unit roles, and orders and scripts	A unit card is not a plan; placement, leadership, morale, and target contact determine whether statistics are delivered.
7. Pretender	Book III - Pretender design as a national system, scales, and blessings	The design should solve national problems rather than maximize an isolated chassis.
8. Research	Book V - research as strategic planning and battlefield magic by function	Research is a response tree whose branches must be deliverable by actual mages and gems.
9. Campaign	Book VI - expansion and first contact, borders and infrastructure, and recovery	Winning a battle matters only if the result can be converted into position, forts, research, or victory.
10. Guided play	Book X - guided first campaign and turn audit	The foundation is translated into a repeatable opening, first contact, first war, siege, and post-game review.
11. Live reference	Turn and Economy Quick Reference, Book XI's master register, Book XII's object register, Book XIII's patch ledger, and Book XIV's command lexicon	Common timing, economy, unit-state, object, current-version, and official mod-language facts can be checked without reopening full chapters or treating an old guide as current.

The first pass can stop once the current question has been answered. Controlled tests, complete object inventories, and specialist essays can wait until they are actually needed.

Path B: The first multiplayer game

Single-player fundamentals still matter, but multiplayer adds hidden intentions, negotiated borders, reputation, timing attacks, and the possibility that an apparently efficient action creates a coalition.

1. Complete stages 1-8 of Path A.
2. Read joining and hosting and the submission protocol.
3. Read scouting, intelligence, and uncertainty.
4. Read raiding and counter-raiding.
5. Read timing attacks and power spikes.
6. Read diplomacy, treaties, and reputation.
7. Read Thrones, Cataclysm, and endgame conversion.
8. Use the campaign decision framework before committing to a major war.

The central multiplayer habit is to calculate political cost alongside material gain. Territory, globals, Thrones, visible research, border dominion, and repeated treaty behaviour all alter how other players price the threat.

Path C: Returning after a long break

This route is for a player who remembers the game but not the current version or the exact order of operations.

1. Read Book I's current baseline.
2. Review Book XIII's release spine and player-facing changes for the period missed.
3. Review Book X's current operational additions.
4. Review current-version corrections in battle, magic, and strategy.
5. Review Book XI's ability-facing patch notes and master register.
6. Use Book XII's versioned object layer for exact spell, item, summon, Pretender, Throne, site, mercenary, and special-dominion lookups.
7. Keep the hosting spine, provincial gold, recruitment gates, and siege calculation open during the first turns.
8. Revisit only the chapter belonging to the nation or mechanic currently being used.
9. If DE and Divinitus are enabled, read the frozen combined baseline before trusting an older build or guide.

Path D: Expert rules lookup

The expert route begins by finding the chapter that owns the answer.

Question	Primary destination	Secondary destination
Create or join a game	Book X - creating the world	Book X - joining and hosting
Interface or shortcut	Book X - main interface	Book X - current additions
Strategic order procedure	Book X - order reference	Underlying system in Books I-VI
Submit or administer turns	Book X - turn submission	Book X - hosting runbook
Operational failure	Book X - troubleshooting	Path E
Unit class or leadership requirement	Book XI - unit classes	Book IV - command and squads
Unfamiliar ability or icon	Book XI - master register	Book XI - unit-reading method
Experience or heroic ability	Book XI - experience	Book XI - Hall of Fame
Affliction or condition	Book XI - conditions	Book IV - affliction resolution
Exact spell or item record	Book XII - spells or items and artifacts	Book V - strategic magic
Summon or summoned-unit relation	Book XII - summons	Book V - summoning
Pretender form availability	Book XII - Pretender forms	Book III - national design system
Throne, site, mercenary, or special dominion record	Book XII - Thrones and sites, mercenaries and independents, or special dominions	Strategic interpretation in Books II, III, and VI
Official change by version or subject	Book XIII - official patch ledger	Current rule in the linked canonical book
Repair an old or undated guide	Book XIII - stale-guide repair	Book XIII - classification model
Command introduction or patch history	Book XIII - command chronology	Book XIV - patch reconciliation
Exact command syntax, context, or manual locator	Book XIV - command lexicon	Book VIII - object and parser method
Exact hosting order	Book I - complete hosting sequence	Field hosting spine
Income or fort economics	Book II - gold, income, and upkeep	Field provincial gold
Recruitment bottleneck	Book II - resources and recruitment	Field recruitment gates
Pretender design	Book III - national design system	Book VII - Pretender families in a dossier

Question	Primary destination	Secondary destination
Bless legality or activation	Book III - blessings	Book IX - exact DE blessing layer
Melee result	Book IV - melee resolution	Book IV - protection and damage
Rout or retreat	Book IV - morale, rout, and retreat	Book VI - army preservation
Battle spell arithmetic	Book IV - battlefield magic	Book V - spell package design
Research branch	Book V - research planning	Book VI - strategic response tree
Communion failure	Book V - communions	Book IV - fatigue
Ritual, dome, or global	Book V - rituals, domes, or globals	Book I - hosting timing
Campaign conversion	Book VI - campaign conduct	Book II - economic state
Nation analysis	Book VII - dossier method	Book VII - MA Arcoscephale pilot
Mod syntax or validation	Book XIV - syntax and lookup	Book VIII - parser model, testing, and release engineering
DE/Divinitus exact source fact	Book IX - technical encyclopaedia	Book IX - source inventory
Collision or load order	Book IX - collision matrix	Book VIII - compatibility engineering

Path E: Diagnosing a failed turn

When a turn fails, trace the causes in order instead of starting with the most frustrating result.

1. Confirm the ruleset. Check patch, mods, load order, map, age, and game settings against Book I's baseline rules.
2. Find the resolution step. Use the hosting sequence to identify when the expected action should have happened.
3. Check operation and legality. Use Book X's troubleshooting route, then confirm paths, gems, laboratory, movement route, commander status, recruitment capacity, target, and order.
4. Check the binding resource. Use Book II's constraint model for gold, resources, Recruitment Points, Commander Points, Holy Points, supplies, or infrastructure.
5. Check tactical delivery. Use Book IV's resolution order, scripting, fatigue, morale, and targeting chapters.
6. Check strategic conversion. Use Book VI's campaign decision framework to decide whether the result was a local loss, a recoverable exchange, or a campaign failure.
7. Check evidence status. If the exact behaviour is listed in the research register, preserve the report as evidence. Do not force a confident explanation where the current record does not support one.

Path F: Modding, source inspection, and website work

1. Read the object-and-parser model.
2. Read identifier allocation and collision safety.
3. Read Book XII's object identity, provenance, and hashing method.
4. Read Book XIII's command chronology and safe treatment of post-manual commands.
5. Use Book XIV's complete command locator, evidence ladder, and patch reconciliation before treating a token as complete syntax.
6. Choose the relevant object chapter in Books VIII, IX, or XII.
7. Apply compatibility engineering before combining releases.
8. Apply testing, validation, and release engineering.
9. Use the website schema described later in this guide rather than scraping prose into unversioned pages.

Part II: Navigation by Problem

Game operation and hosting

Problem	Start here	Continue here
The correct map, mod, or save directory is unclear	Ruleset, installation, and local continuity	Book VIII - user data and packaging
A new game needs reproducible settings	Creating the world	Host setup sheet
A lobby game cannot be joined	Official lobby workflow	Cannot find or join the game
The interface control or shortcut is unclear	The main interface	Current operational additions
A turn may not have been received	Turn submission and revision	A turn staled
Troops, items, or gems are in the wrong place	Recruitment, army setup, and inventories	Troubleshooting by symptom
A special strategic order is unclear	Strategic order reference	Linked mechanics in Books I-VI
A first full campaign needs structure	A guided first campaign	Path A
The host needs a fair administrative standard	Hosting as a competitive institution	Dispute handling

Units, abilities, experience, and conditions

Problem	Start here	Continue here
A unit's type is unclear	Unit classes and status tags	How classes overlap
An army cannot be assigned to its commander	Three leadership pools	Army compatibility audit
A movement icon appears to permit an unusual route	Movement, terrain, water, and position	Book VI - movement and logistics
An unfamiliar ability needs a quick definition	Master ability and condition register	How to read an ability
A counter is needed for a special defence or aura	Counter-construction matrix	Book IV - counter construction
Veteran value or star thresholds are unclear	Experience and veteran units	Official experience thresholds
A Hall-of-Fame formula is being treated as certain	What is officially established	Community-derived heroic families
An affliction, disease, curse, or horror mark needs treatment	Conditions and lasting state	Book IV - lasting loss

Base-game object lookup

Problem	Start here	Continue here
A spell's school, path, cost, or delivery type is unclear	Spell records	Book V - paths, schools, and access
A forge target, artifact, or barding record needs comparison	Item records	Book V - forging, items, and artifacts

Problem	Start here	Continue here
A ritual's summoned result is unclear	Summon relations	Book XII - shape graphs
A Pretender form needs to be filtered by age or nation	Pretender-form records	Book III - design audit
A Throne or magic site needs an exact identity	Thrones and sites	Book VI - endgame conversion
A mercenary company or independent option needs checking	Mercenaries and independent recruitment	Book VI - expansion
A nation's dominion changes the ordinary rules	Special dominion systems	Book III - dominion
A website record needs provenance or refresh instructions	Publication contract	Verification and maintenance

Version history and stale-guide repair

Problem	Start here	Continue here
An old guide conflicts with current play	Stale-guide repair workflow	Current rule in the linked canonical book
A change needs to be found by release	Complete release spine	Official patch ledger method
A patch category appears uncertain	Classification confidence	Open the linked official announcement
A mechanic has changed several times	Player-facing change survey	Search the JSON ledger by domain and named term
A mod command may postdate the manual	Command chronology	Book XIV - patch reconciliation
A patch token differs from the current manual	Controlled exceptions	Book XIV - evidence ladder
A command is listed but not fully explained	Documentation-status model	Book XIV - safe lookup workflow
A new release needs to be ingested	Safe feed update	Website uses

Economy and state

Problem	Start here	Continue here
Income is lower than expected	Income formula	Tax trace, unrest
A unit cannot be recruited	The binding constraint	Recruitment Points, resources, Commander and Holy Points
A fort appears inefficient	Infrastructure as delayed conversion	Fort resource draw, fort-now test
An army is starving	Supplies and supply usage	Strategic logistics
A siege is taking too long	Siege and fort control	Siege as a campaign clock, field calculation
Province Defence is being misused	Province Defence	PD as delay and information
Gem income feels disconnected from strategy	Sites, gems, and magical capital	Gem logistics

Pretenders, dominion, scales, and blessings

Problem	Start here	Continue here
A design has too many unrelated goals	The design in one model	Design audit

Problem	Start here	Continue here
Awake, dormant, or imprisoned is unclear	Awakening, time, and the opening	Opening tests
Dominion is collapsing	Dominion and religious territory	Campaign dominion
Scale trade-offs are unclear	Scales	Economic consequences
A bless looks powerful but unaffordable	Blessings	Sacred capacity audit
The god has died	Pretender death and recall	Campaign recovery
DE changes invalidate a vanilla build	Book IX - global rules	Book IX - blessing revision

Armies and battle

Problem	Start here	Continue here
A strong unit underperformed	Reading a unit	Formation, fatigue, morale
Troops arrived in the wrong shape	Army organisation	Formations and contact
The script broke	Orders, scripts, and spellcasting AI	Battle-magic planning
Melee arithmetic is disputed	Melee resolution	Protection and damage
Missiles hit the wrong target	Missile combat	Formation and contact
The army routed while still large	Morale, fear, rout, and retreat	Army preservation
A thug or supercombatant seems invincible	Thugs and remote force	Damage families and counters
A battlefield spell produced a surprising result	Battlefield magic arithmetic	Magic package design

Magic

Problem	Start here	Continue here
Research feels aimless	Research as strategic planning	Research as a campaign response tree
A spell is known but cannot be delivered	Paths and access	Gems and logistics, boosters
Gems disappear too quickly	Gem spending	Reserve policy
A communion is killing its slaves	Communions	Fatigue
Remote magic is being intercepted or blocked	Domes and remote attacks	Ritual timing
A global is politically dangerous	Global enchantments	Timing attacks and deterrence
A booster chain does not reach the expected path	Forging, items, and artifacts	Booster reference
A level-nine plan is becoming a trap	Legendary magic	Victory conversion

Strategy and campaign

Problem	Start here	Continue here
Expansion results vary wildly	Expansion testing	Battle diagnosis
The border is too wide	Map structure and borders	Raiding fronts

Problem	Start here	Continue here
Research is collapsing under invasion	Research under invasion	Recovery
Raids gain provinces but lose the war	Raiding and counter-raiding	Campaign conversion
A power spike is visible too early	Timing attacks and deterrence	Information denial
A treaty is ambiguous	Diplomacy and treaties	Diplomacy records
A Throne opportunity may end the game	Throne arithmetic	Throne-rush sequence
The army won but the campaign stalled	Victory conversion	Economic conversion

Nations, mods, and combined rulesets

Problem	Start here	Continue here
A nation guide lists strengths but gives no method	Nation dossier method	Evidence architecture
Mage randoms are being described as guaranteed access	Probability method	Mystic worked example
A mod object behaves unlike its visible card	Object and parser model	Copy and selection semantics
Two mods claim the same ID	Compatibility engineering	DE/Divinitus collision matrix
An event chain has become unreliable	Event modding as a state machine	Divinitus event architecture
The AI needs scenario guidance	AI scaffolding	Behavioural sampling
A map changes strategic balance	Maps and scenario design	Map structure and borders
A public guide may be using the wrong mod version	Frozen baseline	Versioned knowledge essay

Part III: Alphabetical Subject Concordance

The concordance lists the best first destination, not every occurrence. Related chapters are included where a subject has a separate mechanical, strategic, or modding treatment.

A

B

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Part IV: Expanded Glossary

This glossary is an orientation layer. Each primary link leads to the fuller rules treatment.

Term	Working definition	Primary anchor	Related anchors
Administration	A fort percentage used in income and adjacent resource draw calculations.	b2-part-vi-infrastructure-and-administration	b2-fort-resource-draw; field-base-and-final-income
Affliction	A persistent injury or impairment usually gained through damage, age, disease, or special effects.	b11-61-afflictions	b4-part-xiii-afflictions-regeneration-and-lasting-loss; b11-37-recuperation-and-healers
Army	A convenient name for commanders and assigned troops operating together; not always one indivisible rules object.	b1-army	b4-part-iii-commanders-squads-leadership-and-army-organisation
Army rout	The battle-wide morale collapse that can force remaining units to retreat even when individual squads have not already routed.	b4-army-rout	b4-part-xi-morale-fear-rout-and-retreat
Artifact	A unique magic item that only one copy can normally exist at a time.	b12-22-artifacts-as-a-world-state-race	b5-artifacts; b5-artifact-races
Ascension Point	A victory point supplied by a claimed Throne of Ascension.	b6-throne-arithmetic	b1-throne-of-ascension
Assassin	A commander or effect that initiates a restricted battle against a target commander.	b6-part-ix-thugs-supercombatants-assassins-and-remote-force	b1-assassinations-resolve-before-conventional-movement

Term	Working definition	Primary anchor	Related anchors
Automatic ID	An object identity assigned by the loader when a mod creates an object without a fixed numeric ID.	b8-automatic-allocation	b9-19-4-automatic-id-collision-risk
Awakening	The process and timing by which a dormant or imprisoned Pretender becomes active.	b3-part-iii-awakening-time-and-the-opening	b3-awakening-points
Battle group	A force that enters and resolves one tactical battle together; several forces in a province may not always form one group.	b4-battle-groups	b1-retreats-belong-to-battle-groups
Battle magic	Spells cast during tactical battle under scripting, range, targeting, gem, fatigue, and AI constraints.	b4-part-xiv-battlefield-magic	b5-part-vi-battlefield-magic-by-function
Bless	The collection of effects granted to a blessed sacred unit or commander.	b3-part-vi-blessings	b9-8-de-blessing-revision
Blood slave	A Blood-magic resource with unit-like and logistical properties distinct from ordinary gems.	b5-blood-slaves	b2-blood-hunting
Bodyguard	A unit assigned to protect a commander in an assassination battle, subject to bodyguard limits and arrival rules.	b11-28-bodyguards-and-warning	b6-assassination-defence
Booster	An item, spell, shape, site, or effect that increases effective magic-path access.	b5-booster-reference	b5-hidden-and-indirect-access
Breakpoint	A research level or access threshold at which a usable strategic or battlefield package becomes available.	b5-research-breakpoints	b6-part-v-research-as-a-strategic-response-tree
Call God	The priestly process used to return a dead Pretender, governed by rules distinct from ordinary resurrection.	b3-call-god	b3-part-vii-pretender-death-recall-and-divine-continuity
Capital-only	A restriction tying recruitment or another feature to a nation's original capital.	b1-capital-only	b2-recruitment-restrictions
Cataclysm	An endgame mechanism that increases late-game pressure and horror activity under relevant game settings.	b6-cataclysm	b6-part-xii-thrones-cataclysm-and-endgame-conversion
Chassis	The Pretender's physical form, including cost, paths, slots, statistics, movement, and special abilities.	b3-chassis-roles	b3-part-ii-chassis-paths-and-design-capabilities; b12-pretenders
Collision	A conflict in which mods claim or alter the same identifier, code, variable, name reference, or dependent object incompatibly.	b8-part-xi-compatibility-engineering	b9-19-combined-load-order-and-collision-matrix
Command	A single-hash instruction whose practical meaning depends on its object language, arguments, selector state, and manual context.	b14-syntax	b14-context; b8-part-i-the-object-and-parser-model
Command template	An official grammar such as `(terrain)` or a numeric range that generates literal command spellings under stated restrictions.	b14-syntax	b14-complete-locator

Term	Working definition	Primary anchor	Related anchors
Commander	A unit that can receive strategic orders and may lead troops, cast spells, preach, patrol, build, or perform other commander actions.	b1-commander	b4-part-iii-commanders-squads-leadership-and-army-organisation
Commander Point	A local recruitment capacity used by commanders, separate from gold, resources, and ordinary Recruitment Points.	b2-commander-points-and-holy-points	field-commander-points
Condition	A temporary or persistent unit state that changes action, statistics, targeting, recovery, loyalty, or future risk.	b11-60-conditions-are-state-not-flavour-text	b11-part-xi-conditions-and-lasting-state
Documentation status	The evidence class distinguishing a full official definition, reference-only entry, prose mention, derived template alias, or patch reconciliation.	b14-evidence	b1-evidence-standard; b13-classification-model
Communion	A battlefield magical network in which masters gain paths while slaves receive distributed fatigue and certain master-cast personal effects.	b5-part-vii-communions-sabbaths-choruses-and-grand-communions	b5-designing-a-safe-communion
Counter	A capability that attacks a necessary layer of an enemy plan rather than merely naming a theoretically favourable unit or spell.	b4-part-xv-counter-construction-and-battle-analysis	b6-counter-portfolios
Critical hit	A fatigue-influenced combat result that can reduce the protection applied against damage.	b4-critical-hits	b4-part-ix-protection-damage-and-survival
Dominion	A Pretender's religious territorial influence, carrying scales and interacting with gods, provinces, units, events, and elimination.	b3-part-iv-dominion-and-religious-territory	b6-dominion-as-campaign-pressure
Dome	A province-centred magical defence that may intercept or interfere with remote spells and attacks.	b5-part-ix-domes-remote-attacks-and-magic-movement	b5-layered-domes
DRN	The open-ended Dominions Random Number roll used in many opposed checks and damage calculations.	b4-the-open-ended-random-roll	b1-randomness-and-the-dominions-random-number
Event	A hosting-time occurrence selected from conditions, rarity, state, targets, codes, variables, and effects.	b1-event	b8-part-vii-event-modding-as-a-state-machine
Event code	An identifier used to coordinate, restrict, or connect event logic; collisions can corrupt chains across mods.	b8-codes-and-variables	b9-19-combined-load-order-and-collision-matrix
Event variable	Stored event state used by modded event systems to remember counters, flags, or progression.	b8-codes-and-variables	b8-event-chains
Experience	Unit-specific development gained over time and through battle, producing star bonuses at defined thresholds.	b11-54-experience-thresholds	b11-56-veteran-preservation

Term	Working definition	Primary anchor	Related anchors
Expansion party	A commander and troop package intended to capture independent provinces at an acceptable cost and tempo.	b6-expansion-party-roles	b6-expansion-testing
Fatigue	An accumulating combat burden that reduces performance, increases vulnerability to critical hits, and can cause unconsciousness.	b4-part-x-fatigue-recovery-and-collapse	b4-fatigue-as-offence
Fear	An effect that pressures enemy morale and can accelerate rout without directly killing every target.	b4-fear	b4-part-xi-morale-fear-rout-and-retreat
Fort	A fortified location that changes recruitment, administration, resource draw, supply, ownership, siege, and retreat behaviour.	b2-part-vi-infrastructure-and-administration	b2-part-viii-siege-and-fort-control
Formation	A squad arrangement that changes density, frontage, contact time, exposure, and movement through the battlefield.	b4-part-v-formations-placement-and-contact	b4-formation-fighter
Gem	A magical resource associated with a non-Blood path and used for rituals, forging, empowerment, and some battle spells.	b1-gem	b5-part-iv-gems-slaves-and-magical-logistics
Global enchantment	A persistent ritual effect with broad world impact and political consequences.	b5-part-x-global-enchantments-and-dispel-wars	b1-global-enchantment
Grand Communion	A special strategic or large-scale communion system with rules distinct from an ordinary battlefield communion.	b5-grand-communions-are-different	b5-part-vii-communions-sabbaths-choruses-and-grand-communions
Harassment	A melee pressure mechanic in which repeated attackers can degrade a defender's effective defence.	b4-harassment	b4-part-vii-melee-resolution
Holy Point	A local recruitment capacity used by some sacred or holy commanders and units.	b2-commander-points-and-holy-points	field-holy-points
Heroic ability	A growing special trait received by an eligible non-Pretender commander while in the Hall of Fame.	b11-57-what-is-officially-established	b11-58-community-derived-heroic-families
Horror Mark	A persistent, stackable hidden mark that creates a monthly risk of a horror attack and makes the bearer a preferred target.	b11-63-curse-and-horror-mark	b11-42-damage-reversal-blood-vengeance-curses-and-horror-marks
Host	To resolve submitted turns; also the computer or service performing that resolution.	b1-host	b1-the-complete-63-step-hosting-sequence
Incarnate	A blessing condition generally requiring the Pretender to be active for the marked effect to function.	b3-incarnate-effects	b3-how-blessings-work
Inspector	A structured data viewer used to inspect game or mod objects; its version and load order determine what it can prove.	b12-part-i-the-object-reference-method	b9-24-website-and-inspector-schema; b12-maintenance

Term	Working definition	Primary anchor	Related anchors
Laboratory	Infrastructure required for research and most rituals and forging; construction finishes too late for earlier same-turn uses.	b2-laboratories	b1-building-construction
Leadership	Commander capacity and type governing troop assignment, morale effects, and special troop compatibility.	b11-24-three-leadership-pools	b4-special-leadership
Load order	The order in which enabled mods are applied, determining which later definitions overwrite or extend earlier ones.	b8-load-order	b9-19-combined-load-order-and-collision-matrix
Mage-turn	One mage's opportunity to research, forge, cast, move, search, patrol, or perform another mutually exclusive order.	b5-mage-turn-opportunity-cost	b2-gem-income-and-mage-turn-economy
Mercenary company	A named, time-limited force bid for during hosting, represented by a commander, troops, price, availability, and continuity fields.	b12-44-mercenary-company-records	b2-mercenaries
Magic phase	Community shorthand for the early hosting steps containing rituals, magical movement, remote attacks, and associated battles.	b1-magic-phase	b1-phase-ii-magic-and-special-threats
Magic Being	A unit class requiring magic leadership unless an overlapping undead or demon tag makes undead leadership take precedence.	b11-11-magic-being	b11-8-classes-can-overlap
Magic Resistance	A defence statistic used in opposed checks against many spells and supernatural effects.	b4-magic-resistance-contests	b4-penetration
Message substitution	A case-sensitive double-hash token inserted inside supported event or enchantment text rather than issued as a mod command.	b14-syntax	b8-messages-can-carry-required-object-names
Mindless	A leadership and morale category with special command, routing, and survival behaviour.	b11-12-mindless	b4-mindless-troops
Mod	A loaded modification, usually defined through `.dm` commands, that can add or alter data within engine-defined limits.	b1-mod	b8-part-i-the-object-and-parser-model
Movement phase	Community shorthand for the hosting steps resolving friendly movement, other movement, movement battles, and storming.	b1-movement-phase	b1-movement-and-conquest
NAP	A non-aggression pact whose exact meaning depends on explicit player convention unless the game setting makes it binding.	b6-non-aggression-pacts	b6-binding-diplomacy
Object ID	A numeric or automatic identity used by the engine, data layer, or mod loader to distinguish and reference an object.	b12-1-an-object-is-an-identity-not-merely-a-name	b8-part-ii-identifiers-allocation-and-collision-safety; b8-object-lifecycle

Term	Working definition	Primary anchor	Related anchors
Patch record	One source-linked entry representing an official update bullet together with derived classification, domains, commands, canonical destinations, and stable hashes.	b13-11-one-official-bullet-becomes-one-patch-record	b13-classification-model; b13-domain-map
Path	A level of magical skill in Fire, Air, Water, Earth, Astral, Death, Nature, Glamour, Blood, or Holy.	b1-path	b5-part-ii-paths-schools-and-access
Penetration	A bonus applied to the attacking side of relevant Magic Resistance contests.	b4-penetration	b4-magic-resistance-contests
Pillage	A strategic order that converts population and order into immediate damage, unrest, and sometimes resources or gold.	b2-pillaging-and-raiding	b6-pillage-as-a-campaign-tool
Plane	A distinct strategic map layer such as the surface, caves, or another connected world.	b1-plane	b8-gates-and-multiple-planes
Population	A province value influencing income, supplies, recruitment capacity, events, and the effects of pillaging or Blood Hunting.	b2-population	b2-part-vii-population-unrest-pillage-patrol-and-blood-hunting
Pretender	The designed god of a nation or team, providing dominion, scales, blessings, paths, and a physical chassis.	b1-pretender	b3-part-i-pretender-design-as-a-national-system; b12-pretenders
Province Defence	Locally purchased automatic defence that appears when a province is attacked and cannot move as a normal army.	b2-part-ix-province-defence	b6-province-defence-as-delay-and-information
Recruitment Point	A local capacity that limits ordinary troop recruitment independently of gold and resources.	b2-recruitment-points	field-recruitment-points
Regeneration	Exact-percentage recovery of hit points during battle, with body-class, affliction, and damage-tempo interactions.	b11-35-regeneration-families	b4-regeneration
Remote attack	A ritual or effect that attacks a distant province or commander without conventional movement.	b5-part-ix-domes-remote-attacks-and-magic-movement	b1-remote-attacks-and-magic-battles
Repel	A weapon-length interaction allowing a defender to threaten or deter an incoming shorter-reach melee attack.	b4-repel	b4-part-vii-melee-resolution
Research point	A contribution toward progress in a school; research resolves very early during hosting.	b1-research-point	b5-the-research-formula
Ritual	A strategic spell cast outside tactical battle.	b1-ritual	b5-part-viii-rituals-and-strategic-magic
Rout	A unit or squad state in which it attempts to leave battle because morale has failed.	b1-rout	b4-part-xi-morale-fear-rout-and-retreat
Sacred	A unit eligible to receive a blessing and often affected by special recruitment or upkeep rules.	b1-sacred	b3-sacred-capacity

Term	Working definition	Primary anchor	Related anchors
Scale	One value in the dominion pairs governing Order, Production, temperature, Growth, Fortune, and Magic.	b1-scale	b3-part-v-scales
School	A research category that unlocks spells at successive levels.	b5-research-schools	b5-part-iii-research-as-strategic-planning
Siege strength	The attacking contribution used against a fort's walls during siege resolution.	field-siege-calculation	b2-part-viii-siege-and-fort-control
Site	A province feature that can provide gems, gold, recruitment, discounts, rituals, unrest, disease, or other effects.	b12-part-vi-thrones-and-magic-sites	b1-site; b2-part-x-sites-gems-and-magical-capital
Size point	A unit of battlefield-square occupancy used by unit size and formation density.	b1-size-point	b4-square-capacity
Special dominion	A national or Pretender rule that changes what dominion does beyond ordinary candle and scale effects.	b12-part-viii-special-dominion-systems	b3-special-dominions; b3-test-p11-special-dominions
Spell fatigue	Fatigue generated by spellcasting after spell cost, caster skill, gems, and other modifiers.	b4-spell-fatigue	b5-fatigue-and-overcasting
Squad	A tactical troop group assigned to a commander and given one formation and order set.	b1-squad	b4-squads
Starvation	The post-battle condition caused by insufficient supplies, producing disease, morale, and attritional consequences.	b2-starvation	b1-starvation-is-late
Stealth	The ability to move or remain hidden in hostile territory, opposed by patrol and detection effects.	b6-patrol-and-stealth	b1-sneaking-discovery-can-cause-a-late-battle
Summon relation	A versioned link from a summoning spell to the unit, unit group, or selection rule that produces its result.	b12-24-a-summon-record-is-a-relationship	b5-summoning
Supply	Provincial and army logistical capacity used to feed units and modified by terrain, forts, dominion, seasons, and abilities.	b2-part-v-supplies-logistics-and-starvation	b6-part-vi-logistics-supply-and-operational-reach
Taskmaster	A leadership ability that manages slave units and changes their morale handling.	b11-26-taskmaster-beast-master-and-special-followers	b4-taskmasters
Tempo	The rate at which a position turns present resources and opportunities into initiative before opponents can answer.	b6-tempo	b6-initiative
Throne of Ascension	A claimable special site providing Ascension Points and other effects toward the configured victory condition.	b12-36-thrones-are-sites-with-victory-meaning	b1-throne-of-ascension; b6-part-xii-thrones-cataclysm-and-endgame-conversion
Thug	A relatively cheap, equipped commander designed for a bounded independent combat or raiding role.	b6-part-ix-thugs-supercombatants-assassins-and-remote-force	b6-thug-roles

Term	Working definition	Primary anchor	Related anchors
Trample	A size-based attack produced by moving through smaller units, with displacement, damage, and fatigue consequences.	b11-45-trample	b4-trampling
Unit class	One of several overlapping type tags that can determine leadership, targeting, supplies, healing, morale, immunity, or movement.	b11-8-classes-can-overlap	b11-part-ii-unit-classes-and-status-tags
Unrest	A province condition that reduces income and administration and interacts with recruitment, events, patrol, pillage, and Blood Hunting.	b1-unrest	b2-part-vii-population-unrest-pillage-patrol-and-blood-hunting
Upkeep	The recurring gold cost of maintaining units and commanders, paid after income during hosting.	b1-upkeep	b2-upkeep
Version delta	An official or verified change between two named ruleset versions, kept separate from the current rule it modifies.	b13-3-patch-notes-are-deltas-not-replacement-manuals	b13-release-timeline; b13-stale-guide-repair
Wall integrity	The remaining defensive strength of a fort during siege, reduced by besiegers and restored by defenders.	b2-part-viii-siege-and-fort-control	field-siege-calculation
Wish	A high-level Astral spell offering a defined but partly version-sensitive set of requested outcomes.	b5-wish	b5-test-18-wish
Zone of control	A battlefield movement constraint created by nearby hostile units.	b4-zones-of-control	b4-part-v-formations-placement-and-contact

Part V: Website Publication Model

The unit of publication

The website should not treat an entire book as one page or every paragraph as an independent fact. The practical unit is a section containing ordered blocks. A section belongs to one versioned ruleset, has one stable destination, and can contain prose, tables, formulas, examples, checklists, claims, and source references.

The hierarchy is:

```
library
book or guide
part
section
content blocks
claims
evidence and sources
```

Each claim can be updated without silently changing the status of the surrounding advice. A strategic recommendation can sit beside an official formula while remaining a different kind of knowledge.

Required metadata

Every publishable section should carry:

- stable ID and URL slug;
- title, short title, and parent;
- book, part, and display order;
- ruleset and exact version scope;
- evidence status;
- source references and access dates;
- topic tags and audience level;
- related sections;
- unresolved-question IDs where applicable;
- last verified and last edited dates;
- replacement or deprecation links when a section moves.

The machine-readable schema makes these fields explicit. Empty fields remain visible during validation rather than being silently discarded.

Structured object records

Book XII adds a second publication unit for facts that are too numerous for readable prose: the object record. The 6.35 register contains 4,196 versioned records across spells, items, summon relations, Pretender forms, Thrones, other sites, mercenary companies, independent-coverage status, and special dominion systems. Each record carries a stable identity, category, ruleset, evidence status, provenance, record hash, source fields, editorial tags, and a canonical Book XII section.

The object register does not compete with the main explanations. Books II-VI still own economic, religious, magical, and strategic interpretation. Object pages expose exact fields and link to those chapters; the chapters use selected examples and link back to the records. Independent population types and unresolved selection-based summons remain visibly incomplete instead of being filled from obsolete data.

Structured patch records

Book XIII adds a third publication unit: the patch record. The 6.36 ledger contains 1,090 records covering all 32 official public update announcements from 6.01 onward. Each record carries release and source identity, official section and bullet locator, source hash, derived change class and confidence, affected domains, commands and named terms, canonical destinations, and a record hash.

The patch record establishes chronology and maintenance impact. It does not replace the official announcement or the current-rule chapter. Source identity is official; classification, materiality, domain routing, and summaries are editorial. The 250 review-recommended classifications remain searchable while their lower interpretive confidence is visible.

Structured command records

Book XIV adds a fourth publication unit: the command record. The 6.36 lexicon contains 1,609 distinct hash tokens found in the current official Modding, Event Modding, and Map Making manuals. Each record preserves spelling, token kind, documentation status, domains, manual versions and pages, syntax locators, patch relations, cautions, canonical destinations, and a record hash. The same data layer also supplies 97 controlled aliases for official terrain and numeric templates and reconciles all 226 patch-note tokens without silently rewriting historical wording. Five commands introduced by 6.36 are marked official patch-only because the announcement does not supply their full syntax.

Command records are locators rather than copied manual prose. A defined record points to the full official explanation. Reference-only and mention-only records keep documentation gaps visible. Double-hash message substitutions remain a separate token kind, while patch family expressions and spelling discrepancies live in explicit reconciliation relations.

Content block types

The schema supports:

1. prose;
2. callout;
3. formula;
4. table;
5. ordered or unordered list;
6. worked example;
7. checklist;
8. quotation within copyright limits;
9. source note;
10. unresolved research question.

Formulas receive their own IDs, variables, units, rounding notes, evidence status, and worked examples. This prevents a formula from becoming an untraceable sentence copied across several web pages.

Version and ruleset behaviour

The website must never display an unqualified value when several rulesets are available. A page may compare unmodded Dominions 6, DE, Divinitus, and the frozen combined load order, but every value is attached to its own scope. Historical values remain accessible through version records rather than being overwritten without explanation.

Recommended default labels are:

- `dom6-6.36` for the live rules baseline;
- `dom6-6.35-data` for records pinned to the Inspector snapshot;
- `de-2.16`;
- `divinitus-1.15.3-de`;
- `de-2.16__divinitus-1.15.3-de` with DE loaded first;
- `historical` with the original version stated;
- `experimental` with project version and test harness.

Beginner and expert presentation

The same source section can support two interfaces:

- Guide view shows the explanation, a restrained number of examples, and the next useful section.
- Reference view foregrounds formulas, exact tables, evidence, version scope, exceptions, and related records.

These are views over the same content identity. Maintaining separate beginner and expert articles would recreate the duplication problem solved in Edition 11.

Search and filtering

At minimum, the website index should support:

- title and full-text search;
- book, topic, ruleset, evidence, and audience filters;
- exact-object lookup by category and numeric ID;
- patch lookup by version range, class, domain, command, named term, and canonical destination;
- command lookup by exact spelling, alias, domain, manual, page, documentation status, patch version, context collision, and token kind;
- unresolved-only and recently-verified views;
- reverse links showing every section that depends on a claim;
- aliases so terms such as `PD`, `Province Defence`, and `province defense` reach the same destination.

The generated content index already records every heading, parent, stable anchor, source file, website path, and source line number. It helps locate material, but it does not replace parsed claims.

Part VI: Prioritised Foundational Research Register

Scope of the active register

The active queue contains questions that can be advanced without asking the player to run bespoke tests. Acceptable routes are current official documentation, official patch records, supplied mod source, current structured data tied to a version, or a published reproduction with enough procedure and evidence to audit. Questions that still depend on undocumented engine behaviour remain visible in a blocked register but do not interrupt the next writing phase.

Priority means:

- P0 - integrity: a wrong answer can invalidate a ruleset, mod load, or large body of derived work;
- P1 - frequent play: the rule affects common economic, combat, magic, or campaign decisions;
- P2 - advanced play: the rule matters regularly to expert planning but less often to a new player;
- P3 - specialist: the rule chiefly affects unusual objects, mod engineering, or edge-case publication.

ID	Priority	Domain	Question	Why it matters	Reliable route	Primary anchor	Status
R-001	P0	Versioning	Which official rules and commands changed after the revision-2 manual and the 6.34, 6.29, and 6.26 auxiliary manuals?	Every later formula and mod claim depends on the correct current baseline.	Book XIII supplies the complete official patch side; Book XIV reconciles every patch token against the current auxiliary manuals.	b14-patch-reconciliation	completed
R-002	P0	Load order	What load order did the Divinitus 1.15.3 DE author intend in the public release wording?	A reversed order can change hundreds of shared objects.	Project description and version 1.15.0 changelog, audited in the independent integrity report.	b9-2-3-public-author-sources	completed
R-003	P0	Collision	What object and dependency chain does the monster 8616 conflict affect under the frozen stack?	The collision breaks the identity shared by DE's Ring, Amulet, and Blood Vial helpers and the Divinitus Crystal Priest.	Exact source trace, upstream accepted repair, and pinned Inspector resolution in the independent integrity report.	b9-20-4-independent-compatibility-publication	completed
R-004	P0	Automatic IDs	What IDs do the 69 automatic Divinitus monsters and 26 automatic spells receive in the frozen load order?	Stable website records and downstream references require versioned secondary identities.	Exact-version structured Inspector register in the independent integrity report; engine confirmation remains separately labelled pending.	b9-20-4-independent-compatibility-publication	completed
R-005	P0	Source integrity	Which commands in the supplied mods fall outside complete current auxiliary-manual definitions?	An unfamiliar command cannot be explained safely until documentation, parser recognition, annotation syntax, and likely errors are separated.	Static command inventory against current official manuals, patch notes, and the pinned parser in the independent integrity report.	b9-20-4-independent-compatibility-publication	completed
R-006	P1	Economy	What are the current unmodded Growth and Death income percentages?	Pretender and fort economics depend on the correct scale multiplier.	Modding Manual 6.34 defines `#deathincome` default 2; no official announcement through 6.36 changes it.	b2-growth-and-death-income	completed
R-007	P1	Economy	What are the current unmodded Order and Turmoil resource percentages?	Production planning and scale evaluation depend on the current value.	Revision-2 main-manual 2% rule checked against the complete official patch ledger through 6.36.	b2-order-and-turmoil-resources	completed
R-008	P1	Economy	At which steps does the engine round income, resources, Recruitment Points, and fort draw?	Close recruitment and fort calculations can change at integer boundaries.	The canonical section now separates six rounding subsystems and their operational displays; complete closure still requires published 6.36 boundary reproductions or developer-confirmed formulas.	b2-rounding-formula-display-and-treasury	queued
R-009	P1	Recruitment	What is the current Commander Point base and how do exceptional modifiers stack?	Commander bottlenecks can determine fort and mage efficiency.	Revision-2 fort bonuses, current 6.35 community base and accumulation reference, official `#slowrec` and `#rpcost` semantics, AI exclusions, and patch review through 6.36.	b2-commander-points	completed

ID	Priority	Domain	Question	Why it matters	Reliable route	Primary anchor	Status
R-010	P1	Upkeep	How are sacred slaves, mounted forms, and shapechanged units charged upkeep?	Persistent roster costs affect long-war sustainability.	The 6.33 observation and pinned 6.35 component fields resolve stacking and mounted decomposition; annual samples exclude a simple final floor, while shape classes and monthly aggregation remain open.	b2-upkeep	in-progress
R-011	P1	Unrest	Which current unrest thresholds reduce Recruitment Points and Commander Points?	A province can appear affordable while being unable to recruit the planned roster.	Official shutdown and current community reduction claims are preserved; the loss-floor reading now has explicit 1-, 2-, and 3-point candidate thresholds, still awaiting a versioned reproduction.	b2-unrest-effects	queued
R-012	P1	Supply	What is the exact fort-supply distance arithmetic under current rules?	Supply range determines operational reach and siege endurance.	Range, maximum distance, and highest-fort selection are separated from the official x6 versus x4 multiplier conflict; a published 6.36 distance series remains required.	b2-fort-supply-range	queued
R-013	P1	Starvation	Are commanders ever exempt from starvation, and which forms or abilities alter the result?	Commander survival affects retreats, sieges, and remote expeditions.	Need Not Eat, the 6.18 transformation correction, 6.35 object fields, and the 6.35 equipment-refresh fix resolve explicit immunity and display state; generic priority remains open.	b2-starvation	in-progress
R-014	P1	Pretenders	What is the current awakening-point distribution for dormant and imprisoned Pretenders?	Opening timing determines whether a design solves expansion or only a later war.	The June 2026 Dominions 6 page republishes Loggy's model, but source tracing reaches pre-Dominions 6 notes, no 6.x raw sample, and a one-turn range discrepancy. Current reproduction or developer confirmation is still required.	b3-test-p1-awakening-distribution	queued
R-015	P1	Dominion	What are the current checks and order for ordinary dominion spread?	Temple, priest, and candle investments depend on the actual spread model.	Revision-2 official formulas and turn sequence, reconciled with the 6.13 random-preaching correction and later patch history.	b3-sources-of-dominion-spread	completed
R-016	P1	Blessings	Which blessing tags, values, and activation edge cases differ from the revision-2 manual?	Small errors can invalidate a Pretender design or sacred package.	6.35 structured bless data plus official rules and patches through 6.36 establish activation gates, automatic blessing, repeatability, overlap, weapon-trigger, item, and mount boundaries; adjacent transformation and cross-source stacking remain separate questions.	b3-the-activation-state-machine	completed

ID	Priority	Domain	Question	Why it matters	Reliable route	Primary anchor	Status
R-017	P1	Pretender death	What are the current Call God thresholds and contribution rules?	Recovery planning after a god's death depends on time-to-return.	Official Holy, Disciple-game, Elegist, Recall God, Trinity, and hosting rules are reconciled with published controlled research establishing a fixed 50-point base and per-priest effective-rating `-1/0/+1` variation; detailed routing and placement remain Current Community Reference.	b3-r-017-decision	completed
R-018	P1	Victory	How are same-turn Throne claim, province loss, and victory checks ordered in current play?	The result can decide a game despite later movement or siege outcomes.	Official steps 8 and 57, full and partial ownership rules, the current conquest rule, and a published same-turn report establish the claimant-death, unfortified-conquest, siege, and fort-storm branches. Exact simultaneous winning-total ties remain separate.	b3-same-turn-claim-loss-and-victory	completed
R-019	P1	Combat	What is the exact current survivor bonus in morale checks?	Rout thresholds influence squad sizing, standards, and casualty tolerance.	Current community formula supplies `round(5 x surviving proportion)`; a current raw boundary set and separate commander treatment are still required.	b4-test-9-morale-survivor-bonus	in-progress
R-020	P1	Combat	How much fatigue do active units recover while conscious under ordinary conditions?	Fatigue breakpoints shape armour, melee endurance, and spell-support value.	Current community reference supplies one per active round plus Reinvigoration; a frame-by-frame 6.36 reproduction remains required.	b4-test-12-ordinary-fatigue-recovery	in-progress
R-021	P1	Combat	What is the exact harassment accumulation and decay model?	Defence collapse and swarm counters depend on more than the visible attack value.	Official accumulation is resolved; a Dominions 5 decay constant is retained only as a regression hypothesis for a current instrumented reproduction.	b4-test-2-harassment-decay	in-progress
R-022	P1	Combat	What are the complete current weapon cooldown and combat-speed constants?	Attack rate changes damage delivery, repel exposure, and fatigue pressure.	Current structured data and published timing reproduction.	b4-test-3-cooldown-and-combat-speed	queued
R-023	P1	Mounted combat	What are the full current mounted carry, targeting, and movement calculations?	Rider and mount statistics otherwise produce misleading army comparisons.	Official targeting and component rules are resolved; carry, mixed-component movement, and exceptional modifier order remain open.	b4-test-7-mounted-targeting	in-progress
R-024	P1	Magic	What thresholds govern optional combat-gem use and refusal?	A scripted spell package can fail because the caster conserves a gem.	Official 6.12, 6.15, and 6.30 corrections bound the historical thresholds; a current reproducible battle set remains required.	b5-test-3-combat-gem-spending	in-progress
R-025	P1	Magic	Where does rounding occur in spell fatigue, penetration, communion sharing, forging, and ritual contests?	Boundary values can change caster safety and access ladders.	Published current reproductions separated by subsystem.	b5-part-xvi-controlled-test-programme	queued

ID	Priority	Domain	Question	Why it matters	Reliable route	Primary anchor	Status
R-026	P1	Communions	What current edge cases govern shared self-buffs, collapse, and automatic communion items?	Communion failure can destroy the most valuable mage concentration in an army.	Manual rules and official 6.12-6.30 corrections resolve the core; automatic-item, form-change, and forced-removal behaviour remain open.	b5-communion-audit	in-progress
R-027	P1	Movement	What is the exact interception probability and battle location when hostile forces swap provinces?	Movement prediction determines reinforcement and retreat planning.	A published chassis-value algorithm supplies a precise hypothesis; a 6.36 map-and-save reproduction remains required.	b6-movement-and-interception	in-progress
R-028	P1	Patrol	What are the current patrol-detection distributions across stealth and patrol modifiers?	Counter-raiding and scout survival depend on risk rather than a binary threshold.	The official open-ended 2d25 formula has been enumerated directly from D=-60 to +60; exceptional contributors remain regression tests.	b6-patrol-and-stealth	completed
R-029	P1	Raiding	What are the current Raid and pillage output functions?	Economic warfare cannot be compared honestly without expected return and population damage.	Official legality and sequence are resolved; historical exact-output formulas are now 6.36 reproduction predicates rather than current law.	b6-raid-order	in-progress
R-030	P1	Diplomacy	Which binding-NAP edge cases occur under every diplomacy setting?	Interface-enforced treaties must not be described through informal multiplayer custom.	Official 6.01-6.30 exceptions are versioned; the complete binding, nonbinding, and absent action matrix remains open.	b6-binding-diplomacy	in-progress
R-031	P1	Thrones	What are the complete current Throne identities and object effects?	Endgame plans require exact Ascension Points, defenders, and claimed bonuses.	Pinned 6.35 structured site data, cross-checked against current official rules.	b12-thrones-sites	completed
R-032	P2	Domes	In what order are layered domes checked, and are their outcomes independent?	Remote warfare portfolios depend on cumulative interception risk.	Published current controlled reproduction.	b5-layered-domes	queued
R-033	P2	Wish	What vocabulary, aliases, distributions, and restrictions does Wish currently accept?	Late-game plans can waste rare Astral access on obsolete or ambiguous requests.	Current official data or versioned published catalogue with reproduction.	b5-wish	queued
R-034	P2	Artifacts	How are simultaneous artifact forges and global casts resolved at exact ties?	Multiplayer races need a defensible risk model.	Official hosting rule or published simultaneous-order reproduction.	b5-test-16-artifact-race-and-yearning	queued
R-035	P2	Assassination	What are the exact bodyguard, Patience, surprise, and mounted-assassination distributions?	Commander survival packages depend on more than nominal bodyguard count.	Published current controlled reproduction.	b6-assassination-defence	queued
R-036	P2	Cataclysm	What is the final current Cataclysm outcome wording and horror interaction?	Endgame clocks and coalition decisions depend on the actual failure state.	Current official object data and patch notes.	b6-cataclysm	queued
R-037	P2	Event systems	In what order do several rarity-5 global state machines update the same state?	Large overhaul compatibility can fail without any numeric collision.	Author documentation or published deterministic harness.	b8-event-execution-and-order	queued

ID	Priority	Domain	Question	Why it matters	Reliable route	Primary anchor	Status
R-038	P2	Mod parser	Which cross-mod name-reference categories resolve before or after later definitions?	Name references can fail even when numeric IDs do not collide.	Official parser documentation or minimal published loader reproduction.	b8-cross-mod-reference-limits	queued
R-039	P2	Object inheritance	Which hidden copied attributes are absent from `ctrl+i` and ordinary inspector cards?	A visible final card may omit inherited behaviour needed for compatibility.	Exact-version source history plus structured engine export.	b8-copied-objects-are-not-self-contained	queued
R-040	P2	Transformations	Which prophet, mount, heroic, item, and temporary states survive combined transformations?	Shape chains can silently lose national or sacred roles.	Published current transformation matrix.	b8-shape-regression	queued
R-041	P3	Events	What are the current event-variable overflow and negative-value behaviours?	Long event campaigns can corrupt state near numeric boundaries.	Official limit documentation or minimal published harness.	b8-variable-discipline	queued
R-042	P3	Performance	How does hosting time scale with large always-event libraries?	Scenario design needs a practical performance budget.	Published hardware, turn, province, and event-count benchmark.	b8-performance-controls	queued
R-043	P3	AI	How often are AI templates selected and how reliably does the AI use multi-plane gates?	Scenario claims should distinguish configured hints from observed behaviour.	Published behavioural sample tied to version and map.	b8-ai-testing-is-behavioural-sampling	queued
R-044	P3	Save compatibility	Which inserted automatic spell and item objects break existing saves?	Release updates need a safe migration policy.	Published version-to-version save matrix.	b8-save-compatibility	queued
R-045	P3	Networking	Which filename and dependency mismatches are rejected or silently tolerated by the lobby?	Public mod releases need predictable multiplayer installation behaviour.	Official documentation or published clean-client matrix.	b8-network-and-lobby-test	queued
R-046	P0	Experience	Does a current five-star unit receive a cumulative +2 or +3 Hit Points from experience?	A public veteran calculator must not conceal a version conflict.	Official 6.13 changed veteran HP to +1 at each star from the third onward, 6.14 corrected XP HP-stat handling, and the current manual repeats the three increments.	b11-54-experience-thresholds	completed
R-047	P1	Heroic abilities	Which Hall-of-Fame scoring and heroic-growth formulas remain unchanged in 6.36?	Old reverse engineering is useful but cannot be represented as current official law.	Edition 28 defines the official boundary and a versioned raw-observation template; current reproducible tests or engine-backed reverse engineering must supply any formula.	b11-57-what-is-officially-established	in-progress
R-048	P1	Perception	How do current perception abilities divide Glamour, Invisibility, Unseen, Illusion, and Spiritform targets?	A false equivalence can invalidate targeting and counter design.	Official 6.36 ability definitions, current spell descriptions, and a patch check establish the category division; two narrower runtime edges moved to R-058.	b11-31-glamour-invisibility-unseen-and-illusion	completed

ID	Priority	Domain	Question	Why it matters	Reliable route	Primary anchor	Status
R-049	P1	Ability stacking	Which ability sources stack, use best-only, or replace one another across form, item, bless, and spell?	Duplicate investment can waste gems, design points, and scripts.	Current definitions confirm best-only Standard and Inspiring Researcher, cumulative experience and Horror Mark, and non-stacking Blur, Displacement, and Invisibility; unlisted abilities remain test-specific.	b11-6-stacking-precedence-and-the-best-only-rule	in-progress
R-050	P2	Experience	Which current passive XP exceptions apply to Mindless units, sites, items, arenas, and events?	Veteran timing and Hall-of-Fame plans depend on the actual gain sources.	Controlled monthly observation and current data export.	b11-53-how-experience-is-gained	queued
R-051	P2	Unit classes	Which condition immunities follow from a visible class and which require a separate hidden tag?	Visual or taxonomic assumptions can produce false counters.	Current object export plus controlled spell and condition matrix.	b11-8-classes-can-overlap	queued
R-052	P2	Mount state	How do mount loss, Reclaim Mount, automatic return, and shape changes transfer experience and conditions?	Mounted commanders can change body and function across the turn boundary.	Controlled mounted-commander series under 6.36.	b11-38-immortality-reformation-and-extra-lives	queued
R-053	P1	Independents	What are the complete 6.35 independent population types and their province recruitment rosters?	Expansion, fort placement, and off-path recruitment depend on exact independent access.	Exact-version engine or inspector export containing population-type membership.	b12-mercenaries-independents	queued
R-054	P2	Summons	Which unit identities satisfy the 25 unresolved selection- or tag-based summon relations?	A spell record is incomplete when it names a selector but not the possible summoned units.	Exact-version engine export or published reproducible selector resolution.	b12-summons	queued
R-055	P2	Object labels	What are the authoritative human labels for remaining source-native item and site property fields?	Public filters should be readable without pretending that an inferred label is official.	Current UI wording, official manuals, and exact-version object export compared field by field.	b12-maintenance	queued
R-056	P2	Patch classification	Which of the 250 review-recommended patch records need a different fine-grained class or more precise canonical destination?	Source completeness is settled, but accurate filters improve website maintenance and command chronology.	Human review of each official source bullet against the Book XIII classification key and canonical ownership map.	b13-editorial-review	in-progress
R-057	P2	Command documentation	Which of the 60 reference-only, nine mention-only, and five 6.36 patch-only tokens can receive verified semantics without inventing undocumented behaviour?	Search is complete, but a token's official existence is not always a complete behavioural contract.	Later official manuals or announcements, developer clarification, or a published minimal reproduction tied to an exact version and object context.	b14-evidence	queued
R-058	P1	Perception edges	Do Spirit Sight or blindness alter innate Glamour's Mirror Image resolution, and which non-scout information channels reveal Glamour units in friendly provinces?	Category boundaries are documented, but these exact interactions still affect counter selection and strategic detection.	Published controlled 6.36 battle and strategic detection matrix with one sense and one information channel changed at a time.	b11-31-glamour-invisibility-unseen-and-illusion	queued

Blocked engine questions

The following subjects remain outside the active queue until a reliable reproduction, current inspector export, or local executable becomes available:

- unresolved same-turn effects whose official timing list does not define the internal branch;
- final cards produced by occupied-ID `#newmonster` behaviour without an engine export;
- undocumented target-selection weights with no published sample;
- all-AI strategic evaluation weights;
- nation-specific expansion ranges without a reproducible map and independent set;
- private multiplayer outcomes that cannot be independently checked.

These are not requests for the player to perform labour. They are publication limits.

Research order

R-001 is resolved by Books XIII and XIV. R-002 through R-005 are resolved by the independent DE-Divinitus integrity publication and are cross-linked through Book IX without absorbing that publication into the encyclopedia. R-006, R-007, R-009, and R-015 through R-018 are resolved in Books II and III at their stated evidence tiers. R-010 and R-013 are in progress; R-008, R-011, R-012, and R-014 remain queued behind reliable reproduction or better structured evidence. Edition 23 supplies their narrow test predicates and safe operational fallbacks. Edition 24 changes the voice of the reader corpus without changing those statuses. Edition 25 advances R-054 and R-055, closes the realm-expansion subtask, and leaves R-053 queued for an exact population-type export. Edition 26 works through R-019 to R-030: R-028 is completed by direct enumeration of the official patrol formula; R-019 to R-021, R-023, R-024, R-026, R-027, R-029, and R-030 are in progress with sharper evidence boundaries and reproducible predicates; R-022 and R-025 remain queued. Edition 27 closes R-046 from the official 6.13-6.14 patch boundary and current manual. R-031 is resolved in the 6.35 object register, while R-057 can advance alongside documentation maintenance.

Part VII: Maintenance Rules

Adding a section

When new material is written:

1. place it in the book that owns the subject;
2. reuse the existing heading destination if the subject is being revised;
3. add aliases to the website index rather than creating duplicate glossary entries;
4. attach ruleset, evidence, sources, and verification date;
5. link related sections without copying their formulas or tables;
6. add unresolved behaviour to the research register with a route and priority;
7. rebuild and validate the PDF and website exports together.

Moving or replacing a section

A moved section should keep its destination ID where possible. If the subject has genuinely split, the old ID should become a redirect to a short landing section that explains the new authoritative homes. Silent deletion would break PDF annotations, website links, saved bookmarks, and citations in future dossiers.

Preventing duplication from returning

Before adding a formula, table, full definition, or technical essay, search the content index by title, alias, and tag. If an authoritative version already exists, the new section should link to it and explain only the new context. Repetition is reserved for field references, worked applications, and deliberately self-contained print tools.

DOCUMENT 2 OF 7

Foundation Book I: Rulesets, Language, and the Anatomy of a Turn

Why this volume comes first

Most rules in Dominions 6 are manageable on their own. The difficulty comes from having hundreds of them interact during the same turn. A player may understand recruitment, movement, rituals, battles, dominion, and upkeep separately, then still misread a result because they resolved in an unexpected order.

Book I sets out the language and turn order used throughout the library. It works at three levels:

- New-player level: enough explanation to understand what an order does, when it happens, and why an apparent failure occurred.
- Experienced-player level: exact timing relationships, failure points, and strategic consequences.
- Research level: a versioned record of sources, interpretations, and unresolved edge cases.

Nation-specific builds are left for later books. The examples use ordinary commanders, troops, provinces, rituals, and forts so the same conclusions can be used in any age.

> Foundation rule: A strategy should never depend on an unexplained timing assumption. When a plan works only because one action resolves before another, that timing needs to be stated here.

How to read the library

There is no need to read the whole library before playing. The boxed rules, plain-language summaries, and checklists are enough to support a first campaign. The full chapters become useful when a turn behaves strangely, a multiplayer plan depends on exact timing, or a rule needs to be checked for publication. Source notes and unresolved tests sit alongside the rules so that doubtful points remain visible instead of becoming folklore.

Where each subject lives

Each rule has one main home. Later books may give a short reminder when the subject crosses into another system, but the full explanation should not be repeated.

Subject	Authoritative home
terminology, evidence labels, ruleset versions, and hosting order	Book I
order-writing formulas needed at a glance	Turn and Economy Quick Reference
provinces, income, recruitment, infrastructure, supply, PD, and siege economy	Book II
Pretenders, dominion, scales, blessings, and religious systems	Book III
formations, combat arithmetic, morale, fatigue, and battle resolution	Book IV
research, paths, gems, communions, rituals, items, and magical strategy	Book V

Subject	Authoritative home
expansion, intelligence, logistics, war, diplomacy, and victory conversion	Book VI
nation-dossier method and faction-specific application	Book VII onward
mod construction, events, AI scaffolding, maps, testing, and compatibility method	Book VIII
exact Dominions Enhanced and Divinitus definitions and combined-load-order findings	Book IX

The quick reference is the one deliberate exception. It repeats a small number of formulas and timing facts from Books I and II because its purpose is to remain open while orders are written. It should never become the source of a new rule.

The baseline used by this edition

Public unmodded baseline

The current public game release recorded by Illwinter on 25 August 2026 is Dominions 6.36, released on 17 August 2026 UTC. The principal rules source remains the Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2. The official documentation page presents that manual as the main reference for the rules and tables of the game.

The preserved manual is 449 PDF pages and has this fingerprint:

`65f430fd97c9f27285d63b797b43bc7fe3844241fdf40230b1d25a901ab9f33f`

The preserved Dominions 6 Modding Manual, version 6.34, is 65 PDF pages and has this fingerprint:

`5ac40698e05703f5628db123548c4e6a57fe0ed9bbcb65fb8f72fc589ab309ab`

The official Event Modding Manual, version 6.29, remains relevant for event timing, requirements, event chains, and mod-added monthly effects.

Frozen modded baseline

The working modded library uses:

1. `DomEnhanced2_16.dm` - Dominions Enhanced 2.16.
2. `Divinitus_1.15.3_DE.dm` - Divinitus 1.15.3 DE edition.

Dominions Enhanced is loaded first and Divinitus second.

Neither supplied file declares `#domversion`, so neither states a minimum compatible game version. Their source can be analysed exactly. Complete compatibility with Dominions 6.36 still needs to be tested and cannot be assumed.

Ruleset labels

Every future article must display one of the following labels.

Label	Meaning
Unmodded 6.36	The public base game as of 25 August 2026
DE 2.16	Dominions Enhanced 2.16 without Divinitus

Label	Meaning
Divinitus 1.15.3 DE	The supplied Divinitus DE file considered by itself
DE 2.16 + Divinitus 1.15.3 DE	The exact two-file ruleset in the recorded load order
Historical	Material retained from an older game or mod version
Experimental	A proposed mechanic, test mod, or result not yet part of a published ruleset

The label applies to the whole article unless a subsection explicitly overrides it.

Evidence and confidence

The five evidence labels

Label	Meaning	Suitable public wording
Official	Directly stated by Illwinter or visible in current in-game data	State as a rule and cite the source
Source-confirmed	Directly encoded in the exact relevant mod source	State as a rule for that mod version
Reproduced	Repeated in a documented controlled test	State with the tested setup and result
Community-tested	Supported by a detailed outside investigation but not yet reproduced here	Attribute and preserve the test conditions
Unverified	Plausible, incomplete, contradictory, historical, or unsupported	Present only as an open question or hypothesis

Evidence priority

The evidence ledger uses the following general hierarchy:

1. Current in-game result or exported current game data.
2. Current Illwinter manual or official change note.
3. Exact mod source for the named version and load order.
4. Reproducible controlled test.
5. Maintainer explanation.
6. Detailed community test or tournament account.
7. General guide, video, forum advice, or historical conversation.

The manual does not contain every rule. It is authoritative where it is explicit, while implementation details, targeting decisions, hidden limits, and unusual interactions may still need testing. If an official statement disagrees with repeatable current-game behaviour, both sides of the discrepancy must be recorded.

Fact, consequence, recommendation

Three different kinds of statement must not be blended together.

- Fact: the hosting sequence resolves recruitment at step 3.
- Consequence: recruited units exist before movement battles at step 26.
- Recommendation: recruiting emergency defenders may save a province that is attacked during the same hosting cycle.

The first statement is an official rule. The second is a direct timing consequence. The third is strategic advice whose value depends on gold, recruitment capacity, the attacking force, and whether the province can recruit an effective defence.

Citation standard

Every finished chapter should include:

- ruleset and version;
- last verified date;
- primary source;
- manual page or relevant source location;
- evidence label;
- mod-file hash where applicable;
- test record for reproduced claims;
- unresolved questions.

The public TheHoboKingdom edition can keep citations compact. The private research edition retains full fingerprints, links, source extracts, and test conditions.

Core notation

Magic paths

Symbol	Path
F	Fire
A	Air
W	Water
E	Earth
S	Astral
D	Death
N	Nature
G	Glamour
B	Blood
H	Holy or priest level

Path level follows the symbol. `S3` means Astral 3. `F2A1` means Fire 2 and Air 1. A requirement written as `S5E3` requires both Astral 5 and Earth 3 unless stated otherwise.

The letter `G` is reserved for Glamour. Gems are written in words or with their path, such as `15 fire gems` or `15F gems`, when the context cannot be mistaken for a path level.

Research schools

Short form	School
Conj	Conjuration
Alt	Alteration

Short form	School
Evo	Evocation
Const	Construction
Ench	Enchantment
Thaum	Thaumaturgy
Blood	Blood Magic
Divine	Divine spell list rather than an ordinary research school

`Alt 5` means Alteration level 5. `Thaum 9, S5E3` means a Thaumaturgy 9 spell requiring Astral 5 and Earth 3.

Common statistics

Symbol	Meaning
HP	Hit points
STR	Strength
ATT	Attack skill
DEF	Defence skill
PROT	Protection
MR	Magic Resistance
MOR	Morale
PREC	Precision
ENC	Encumbrance
AP	Armour-piercing
AN	Armour-negating
AoE	Area of effect
PD	Province Defence
RP	Research points or recruitment points; the full term must be written when ambiguous

Randomness

`DRN` means the Dominions Random Number roll. Dominions commonly uses an open-ended roll built from two six-sided dice, with more rolls after high results. The later mathematics material deals with the full probability system. Here, `attribute + DRN` means the visible attribute does not decide the final result by itself.

Chance statements must distinguish:

- a fixed percentage;
- a percentage per path or priest level;
- a percentage per dominion candle;
- a chance checked once per unit;
- a chance checked once per province;
- a chance checked once per turn;
- an open-ended opposed roll.

Time

Dominions commonly uses turn, month, and hosting for closely related ideas.

- A turn is the set of orders submitted by all players and the resulting game state.
- A month is the in-world time represented by one turn.
- Hosting is the process that resolves all submitted orders.
- A battle round is a tactical interval inside a battle and must not be confused with a strategic turn.

Spatial terms

- Province: a territory on the strategic map.
- Location: a distinct place within a province, such as the open province or the interior of a fortress.
- Adjacent: connected by a valid province border or other relevant link.
- Plane: a separate strategic layer such as the main world, cave plane, or Nexus/Void plane.
- Square: a tactical grid space on a battlefield.
- Size point: part of the capacity used by units occupying a battlefield square.

Essential glossary

Army

A group of commanders and their assigned troops. The word is convenient but not always a single rules object: different commanders in the same province may have different orders and may fail, move, or fight separately.

Battle magic

Spells cast during tactical combat. Battle magic is governed by scripting, fatigue, range, targeting, battlefield conditions, and the spellcasting AI.

Bless

The set of effects granted to blessed sacred units and commanders. Some bless effects are always available when the unit is blessed; Incarnate effects generally depend on the Pretender being active.

Capital-only

A recruitment or availability restriction tied to the nation's original capital. Conquering another nation's capital does not normally convert its capital-only roster into the conqueror's roster.

Commander

A unit capable of receiving strategic orders and leading troops. Leadership type and capacity determine which troops can be assigned and what morale effects may apply.

Communion

A magical network in which masters receive path bonuses and slaves absorb distributed spell fatigue and certain master-cast personal buffs. The exact mechanics belong in the magic volume.

Dominion

The religious influence of a Pretender, shown as candles in provinces. Dominion is both territorial pressure and a carrier for scales, bless conditions, Pretender hit-point modification, special national effects, and elimination.

Event

A hosting-time occurrence selected from event rules. Events may depend on scales, dominion, population, terrain, commanders, sites, orders, globals, variables, and many other conditions. Modded events can form chains and can imitate systems that the ordinary interface does not expose.

Fort

A fortified location within a province. A besieging force may control the province while the defender retains the fort, creating partial ownership.

Gem

A magical resource associated with Fire, Air, Water, Earth, Astral, Death, Nature, or Glamour. Blood slaves fill a similar strategic role for Blood magic but are units/resources with distinct rules.

Global enchantment

A ritual whose ongoing effect applies broadly to the world or to a large strategic system. Casting occurs during the ritual step, while the continuing world effect is processed later in the hosting sequence.

Host

As a verb, to resolve submitted turns. As a noun, the computer or service processing a multiplayer game.

Laboratory

The infrastructure required for research, most forging, and most ritual casting. A new laboratory is completed late in the turn, after that month's research and ritual steps have already passed.

Magic phase

Community shorthand for the early part of hosting in which rituals, magical movement, remote attacks, and resulting battles occur before ordinary movement. It is useful shorthand, but the official sequence divides it into several distinct steps.

Magic Resistance

A defence statistic used by many spells and supernatural effects. An MR check is not automatically a simple percentage; it may involve opposed DRN rolls, penetration bonuses, and path-based modifiers.

Mage

A commander with one or more magic paths or another ability that permits research, ritual casting, forging, or battle magic. Not every researcher is a conventional mage, and not every mage can perform every magical order.

Mod

A `.dm`-based modification loaded by the game. A mod can add or alter many data objects but cannot necessarily rewrite executable-level systems.

Movement phase

Community shorthand for the part of hosting in which conventional map movement resolves. The official sequence distinguishes friendly movement, other movement, movement battles, and castle storming.

Path

A level of magical skill in Fire, Air, Water, Earth, Astral, Death, Nature, Glamour, Blood, or Holy magic. Paths determine spell access, research value, item access, and many special interactions.

Pretender

The god designed for a nation or team. The Pretender supplies dominion, scales, bless design, magic access, and a physical chassis that may be awake, dormant, or imprisoned.

Province Defence

Locally purchased defence that appears automatically when a province is attacked. It is not a standing army that can move. Its composition and commander structure depend on the nation and investment.

Recruitment point

A local capacity used when recruiting units. It is distinct from gold and resources, and it can prevent recruitment even when the other costs are affordable.

Research point

A contribution toward a school of magical research. Research is processed very early during hosting, before assassinations and most forms of death.

Ritual

A strategic spell ordered outside battle. Rituals can summon units, alter provinces, move commanders, attack remotely, create globals, search, scry, or cause other world-map effects.

Rout

The state in which a unit or squad attempts to flee battle. Dominions battles are normally decided by morale collapse rather than the literal death of every unit.

Sacred

A unit capable of receiving a blessing and often subject to recruitment or upkeep advantages. Sacred does not mean permanently blessed; a blessing still needs to be active.

Scale

One side of the dominion-scale pairs: Order/Turmoil, Production/Sloth, Heat/Cold, Growth/Death, Fortune/Misfortune, and Magic/Drain. Scales affect the world through dominion and can also interact with units, events, sites, and spells.

Site

A magical or special feature located in a province. Sites may provide gems, gold, recruitment, unrest, disease, discounts, ritual access, or other effects. Some are hidden until found.

Squad

A tactical group assigned to a commander. Morale, formation, scripting, and leadership penalties are often evaluated at squad level rather than across the entire army.

Throne of Ascension

A special site that can be claimed by an appropriate priest. Claimed Thrones provide Ascension Points and may grant other effects. The game can end when the configured Ascension requirement is met.

Unrest

A province condition that reduces effective administration and income and interacts with events, recruitment, patrolling, pillaging, and Blood Hunting.

Upkeep

The recurring gold cost of maintaining units and commanders. Upkeep is paid after income is collected in the official hosting sequence.

The central idea: orders are simultaneous, resolution is sequential

Players submit orders without watching the other nations' orders resolve. Hosting then processes every nation's orders through a fixed sequence.

This creates three different kinds of time:

1. Planning time: all players choose orders from the same pre-host game state.
2. Resolution time: the engine processes different kinds of orders in a fixed sequence.
3. Battle time: tactical battles resolve internally after their triggering strategic step.

Players submit their decisions simultaneously, but the engine resolves them in sequence.

This distinction explains many apparently contradictory outcomes:

- a mage contributes research before being assassinated;
- units are recruited before an attacking army arrives;

- a remote attack can strike an army before ordinary movement;
- a new laboratory finishes too late to support research or rituals that month;
- starvation is applied after battles;
- income is collected before upkeep;
- general dominion spread happens after most battles;
- an immortal can be due to return after the victory check has already ended the game.

A six-phase model of hosting

The official manual lists 63 separate steps. For practical reading, those steps can be grouped into six phases. These phase names are editorial tools; the numbered order remains the authority.

Phase	Steps	Main contents
I. Commitments and production	1-9	Messages, research, recruitment, empowerment, forging, preaching, Thrones, quick orders
II. Magic and special threats	10-23	Rituals, remote attacks, magic battles, searching, awakening, Blood Hunting, Horrors, assassinations
III. Movement and conquest	24-27	Friendly movement, other movement, field battles, castle storming
IV. World effects and hidden conflict	28-33	Global effects, random events, item/monster effects, event battles, sneak discovery
V. State, economy, and dominion	34-45	Besiegers, construction, special orders, pillage, income, unrest, starvation, upkeep, dominion, sites
VI. Attrition and end-state	46-63	Aging, disease, insanity, mercenaries, heroes, elimination, victory, immortality, aftermath

The six-phase model is useful for memory. It must not replace the full sequence when exact timing matters.

The complete 63-step hosting sequence

Evidence: Official. Primary source: Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2, pages 55-57. Verified: 25 August 2026.

The following table paraphrases the official sequence and adds timing consequences. The step names and order follow the manual; the explanations are written for this library.

Step	Resolution	What happens	Why the timing matters
1	Send messages	Diplomatic messages and attached gold, gems, or items are dispatched.	Transfers occur before events that could kill a courier, capture a province, or remove a commander. The manual states that the early timing makes sent resources reliable.
2	Research	Assigned researchers contribute research points.	A researcher killed later in the same hosting cycle still contributes for that month.
3	Recruitment	Paid troops and commanders are created.	New defenders exist before movement battles. They cannot receive new orders during the hosting cycle in which they appear.

Step	Resolution	What happens	Why the timing matters
4	Empowerment	Ordered permanent path increases are applied.	The path exists before forging and ritual steps, although the empowering commander cannot also perform a second ordinary order that month.
5	Forge items	Completed items enter the nation's magic-item inventory.	Forging occurs before rituals, but an item in the treasury is not the same as an item already equipped by a caster.
6	Preach	Priests resolve ordinary preaching and adjust dominion.	Preaching can alter dominion before movement battles, unlike general dominion spread at step 42.
7	Heretic preaching	Heretics, insane commanders, and shattered-soul commanders apply their religious influence.	These changes also occur before movement and most battles.
8	Claim Thrones	Eligible priests claim Thrones of Ascension.	A claim is processed before rituals and battles that might remove the claimant later in the month.
9	Quick special orders	Fast special orders such as entering a site to scry or cultivating pearls resolve.	These orders precede the main ritual step; their precise value depends on the named order.
10	Magic rituals	Ritual casters perform their rituals in random caster order.	Competing or interacting rituals cannot be assumed to follow nation number, player order, or script order.
11	Remote attacks	Rituals that strike hostile armies in remote provinces are applied.	An army can be damaged before it performs ordinary movement.
12	Magic battles	Battles created by magic resolve, including hostile teleportation and certain movement rituals.	Magical movement can fight before conventional armies move. Retreats from the group of magic battles are placed after all such battles finish.
13	Lost in other planes	Units become lost in other planes and relevant other-plane battles resolve.	Planar displacement is settled before site searching, ordinary movement, and field battles.
14	Site searches	Magical site-search orders resolve.	A commander can search a province before conventional movement changes the province later in hosting.
15	Prophets	New prophets are declared.	The prophet exists before Call God, awakening, Blood Hunting, assassinations, and ordinary battles, but after ritual and magic-battle steps.
16	Call God	Priests assigned to Call God contribute to returning a banished Pretender.	The recall attempt occurs before ordinary battles can kill those priests that month.
17	Awakening	Dormant or imprisoned Pretenders that are due to awaken enter play.	A newly awakened Pretender exists before ordinary movement battles but received no normal order from the prior map state.
18	Blood hunting	Blood Hunt orders resolve and slaves are collected according to the Blood Hunting rules.	Blood hunters are exposed to the results before assassinations and conventional movement.
19	Horrors	Units due to be visited by Horrors are attacked or affected.	Horror attacks can remove a commander before assassination and movement steps.
20	Assassinations	Assassination, seduction, corruption, and similar attempts resolve immediately.	Killing a commander here can prevent that commander's army from moving later. The research contribution at step 2 has already been secured.

Step	Resolution	What happens	Why the timing matters
21	Relinquish province	A province may be transferred to a qualifying non-stealthed ally already present.	Transfer happens before movement, so an ally arriving later in the turn does not satisfy the presence requirement for this order.
22	Claim mounts	Riders without mounts attempt to obtain suitable mounts.	Mount status is updated before ordinary movement and battles.
23	Lone mounts	Riderless intelligent mounts or mountless riders may return home or disperse.	Mount cleanup occurs before movement, preventing stale mount states from persisting into field battles.
24	Friendly movement	Movement ending in a friendly province resolves.	Reinforcement of an already friendly destination receives priority over hostile arrivals unless an earlier effect intervenes.
25	Other movement	Remaining conventional movement resolves, including Break Siege.	Hostile movement and movements that change control are processed after friendly movement.
26	Resolve battles	Field battles caused by conventional movement are fought.	Province control established here can affect storming, pillage, income, ownership, and later events.
27	Castle storming	Storm Castle battles resolve.	Storming occurs after movement battles. Retreats from the movement and storming groups are placed only after the relevant battles finish.
28	Global enchantments	Ongoing global enchantment effects are applied to the world.	A global is cast at step 10, but its continuing world effect begins here, after movement and castle-storming battles for the month.
29	Random events	Ordinary Fortune, Misfortune, and other eligible random events occur.	These events see the world state produced by magic, movement, battles, storming, and global effects.
30	Resolve battles	Battles created by random events are fought.	Event-created attackers do not fight during the earlier movement battle step.
31	Magic item and monster effects	Special monthly effects generated by items or monsters occur.	Items were forged at step 5, while special monthly effects are delayed until this stage. Item-assisted rituals still belong to step 10.
32	Resolve battles	Battles created by the preceding special effects are fought.	These battles form a separate retreat group after random-event battles.
33	Sneak discovery	Detected stealthy units fight for survival.	A stealth force can avoid the ordinary movement battle and still be discovered and attacked later.
34	Change besieger	When allied forces share a siege, the game determines which ally is the active besieger, favouring the larger force.	Siege ownership and control are settled after field, storming, event, and sneak-discovery battles.
35	Building construction	Forts, temples, and laboratories finish construction or demolition; fort melting also occurs.	New infrastructure is too late for this month's recruitment, research, forging, rituals, preaching, or movement. It becomes useful from the next order phase onward.
36	Special orders	Orders such as Reanimate and Summon Allies resolve.	The manual explicitly notes that allies created here are too late for this month's battles.
37	Pillage	Pillaging increases unrest and kills population.	Pillage occurs immediately before income, so the damage can reduce or remove income from a province captured earlier that month.

Step	Resolution	What happens	Why the timing matters
38	Income	Nations collect provincial income.	New ownership and pillage have already been resolved. Income arrives before upkeep is charged.
39	Unrest alterations	Unrest changes from dominion, scales, patrolling, and related systems are applied.	Income was already collected using the earlier state; the new unrest primarily affects the following month.
40	Starvation	Units without sufficient supplies suffer starvation effects.	Battles are already over. An army newly without supply fights this month's battles before the new starvation penalties are applied.
41	Upkeep and desertion	Unit upkeep is charged and desertion occurs.	Income is collected first, so the treasury has this month's income available when upkeep is assessed.
42	Dominion spread	General dominion spread from temples and other sources resolves.	Most battles have already occurred. New candles from ordinary spread do not retroactively alter those battles.
43	Dominion effects	Population loss, insanity pressure, temperature movement, and other special dominion effects are applied.	Dominion first spreads, then its special world effects are calculated from the resulting state.
44	Site effects	Sites generate disease, unrest, or other monthly effects.	Site effects happen after income, upkeep, and dominion effects but before healing and disease resolution.
45	Overpopulation	If global unit or commander limits are approached, the game removes some common entities.	This is an emergency engine-maintenance step rather than ordinary strategic attrition.
46	Aging	In midwinter, units age and may acquire age-related afflictions such as disease.	Aging is seasonal and occurs before the healing/disease step.
47	Resolve battles	Remaining battles generated by previous effects are fought.	Late world effects can create battles after normal movement, event, and sneak battles.
48	Heal and disease	Units heal lost hit points; diseased units instead suffer disease damage and may gain afflictions.	A surviving unit may recover after all ordinary battles, while disease can turn survival into a later death.
49	Insanity	Eligible units may become insane.	Insanity for the next order phase is determined after battles and healing.
50	Mercenaries	Mercenary bids, purchases, and continued contracts are resolved.	Mercenary availability is decided after income, upkeep, disease, and insanity.
51	New random heroes	Eligible national heroes may appear at the capital.	A new hero arrives after all battles and cannot act during the month of arrival.
52	Kill lone units	Non-commanders stranded in enemy territory without a commander are removed.	Troops left behind by commander death or separation cannot persist indefinitely as an uncontrolled hostile stack.
53	Reclaim provinces	A fort can restore province ownership to its owner or allied team under the stated conditions.	Partial ownership can be corrected late in hosting if the fort is not under siege.
54	Conscription	Province Defence is raised to at least one where applicable, and dominion or commander effects that add PD resolve.	Automatic PD appears after battles and therefore protects future turns, not the battle that caused the ownership change.
55	Scouting	Fresh scouting reports are generated.	Reports show the end-of-hosting state rather than the exact state seen during earlier movement or battles.

Step	Resolution	What happens	Why the timing matters
56	Elimination	Nations meeting elimination conditions are removed.	Elimination is checked after dominion spread and effects, but before the victory check and before immortals reform.
57	Victory	Configured victory conditions are checked and the game may end.	Later administrative steps cannot rescue a position once victory has been declared.
58	Update stats	Hall of Fame and scoregraph information is updated.	Public statistics reflect the completed turn after victory evaluation.
59	Heroic abilities	Eligible units gain or improve heroic abilities.	A unit's new heroic benefit is normally available from the following turn.
60	Reform Immortals	Immortals due to return reform their bodies.	The victory check has already occurred. An imminent immortal return cannot prevent a game that ended at step 57.
61	Reduce PD	Province Defence is reduced where population cannot support it; the manual gives a requirement of at least 10 population per PD point.	Unsustainable PD can disappear after the victory and scouting checks, altering the next turn's defence.
62	Yearning artifacts	Artifacts that newly become yearning change state.	Artifact yearning is an end-of-turn transition rather than an effect applied during forging or battle.
63	Aftermath	The engine validates orders and items, applies necessary shape changes, and performs final cleanup.	The next player turn opens only after these consistency checks and state transitions finish.

Phase I: commitments and production

Messages resolve before danger

Messages and attached resources are dispatched at step 1. The rule has an important diplomatic consequence: a trade agreed during the order phase is not interrupted because the sending capital is captured or the supposed courier dies later in hosting.

This makes the act of sending reliable. It does not make the agreement honest. A player can still send less than promised, send the wrong item, or accept payment while making hostile orders.

New-player rule: Resource transfers are processed before almost anything can interfere.

Expert consequence: A nation expecting to be eliminated can still transfer resources before the elimination check. Multiplayer rules may need to address kingmaking or last-turn treasury transfers explicitly.

Research is secured early

Research occurs at step 2. The official manual explicitly states that a researcher killed or assassinated later in the turn still contributes that month's research.

This timing separates research production from researcher survival:

- the current month's points are earned;
- the researcher may still be lost before the next order phase;
- research enabled at step 2 may make new spells available for later battles in the same hosting cycle, subject to casting orders already submitted and the game's handling of scripted availability.

The last point requires care. A script submitted before hosting cannot safely be assumed to select a spell that was unavailable when orders were written. Research can complete early, but practical same-turn spell use depends on scripting and spell-selection behaviour. That interaction belongs in the magic test suite.

Recruitment occurs before invasion

Recruitment resolves at step 3. Units paid for in the preceding order phase exist before magic attacks, assassinations, ordinary movement, field battles, and storming.

Practical consequences:

- emergency recruits can defend a province attacked that month;
- newly recruited commanders can be present as battlefield commanders;
- new units cannot receive a new strategic order until the following player turn;
- a province captured later does not cancel recruitment already completed;
- a recruitment queue still depends on the gold, resources, recruitment points, and local eligibility checked by the game.

Recruitment timing is one reason a projected attack cannot rely solely on last turn's scouting report. A fort or capital can add another month of defenders before the attack lands.

Empowerment and forging are separate commitments

Empowerment resolves at step 4 and forging at step 5. The sequence does not normally let one commander empower and forge in the same month because both require the commander's order. It does establish that permanent path changes exist before later systems inspect the commander.

A newly forged item enters the national item inventory. It is not automatically equipped by a commander whose orders were already submitted. If a battle or ritual needs a booster, the commander must have it equipped before hosting. Forging it during that hosting is too late.

Preaching is not ordinary dominion spread

Ordinary preaching resolves at step 6 and heretic preaching at step 7. General dominion spread waits until step 42.

This is strategically significant:

- successful preaching can change dominion before battles;
- general temple spread cannot change earlier battle conditions that month;
- heretic and insanity-related religious effects are also early;
- blood sacrifice is a different special order and should not be silently treated as ordinary preaching.

Dominion-dependent hit points, morale, scales, sacred effects, and special national mechanics make this distinction worth testing in controlled battles.

Throne claims are early

Thrones are claimed at step 8, long before the victory check at step 57. A priest who successfully performs the order can establish the claim even if later killed.

The claim does not cause an immediate mid-sequence victory. The remaining hosting steps still resolve before victory is checked.

This creates a dangerous endgame pattern:

1. a Throne is claimed at step 8;
2. the claimant may lose battles or territory later;
3. the game evaluates the configured victory condition at step 57.

Book III resolves the ownership branch at an Official plus Community-tested tier. Killing the claimant after step 8 does not undo the claim. Conquering an unfortified Throne, or storming and conquering the fort that contains one, makes it unclaimed before step 57 and removes its points from the winning total. Merely besieging a fortified Throne does not conquer the fort or unclaim the Throne. Book III retains the evidence and complete state matrix; this chapter owns only the shared turn order.

Phase II: magic and special threats

Rituals have random caster order

All ritual casters resolve at step 10 in random order. This is one of the most important expert-level timing rules.

When two rituals interact, no plan should depend on one particular mage resolving first unless the game provides a separate explicit priority. Examples include:

- two commanders attempting to affect the same unique target;
- competing globals;
- rituals that move, kill, transform, or empower a target;
- rituals that alter a province before another ritual checks it;
- ritual combinations that depend on gem availability or a surviving caster.

Random caster order means that a multi-ritual plan should be robust in every plausible order or should be tested to determine whether the particular rituals belong to separate substeps.

> Expert rule: "Both happen during the magic phase" does not mean "they happen simultaneously." It often means "the engine resolves them one at a time in an order the player cannot choose."

Casting a global and receiving its world effect are different steps

A global enchantment is cast during rituals at step 10. The global's continuing world effect is applied at step 28.

This division creates a clear dependency:

- the global can be established before ordinary movement;
- its normal world-processing stage occurs after movement battles and castle storming;
- the spell's immediate casting effect, if any, must be distinguished from its later monthly effect;
- losing a province or caster after step 10 may or may not end a province-centred global before step 28, depending on that global's rules.

Every global guide should record:

1. casting requirements;
2. immediate casting result;
3. ongoing effect step;
4. dispel rules;
5. termination condition;
6. whether it is centred on a province, caster, site, or global slot.

Remote attacks strike before ordinary movement

Remote army attacks resolve at step 11. A conventional army ordered to leave the targeted province has not yet performed ordinary movement.

This creates several practical uses:

- damage a stack before it marches;
- kill or disable a commander and strand troops;
- force attrition before a later conventional attack;
- attack a force whose destination is uncertain while it is still at its starting location.

There is one important qualification. A commander may leave or arrive through magical movement at step 10, and magic battles occur at step 12. In this context, "before movement" needs to mean "before conventional movement."

Magic battles are their own battle group

Battles created by magic resolve at step 12. This includes examples such as hostile teleportation and units moved by certain rituals.

Retreats are placed after all battles in the group have resolved. That detail matters when multiple magic battles use adjacent provinces or when a retreat destination is itself affected by another magic battle.

"A battle" is too broad to be a safe unit of analysis. The useful sequence is:

- the step that created the battle;
- the battle group to which it belongs;
- the point at which retreats from that group are placed.

Site searching precedes conventional conquest

Site searches resolve at step 14. A mage searching a province can complete the order before an enemy conventional army arrives.

The newly found site then exists for later steps, but each site benefit has its own timing:

- gem income is not necessarily granted immediately upon discovery;
- a site effect may be processed at step 44;
- recruitment unlocked by the site cannot be ordered retroactively;
- a conqueror may take control of the newly discovered site later in the same turn.

The distinction between discovering a site and receiving every benefit of that site should be preserved.

Prophets, recalled gods, and awakening

Prophets are declared at step 15. Call God resolves at step 16. Dormant and imprisoned Pretenders awaken at step 17.

All three occur before ordinary movement and field battles, but after magic battles.

This ordering produces several boundaries:

- a new prophet can defend against a later conventional attack;
- a prophet is not available for an earlier magic battle;
- an awakening Pretender can exist for later defence but generally has no fresh order that month;

- priests calling a god make their contribution before conventional attackers arrive;
- the returned god's exact availability and location must be checked under the Call God rules.

Blood Hunting is early enough to be dangerous

Blood Hunting occurs at step 18, before assassinations and movement. The hunt can generate slaves and unrest before later state-processing steps.

The full economic consequences require the Blood Hunting chapter, but the timing model already establishes that:

- hunters remain in their starting province while hunting;
- a hunter can be assassinated after contributing to the hunt;
- unrest alterations from the broader turn are processed later;
- newly collected slaves exist before later upkeep and income steps, although their immediate availability for already-submitted rituals should not be assumed without testing.

Horrors and assassinations can remove movement leaders

Horror visits occur at step 19 and assassinations at step 20. Both can kill a commander before conventional movement.

An army's movement order belongs to a commander. If that commander dies before step 24 or 25, assigned troops may remain behind, become uncommanded, or eventually be removed if stranded in hostile territory.

A resilient army-movement plan considers:

- redundant commanders;
- bodyguards;
- stealth and assassination threats;
- Horror Marks;
- whether critical troops can be reassigned before hosting;
- whether the loss of a single leader invalidates an entire movement chain.

Relinquishing requires an ally already present

Relinquish Province resolves at step 21. The official description requires the receiving non-stealthed allied commander to already be in the province.

An ally moving into the province at step 24 is too late. A stealthy allied commander does not satisfy the stated condition.

This is a good example of why a plain-language order description is not enough. The order's position in hosting determines which board state it can see.

Phase III: movement and conquest

Friendly movement receives its own step

Movement ending in a friendly province resolves at step 24. Other conventional movement resolves at step 25.

The manual explains the practical purpose: a force trying to enter a friendly province before an enemy arrives normally succeeds unless an earlier event prevents it.

This is not a universal guarantee that every reinforcement arrives safely. Earlier dangers include:

- remote attacks;
- magic battles;
- planar loss;
- Horrors;
- assassination;
- failed movement requirements;
- commander death;
- terrain or movement limitations.

It does mean that an ordinary hostile arrival does not normally prevent valid friendly reinforcement from reaching the province first.

"Other movement" contains several different intentions

Step 25 covers the remaining conventional movements, including Break Siege. It can include:

- invasion of hostile territory;
- movement into independent provinces;
- armies crossing toward a province that changes ownership;
- breaking out of a siege;
- opposing movements that produce a meeting or province battle.

Movement validity depends on the movement rules: map-move allowance, terrain costs, roads, rivers, survival abilities, flying, sailing, planes, army composition, and the slowest or otherwise limiting elements of the force.

Book I records when movement resolves. The movement and logistics material handles the detailed calculation of whether a move is valid.

Field battles occur after both movement steps

Battles created by conventional movement resolve at step 26. The defender seen in battle may include:

- the pre-existing garrison;
- recruited units from step 3;
- friendly reinforcements from step 24;
- Province Defence;
- commanders or units that did not move;
- magical arrivals from earlier steps, if they survived;
- units altered by early effects.

It may exclude:

- conventional reinforcements whose movement failed;
- commanders killed by Horrors or assassinations;
- allies summoned later at step 36;
- infrastructure completed later at step 35;
- dominion changes that wait for step 42.

Castle storming is later than field battle

Castle storming resolves at step 27. A storming force must survive the month's preceding events and battles before entering the assault.

This ordering matters when:

- a relief army arrives;
- the besiegers fight a field battle;
- an army attempts to break siege;
- assassinations remove storm leaders;
- remote attacks weaken the besiegers;
- multiple allied forces are involved.

Storming is a separate battle step, resolved later than movement battles and governed by its own deployment, wall, gate, and defender rules.

Retreats belong to battle groups

The manual repeatedly notes that retreats to adjacent provinces occur after all battles in a relevant group have resolved.

This prevents an oversimplified model in which a routed army immediately appears in a neighbouring province while other same-step battles are still being processed.

For expert analysis, a retreat question should record:

- which step caused the battle;
- which other battles shared the step;
- candidate retreat provinces at the time retreats are placed;
- control and hostile forces in those provinces;
- whether the unit was inside or outside a fort;
- whether the route crossed planes or special connections.

Phase IV: world effects and hidden conflict

Global effects are late relative to conquest

Ongoing global enchantment effects resolve at step 28, after conventional movement and castle storming.

This means a global cast at step 10 may be visible and active as an enchantment before its normal monthly world effect is processed. If the effect depends on a province, site, caster, or global state that can be lost during movement, the exact spell wording and tests become important.

No global should be described merely as "going off in the magic phase." Its casting and its world tick may be separated by most of the month's major battles.

Random events see a heavily updated world

Random events occur at step 29. By then, the game has already processed:

- research and recruitment;
- preaching and Throne claims;
- rituals and magical attacks;
- assassinations;
- conventional movement;
- field battles and storming;
- global world effects.

Events can react to a state that did not exist when orders were submitted.

The Event Modding Manual confirms that events can test a wide range of conditions, including:

- era and turn;
- season and month;
- nation;
- treasury and gems;
- research;
- population;
- unrest and PD;
- buildings;
- terrain and plane;
- sites and Thrones;
- dominion and scales;
- particular monsters, Pretenders, priests, mages, and orders;
- global enchantments;
- event codes and variables.

This is why event systems can simulate diplomacy, doctrine, religious activity, or evolving stories without directly rewriting the strategic AI.

Event battles resolve separately

Battles created by random events occur at step 30. A nation can win its movement battle and then face a later event battle in the same province.

Reports should be read in timing order. Two battles in one province during the same month may be caused by different systems and may see different surviving forces.

Item and monster effects have a separate monthly tick

Monthly effects from magic items and monsters resolve at step 31, followed by any battles they cause at step 32.

The manual distinguishes:

- item forging at step 5;
- item-assisted ritual casting at step 10;
- special monthly item or monster effects at step 31.

This prevents a common category error in which every effect attached to an item is assumed to occur when the item is forged or when rituals resolve.

Stealth failure can produce a late battle

Sneak discovery occurs at step 33. A stealthy force may avoid conventional combat because it remained undiscovered, then be exposed and forced to fight later.

Stealth changes what triggers combat. It does not make a force immune to hostile troops.

Expert stealth analysis should distinguish:

- successful sneaking movement;
- patrol detection;
- event-based detection;
- Glamour visibility;

- assassination or spy actions;
- late sneak-discovery battles;
- retreat and survival after discovery.

Phase V: state, economy, and dominion

Allied siege leadership is determined after combat

At step 34, the game selects the active besieger when allied armies share a siege. Larger armies take precedence according to the manual.

This decision occurs after the major battle groups. Losses suffered earlier in the month can change which ally counts as the besieger.

Buildings finish after the month's active systems

Construction and demolition occur at step 35.

A building ordered this month is too late to support:

- step 2 research;
- step 3 recruitment;
- step 5 forging;
- step 6 preaching requirements where a temple matters;
- step 10 ritual casting;
- step 14 site-search orders;
- earlier battles.

The completed structure is principally an investment in the following turn.

This is the first major principle of infrastructure timing:

> A building consumes resources in the present to unlock actions in the future.

The economy volume will extend this into fort construction time, administration, recruitment access, laboratory networks, temple spread, and opportunity cost.

Special-order summons arrive after battle

Special orders such as Reanimate and Summon Allies occur at step 36. The manual explicitly states that allies summoned here do not participate in this month's battles.

This differs from:

- recruitment at step 3;
- ritual summons at step 10;
- event-created units at their event step;
- units arriving through movement.

When a unit appears is as important as how it is created.

Pillage damages the same month's income

Pillage occurs at step 37, immediately before income at step 38. The official manual explicitly warns that pillaging a newly conquered province can reduce or remove the income collected from it.

This creates a direct trade:

- immediate pillage effects;
- increased unrest;
- population loss;
- reduced current income;
- reduced future economic value;
- possible strategic denial if the province cannot be held.

Pillage should never be evaluated only by its immediate gold or damage result.

Income precedes upkeep

Income is collected at step 38. Upkeep is paid at step 41.

This means the month's provincial income is available before the game assesses unit maintenance. A treasury that appears unable to cover upkeep at the end of the order phase may survive if sufficient income is collected.

Income may already have been altered by:

- conquest;
- pillage;
- ownership;
- unrest existing before step 39;
- population;
- scales and dominion already present;
- sites and other modifiers;
- events or earlier effects.

Unrest changes after income

The broad unrest-alteration step is 39, after income. Patrolling, dominion, scales, and related changes are reflected here.

This suggests a timing distinction between:

- unrest already present when income is collected;
- unrest created directly by pillage at step 37;
- general unrest alterations processed at step 39.

Each unrest source should be tested against income on its own. One slogan cannot safely describe all of them.

Starvation follows battle

Starvation is processed at step 40. The manual states that an army newly without supplies fights its battles before starvation effects are applied.

This does not make supply unimportant. Existing starvation penalties and afflictions may already be present. The rule means that the first new month of shortage does not retroactively weaken battles that occurred earlier in that hosting cycle.

For campaign planning, supply is a delayed threat that compounds over time:

1. the army enters or remains in a low-supply situation;
2. it fights before the new starvation tick;

3. starvation is applied afterward;
4. the weakened army enters the next order phase with penalties, disease risk, or afflictions.

Upkeep and desertion follow income

At step 41, upkeep is charged and desertion occurs.

This timing means conquest and income may fund the army before payment is due. It also means pillage, income loss, or treasury transfers can contribute to a shortfall.

The exact desertion priority and behaviour require a dedicated economy test. A reliable guide should not claim which units desert first without current evidence.

Dominion spread, then dominion effects

General dominion spread occurs at step 42. Dominion effects follow at step 43.

This produces a clear two-stage model:

1. candles spread or contest one another;
2. special effects of the resulting dominion state are applied.

Possible effects include:

- population loss;
- insanity;
- temperature movement;
- national or Pretender-specific dominion effects;
- event eligibility;
- other mechanics tied to friendly or hostile candles.

Most conventional battles are already over. Preaching at steps 6 and 7 is the major earlier religious exception.

Sites apply their monthly effects

Magic-site effects occur at step 44. Disease, unrest, and other site-driven changes are applied after dominion effects.

Site-search discovery occurred at step 14. A newly found site may apply an effect later in the same month, although the timing still needs to be checked for the specific site and effect.

Phase VI: attrition and end-state

Aging is seasonal

Aging occurs at step 46 and only during midwinter. Units gain a year and may receive age-related afflictions.

The seasonal condition matters when planning:

- old mages;
- rejuvenation or age modification;
- disease management;
- transformation;
- long campaigns;

- effects that trigger at a particular month.

The Event Modding Manual identifies month 10 as midwinter in its month numbering, but a full calendar reference should be verified in the dedicated time-and-seasons appendix.

Healing and disease share a late step

At step 48, ordinary units regain lost hit points while diseased units instead suffer disease damage and may gain more afflictions.

This occurs after ordinary battles, global effects, events, item effects, site effects, aging, and any late battles.

Surviving the battle report does not always mean surviving until the next player turn.

Insanity is determined after healing

Insanity changes occur at step 49. An affected unit enters the next order phase with the resulting behaviour or lost control.

Insanity also appears in earlier steps, including heretic preaching at step 7. It is not confined to one moment in the turn. The step 49 check establishes or changes the condition that will affect later orders.

Mercenaries and heroes arrive too late to act

Mercenary resolution occurs at step 50 and new random heroes at step 51.

Neither can receive an order or join an earlier battle during the month of arrival. They become assets for the following order phase.

Lone troops are cleaned up

At step 52, non-commanders left alone in enemy territory are removed.

This can be the delayed consequence of:

- assassination;
- commander death in an earlier battle;
- failed or split movement;
- a commander retreating separately;
- ownership changes;
- units being created without a valid leader.

The lesson goes beyond the cleanup rule. Commander redundancy protects logistics as well as morale.

End-of-turn ownership can still change

At step 53, a fort can reclaim province ownership under the conditions stated in the manual, including the absence of an active siege.

This reflects the distinction between:

- ownership of the open province;
- ownership of the fortress;
- partial ownership;

- full ownership.

Any guide to events, income, recruitment, or province transfer that says only "owner" must specify which kind of ownership the rule requires.

Conscription is for the next attack

At step 54, Province Defence can be raised to a minimum and PD-adding dominion or commander effects occur.

This is after every ordinary battle. The new defence cannot save the province from the attack that caused its creation or transfer.

Scouting reports are end-state reports

Scouting updates at step 55. A report is a view of the state after most monthly transformations, not a recording of every force that passed through the province.

This explains why scouting can omit:

- an army that moved onward;
- units killed in an earlier battle;
- a stealth force not discovered;
- a temporary magical arrival;
- infrastructure or ownership that changed again later.

Intelligence should be dated and treated as a snapshot.

Elimination precedes victory

Elimination is checked at step 56 and victory at step 57.

Dominion spread and effects have already resolved, so a dominion collapse can matter immediately. Immortal return is still three steps away at step 60.

The sequence prevents a player from assuming that a future recovery effect will be processed before the game decides whether the nation or game has ended.

Heroic abilities and immortality are post-victory

Statistics update at step 58, heroic abilities at step 59, and immortal reformation at step 60.

These are transitions into the next turn unless the game has already ended.

Province Defence can be reduced after reports

At step 61, PD is reduced if population cannot support it. The manual states that at least 10 population is required for each PD point.

Because scouting updates at step 55, an edge case exists: the displayed or reported value may need to be checked against the final post-reduction state. The user interface behaviour should be verified in a controlled test.

Aftermath closes the turn

Artifact yearning occurs at step 62. Final validation, item checks, and shape changes occur at step 63.

Aftermath is a reminder that not every visible state transition has a named strategic order. Shape-changing units, invalid item states, and other cleanup may be corrected only at the end.

Timing chains every player should know

Researcher assassination

Order	Event
2	The mage contributes research
20	The assassination attempt occurs
48	If wounded and surviving, healing or disease is processed
Next turn	The nation keeps the research but may have lost the mage

Conclusion: Assassination disrupts future research, not the research already produced that month.

Emergency recruitment against invasion

Order	Event
3	Recruits are created
24	Friendly reinforcements may arrive
25	The hostile army moves
26	The field battle includes eligible new defenders

Conclusion: Recruitment and friendly reinforcement can both increase a defence beyond what the attacker saw in the preceding scout report.

Commander assassination strands an army

Order	Event
20	The movement commander is assassinated
24-25	The dead commander cannot complete conventional movement
52	Troops left alone in hostile territory may be removed

Conclusion: A cheap assassination can have a strategic effect much larger than the commander's personal value.

Remote attack before a march

Order	Event
10	The attacking ritual is cast
11	Its remote strike hits the army
25	The surviving conventional army attempts movement
26	It fights any resulting field battle

Conclusion: Remote attacks can soften, disorganise, or decapitate an army before its conventional operation.

Teleportation and conventional invasion

Order	Event
10	Magical movement ritual resolves
12	Any resulting magic battle is fought
24-25	Conventional armies move
26	Conventional movement battles occur

Conclusion: A teleporting force cannot be treated as arriving at the same moment as a marching army. The magical force may fight alone first.

Constructing a laboratory

Order	Event
2	Research occurs without the unfinished laboratory
5	Forging occurs without it
10	Rituals occur without it
35	The laboratory finishes
Next turn	Eligible commanders can use the laboratory

Conclusion: A laboratory order is an investment in next month's magic, not a way to enable this month's rituals.

Pillage after conquest

Order	Event
25	Invaders move
26	They win the province
37	A valid Pillage order is processed
38	Income is collected from the damaged province

Conclusion: Pillaging a newly conquered province can sacrifice immediate and future economic value.

Starvation after combat

Order	Event
26-33	Ordinary, event, special-effect, and sneak battles occur
40	New starvation effects are applied
48	Healing or disease is processed
Next turn	The army begins in its worsened condition

Conclusion: An army can fight at its pre-starvation state and still emerge strategically crippled afterward.

Dominion before and after battle

Order	Event
6-7	Preaching and heretic preaching adjust dominion
26-33	Most battles occur
42	General dominion spread occurs
43	Dominion effects apply

Conclusion: Active preaching can matter before battle. Passive monthly spread generally affects the state after battle.

Victory before immortal return

Order	Event
56	Elimination is checked
57	Victory is checked
60	Due immortals reform

Conclusion: A return scheduled for the end of the month cannot undo a game-ending state already recognised at step 57.

A new player's turn checklist

Before finalising orders

- Check the treasury after recruitment, construction, forging, and expected transfers.
- Confirm that every army has a commander with the correct normal, magic, or undead leadership.
- Confirm that the slowest movement restriction has not invalidated an army's route.
- Check whether rivers, roads, mountains, forests, swamps, caves, sailing, or planes alter movement.
- Give bodyguards to commanders exposed to assassination.
- Verify that critical mages have the required paths, gems, laboratory, and target.
- Equip boosters before hosting; forging them this turn is too late for the same caster to use them.
- Check whether a ritual target is the starting province or expected destination of an enemy.
- Inspect every fort for recruitment, siege, storm, and repair intentions.
- Confirm that researchers are actually assigned to Research.
- Review starving, diseased, old, insane, or heavily Horror Marked commanders.
- Check dominion and retreat routes around important battles.
- Confirm that a Throne claimant has the required priest level and correct order.
- Recheck diplomacy messages, gold, gems, and items before sending.
- Save or archive the turn file when a test or major operation needs later reconstruction.

After hosting

- Read messages before changing orders.
- Separate magic battles, movement battles, event battles, and assassination battles.

- Compare recruitment reports with surviving units.
- Check whether movement failed or whether the commander died before movement.
- Inspect new sites, buildings, heroes, mercenaries, globals, and dominion changes.
- Review income, upkeep, unrest, and supply summaries.
- Inspect wounded survivors for disease and new afflictions.
- Check whether stealthy units remained hidden or fought discovery battles.
- Review scouting reports as end-state snapshots.
- Record any result that contradicts the expected hosting sequence.

Expert operational checklist

For a complex operation, write the dependency chain before submitting orders.

Target

- What province, fort, army, commander, site, or global must change?
- Which exact end-state counts as success?

Earliest interference

- Can a message transfer remove required gems or items?
- Can a remote ritual kill or move the target?
- Can a Horror, assassination, or seduction remove a critical commander?

Magic-phase dependencies

- Which rituals interact?
- Does random ritual order matter?
- Will magical movement fight alone before conventional movement?
- Are retreats from several magic battles competing for the same provinces?

Movement dependencies

- Is the destination friendly at step 24 or hostile at step 25?
- Could ownership change between planning and movement?
- Is Break Siege involved?
- Is there a valid retreat province after all battles in the group?

Post-battle dependencies

- Does a global tick at step 28?
- Can a random event or item effect create another battle?
- Will a stealth force face discovery at step 33?
- Does construction finish too late for the intended action?

Economic dependencies

- Does Pillage reduce the income expected to pay upkeep?
- Is the army supplied before the starvation tick?
- Does income arrive before the planned upkeep obligation?
- Could population loss reduce PD at step 61?

End-state dependencies

- Can dominion spread eliminate a nation?
- Is victory checked before an expected immortal return?
- Does a hero, mercenary, or summoned ally arrive too late to matter?

Troubleshooting: why did the order fail?

"My army did not move"

Check, in order:

1. Was the commander killed by a Horror, assassination, magic battle, or remote effect before movement?
2. Did the commander become lost in another plane?
3. Was the route valid for every unit in the army?
4. Did terrain, a river, road status, sailing, flying, or survival ability change the cost?
5. Did the destination change from friendly to hostile or otherwise alter the movement category?
6. Was the commander performing a different order?
7. Was the army inside a fort, besieging, breaking siege, patrolling, or sneaking?
8. Did part of the army move while incompatible units remained?
9. Was the apparent failure actually movement followed by defeat and retreat?

"My ritual did not happen"

Check:

1. Did the caster have the required laboratory?
2. Were the path requirements met after all equipped items and effects?
3. Were sufficient gems or slaves available to that caster?
4. Was the target legal and correctly selected?
5. Did the caster receive the ritual order rather than a battle script or different strategic order?
6. Was the ritual blocked, resisted, intercepted, or converted into a battle?
7. Did another randomly ordered ritual change the target first?
8. Was the expected result an ongoing global effect that waits until step 28?
9. Was the spell from a different ruleset or mod version?

"My new building did nothing"

Construction finishes at step 35. It cannot enable research at step 2, recruitment at step 3, forging at step 5, or rituals at step 10 during that same hosting cycle.

"My summoned allies missed the battle"

If they came from a special order such as Summon Allies or Reanimate, they arrived at step 36 after the battle steps. Ritual summons follow different timing and must be analysed under the ritual that created them.

"The battle used different dominion than expected"

Check:

- preaching at step 6;
- heretic preaching at step 7;

- special religious effects;
- the pre-host candle state;
- whether ordinary dominion spread at step 42 occurred only after the battle;
- whether the battle report or later map screen is being used as the reference state.

"The province produced less income than expected"

Check:

- ownership after movement and battle;
- pillage at step 37;
- population;
- unrest already present before the income step;
- dominion and scales;
- sites and events;
- partial ownership caused by a fort;
- whether the figure came from a pre-host projection or the final income report.

"The unit survived battle but disappeared"

Possible causes include:

- a later event or special-effect battle;
- starvation;
- upkeep desertion;
- site or dominion damage;
- disease at step 48;
- lone-unit cleanup at step 52;
- elimination or victory;
- end-of-turn shape or item validation.

Ruleset and mod implications

Core sequence versus mod-added content

Ordinary `.dm` mods can add or modify:

- units;
- weapons and armour;
- spells;
- items;
- sites;
- nations;
- blessings;
- population types;
- mercenaries;
- events;
- AI templates and preferences;
- many special attributes.

The current modding manuals do not expose a command for rewriting the engine's entire 63-step hosting sequence.

The practical model is:

- the engine retains its main sequence;
- mods insert new content into the steps appropriate to that content;
- a modded ritual still belongs to ritual processing;
- a modded event still belongs to event processing;
- a modded monthly monster or item effect belongs to the relevant special-effect stage;
- mod load order determines the final data definitions used when those steps run.

This conclusion is Official limits plus inference, not proof that no executable-level modification could ever alter hosting.

Mod load order

The Modding Manual states that complete mods are loaded one at a time. Within a mod, command categories are parsed in an internal order including weapons, armour, units, names, blessings, sites, nations, spells, items, general commands, population types, mercenaries, and events.

When two enabled mods alter the same object, later alterations can overwrite earlier values. The manual warns that overlapping modifications can produce unpredictable behaviour.

For the frozen ruleset, Dominions Enhanced loads before Divinitus. Book IX owns the exact overlap and collision record, while the Grand Hierophant reconstruction is kept with the Arcoscephale dossier in Book VII. The timing lesson here is simply that load order belongs to the ruleset.

Event chains and compatibility

The Event Modding Manual warns that event-code collisions between mods can scramble event chains and create severe bugs. It recommends negative event codes in a reserved range and careful compatibility checking.

Both active mods add large event libraries. Their size alone does not prove a collision, but it makes code and variable auditing a foundational requirement. The exact registries and current collision findings are recorded once in Book IX.

Controlled tests required by Book I

The official sequence is explicit, but several practical interactions still need current-game reproduction.

Test protocol

Every test should record:

- game version;
- operating ruleset;
- enabled mods and load order;
- map and game settings;
- turn number and season;
- relevant units, IDs, paths, items, sites, and province state;
- exact submitted orders;
- pre-host save;
- messages and battle reports;
- before-and-after screenshots or extracted state;
- number of repetitions;
- conclusion and confidence label.

Priority timing tests

#	Test	Controlled question
1	Research completion and same-turn scripting	Can a newly completed research level make a pre-scripted spell available in a later battle that month, and how are invalid scripts handled?
2	Preaching and battle dominion	Does successful step-6 preaching change dominion-dependent battle statistics before a step-26 battle?
3	Throne claim-loss regression	Confirm that later claimant death preserves a completed claim, while unfortified conquest or a successful fort storm makes the Throne unclaimed before step 57.
4	Forged item availability	Can a step-5 forged item influence an already-submitted same-turn ritual or special effect without being equipped beforehand?
5	Newly discovered site effects	Does a site discovered at step 14 apply its monthly effect at step 44 in the same month?
6	Assassinated movement commander	What happens to movement and assigned troops when their only commander dies at step 20?
7	Friendly movement priority	Which forces appear in battle when friendly reinforcement and an enemy invasion enter the same province during an ownership change?
8	Global casting versus first world tick	Which parts of a global occur at casting step 10 and which wait for world-effect step 28?
9	Pillage and same-turn income	How much income is lost when a newly captured province is pillaged at step 37 before income at step 38?
10	Unrest timing	Which of pre-existing unrest, pillage unrest, patrol reduction, and dominion-driven unrest changes influence step-38 income?
11	Starvation timing	Does a newly undersupplied army fight at its prior state before receiving the post-host starvation effects?
12	Upkeep desertion priority	Which units desert first during a controlled treasury shortfall?
13	Site, dominion, and disease ordering	How do site disease, dominion effects, aging, regeneration, and existing disease combine in the end-of-turn health sequence?
14	Scouting before PD reduction	Do reports or interface values show PD before or after the step-61 population reduction?
15	Victory before immortal return	Can victory or elimination end the game on the same turn an immortal is due to reform at step 60?
16	DE and Divinitus event-code audit	Do the two supplied files collide in event codes, variables, rarity classes, or order requirements?

Source record

Primary official sources

- Illwinter Dominions 6 documentation, accessed 25 August 2026.
- Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2, especially pages 13, 47-57, 73-87.
- Illwinter update record, recording Dominions 6.36 on 17 August 2026 UTC.
- Official Dominions 6.36 announcement.
- Dominions 6 changes from Dominions 5.
- Dominions 6 Modding Manual, version 6.34, especially pages 3-5 and 63-65.
- Dominions 6 Event Modding Manual, version 6.29, especially pages 2-11.

Exact mod sources

- `DomEnhanced2_16.dm`, SHA-256 `72558697f8dae3a1fccf8fb57b3faccde56c7fe6c05dac6403cefe153faf6c1b`.
- `Divinitus_1.15.3_DE.dm`, SHA-256 `cf7f21900a3812b66edddd831df779743eaf33080aef983f9bdea8ec47642809`.

Verification note

The public base game is version 6.36, while the current official Modding Manual identifies itself as version 6.34 and the Event Modding Manual as version 6.29. This is not automatically a contradiction: auxiliary manuals are updated when their documented interfaces change. It does mean that later patch notes and current-game tests remain necessary whenever a rule could have changed after a manual's stated version.

DOCUMENT 3 OF 7

Foundation Book II: Economy, Provinces, and the Machinery of State

Why the economy needs its own book

Dominions 6 presents its economy as a row of numbers: gold, gems, resources, Recruitment Points, supplies, population, unrest, and upkeep. Those numbers do not all work in the same way. Some are national, some belong to one province, some vanish unused, and others can be saved indefinitely. A few are not spendable resources at all; they limit how quickly something else can be turned into useful power.

This is why the richest nation can still fail to raise an army. It is also why a poor province can decide a war by preserving tax trace, feeding a siege, or shortening a reinforcement route. Book II follows those connections from the province screen to the wider war effort. Ordinary play comes first, followed by the formulas, edge cases, and source disputes needed for closer work.

> Foundation rule: Economic value is not the number printed beside a province. It is the useful power that can be converted from that province, through the available infrastructure, before an opponent can interrupt the conversion.

Edition note

Book I defines the common Dominions 6.36 baseline and evidence labels. Book II relies mainly on the revision-2 manual and Modding Manual 6.34. Where those official documents disagree, both readings remain visible. Book IX owns the exact DE and Divinitus definitions; only their economic consequences are repeated here.

The Edition 23 revision returns to R-008 and R-010 through R-013 without opening another economy volume. It separates every known rounding stage, turns the community unrest wording into explicit candidate thresholds, records what the annual upkeep observations do and do not prove, bounds the two printed fort-supply systems, and incorporates the official 6.35 Supply Usage refresh correction. No uncertain engine rule has been promoted merely because one interpretation is convenient.

A sensible way through

For a first campaign, begin with the economic model, province anatomy, recruitment gates, supply, and infrastructure. The formula sections, PD curves, siege economics, Blood opportunity costs, and diagnostic ratios are there for closer planning. Source conflicts and controlled tests can be left until a disputed number actually matters.

Part I: The Economic Model

Dominions as a game of conversion

Territory is not victory by itself. Territory provides inputs which can be converted into military and magical effects:

```
population and scales
-> gold, supplies, and recruitment capacity

terrain and forts
-> resources, infrastructure, and strategic position

gold and local capacity
-> troops, commanders, buildings, and province defence

labs, mage-turns, and research
-> spells, items, rituals, summons, and battlefield packages

sites and blood hunting
-> gems and blood slaves

armies, magic, information, and diplomacy
-> territory, forts, thrones, and denial

thrones and survival
-> victory
```

Every arrow takes time. Every conversion can be interrupted. Much of expert play consists of identifying which arrow is currently limiting the nation.

Stock, flow, capacity, and position

Four categories keep economic discussions clear.

Category	Meaning	Examples
Stock	A resource saved for future use	Treasury gold, gems, blood slaves, forged items
Flow	A recurring gain or loss	Monthly income, gem income, upkeep, population growth
Capacity	A local or national limit on conversion	Resources, Recruitment Points, Commander Points, Holy Points, mage-turns
Position	Map state that makes conversion possible or safe	Fort network, tax trace, laboratory access, supply reach, defensible borders

Economic mistakes often begin by treating one category as another. Resources do not accumulate, so they are not a stock. A large treasury does not create recruitment capacity. A fort has a price, but it also changes strategic position and several local limits. A mage is a unit and a recurring choice about how to spend a mage-turn.

National and local resources

Resource or limit	Scope	Accumulates?	Portable?	Principal uses
Gold	National treasury	Yes	Effectively national	Recruitment, buildings, PD, mercenaries, some rituals and events
Magic gems	National pool and commanders	Yes	Transferable through labs, commanders, and messages	Rituals, forging, combat magic, empowerment

Resource or limit	Scope	Accumulates?	Portable?	Principal uses
Blood slaves	National pool and commanders	Yes	Transferable, but with distinct handling	Blood rituals, forging, battle magic, sacrifice
Resources	Province	No	No	Equipping recruits
Recruitment Points	Province	No	No	Ordinary troop throughput
Commander Points	Province	No	No	Commander throughput
Holy Points	Nation/local sacred queue interaction	Refreshes	No direct transfer	Sacred recruitment
Supplies	Province and army situation	No strategic stock, except siege storage and temporary pillage food	Army uses local supply	Sustaining units
Population	Province	Changes over time	No	Income, Recruitment Points, supplies, PD support, Blood Hunting
Mage-turns	Commander-time	No	Commander can move	Research, site search, forging, rituals, Blood Hunting, combat

The table explains why "What can the nation afford?" is incomplete. The more useful question is:

> What can be paid for, recruited at the correct location, led, supplied, scripted, and delivered before the relevant deadline?

The binding constraint

Production is governed by the tightest active limit.

Suppose a fort has:

- 1,000 gold available nationally;
- 120 local resources;
- 80 local Recruitment Points;
- one available Commander Point;
- three Holy Points.

A 10-gold, 5-resource, 10-RP troop is not limited by gold or resources. It is limited to eight by Recruitment Points. A 100-gold commander that costs two Commander Points cannot be recruited there even though the treasury is sufficient. A sacred costing one Holy Point can be limited to three even when every local pool remains.

The bottleneck can change when the recruit mix changes. Adding an expensive armoured unit may convert an RP-limited queue into a resource-limited one. Adding a cheap commander may consume the Commander Point needed for the mage who makes the fort strategically valuable.

Bottleneck audit

For every major recruitment centre:

1. Identify the desired troop and commander package.
2. Calculate gold, resources, Recruitment Points, Commander Points, and Holy Points separately.
3. Find the first exhausted pool.
4. Ask whether a different mix uses otherwise stranded capacity.

5. Compare the value of expanding capacity against building another centre.

This is more accurate than optimising a single "gold efficiency" statistic.

Opportunity cost

The true cost of an action includes the best alternative foregone.

Examples:

- A 600-gold laboratory is also troops not recruited this month.
- A searching mage is research not produced.
- A Blood Hunter is research, forging, or ritual work not performed.
- Province Defence is permanent local defence, but the same gold could have become a mobile army.
- A fort under construction ties up a commander and delays military spending before its benefits begin.
- A mage carrying gems into battle makes those gems unavailable for a ritual and risks losing them.

Opportunity cost changes with time. A laboratory that delays the first expansion party may be disastrous; the same laboratory may be essential once the province's recruitable mage or site income becomes relevant.

Economic tempo

An investment is measured by more than eventual return.

```
payback time =
investment cost / recurring net gain
```

This simple ratio is useful but incomplete. Dominions adds:

- construction delay;
- commander-turn cost;
- risk of capture;
- military value during payback;
- capacity unlocked;
- strategic location;
- the possibility that the game ends before repayment.

A fort may never repay its gold through Administration income alone yet still be a strong investment because it recruits mages, concentrates resources, projects supply, protects a laboratory, delays an invasion, and creates a tax-trace anchor.

Part II: Provinces, Terrain, and Population

A province is a bundle of systems

A province can contain:

- one or more terrain types;
- population;
- potential and available resources;

- income;
- supplies;
- dominion and scales;
- unrest;
- corpses;
- Province Defence;
- a fort, temple, and laboratory;
- discovered and undiscovered sites;
- recruitable independent or national units;
- commanders and armies;
- partial ownership between the exterior and a besieged fort.

The printed income number is only one part of the province's value.

Provincial roles

Role	What makes it valuable
Income province	High population, favourable scales, low unrest, tax trace, Administration
Production province	High potential resources, strong fort draw, suitable national roster
Mage centre	Valuable commander roster, lab, Commander Points, safety
Logistics node	Fort supply reach, roads or movement position, defensible route
Site province	Gem income, recruit access, discounts, ritual or entry functions
Blood province	Sufficient population, patrol capacity, acceptable economic sacrifice
Buffer province	Raid tax, warning time, retreat geometry, denial
Throne province	Ascension value, special throne effects, strategic obligation

One province may fill several roles. Its correct investment level depends on the most important role, not on a universal province template.

Corpses as provincial stock

Unburied corpses are a local provincial stock. They are not gold, population, supplies, or units waiting to be recruited, but several Death effects and reanimation orders can convert them into value. The revision-2 manual names Raven Feast and the raising of undead as ordinary examples.

The stock is deliberately concealed from most observers. Its number is visible when a Death mage or undead priest is present in the province. A nation's ordinary priests can also see it when those priests possess national reanimation. Ermor's Ashen Empire dominion supplies a broader special exception by sensing unburied corpses in covered provinces.

Question	Current verified answer
What does the number represent?	Unburied corpses currently available in the province.
Who normally sees it?	A Death mage or undead priest in the province.
Which ordinary priests can see it?	Priests of a nation whose normal priests can reanimate undead.
What consumes it directly?	Reanimating Soulless reduces the available corpse count; corpse-dependent spells and abilities may have their own rules.
What does not require this stock?	Ordinary Longdead reanimation has no corpse limit under the manual's basic distinction.

Question	Current verified answer
Is every battlefield death guaranteed to add one usable corpse?	No general one-for-one rule is stated. Corpse eligibility has changed through patches, so the casualty total is not a safe substitute for the visible stock.
Is a universal decay rate documented?	No general monthly decay formula is stated in the current official foundation sources used here.

The last two limits matter. Version 6.08 specifically changed humanoid apes and dogs so that they leave corpses when killed. That official correction shows that corpse production depends on unit eligibility rather than on a universal "one dead body equals one corpse" rule. Until an exact current production table is available, battle losses should be treated as a clue, not as an exact corpse forecast.

Corpse-dependent conversions

The manual separates three common reanimation economies:

- Ghouls convert living population into undead, reducing the population left behind.
- Soulless convert unburied corpses and reduce the local corpse stock.
- Longdead can be reanimated without a stated population or corpse ceiling.

Asphodel uses a different branch. Human inhabitants or dead human corpses permit a chance of Manikins and Mandragoras; when those are unavailable, animal-based carrion creatures remain possible. This is a national conversion rule, not a universal reanimation formula.

Operationally, a corpse-dependent plan needs four checks:

1. a legal commander, spell, or ability;
2. visibility or another reliable reason to believe the local stock exists;
3. the correct province at the relevant order or ritual step;
4. a comparison between consuming the stock now and reserving it for a stronger conversion later.

Book X's special-order reference owns the order-entry procedure. Exact spells and summoned objects remain in the Book XII data layer. Book II owns the economic reading: corpses are hidden, local, exhaustible in some uses, and valuable only through a legal converter.

Terrain

The manual characterises terrain by broad tendencies:

Terrain	Population tendency	Resource tendency	Site tendency
Plains	Neutral	Neutral	Neutral
Mountain Ranges	Neutral	Excellent	Many
Forest	Low	High	Many
Highlands	Low	High	Neutral
Swamp	Very low	Neutral	Many
Waste	Extremely low	Neutral	Abundant
Farm	Very high	Low	Few
River	High	Neutral	Neutral
Sea	Low	Neutral	Neutral

Terrain	Population tendency	Resource tendency	Site tendency
Deep Sea	Very low	High	Many
Kelp Forest	High	Neutral	Neutral
Gorge	Low	High	Abundant
Cave	Low	Neutral	Neutral
Drip Cave	Neutral	Excellent	Neutral
Crystal Cave	Very low	High	Abundant
Forest Cave	High	Neutral	Many

Multiple terrain types can coexist and their effects add. Terrain also affects movement, survival skills, combat environments, national recruitment, building costs, site pools, and the boundary between land and underwater systems.

Strategic reading of terrain

Farms often deserve protection because their population supports income, supply, and recruitment capacity. Highlands, forests, mountains, and special caves often make stronger production or search targets. Wastes and unusual terrain may be economically poor in gold yet rich in site opportunity.

This creates a recurring division:

- population-rich terrain funds the state;
- resource-rich terrain equips the army;
- site-rich terrain may fund magic;
- movement terrain determines whether any of that value can be defended.

Population

Population supplies four fundamental systems:

1. base income;
2. Recruitment Points;
3. provincial supplies;
4. support for Province Defence.

It is also consumed or damaged by:

- Death scales and extreme temperatures;
- pillaging;
- some forms of patrolling;
- Blood Hunting and related events;
- hostile dominions and special national effects;
- sites, spells, and random events.

Population is slow capital. A temporary gold gain purchased with permanent population loss can weaken income, recruitment, supply, and PD support for the remainder of the game.

Growth and decline

The current unmodded 6.36 baseline gives ordinary Growth as:

- population growth of 0.2% per month per step;

- 10% additional supplies per step;
- 2% additional income per step.

Death reverses those values.

The revision-2 main-manual scale table prints 1% income per step, but the newer official Modding Manual 6.34 defines the unmodded `#deathincome` default as 2. No version 6.35 announcement alters that default. The newer explicit default governs this edition; the old one-percent value remains useful only for identifying stale guides. Dominions Enhanced 2.16 also sets the income change to 2%, while changing population movement to 0.25% per scale step.

Compounding

Population growth compounds:

```
future population =
current population x (1 + monthly rate)^months
```

The formula illustrates scale, but practical forecasting must account for integer rounding, changing candles and scales, events, patrolling, pillage, and hostile effects.

Growth affects the present month and the province's longer future. Its value rises with:

- early control of populous provinces;
- a long expected game;
- stable dominion;
- protection from raiding and pillage;
- units and forts that can use the resulting recruitment and supply.

Death or destructive economy can still be strategically rational for nations whose population contributes little, whose dominion deliberately kills population, or whose power spike is intended to end the game before the long-term loss dominates.

Tax trace and the administrative map

Official rule: a province produces no income for the turn if it cannot trace an unbroken chain of friendly provinces to a friendly fort. Disciples can trace through allied provinces.

Tax trace creates an economic network:

- forts are collection anchors;
- friendly province chains are conduits;
- raiding can disconnect rather than merely steal;
- a single captured bridge province can suppress the income of a whole pocket;
- recovering the chain before step 38 can restore collection that month.

The system makes map topology economically meaningful. A low-income corridor can protect the income of several rich provinces.

Tax-cut warfare

A raid should be evaluated by total denied value:

```
raid value =
direct province denial
+ disconnected income
+ queue disruption
+ commander attention
```

```
+ movement distortion
+ information gained
- raider losses
- opportunity cost
```

The direct income printed on the raided province may be the smallest term.

Part III: Gold, Income, and Upkeep

Income formula

The official main-manual formula is:

```
base income = population / 100

modified income =
(population / 100)
x dominion-scale modifiers
x (1 + fort Administration / 200)

final income =
modified income / (1 + unrest x 0.02)
```

The province display reports the already modified number.

Administration

Administration increases provincial income by half its rating:

Administration	Local income bonus
15	+7.5%
30	+15%
45	+22.5%
60	+30%
70	+35%

The bonus applies to the province containing the fort, not to neighbouring income.

Scale interaction

The manual gives:

- Order/Turmoil: 3% income per step;
- Productivity/Sloth: 3% income per step;
- each temperature step away from preference: -5%;
- Growth/Death: 2% per step under the current official Modding Manual default.

The main manual also contains an example saying Order 2 increases income by 4%, conflicting with its own repeated 3%-per-step tables. The tables are the stronger internal evidence; the example is treated as a likely textual error.

Rounding: formula, display, and treasury

The income formula identifies the factors but not every integer conversion. Three different numbers must be kept apart:

1. the unrounded result of a written formula;
2. the whole number displayed for the province;
3. the amount actually credited to the treasury after all current modifiers and collection rules.

The revision-2 manual does not state whether the engine floors after population, after each scale, after Administration, only at the end, or through some combination of those stages. Community documentation describes the population-derived base as rounded down, but it does not provide a versioned boundary test for the whole chain. R-008 remains open.

For ordinary play, the province display is authoritative. For a forecast near a one-gold boundary, record the displayed value before and after changing exactly one input. Do not reverse-engineer a hidden intermediate from the final integer and then present it as an official rule.

The word rounding conceals several different questions. They should not be allowed to borrow evidence from one another:

Subsystem	What is established	What remains open	Safe operational value
Provincial income	Official factor chain and unrest divisor	Intermediate floors, final conversion, and treasury treatment	Province display and the Income Overview
Resources	One worked donor contribution of 13.8 is reduced to 13	The printed aggregate does not reconcile; fort draw, scale, and unrest stages are not fully ordered	Current province resource pool
Recruitment Points	Official population bands, fort bonus, and Order/Turmoil modifier	Band, modifier, and final integer order	Current spendable RP shown by the recruitment screen
Commander Points	Ordinary pool and multi-month accumulation	Reduction and rounding under unrest	Current commander queue progress
Upkeep	Official monthly divisors and observed annual whole-number entries	Monthly fractional aggregation and desertion boundary	Income Overview, checked after roster or equipment changes
Fort supply	Range and highest-fort rule	Competing official multipliers and final integer conversion	Displayed province supply

A floor observed in a resource example does not prove that income is floored at the same stage. A whole annual upkeep entry does not prove that the treasury discards monthly fractions. Whenever a result can decide a deadline, a calculator should keep three fields: the written decimal, the displayed integer, and the evidence status of the conversion between them.

Unrest is hyperbolic, not linear

Income is divided by `1 + 0.02U`, where `U` is unrest. This has two important consequences:

1. The first unrest points do substantial damage.
2. Each later unrest point removes a smaller fraction of the already reduced income.

Unrest	Multiplier	Income lost
10	0.833	16.7%
25	0.667	33.3%
50	0.500	50.0%
75	0.400	60.0%

Unrest	Multiplier	Income lost
100	0.333	66.7%
200	0.200	80.0%

Unrest 100 is more severe than the income multiplier suggests because it also stops recruitment.

Income timing

Income is hosting step 38.

Before income:

- ordinary battles and storming have resolved;
- random events and several late battles have resolved;
- buildings complete at step 35;
- pillage resolves at step 37.

After income:

- ordinary unrest alterations resolve at step 39;
- starvation resolves at step 40;
- upkeep resolves at step 41.

This timing means:

- a province captured through ordinary movement can pay its new owner that month if collection conditions are met;
- pillage can damage the same month's income;
- patrol and Order reductions at step 39 usually improve the next month's income, not the current collection;
- upkeep can use the income collected moments earlier.

Treasury discipline

The treasury must cover several different horizons:

Horizon	Typical commitments
Immediate order phase	Recruitment, buildings, PD, mercenary bids, gold-cost rituals or events
Hosting income step	Expected provincial income after conquest, trace, pillage, and unrest
Hosting upkeep step	Recurring unit and commander costs
Contingency reserve	Emergency recruitment, fort repair decisions, diplomacy, unexpected events

Planning to exactly zero before uncertain income is a risk decision. The danger is highest when:

- tax traces are exposed;
- capitals or rich forts may be besieged;
- unrest is rising;
- pillage or raiding is expected;
- mercenary contracts or events can change expenditure;
- a large sacred or cavalry force obscures the apparent upkeep calculation.

Upkeep

The manual states:

```
ordinary upkeep = gold cost / 15 per month
sacred or slave upkeep = gold cost / 30 per month
```

Most summoned units are exempt. Some exceptions carry additional upkeep.

Annual display

The detailed unit interface commonly displays annual upkeep:

```
annual upkeep = monthly upkeep x 12
```

A 30-gold ordinary unit costs 2 gold per month and displays 24 per year.

Sacred slaves

The manual says Sacred units and Slaves each pay half upkeep. A current-game discussion published on 21 December 2025, under the 6.33 release, identifies their interaction explicitly: the two reductions stack, producing a divisor of 60. The R'lyeh Slave Priest is the clean example because the current structured row carries both the Sacred and Slave tags.

```
sacred slave upkeep = gold cost / 60 per month
```

The official announcements for 6.34 through 6.36 contain no general upkeep change. The stacking rule is published here as Community-tested under 6.33; current through 6.36 by patch review. It is not wording taken from the revision-2 manual.

Mounted upkeep is component-based

A mounted card can hide more than one upkeep basis. Rider and mount are separate objects, and each component keeps its own base cost and its own Sacred or Slave status. The visible recruitment price is consequently not always enough to reconstruct upkeep.

The 6.33 observation gives a direct check:

Mounted card	Rider basis	Mount basis	Observed annual split	Total annual upkeep
Logrian Cavalry	10 ordinary	20 ordinary	8 + 16	24

The pinned 6.35 object snapshot supplies further examples of the underlying component structure:

Mounted card	Rider object	Mount object	Consequence
Mouflon Cataphract	base-cost adjustment 15, Slave	base-cost adjustment 25, not Slave	the Slave reduction applies to the rider, not automatically to the mount
Sacred Serpent Cataphract	base-cost adjustment 15, Sacred	base-cost adjustment 30, Sacred	both components receive their own Sacred reduction
Logrian Cavalry	base-cost adjustment 10, ordinary	base-cost adjustment 20, ordinary	the component total reproduces the observed 24 gold per year

These examples do not establish a universal shortcut from the displayed recruitment price. They establish the opposite: inspect both component cards when cavalry upkeep matters. Patch 6.31 also fixed mounts that could desert separately when the treasury was empty, further confirming that mount state participates in economic resolution even though that bug does not define the upkeep formula.

Added upkeep and shape changes

The Modding Manual defines `#addupkeep` as increasing the gold basis used for upkeep. It belongs to the object that carries it. Mounted objects need to be checked component by component; one combined modifier should not be applied to the whole recruitment card.

Shapechanged upkeep remains unresolved. The manuals define many shape relations and advise fixed gold costs for shapechanging Pretenders, but they do not say which form supplies the monthly upkeep basis for every temporary, voluntary, seasonal, death, or world shape. A current transformation matrix must compare the Income Overview before and after each shape class. Until then, a transformed commander's visible annual entry is the operational value. R-010 remains in progress.

Reading the annual line

The December 2025 observation also records ordinary annual values of 6 for a 7-gold unit and 13 for a 16-gold unit. Those are consistent with multiplying monthly upkeep by twelve and displaying a whole number. The sample does not distinguish every possible rounding rule, and the national treasury may retain fractional liabilities that the annual line hides. Annual display rounding must not be reused as proof of monthly treasury rounding.

The same observation gives enough cases to exclude one tempting shortcut:

Ordinary gold basis	Exact monthly formula	Exact annual equivalent	Observed annual line	What the observation proves
7	7/15	5.6	6	The annual line is not simply floored at the end
10	10/15	8.0	8	Exact integers survive unchanged
16	16/15	12.8	13	The annual line is not simply floored at the end

These cases are compatible with ordinary nearest-integer rounding and with a ceiling rule; they do not distinguish between them. Nor do they reveal whether twelve fractional monthly charges are accumulated precisely, rounded as a group, or represented through another internal unit. The annual line is a readable estimate of burden, while the treasury change remains the decisive measurement for a zero-margin budget.

Upkeep as force structure

Upkeep does more than tax army size. It decides which forces can remain permanently mobilised.

- Gold-recruited elite armies preserve battlefield quality but continually consume income.
- Summoned forces shift the burden toward gems and mage-turns.
- Sacred troops can be capital- or Holy-limited but cheaper to maintain.
- Militia-like troops may be cheap to recruit yet expensive relative to their battlefield effect.
- Commanders, scouts, priests, and logistical specialists add recurring cost without always appearing in a front-line count.

The relevant comparison is lifecycle cost:

```
lifecycle gold cost =
recruitment cost
+ expected months of upkeep
+ replacement and support cost
```

A unit that survives for thirty months can cost far more through upkeep than through recruitment.

Part IV: Resources and Recruitment

Resources are local industrial capacity

Resources represent the materials and labour needed to equip recruits. They:

- belong to a province;
- refresh each month;
- do not stockpile;
- cannot be moved through the treasury;
- are spent only by local recruitment.

Unused resources are lost opportunity, not saved wealth.

Potential and available resources

An unfortified province uses half its potential resources locally. A fort:

1. raises the host province to its full local potential;
2. draws its Administration percentage from eligible neighbouring provinces' potential resources.

Unrest then reduces availability:

```
final resources =
resources / (1 + unrest x 0.01)
```

At unrest 100, half remain, but recruitment is prohibited entirely.

Fort resource draw

The manual's restrictions are exact:

- land cannot draw from sea, nor sea from land;
- a neighbouring province with a fort does not contribute;
- an enemy province does not contribute;
- eligible shared neighbours can contribute to more than one fort.

The manual's worked example demonstrates that draw uses the neighbour's potential resources, not the half-sized pool visible in an unfortified neighbour.

Production geometry

A production fort should be evaluated by:

```
fort resource value =
full local potential
+ Administration% of each eligible adjacent potential
- expected disruption
```

Expected disruption includes:

- future adjacent forts removing donors;
- hostile raids changing ownership;
- unrest;
- land/sea boundaries;
- a roster unable to use the extra resources;
- supply or gold limits that prevent full production.

Fort spacing

Dense fort networks increase recruitment sites, Commander Points, laboratories, siege resistance, and tax anchors. They can also remove resource draw between adjacent fortified provinces.

This is not a simple argument for wide spacing. The correct spacing balances:

- mage production;
- troop production;
- resource donors;
- travel time;
- defensibility;
- supply projection;
- capital and Throne protection;
- the expected duration of the game.

Recruitment Points

Recruitment Points model the province's ability to organise ordinary troop production.

Start at 20, then add population-band contributions:

```
RP(population) =
20
+ min(pop, 5,000) / 100
+ min(max(pop - 5,000, 0), 5,000) / 200
+ min(max(pop - 10,000, 0), 10,000) / 300
+ min(max(pop - 20,000, 0), 20,000) / 400
+ max(pop - 40,000, 0) / 500
```

The fort's recruitment bonus is applied afterward. Order or Turmoil changes the result by 10% per step.

Population examples before fort and scales

Population	Calculation	Recruitment Points before rounding
0	20	20
1,000	20 + 1,000/100	30
5,000	20 + 5,000/100	70
6,000	20 + 50 + 1,000/200	75
10,000	20 + 50 + 5,000/200	95
20,000	20 + 50 + 25 + 10,000/300	128.33
40,000	prior + 20,000/400	178.33
50,000	prior + 10,000/500	198.33

The declining contribution per additional inhabitant means population has diminishing marginal effect on RP even while remaining valuable for income and supplies.

Official-versus-historical conflict

Older community pages preserve a different formula with a lower base and different population bands. Foundation Book II uses the revision-2 main manual formula. Historical formulas must not be used as proof of current Dominions 6 behaviour.

Rounding

The manual gives formulas and examples but does not fully document every rounding stage:

- population band;
- scale modifier;
- fort bonus;
- final displayed and spendable total.

Until reproduced, calculations should be treated as capacity estimates near fractional boundaries. The interface remains the final operational value.

Commander Points

Commander Points limit local commander production. The current ordinary pool is:

```
Commander Point pool = 1 base point + current fort bonus
```

Recruitment location	Base	Fort bonus	Ordinary total
No fort	1	0	1
Palisades	1	+0	1
Fortress	1	+1	2
Castle	1	+1	2
Citadel	1	+2	3
Grand Citadel	1	+2	3

The fort bonuses are official revision-2 values. The one-point unfortified base and multi-turn accumulation are stated by the current community commander reference, last updated under 6.35; no 6.36 announcement changes the system. This closes R-009 at Official plus Community-tested evidence.

The distinction between the pool and the cost is essential. The Modding Manual defines a simple commander as normally costing one point, permits explicit Recruitment Point costs, and defines `#slowrec` as doubling the Commander Points needed for that commander. A two-point commander in a one-point province is not illegal. The queue invests capacity over multiple months until the cost is met.

```
months to complete, before disruption = ceiling(commander cost / local CP per month)
```

Commander cost	1 CP location	2 CP location	3 CP location
1	1 month	1 month	1 month
2	2 months	1 month	1 month, with 1 point unused for that order

Commander cost	1 CP location	2 CP location	3 CP location
3	3 months	2 months	1 month
4	4 months	2 months	2 months

The table describes an uninterrupted single order. Queue state, a change of recruit, unrest, ownership, or loss of eligibility can alter the actual completion date.

What does not multiply Commander Points

- Fort statistics replace the previous stage; their bonuses do not stack across upgrades.
- AI difficulty bonuses apply to income, resources, ordinary Recruitment Points, and magic, but the manual explicitly excludes commander recruitment rate and Holy Points.
- `#slowrec` changes the commander's cost, not the province's pool.
- A recruitable commander supplied by a site changes roster access; the site commands do not by themselves add Commander Points.
- Unrest is a separate local reduction question retained under R-011.

Commander Points are often the real reason to build a fort. A nation may have enough gold to recruit more mages but no place capable of producing them.

Commander-turn accounting

Gold measures purchase price; Commander Points measure time on the production line. A 400-gold, four-point mage and four 100-gold, one-point commanders may consume the same gold, but they do not create the same schedule. Any comparison should record both:

```
gold per completed commander
commander-months per completed commander
```

A higher fort is most valuable when it changes a roster's calendar: two-point mages every month instead of every second month, or four-point mages every second month instead of every fourth. That throughput can outweigh the fort's direct Administration income.

Holy Points

Sacred recruitment consumes Holy Points in addition to ordinary costs. The manual ties the ordinary sacred recruitment limit to maximum dominion. Temples, national rules, Pretender design, sites, and mod commands can alter the system.

Holy Points create several strategic distinctions:

- a sacred may be affordable but unavailable;
- sacred queues can accumulate behind the cap;
- buying ordinary troops can use local resources and RP left stranded by the Holy limit;
- higher maximum dominion can be both religious resilience and production capacity;
- capital-only sacreds concentrate risk at the capital even when other forts have spare resources.

Queue mechanics and diagnosis

Recruitment orders can fail or wait for different reasons:

Symptom	Likely gate
Unit cannot be added	Insufficient treasury, ineligible location, unrest 100+, or limit reached
Unit remains queued	Resource, RP, Holy Point, or limited-recruit shortage
Commander does not appear	Commander Point shortage, eligibility, gold, or recruitment disruption
Resources remain while queue stalls	RP, Holy, commander, or unit-specific cap
RP remains while queue stalls	Resources, Holy, or local eligibility
Province captured yet recruits fought	Recruitment resolved at step 3 before movement battle
Recruits trapped inside fort	Recruitment completed before siege control changed

The queue should be read as a production plan constrained by several ledgers, not as a single purchase list.

Part V: Unrest and Coercive Economy

What unrest does

Officially, unrest:

- reduces income;
- reduces resources;
- prevents recruitment at 100 or greater;
- reduces Blood Hunting success;
- obstructs patrol detection;
- is capped at the lesser of 500 or population divided by 10.

It can rise through:

- random events;
- spies and agitators;
- Blood Hunting;
- sites;
- targeted spells;
- globals;
- pillaging;
- hostile dominion and special effects.

It can fall through:

- patrolling;
- Province Defence;
- Order;
- sites;
- events;
- other national, unit, or magical effects.

Income and resource damage

```
income multiplier = 1 / (1 + 0.02 x unrest)
resource multiplier = 1 / (1 + 0.01 x unrest)
```

Income is twice as sensitive in the denominator. At unrest 50, the province retains half its income but about two-thirds of its resources.

Recruitment shutdown

At unrest 100, no ordinary units or commanders can be recruited. This creates a production-denial objective:

- unrest attacks can neutralise a fort without breaching its walls;
- Blood Hunting can disable its own patrol and recruitment base;
- a province may still show resources while being unable to recruit;
- reducing unrest at step 39 is too late to restore step-3 recruitment that month.

The unrest cap

```
maximum unrest = min(500, population / 10)
```

A province with zero population cannot retain unrest. Population loss can reduce the numerical cap while destroying nearly every ordinary economic reason to own the province.

Patrolling

The main manual gives individual patrol strength as:

```
individual patrol strength =
(Precision + Map Move) / 20
```

Flying units use 30 in place of Map Move. Commanders are doubled. Undisciplined and Mindless units are halved.

The total search strength is reduced by half the province's unrest, capped at 100, and gains Province Defence patrol strength beginning at PD 15.

The same patrol force must often satisfy several tasks:

- lower unrest;
- protect Blood Hunters;
- discover scouts, spies, and raiders;
- remain strong enough to survive a discovery battle;
- avoid destroying too much population.

High nominal patrol strength is not the same as a safe patrol. A stealth force that is discovered may still defeat the patrol.

Community sub-formulas

Current community documentation describes a multi-stage unrest reduction process involving:

1. a baseline affected by friendly candles and PD;
2. an Order/Turmoil-dependent proportional reduction;
3. patrolling.

It also reports that unrest reduces Recruitment Points and Commander Points by one percent per point, with the Commander Point reduction rounded down. The current page states the result but does not publish a 6.36 boundary table, save, or test setup. The precise breakpoints remain queued under R-011.

That wording admits two materially different readings for a small integer pool: round down the amount lost, or round down the capacity remaining. For a one-point Commander Point pool, the first reading preserves the point until the recruitment shutdown; the second can remove it as soon as unrest rises above zero. The page does not state which intermediate is rounded and does not provide the small-pool observations needed to decide between them.

If the intended community rule is "round down the amount lost," its test predictions are:

Ordinary pool	First predicted loss	Second predicted loss	Capacity before unrest 100
1	Unrest 100	-	1
2	Unrest 50	Unrest 100	1 from unrest 50-99
3	Unrest 34	Unrest 67	1 from unrest 67-99

This is a candidate boundary table, not a promoted game rule. Its value is diagnostic: a single version-labelled observation at one of those thresholds can support or reject the interpretation far more efficiently than an anecdote from a high-unrest province.

This distinction matters most for the tiny Commander Point pool. A one-point rounding decision can change a mage from a one-month recruit into a multi-month project. Until the breakpoints are reproduced, use three tiers of certainty:

Claim	Publication state
Unrest 100 or more prohibits ordinary unit and commander recruitment	Official
Unrest reduces ordinary Recruitment Points before shutdown	Current community reference
Unrest also reduces Commander Points	Current community reference
Exact first-loss threshold for a 1-, 2-, or 3-point pool	Test pending

The recruitment screen is authoritative for orders. A written forecast near an unrest boundary should preserve a spare month rather than assuming the most favourable rounding.

Pillaging and raiding

Pillage:

- raises unrest;
- kills population;
- reduces supplies;
- gives gold and temporary food to the pillaging army;
- becomes stronger with larger, faster, and larger-sized forces;
- particularly favours barbarians and units with Fear.

The temporary supplies last one month.

A Raid combines movement with reduced-strength pillage. It requires a commander with Pillager and an army with Map Move 20 or more. Only Pillager units contribute, at half pillage strength, and the force must win any resulting battle before pillaging succeeds.

Strategic uses

Pillage and raid actions can:

- suppress income before step 38;
- raise a fort province toward recruitment shutdown;
- damage future population and supplies;
- feed an army for the current month;
- force patrols and defensive movement;
- create tax-trace breaks.

They can also destroy value that the attacker expects to conquer. The action is most coherent when denial matters more than future ownership.

Part VI: Supplies, Armies, and Logistics

Supply is a location check

Supply is not a national stock. An army consumes the supply available in its current situation.

The decisive logistical questions are:

- Where will the army be when starvation resolves?
- Which fort projects the highest supply there?
- What scales and population will remain after conquest, battle, and pillage?
- Is the army outside a fort, inside a fort, or trapped in a siege?
- Which units consume supply despite appearing small or inexpensive?

Population-based supply

```
base population supply =
first 15,000 / 30
+ population above 15,000 / 60
```

Growth or Death modifies the result first. Temperature deviation modifies it second.

Population	Base supply before scales
3,000	100
7,500	250
15,000	500
21,000	600
30,000	750

The lower marginal supply above 15,000 mirrors the declining RP value of very large populations.

Fort-based supply

The manual's stated formula is:

```
fort supply =
(Administration x 6) / (Distance + 1)
```

The maximum distance is four. Only the largest nearby fort contribution applies.

Official internal conflict

The same manual also prints a distance multiplier table of 400%, 200%, 133%, 100%, and 80% at distance zero through four. Those percentages correspond to `Administration x 4 / (Distance + 1)`, not the printed multiplier of six. Its worked example gives only 30 supply from an Administration-30 Castle at distance three, agreeing with the table but disagreeing with the formula, which produces 45.

Distance	Printed `Admin x 6` formula for Admin 30	Printed percentage table for Admin 30
0	180	120
1	90	60
2	60	about 40
3	45	30
4	36	24

A second official sentence says an Administration-50 fort contributes 150 to an adjacent province. That agrees with the multiplier-of-six formula at distance one and disagrees with the percentage table. The manual contains two internally coherent calculations, each supported by at least one example.

The current community population reference uses the multiplier-of-six formula and gives a Palisades example at distance two. It is useful corroboration but not a published controlled reproduction across all five distances. R-012 remains open.

These three representations cannot all be correct under the same definition of distance. The safe publication policy is:

- preserve the formula as the stated rule;
- describe the example conflict;
- use the in-game displayed supply for operational orders;
- reproduce every distance from zero through four in 6.36.

For forecasts, the two printed systems can be carried as a documentary interval:

```
lower printed candidate = Administration x 4 / (Distance + 1)
upper printed candidate = Administration x 6 / (Distance + 1)
```

This interval is not a claim that the executable must lie between the two. It is a compact way to expose how much of a supply plan depends on the unresolved multiplier. The disagreement is a constant one-third of the larger candidate, so an army that fits only under `x6` is not safely supplied by the documents alone. The range, the four-province limit, and the rule that only the single highest nearby fort contribution applies are not part of the conflict.

Supply usage

The main manual describes usage by physical size:

Unit	Ordinary supply use
Size 0	0
Size 1-2	0.5
Size 3	1
Size 4	2
Size 5	3
Size 6	4

Animals use half the ordinary amount. Rider and mount both consume supply. Nature magic indirectly contributes 10 supply per path level.

Special abilities, forms, national rules, and modded effects can change ordinary expectations.

Starvation selection and effects

When usage exceeds supply, the engine selects troops whose combined usage is approximately the deficit.

First selection:

- the unit becomes Starving;
- morale falls by 4;
- disease chance is 5%.

Selection while already Starving:

- disease chance rises to 50%.

Appropriate survival skill:

- 50% chance to be completely unaffected;
- a separate 50% chance to avoid disease.

When supply becomes sufficient, Starving ends. Disease does not.

Timing

Starvation resolves at step 40, after all ordinary battles and immediately before upkeep. A newly overextended army normally fights this month's battle without the new Starving condition, then carries the penalty into the next order phase.

This makes starvation a delayed logistical debt. It is easy to ignore after a victory and expensive when the next battle arrives.

Commander uncertainty

Commanders are commonly described as being fed before troops. That is a priority claim, not the same thing as categorical immunity. The main manual does not grant all commanders a general exemption, and no current controlled sample has exhausted the troop pool and shown the commander-selection boundary. Generic commander immunity remains test pending.

The wording fed first is safest read as a ranking within the eligible selection pool. It cannot support never starves: once the deficit exceeds the consumption of lower-priority eligible units, the selection process must either reach commanders, leave part of the deficit unmatched, or apply another undocumented exception. No source in the current evidence set demonstrates which branch occurs. Animals being described as fed last is the same kind of priority claim, not proof that every animal starves before any ordinary troop.

Need Not Eat is the decisive explicit tag

The official Modding Manual gives a firmer rule for individual objects: `#neednoteat` means the monster consumes no supplies and cannot starve. It also explains how to create a creature that still consumes supplies but cannot starve, proving that consumption and starvation eligibility are distinct properties.

The pinned 6.35 object snapshot reinforces that distinction:

- 985 rows carry Need Not Eat;
- 47 rows combine Need Not Eat with Appetite;
- several Undead and Demon rows do not carry the Need Not Eat field explicitly.

Object counts include helpers and non-recruitable forms, so they are not army demographics. Their value is structural: class labels such as Undead, Demon, Inanimate, or commander cannot safely substitute for the actual food and starvation fields.

Official update 6.18 adds the transformation boundary: changing into a non-eating entity removes the Starving condition. The correction does not document the reverse direction, temporary battle shapes, or a universal commander-priority rule. R-013 remains in progress.

Official update 6.35 repaired Supply Usage failing to refresh when magic items were changed. The supply formula did not change, but the correction affects how evidence should be gathered. Screenshots or observations from earlier versions may show a stale usage total after equipment changes. Under the 6.36 baseline, recheck the current Supply Usage after equipping or removing any item that affects size, appetite, supply production, a mount, or a form. The corrected display is the intended operational total, although it still does not prove selection priority.

Logistics audit for unusual units

For any expensive commander, mount, transformed unit, or summoned army, inspect in this order:

1. current Supply Usage;
2. Need Not Eat or Appetite on every component;
3. rider and mount separately;
4. current Starving and Disease conditions;
5. survival skill in the destination terrain;
6. whether a shape change occurred before starvation resolution;
7. the displayed fort and population supply in the destination.

This avoids the two most common category errors: assuming that a unit which consumes supply must be able to starve, and assuming that a unit which cannot starve contributes no supply burden.

Siege supply

A besieged fort uses Supply Storage divided by the number of consecutive siege turns:

```
available interior supply =
storage / siege turn number
```

Example for 300 storage:

Siege turn	Interior supply
1	300
2	150
3	100
4	75
5	60
10	30

This is different from Administration-based supply projection. Storage sustains defenders inside the fort; Administration helps the surrounding province network.

Siege logistics as a clock

Even an unbreached wall can become untenable through:

- falling interior supplies;
- cumulative starvation;
- disease;
- upkeep and lost exterior income;
- inability to recruit or move normally;
- the approach of a storm force.

The fort's wall clock and supply clock should be tracked separately.

Part VII: Infrastructure

Forts, temples, and laboratories

Each building converts a province in a different dimension.

Building	Converts the province into
Fort	A protected recruitment, resource, tax, and logistics node
Temple	A dominion-production and preaching node
Laboratory	A research, ritual, forging, gem, item, and site-access node

The standard temple and laboratory each cost 600 gold. Fort stages have separate costs and times. Nations and terrain can alter all of these.

Construction timing

Buildings complete at hosting step 35.

This is later than:

- research at step 2;
- recruitment at step 3;

- forging at step 5;
- preaching and Throne claims at steps 6-8;
- rituals at step 10;
- site searching at step 14;
- ordinary battles and storming at steps 26-27.

This gives the following results:

- a new lab cannot support research, forging, or ritual casting that month;
- a new temple cannot improve that month's ordinary preaching;
- a new fort cannot expand this month's recruitment or protect against battles already fought;
- infrastructure is operational from the following order phase.

Construction and demolition

Officially:

- any commander can construct a fort;
- a sacred commander is required for a temple;
- a mage is required for a laboratory;
- any commander can demolish a fort or laboratory;
- demolition takes one month;
- temples cannot be demolished by order;
- enemy temples are destroyed automatically upon conquest;
- a fort cannot be demolished while under siege.

The construction order itself consumes the commander's month. The economic cost includes both gold and commander-time.

Standard fort progression

Fort	Stage cost	Stage time	Admin	Commander Points	Recruitment bonus	Storage	Wall
Palisades	1,000	5	15	+0	+50%	150	200
Fortress	600	3	30	+1	+75%	750	500
Castle	600	3	45	+1	+100%	2,500	1,000
Citadel	600	3	60	+2	+125%	7,500	1,500
Grand Citadel	1,000	5	70	+2	+150%	10,000	2,000

Statistics replace the previous stage rather than adding to it.

The standard maximum is:

- Early Age: Fortress;
- Middle Age: Castle;
- Late Age: Citadel.

Primitive and advanced national access can differ. Masons can construct one level above the ordinary national limit. A Grand Citadel requires Citadel access and a Mason.

Fort valuation

A fort can create:

1. full local resource use;
2. adjacent resource draw;
3. local income through Administration;
4. Recruitment Point bonus;
5. Commander Point bonus;
6. regional supply;
7. siege storage;
8. wall integrity and protected interior;
9. national recruitment access;
10. a tax-trace anchor;
11. a secure laboratory or temple location;
12. a movement and reinforcement node.

No single payback formula captures all twelve.

Fort question set

Before construction:

- Which units and commanders become recruitable?
- Which local pool will bind after the fort is complete?
- How many adjacent potential resources are eligible?
- Does another planned fort remove a major donor?
- What tax region will this fort anchor?
- What routes and provinces fall within supply range?
- How many turns until the first new mage or army leaves?
- Can the province be held during construction?
- Is the builder's command-turn scarce?
- What military force is delayed by the gold payment?

Laboratories

Official functions:

- permit Research;
- permit ritual casting;
- permit access to the national pool of gems, slaves, and items;
- serve as gem collection points;
- enable site functions that require a lab.

Laboratories are strategic concentration points. Losing one can strand mages away from the national pool even when the nation still owns gems elsewhere.

Laboratory risk

A lab attracts:

- researchers;
- gems and slaves;
- forged items;
- ritual casters;

- valuable site recruits.

The 600-gold structure can protect assets worth far more than its price. Defence should be based on the value concentrated there, not only the cost of replacing the laboratory.

Temples

Official functions:

- ordinary dominion spread for most nations;
- preaching bonus;
- Blood Sacrifice access where the nation allows it;
- religious and national mechanics tied to temple count or location.

Only one temple can exist in a province. Capture destroys an enemy temple automatically.

Temples belong fully to the dominion volume, but their economic effect begins here:

- they cost gold and sacred commander-time;
- maximum dominion and Holy Points can affect sacred throughput;
- temple loss can weaken recruitment, candles, preaching, and special national systems;
- temples in exposed provinces can be destroyed without a separate demolition delay.

Part VIII: Siege and Fort Control

Province exterior and fort interior

A besieged province can have divided control:

- the besieger controls the exterior;
- the defender retains the fort interior;
- armies, laboratories, temples, and recruitment must be interpreted by location and ownership rules rather than a single flag.

This partial ownership affects:

- income and recruitment;
- movement and retreat;
- assassination and stealth;
- supply;
- siege contribution;
- the eventual reclaim-province step.

Reducing walls

Official formulas:

```
reduction strength = Strength squared
repair strength = Strength squared / 2
```

Flying doubles both contributions.

Repair penalties:

- Mindless: one-eighth of calculated value;

- Animal: half;
- Undisciplined: half.

Only forces whose commanders remain on Maintain Siege contribute.

Squaring rewards strength

Strength-squared means one stronger unit can contribute more than several weaker units with the same total linear Strength.

Strength	Reduction contribution	Base repair contribution
5	25	12.5
10	100	50
15	225	112.5
20	400	200
30	900	450

Flying doubles the result. Special siege abilities and modded values can further alter practical contribution.

Wall resolution

Each turn:

- total reduction is compared with total repair;
- the difference damages or repairs wall integrity;
- repair cannot exceed original wall integrity;
- an unbesieged damaged fort fully restores.

The defender receives exact wall information. The attacker normally receives a descriptive estimate, creating an information problem around the storm date.

Storm timing

A fort can be stormed only after wall integrity reaches zero and the next order phase presents the Storm Castle order.

Storming resolves at step 27, after movement battles at step 26. This has several immediate consequences:

1. a relieving army may arrive;
2. the besiegers fight it first;
3. surviving storm commanders and assigned troops attack the fort;
4. a storm commander killed before the gate battle contributes no troops to the storm.

Maintain Siege and Storm Castle are commander orders. A commander performing another action does not supply siege strength merely because it remains in the province.

Fort defenders

Forts supply Castle Guards and Wall Defenders:

- their number depends on fort level;

- they replenish for each fight like PD;
- they add repair strength;
- Wall Defenders have unlimited ammunition, extra range, and wall protection;
- they are fort defence, not the same system as Province Defence.

The shared word "defence" is a recurring source of confusion:

Term	Meaning
Province Defence	Gold-purchased local force attached to province control
Wall integrity or fort Defence	Damage required before storming
Castle Guards and Wall Defenders	Fort-generated troops in a storm battle
Unit Defence skill	Tactical chance to avoid melee attacks

Part IX: Province Defence

Cost curve

The first point is free. Every later point costs its new level.

```
total cost to PD n =
2 + 3 + ... + n
= n(n + 1)/2 - 1
```

PD	Total cost	Additional cost from prior listed row
1	0	-
5	14	14
6	20	6
10	54	34
15	119	65
20	209	90
25	324	115
30	464	140
40	819	355
50	1,274	455
100	5,049	3,775

The convex curve means "another ten PD" is not a consistent investment. Going from 1 to 10 costs 54; going from 40 to 50 costs 455.

What PD provides

Officially:

- level 1 provides a commander and troops;
- further levels add troops;
- level 20 adds new commander and troop types;

- additional benefits occur at 10, 15, and 20;
- every full 10 points reduces unrest by 1 per turn;
- stealth detection begins at 15;
- patrol strength is `PD - 14` from that point;
- maximum PD is 100;
- no upkeep is charged;
- the force fully returns after battle if the province is retained.

The actual roster is national. One nation's PD may deter a raider that walks through another nation's equal investment.

Population support and permanence

Each PD point requires 10 population. Unsupported PD is reduced at hosting step 61.

PD cannot be voluntarily lowered. It is reduced by:

- insufficient population;
- capture, which wipes it;
- disciple-game relinquishment, which removes 25%;
- special exceptions for some populationless nations.

Because the spending is irreversible while control is retained, excessive PD can trap gold in the wrong place after a border moves.

Roles of PD

Raid tax

Low or moderate PD forces an attacker to bring a credible commander and force rather than a single opportunist.

Alarm and information

A battle report reveals attacker composition, script, and direction. Even a losing PD force can improve the next decision.

Unrest control

Every ten points creates recurring unrest reduction, though buying PD solely for this purpose must be compared with a mobile patrol.

Stealth detection

From 15 onward PD contributes patrol strength. Detection is not capture; the revealed stealth force may still win.

Battle support

PD can combine with a local army, fort defenders, terrain, and battle magic. Its expendability can buy time for mages whose spells decide the fight.

Why PD is not an army

PD:

- cannot move;
- cannot choose a different strategic target;
- cannot retreat into a future offensive;
- may have poor leadership, morale, equipment, or formation;
- scales in gold cost faster than it scales in quality;
- disappears on capture.

High PD can still be correct at a throne, capital approach, blood centre, or mage concentration. The decision must price the attack it is intended to defeat.

Community thresholds

Some guides recommend values such as 6 or 11 to prevent particular event outcomes or deter generic raiders. Such numbers are rules of thumb, not universal mechanics. Event pools, nation, mods, map settings, and attacker design can change the result.

Part X: Sites, Gems, and Magical Capital

Site frequency and terrain

The main manual states that sites are more common in terrain such as:

- forests;
- wastes;
- deep seas;
- mountains and unusual cave terrain.

They are less common in plains and farmlands.

This is a probability, not a guarantee. Search planning should combine:

- terrain;
- path availability;
- prior searches;
- national site frequency;
- opportunity cost of the mage-turn;
- value of remote search spells;
- safety of the searching mage.

Search difficulty

Hidden sites have difficulty 1 through 4. A mage manually searching a path finds sites in that path up to the mage's level. Path 4 is the highest ordinary requirement.

Examples:

- N1 finds difficulty-1 Nature sites.

- N3 finds difficulty 1-3 Nature sites.
- N4 finds every Nature site detectable by ordinary path search.
- An N3 mage says nothing about Fire, Death, or Glamour sites.

Remote path-search rituals reveal all sites of their path. Acashic Knowledge reveals all paths.

Site benefits and harms

Sites may provide:

- monthly gems;
- gold;
- resources or supplies;
- units and commanders;
- laboratories, temples, forts, or discounts;
- rituals or enter-site orders;
- path bonuses;
- scale or dominion effects;
- unrest, disease, population loss, or other harms.

A harmful undiscovered site can still operate. Discovery explains a problem; it does not necessarily create it.

Ownership and national recruitment

A captured site that recruits another nation's national unit does not normally grant that recruit to the conqueror. The conqueror can still collect the site's gem income where applicable.

Some sites require a laboratory before recruitment or another function becomes available.

Gem income and mage-turn economy

Gems accumulate nationally and can be converted into:

- rituals;
- summons;
- forged items;
- empowerment;
- battle magic;
- global enchantments;
- trades and diplomacy.

The site-search decision has an expected-value structure:

```
expected search value =
probability of discovery
x expected monthly and strategic value
x expected remaining turns
- mage-turn cost
- travel and risk
```

The formula is not intended to assign fake precision. It identifies the relevant terms. A single rare site can dominate the average, and information about a searched path has future value even when nothing is found.

Search records

Every serious game benefits from recording:

- province;
- terrain;
- path searched;
- manual or remote method;
- path level;
- discovered sites;
- remaining unsearched paths;
- laboratory requirement;
- hostile or passive effects.

Without a record, mages repeat searches or leave valuable paths untouched.

Part XI: Blood Economy

Blood slaves are produced, not passively collected

Blood magic substitutes an active extraction system for ordinary gem-site income. Blood Hunting consumes a commander order and damages the province through unrest and possible population loss or attacks.

The economic chain is:

```
blood mage-turns
+ suitable population
+ patrol strength
+ dominion security
-> blood slaves
-> forging, rituals, summons, battle magic, and sacrifice
```

Official hunting checks

The main manual gives:

```
Blood check success =
10% + 30% x Blood level

population check success =
population / 75 percent

unrest failure chance =
unrest / 4 percent
```

All three must succeed.

If they do:

```
slaves = d6 + Blood level
unrest gained = d(slaves x 3 + 4)
```

If any fails:

```
slaves = 0
unrest gained = d6 - 1
```

At 7,500 population, the population check reaches a nominal 100%. At Blood 3, the Blood check reaches a nominal 100%. Existing unrest can still cause failure.

Site frequency changes average yield by 0.5 slaves for every five percentage points away from 50%.

Dominion and retaliation

Commoners may attack Blood Hunters. Strong friendly dominion makes the sacrifice appear religiously legitimate; the manual states that dominion 10 leaves almost no resistance.

The risk extends beyond lost slaves:

- the hunter can be injured or killed;
- bodyguards consume gold, supply, and patrol capacity;
- a hidden enemy can exploit the concentration;
- hostile dominion can make a previously safe centre unstable.

The blood-province cycle

A functioning centre balances:

1. hunters create slaves and unrest;
2. patrols remove unrest and detect hostile infiltrators;
3. population and income absorb the damage;
4. labs provide pool access and ritual logistics;
5. forts or armies protect the investment;
6. replacement hunters and patrollers sustain throughput.

If patrol strength is insufficient, unrest reduces success, income, resources, and eventually recruitment. Adding more hunters can then reduce total output.

Rule of thumb versus rule

Community guides often estimate that roughly 25 patrol strength supports each Blood-3-equivalent hunter under ordinary conditions. This is a planning heuristic, not an official fixed ratio. Patrol efficiency, population loss, unrest, dominion, site frequency, hunter abilities, and national mechanics change the result.

Measuring the blood economy

Useful records:

Measure	Purpose
Slaves per hunter-turn	Compares extraction efficiency
Unrest before and after hosting	Reveals patrol shortfall
Population trend	Detects hidden long-term collapse
Lost research per month	Prices mage-turn diversion
Patrol gold and upkeep	Prices support force
Hunter and lab losses	Prices security failures
Slaves converted to effects	Distinguishes stockpiling from power

The goal is not the largest slave count. It is the most decisive magical output produced without collapsing the rest of the state.

Part XII: Economic Timing Through Hosting

The state-economy chain

The most important monthly sequence is:

Step	Event	Economic reading
3	Recruitment	Existing infrastructure and local capacity create units first.
18	Blood Hunting	Slaves and hunting unrest are generated early.
24-27	Movement, battles, storming	Control and siege state change.
29-33	Events and later battles	Income provinces can still be altered.
35	Construction	New buildings become part of the end-state, too late for earlier production.
37	Pillage	Immediate population, unrest, and supply damage occurs.
38	Income	Collection uses the post-conquest, post-pillage state and tax trace.
39	Unrest changes	Patrolling, Order, and related adjustments primarily prepare next month.
40	Starvation	Armies acquire logistical penalties after battle.
41	Upkeep	Recurring military costs are charged after income.
42-44	Dominion and site effects	Longer-term provincial state changes arrive.
53-54	Reclaim and conscription	Late ownership correction and automatic PD prepare the next turn.
61	Unsupported PD reduction	Population-depleted provinces lose excess PD at the end.

Worked timing cases

Emergency recruitment under attack

- Units are queued during the order phase.
- Recruitment resolves at step 3.
- An enemy army arrives and fights at step 26.
- The new units defend.
- They had no opportunity to receive a new strategic order.

New laboratory under invasion

- A mage is ordered to build a lab.
- Research, forging, rituals, and battles all occur before step 35.
- The lab completes only if the builder and province still satisfy the construction result.
- Its practical magical use begins next order phase.

Pillage before collection

- A province changes hands at step 26.
- The winner pillages at step 37 if the relevant order succeeds.
- Pillage damage occurs before income at step 38.
- The new owner may collect less than the pre-battle province panel suggested.

Patrol after income

- A Blood Hunt at step 18 raises unrest.
- Income is collected at step 38.
- Patrol and ordinary unrest alterations occur at step 39.
- The province may pay reduced income this month even if the patrol restores order moments later.

Siege relief before storm

- The wall was already at zero when orders were written.
- A relief army moves and battles at step 26.
- Surviving storm commanders attack at step 27.
- Defeating or killing them in the relief battle prevents or weakens the storm.

Part XIII: Strategic Frameworks

Expansion income versus expansion burden

A conquered province can provide:

- income;
- resources;
- Recruitment Points;
- supplies;
- independents;
- sites;
- tax trace;
- movement position.

It also creates:

- a border to defend;
- unrest to manage;
- commander travel;
- potential tax isolation;
- a target for raids;
- a possible need for PD, patrol, lab, temple, or fort.

The correct expansion measure is not provinces per turn alone. It is useful, connected, defensible economic mass acquired per loss and per commander-turn.

Infrastructure tempo

Infrastructure has a delay chain:

```
decide and pay
-> construction months
-> completion at step 35
-> next order phase
-> first enabled recruitment or magical order
-> travel to the war
```

A fort whose first mage reaches the front in twelve months belongs to a different strategic horizon than emergency troops recruited now.

Fort-now test

Build when most of the following are true:

- the commander or troop roster is valuable;
- capacity will be used continuously;
- the location anchors tax or supply;
- the province can be defended through construction;
- the expected game horizon allows military conversion;
- no nearer timing attack requires the gold;
- resource geometry is favourable;
- the nation needs another mage or commander stream.

Delay when:

- the war is decided before completion;
- the site cannot be held;
- the desired roster remains gold-limited elsewhere;
- adjacent forts remove most resource gain;
- the builder or gold has a more urgent conversion.

Mage-turn accounting

A mage can usually do one major strategic job per month:

- research;
- search;
- forge;
- cast a ritual;
- Blood Hunt;
- build a lab;
- move;
- participate in battle;
- perform a special order.

The cost of a ritual is not limited to gems. It also includes:

```
ritual cost =
gems
+ caster-turn
+ laboratory and position requirements
+ risk
+ research or other work displaced
```

This accounting becomes decisive for small mage corps and Blood nations.

Static and mobile gold

Gold can become:

- static power: PD, forts, temples, labs;
- mobile power: troops, commanders, mercenaries;
- productive power: mages, researchers, infrastructure;
- religious power: temples, priests, sacred throughput;
- insurance: treasury reserve.

An efficient state carries a deliberate mix. Too much static power loses the field. Too much mobile power can lack replacement, research, and safe logistics. Too much productive power can die before repayment.

Denial and recovery

Economic warfare targets conversion rather than ownership alone.

High-value actions include:

- cutting a tax trace;
- besieging a mage fort;
- raising unrest to 100;
- killing the patrols of a blood centre;
- taking a lab with stored items or positioned casters;
- forcing an army into poor supply;
- damaging population that supports PD and RP;
- building an adjacent fort that changes resource geometry;
- repeatedly raiding the same reconstruction corridor.

Recovery priorities:

1. restore tax trace and province control;
2. prevent recruitment shutdown;
3. preserve or rebuild irreplaceable mage production;
4. feed armies and halt disease;
5. reconnect labs and gem access;
6. replace mobile defence before rebuilding luxury infrastructure.

Part XIV: New-Player Operational Guide

First-turn provincial reading

For each owned province:

1. Read population, income, resources, supplies, unrest, terrain, and PD.
2. Identify whether income has a valid fort trace.
3. Check the recruit roster before buying infrastructure.
4. Note site searches already completed.
5. Compare the province's best role with its exposed position.

Recruitment checklist

- Is the unit recruitable here?
- Is gold available now?
- Are resources sufficient?
- Are Recruitment Points sufficient?
- Is a commander using the local Commander Point?
- Is the unit sacred or limited?
- Will unrest reach or remain at 100?
- Is the army's future supply sufficient?
- Is there leadership for the recruited troop type?
- Does the queue create a usable army package?

Army logistics checklist

- Current Supply Usage.
- Destination population and scales.
- Highest nearby fort contribution.
- Expected pillage or ownership change.
- Survival skills.
- Mounted and large-unit consumption.
- Existing Starving or disease conditions.
- Siege interior versus exterior.
- Retreat province supply.

Building checklist

- Correct constructor type.
- Gold after recruitment and reserve.
- Completion date.
- Step-35 timing.
- Province security.
- Roster or magical function unlocked.
- Tax, supply, and resource geometry.
- Commander-turn cost.

End-of-host checklist

- Income and upkeep totals.
- Queued recruits.
- New unrest.
- Tax-trace breaks.
- Starving and diseased units.
- Fort wall and siege duration.
- New sites and lab requirements.
- Population losses.
- PD reductions.
- Empty or overloaded recruitment centres.

Part XV: Expert Diagnostics

Warning indicators

Indicator	Likely problem
Large treasury, weak army	Local capacity, commander throughput, logistics, or delayed conversion
Resources unused every month	RP, gold, Holy limit, or unsuitable roster
RP unused every month	Resources, sacred cap, or recruit-mix problem
Mages available but research stagnant	Movement, searching, forging, hunting, combat, or lab denial
Income drops without province loss	Tax trace, unrest, scales, dominion, event, or Administration change
Blood output falls as hunters increase	Unrest and patrol saturation
Armies win then decay	Supply debt and disease
Fort never produces enough	Wrong roster, resource geometry, gold shortage, Commander Points, exposure
High PD still loses	National roster, magic, morale, raider design, or convex overinvestment
Siege stalls unexpectedly	Commanders left Maintain Siege, defender repair, strength composition, relief activity

Ratios worth recording

No ratio is universal, but consistent tracking reveals a nation's own failure modes.

- upkeep as a percentage of gross income;
- unspent resources and RP at major forts;
- commander slots used per turn;
- research per mage-turn;
- gems converted per month;
- slave yield per hunter-turn;
- unrest change per blood centre;
- turns from fort payment to first useful output;
- gold lost to disconnected tax regions;
- mobile army value versus static PD spending;
- siege reduction per supplied unit.

Decision ledger

For major investments, record:

Field	Example question
Goal	What military or magical capability is being created?
Cost	Gold, gems, mage-turns, commander-turns, upkeep
Bottleneck	Which local or national pool limits output?
Completion	When does the first useful effect occur?

Field	Example question
Risk	What raid, siege, assassination, or diplomacy can interrupt it?
Alternative	What is the best use of the same resources?
Exit	Can the investment be repurposed if the front changes?

This turns economic planning into falsifiable reasoning rather than habit.

Part XVI: Modded Economy

Read the global layer once

Book IX, Section 7 is the authoritative table for DE's six global commands. It records the exact source values, their vanilla defaults, and the result under the frozen load order. The Turn and Economy Quick Reference repeats only the final values because they are needed during play.

The economic consequence is straightforward. DE changes the income weight of Order/Turmoil, Productivity/Sloth, and Growth/Death; changes monthly population movement under Growth and Death; and strengthens the event-frequency effect of Fortune and Misfortune. Divinitus does not later redefine those globals.

Local changes still decide the real economy

The global layer is only the starting point. The two mods also alter unit costs and upkeep, recruitment limits, sites, event income, supplies, forts, temples, research output, gem flow, and national mechanics. Those changes belong to the final object or nation, not to a universal economy formula.

Accordingly, a modded economic claim needs a ruleset label and an object boundary. "Growth is worth more under DE" is a global statement. "This fort produces more useful mages" requires the final national roster, costs, site access, and any Divinitus event layer. Book IX and the machine-readable catalogue provide that source record; nation dossiers provide the strategic application.

Part XVII: Contradictions and Controlled Tests

Known documentary conflicts

Growth and Death income

- Main manual revision 2: 1% income per step.
- Modding Manual 6.34: default `#deathincome 2`.
- Official announcements through 6.36: no later change to the general default.

Publication state: resolved for unmodded 6.36 at 2% per step. The newer explicit official default supersedes the older table entry. DE 2.16 independently pins the same income value.

Order and Turmoil resources

- Main manual revision 2: 2% resources per step.
- Official announcements through 6.36: no general change to this scale effect.
- Unsourced or historical three-percent tables do not override the official value.

Publication state: resolved for the unmodded 6.36 publication baseline at 2% per step. Integer rounding remains part of the separate R-008 question.

Fort supply distance

- Main-manual formula: `(Administration x 6)/(Distance + 1)`.
- Printed multiplier table: 400%, 200%, 133%, 100%, 80%, equivalent to a multiplier of four.
- Worked example: Administration 30, described as three provinces away, adds 30 and agrees with the table.
- Adjacent example: Administration 50 adds 150 and agrees with the multiplier-of-six formula.

Publication state: internally inconsistent. The current community reference follows the multiplier-of-six formula, but a versioned reproduction at distances zero through four is still required.

Recruitment Points

- Revision-2 main manual: base 20 and five listed bands.
- Older community reference: different base and bands.

Publication state: revision-2 formula wins; verify rounding only.

PD 15 patrol strength wording

The manual says detection starts at 15 and that each point "above 15" adds one patrol strength, then gives PD 25 as patrol strength 11. The example corresponds to `PD - 14`, counting level 15 as one.

Publication state: use the numerical example and formula `PD - 14`; note wording discrepancy.

Controlled-test programme

Test E1: scale-income matrix

Create identical provinces under every Order/Turmoil, Productivity/Sloth, temperature, and Growth/Death value. Record:

- population;
- fort Administration;
- unrest;
- displayed income;
- treasury change;
- rounding.

Run unmodded and the frozen combined mod set.

Test E2: resource matrix

Use a fixed terrain and resource value. Vary:

- Order/Turmoil;
- Productivity/Sloth;

- unrest;
- fort stage;
- adjacent fort;
- shared resource donor;
- enemy ownership;
- land/sea boundary.

Record potential, displayed, spendable, and queue behaviour.

Test E3: Recruitment Point boundaries

Test population immediately below, at, and above:

- 5,000;
- 10,000;
- 20,000;
- 40,000.

Apply every fort bonus and Order/Turmoil step. Determine each rounding stage.

Test E4: Commander and Holy Points

The ordinary base and fort ladder are now closed. The remaining test should isolate exceptional interaction. Record unfortified and each standard fort stage, then vary:

- one-, two-, three-, and four-point commanders;
- `#slowrec` and an explicit `#rpcost` test object;
- site recruitment without changing the fort;
- unrest immediately around every visible Commander Point loss;
- sacred queues;
- temple and maximum-dominion changes.

The baseline prediction is one point plus the current fort bonus. AI difficulty must not alter Commander Points or Holy Points.

Test E5: upkeep

Use units with:

- ordinary gold recruitment;
- Sacred;
- Slave;
- Sacred and Slave;
- rider and mount;
- summons;
- `#addupkeep`.

Compare the detailed annual display, monthly treasury charge, and base object costs. The 6.33 published observation already predicts divisor 60 for Sacred Slaves and separate rider/mount bases. Concentrate the new test on:

- monthly fractional aggregation;
- a Slave rider with an ordinary mount;
- a Sacred rider with an ordinary mount;
- a pair where both components are Sacred;
- voluntary, battle-only, seasonal, and death transformations;

- whether `#addupkeep` follows the active or persistent form.

Test E6: supply distance

Place an Administration-known fort at each distance zero through four from a fixed province. Remove population supply where possible. Record displayed and consumed supply. Repeat with two forts in range.

Test E7: starvation

Test:

- troops and commanders;
- survival skills;
- animals;
- mounts;
- Need Not Eat with zero usage;
- Need Not Eat combined with Appetite or negative supply production;
- transformation into a non-eating form and back;
- existing Starving;
- siege interior;
- restoration of supply.

Record selection priority, Supply Usage, Starving, morale, disease, and recovery. Separate "fed first" from "cannot be selected."

Test E8: unrest resolution

Vary:

- candles;
- Order/Turmoil;
- PD;
- patrol strength;
- population;
- Blood Hunters.

Record income, resources, RP, Commander Points, recruitment eligibility, and end-turn unrest.

For Commander Points, test every unrest integer around the first and second visible loss from ordinary pools of one, two, and three. The purpose is to distinguish rounding of the reduction from rounding of the remaining capacity.

Test E9: construction timing

Complete a lab, temple, and fort during threatened turns. Verify:

- research;
- ritual and forging access;
- preaching;
- recruitment;
- fort protection;
- tax trace and Administration income;
- demolition edge cases.

Test E10: siege contribution

Vary Strength, Flying, Mindless, Animal, Undisciplined, siege abilities, and commander orders. Record exact wall changes from both sides.

Test record format

Field	Required entry
Test ID	Stable identifier such as E6-03
Game version	Exact patch
Ruleset	Unmodded or exact mod list and order
Map and province	Reproducible setup
Starting state	Population, scales, unrest, buildings, units
Orders	Every relevant order
Prediction	Formula and expected result
Observation	Interface, message, treasury, battle, or wall result
Repetitions	Count and variation
Conclusion	Supported, contradicted, or unresolved
Artifacts	Save, turn file, screenshot, source diff

Part XVIII: Essays

Essay I: The Economics of Forts and Mages

A fort is often evaluated as if it were a bank: pay gold now, receive additional income later, and ask how many turns are needed to break even. That calculation is useful only as a lower bound. A Dominions fort is simultaneously an industrial concentrator, recruitment licence, tax office, supply depot, laboratory shelter, siege obstacle, and movement node.

Its most valuable output is frequently a commander slot. A nation whose power depends on mages does not become stronger merely because the treasury grows. Gold must pass through a fort's Commander Points and national roster before it becomes research or battlefield magic. If the existing forts already consume every commander slot, the marginal value of another fort can exceed its Administration income by an order of magnitude.

The opposite error is to treat every possible mage fort as mandatory. A fort begun during an immediate war may not produce its first useful mage until after the decisive campaign. Construction takes months, resolves late in hosting, and then begins a sequence of recruitment and travel. The gold and builder are absent from the present front throughout that delay.

The correct question is not whether forts are economically efficient in the abstract. It is whether this fort converts current resources into the capability needed at the time and place it will matter. A safe high-resource province with valuable mages, strong tax geometry, and central supply position may justify investment without a short cash payback. An exposed province with redundant recruits and poor donors may not justify even a superficially attractive income bonus.

Fort networks also shape one another. Adjacent fortified provinces stop donating resources to each other, while a shared unfortified donor can feed both. Dense forts provide more mage streams and protection but may reduce the resource concentration required for elite troops. The best geometry is national: mage-heavy nations often favour more production centres than resource-hungry troop nations can fully equip.

A fort is a promise about future conversion. Its value depends on whether the nation can keep that promise.

Essay II: Population Is Strategic Capital

Population looks passive. It sits in a province and produces a little gold each month, but it also supports income, Recruitment Points, supplies, and PD. Damaging it can strike the treasury, troop throughput, army logistics, and static defence at the same time.

This makes population loss qualitatively different from an ordinary expense. Gold spent can be earned again from an intact economy. Population destroyed by pillage, patrolling, Death, Blood Hunting, or hostile effects reduces the machinery that would have produced future gold and capacity.

The value is nevertheless not uniform. The first population bands contribute more Recruitment Points and supplies per inhabitant than later bands. A small province can lose its ability to support meaningful PD quickly, while a huge farm province may retain considerable capacity after the same absolute loss. Terrain, dominion stability, game length, and national mechanics all change the horizon.

Blood magic demonstrates the tension most clearly. A Blood nation converts population and mage-turns into slaves, then converts slaves into effects that may dwarf the foregone income. Refusing all population damage would misunderstand the nation's power. Ignoring the damage would eventually shut down recruitment and tax collection. Mastery lies in choosing which provinces become extraction zones, supporting them with patrols, and spending the slaves quickly enough that the sacrifice becomes strategic advantage.

Population is capital with a location and a lifespan. It is most valuable when connected, protected, and given enough time to grow. It is expendable only when the return arrives before the loss matters.

Essay III: The Hidden Price of Static Defence

Province Defence is attractive because it has no upkeep, restores after successful battles, and requires no commander management. Those strengths conceal a convex cost curve and absolute immobility.

The first points are cheap. They tax careless raids, generate reports, and can combine with a real army. Later points become dramatically more expensive while remaining tied to one province. The gold that raises PD from 40 to 50 could fund several commanders, a laboratory, or a significant mobile force. Once purchased, PD cannot voluntarily be recovered or moved.

This does not make high PD irrational. A capital approach, Throne, blood centre, or mage fort can have enough concentrated value that static defence is exactly correct. National PD rosters also vary wildly. Battlefield magic can make disposable bodies valuable, and the need to force an attacker into a full army can protect an entire region.

The mistake is to value PD by the number alone. Its return is the attack it prevents, delays, reveals, or defeats. If no plausible enemy force is affected, the investment is decorative. If the attacker must reveal a major army, consume gems, or delay a campaign, even losing PD may have succeeded.

Static defence buys local certainty. Mobile armies buy choices. A healthy state knows which one the province requires.

Essay IV: Logistics After Victory

The most dangerous logistical moment often comes after a successful battle. The army has moved into hostile terrain, the province may be pillaged or depopulated, the fort may still belong to the enemy, and the new supply state is easy to overlook because the battle report is positive.

Starvation resolves after battle. That timing allows an army to win first and acquire its -4 morale penalty afterward. The next turn begins with a force that looks victorious but may already carry Starving, disease risk, damaged units, and an uncertain retreat path. If the next battle follows immediately, the logistical debt becomes tactical collapse.

Fort supply projection and siege storage are separate. A nearby high-Administration fort can sustain provinces outside its walls, but a besieged garrison consumes a declining fraction of interior storage. A large relieving army may also worsen local supply even while saving the fort.

Operational planning needs to extend one turn beyond contact. Before an attack, calculate the destination's supply under the state expected after conquest, not the state currently shown. Include temperature, Growth or Death, population damage, mounts, animals, large units, and the possibility that the enemy fort remains.

Winning the battle secures a position. Supplying the survivors converts it into a campaign.

Essay V: Unrest as Administrative Warfare

Unrest is often treated as a local nuisance to be patrolled away. Its actual effect is to attack the conversion machinery of a province.

The income formula loses one-third of output by unrest 25 and half by unrest 50. Resources decline more slowly, but at unrest 100 recruitment stops completely. Blood Hunting becomes less reliable, patrolling becomes harder, and community evidence suggests local recruitment capacities may also fall continuously.

Because unrest alteration normally occurs after income, restoration has a one-month lag. A province can be pacified at step 39 only after paying reduced income at step 38. Reaching recruitment shutdown is worse: step-39 recovery cannot retroactively restore recruitment that already failed at step 3.

This makes unrest a weapon against fortified production. Walls do not prevent spies, sites, spells, hunting mistakes, or some globals from degrading the province. A high-value fort at 100 unrest can retain its physical infrastructure while losing the reason it was built.

Administratively resilient nations do more than patrol after the damage. They keep baseline unrest low, maintain spare patrol capacity, protect Blood centres, identify hostile infiltrators, and avoid placing every economic function in the same vulnerable province.

Essay VI: Conversion, Not Accumulation

A full treasury and gem stockpile create options, but they do not fight. A large research total creates spell access, but access does not script a mage or supply the gems. A broad empire creates potential income, but disconnected provinces may collect nothing. Dominions rewards stockpiling only when a later conversion justifies the delay.

Every stored resource should have a plausible route:

- gold to commander and troop production;
- gems to a research breakpoint, item, ritual, or battlefield package;
- blood slaves to a defined Blood power;
- population and safe time to infrastructure;
- information to a movement, diplomacy, or scripting decision.

Premature conversion is also dangerous. Troops create upkeep, gems carried into battle can be lost, and a fort begun too early can remove the army needed to defend it. The central skill is timing: retain flexibility until the strategic question is clear, then convert fast enough to decide it.

The pinnacle of economic play is not owning the largest numbers. It is reaching the decisive battlefield, ritual, or Throne state with the right power one turn before the opponent.

Essay VII: The Month Hidden Inside a Single Point

Dominions displays most of its economy as integers, which makes one point look trivial. At a production boundary, one point can be an entire month.

Commander Points are the clearest case. A two-point mage in a two-point fort appears every month. Reduce the usable pool to one and the same mage appears every second month. Nothing on the mage card has changed: not price, paths, Research Points, or battlefield value. Yet a twelve-month plan has fallen from twelve mages to six. The missing point is not one unit of capacity; it is half the production stream.

Recruitment Points can behave similarly when a queue sits just above the local total. One missing point may delay a complete army package, strand unused resources, and postpone expansion or a relief force. A single point of supply can decide whether another unit enters the starvation selection pool. A single point of income can determine whether the treasury pays every component of a mounted army without desertion risk.

This is why exact rounding matters, but also why false precision is dangerous. A spreadsheet can calculate decimals the engine never exposes and place the apparent total on the favourable side of a boundary. If the internal rounding stage is unknown, more decimal places do not create more knowledge.

The practical response is to plan in layers. Use the official formula for direction, the current interface for the operative integer, and a reserve when one point controls a deadline. Record the boundary if it repeats often enough to matter. A reliable player does not need every hidden rounding rule memorised; a reliable player knows when an unverified rounding rule is carrying the entire plan.

Part XIX: Sources and Open Questions

Primary official sources

- Dominions 6 documentation
- Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2
- Dominions 6 Modding Manual, version 6.34
- Dominions 6 official changes
- Illwinter home and current release record

Principal manual sections:

- Province attributes and economy, pages 21-29.
- Strategic orders, especially Blood Hunting, sieges, construction, demolition, pillage, and raids, pages 50-54.
- Turn resolution, pages 55-57.
- Sieges and storming, pages 71-72.
- Dominion scales and extreme scales in the Dominion chapter.

Community sources used as leads

- Current Commander Point reference
- Illwiki unrest reference
- Illwiki starvation reference
- Illwiki supplies reference
- Current population and fort-supply reference
- Illwiki Province Defence reference
- Illwiki fort reference
- Illwiki Blood Hunting reference
- Illwiki generic Blood guide
- December 2025 in-game upkeep observations

Community pages are not treated as final authority. Several retain historical Dominions 5 material or conflict with current official text. They are used to locate edge cases and testable claims. The upkeep discussion has firmer limits than a general guide because it records the observation date, annual values shown in game, a mounted component example, and the manual rule being checked. Its claims remain Community-tested evidence, below an official rule or an archived controlled save.

Mod sources

The economic discussion uses the supplied DE 2.16 and Divinitus 1.15.3 DE files. Their hashes, order, and exact global commands are recorded in Book IX.

Open questions

- fort-supply distance arithmetic;
- exact rounding in income, resources, RP, and fort draw;
- shapechanged upkeep and monthly fractional aggregation;
- full unrest effects on RP and Commander Points;
- generic commander feeding priority and starvation eligibility;
- national and object-specific effects from DE and Divinitus.

For the unmodded 6.36 publication baseline, Growth/Death income and Order/Turmoil resources use 2% per step. The ordinary Commander Point pool is one plus the current fort bonus. At the stated

Community-tested tier, Sacred and Slave reductions stack and mounted upkeep uses separate component bases. No 6.36 announcement changes those rules. Until the remaining questions are reproduced under the current game, close calculations should state their exact uncertainties instead of hiding them inside a rounded recommendation.

DOCUMENT 4 OF 7

Foundation Book III: Pretenders, Dominion, Scales, and Blessings

The design problem

Pretender design is the first strategic decision in a game of Dominions 6 and one of the last decisions that can be judged in isolation. A design determines more than the strength of a god. It determines when that strength exists, which sacred units justify their cost, how quickly faith spreads, what kind of provinces the nation creates, which divine spells its priests know, and which magical paths are available when the national roster runs out of answers.

The design screen asks a larger question than "Which Pretender is strongest?"

> Foundation rule: A Pretender design is a contract between the nation's roster, the map, the expected war schedule, and the intended route to victory.

The chapters begin with the unmodded design screen, then follow the consequences through awakening, dominion, scales, blessings, priesthood, death, and team play. Exact arithmetic is included when it helps settle a choice.

Edition note

Book I owns the common Dominions 6.36 baseline and evidence vocabulary. The revision-2 manual remains the main rules source here, but its printed blessing appendix predates several official balance changes. The structured object snapshot behind the current bless table is still pinned to the Inspector's 6.35 commit; the 6.36 announcement changes a Pretender-loading bug, not any listed bless cost or effect. Current values, historical values, and the one-version data lag are stated separately so they cannot be quietly blended together. Edition 22 reconciled Call God and same-turn Throne ownership. Edition 23 traces the newly republished awakening model back to its pre-Dominions 6 source and keeps it below current-version proof. Book IX is the authoritative source for DE 2.16 and Divinitus 1.15.3 DE changes.

Finding the useful layer

A new player can move from the one-model design summary through awakening, dominion, scales, blessings, and the final audit. Detailed point curves, dominion checks, sacred throughput, special dominions, disciples, and god-death mechanics support more demanding designs. The test programme is mainly for cases where the interface and documentation do not settle the same question.

Part I: Pretender Design as a National System

The design in one model

The unmodded design begins with 450 points before paying for the physical form. Those points are allocated across four linked budgets:

```
450 design points
- physical form
- purchased magic
- dominion strength and scales
+ deferred-awakening points
= unspent remainder
```

The arithmetic is simple. The strategic valuation is not.

Budget	Immediate result	Long-term consequence
Physical form	Body, slots, statistics, abilities, starting paths, scale limits	Determines personal roles, survivability, mobility, and path-buying efficiency
Magic	Personal paths and bless-point pool	Determines research or ritual access, forging, divine spell family, and sacred enhancements
Dominion and scales	Candles, provincial tendencies, sacred recruitment capacity	Shapes economy, faith conflict, terrain, events, population, research, and religious survival
Awakening	Availability date	Trades immediate agency for design points and changes when Incarnate blessings operate

These budgets cannot be evaluated independently. An imprisoned god may buy a powerful Incarnate blessing that is unavailable during expansion. An awake monster may defeat independents but leave no useful magic or economy after its expansion role ends. Excellent scales may produce gold that a low-resource or Holy-limited roster cannot convert. High paths may purchase many bless points while satisfying none of the prerequisites needed by the sacred roster.

The five obligations

A complete design should state how it addresses five obligations:

1. Expansion: how provinces are taken reliably and at an acceptable loss rate.
2. Economy: which scales and dominion support the planned recruitment and research.
3. Sacred plan: whether sacred units are central, supplementary, or mostly irrelevant.
4. Magic access: which national weaknesses the Pretender repairs or which strengths it accelerates.
5. Timing: when the design becomes stronger than the alternatives whose points were spent elsewhere.

A design need not solve every obligation through the Pretender. It must show where each solution comes from.

Begin with the nation, not the god

Before opening the Pretender screen, record:

- recruitable sacred troops and commanders;
- capital-only, fort-only, terrain-only, foreign, and summonable sacreds;
- Holy Point and Commander Point bottlenecks;
- ordinary expansion troops and commanders;
- national mage paths, randoms, and missing paths;
- early research packages;
- gold, resource, and Recruitment Point demand;
- temperature preference and scale limits;

- special dominion rules;
- expected map and lobby settings.

The purpose is to identify problems before selecting an attractive solution.

Roster questions

Question	Why it changes the design
Are the principal sacreds massed or elite?	Flat bonuses scale with body count; survival and percentage effects often gain value on expensive bodies
Are sacreds capital-only?	A powerful bless may apply to too few units to justify its design cost
Are sacred commanders strategically important?	Passive leadership, stealth, recuperation, or magic-related blessings may matter outside battle
Can ordinary troops expand reliably?	If yes, an awake expander is optional rather than compulsory
Is the nation gold-, resource-, RP-, or Holy-limited?	Scales should support the actual bottleneck
Which magic paths are missing?	Pretender paths may open boosters, summons, rituals, or counters unavailable nationally
Does the nation need an early battlefield caster?	Awakening time and chassis mobility become central
Does the nation possess a special dominion?	Candles and temples may become economic or military infrastructure

Lobby questions

Pretender value changes with:

- independent strength;
- map size and terrain;
- number of players;
- team or disciple rules;
- research speed;
- site frequency;
- magic-resource settings;
- throne distribution and points required;
- diplomacy rules;
- starting provinces;
- mods and load order.

A design that is excellent on a crowded, high-independent-strength map may be wasteful in a spacious game with weak independents. An imprisoned research-and-access design may mature comfortably on a slow diplomatic map and arrive too late in a knife-fight.

Chassis roles

Physical forms should be compared by the jobs they can perform, not by a single tier list.

Expansion chassis

An expansion chassis personally captures independent provinces during the opening.

Requirements usually include:

- sufficient protection or avoidance;

- a way to prevent chip damage from accumulating;
- enough offence to end battles before fatigue or attrition wins;
- resistance to common independent threats;
- acceptable map movement;
- a script that works without unavailable research or equipment.

An expander is an economic asset only while its conquest produces more value than the alternative use of its design points and commander-turns.

Bless anchor

A bless anchor buys the paths and bless points required by the sacred plan. Its own combat performance may be secondary.

The anchor must answer:

- which sacreds receive the benefit;
- how many can be recruited;
- when they can be blessed;
- whether the decisive effects are Incarnate;
- which counters remain;
- whether the same paths have a useful later role.

Scales anchor

A scales anchor spends relatively little on personal power so that the nation can afford strong dominion and favourable scales. It is commonly dormant or imprisoned, but awakening and form are separate choices.

The design succeeds when the nation can convert the improved economy into more useful power than a direct bless or awake form would have supplied.

Rainbow and access chassis

A rainbow distributes points across several paths to:

- obtain efficient early path levels;
- expand the bless-point pool;
- search for sites;
- forge cross-path items;
- provide ritual access;
- open booster chains;
- diversify divine spells.

The danger is diffuse capability without a timetable. "Can eventually cast many things" is not a plan until the required research, gems, boosters, laboratories, and safe commander-turns are named.

Ritual platform

A ritual platform buys one or more high paths for a defined strategic package:

- global enchantments;
- remote attacks;
- large summons;
- mobility rituals;
- high-path forging;

- late-game access.

Its value depends on the earliest realistic casting date, not only the final path display.

Battlefield caster

A battlefield caster supplies spells the national roster cannot cast at the required time. It needs:

- arrival before the relevant war;
- sufficient combat speed or cast time;
- fatigue management;
- gems and research;
- protection from assassination, seeking arrows, remote attacks, and battlefield counters;
- a retreat or immortality plan.

Thug or supercombatant platform

A thug or supercombatant design intends to fight armies, raid, hold positions, or force specialised counters. Personal statistics alone are insufficient. The design must cover:

- damage types and attack volume;
- fatigue;
- mundane and magical defence;
- elemental and physical resistances;
- magic resistance;
- control effects;
- anti-undead or anti-demon tools where relevant;
- mobility;
- recovery from afflictions;
- escape and death consequences.

Immobile oracle

Immobile forms often purchase magic efficiently and may have strong dominion or special sites. They trade away conventional movement.

Some can move by teleportation, while others are too large for particular transport effects. Mobility must be checked for the exact form.

Shape-changer

Dragons and other shape-changers can separate casting and combat forms. The manual notes that a dragon may appear as a humanoid wizard until changing shape or being wounded.

The two forms should be audited separately:

- paths and casting convenience;
- slots;
- movement;
- protection and attacks;
- regeneration or recuperation;
- transformation conditions;
- whether an affliction or shape loss changes the planned role.

Trinity

A Trinity consists of three entities. According to the manual:

- the members share part of their magical power;
- separated members lose some magic;
- a lone member loses more;
- exact penalties vary by Trinity;
- each member can research, though at reduced ability;
- a dead member can be Called God in half the ordinary time.

Trinities create parallel commander-turns and map presence at the price of coordination and reduced separated power. Every proposed Trinity design needs exact-form testing; the category does not guarantee identical behaviour.

Immortal and dominion-immortal forms

These forms alter the cost of personal risk.

- Immortal: normally reforms regardless of ordinary-plane dominion.
- Dominion Immortal: normally reforms after death in friendly dominion.
- Neither: requires Call God after death unless another special rule applies.

Soul destruction and death on a remote plane can bypass ordinary reform. Immortality reduces some consequences of death; it does not make every battle strategically free.

Chassis comparison sheet

Field	Record
Form and nation	Exact form, age, nation, and ruleset
Base point cost	Points removed before all other purchases
Starting paths	Innate path levels in each form
New Path Cost	Cost of opening an absent path
Starting dominion	Base candle value
Scale-limit changes	Direction and amount
Awakening restrictions	Ordinary, minimum prison, maximum prison, or other
Movement	Map Move, terrain survival, sailing, teleport eligibility
Combat shell	HP, protection, defence, MR, resistances, recuperation, regeneration
Slots	Hands, head, body, feet, misc, special restrictions
Special mechanics	Shape change, Trinity, immortality, freespawn, sites, dominion effects
Opening job	Expansion, research, site search, forging, ritual, deterrence
Middle-game job	Named repeatable use
Failure condition	What makes the investment non-functional

Part II: Exact Design-Point Arithmetic

Physical-form cost

Every form has an inherent point cost. The cost is paid from the initial 450.

```
points after form = 450 - form cost
```

A Phoenix costing 110, for example, leaves 340 before magic, dominion, scales, and awakening are applied.

Form cost cannot be judged without its embedded value:

- starting magic;
- cheaper or more expensive new paths;
- starting dominion;
- scale-limit adjustments;
- combat statistics;
- slots;
- mobility;
- special abilities;
- national availability.

Magic-path costs

The official cost for each path level added by the player is:

Added level number	Marginal cost	Cumulative cost
1st	8	8
2nd	16	24
3rd	24	48
4th	32	80
5th	40	120
6th	48	168
7th	56	224
8th	64	288
9th	72	360
10th	80	440

These are levels added by the design, not the displayed final path.

If a form begins with Nature 2, raising it to Nature 3 is the first purchased level in that path and costs 8. Raising it from Nature 2 to Nature 6 adds four levels and costs:

```
8 + 16 + 24 + 32 = 80
```

Opening a new path

If the form begins with no level in a path:

1. the first level costs the form's New Path Cost;
2. the second added level costs 16;
3. the third costs 24;
4. the sequence then continues normally.

The New Path Cost replaces the ordinary 8-point first purchase. It does not replace the entire path curve.

Official worked example

The Carrion Dragon begins with Death 1 and Nature 1. Raising it to Death 4 and Nature 4 adds three levels in each:

```
Death: 8 + 16 + 24 = 48
Nature: 8 + 16 + 24 = 48
```

Opening Fire at a New Path Cost of 80 and raising it to Fire 2 adds:

```
Fire: 80 + 16 = 96
```

Total:

```
48 + 48 + 96 = 192 design points
```

Magic-purchase audit

For every path, record:

Path	Innate	Purchased	Final	Cost	Purpose
Fire					
Air					
Water					
Earth					
Astral					
Death					
Nature					
Glamour					
Blood					

"Purpose" should be specific: a blessing prerequisite, a named booster chain, a site-search threshold, a combat spell, a ritual, or a divine-spell family. A path bought only because it looks flexible is a candidate for removal.

Dominion-strength costs

Every form begins with at least Dominion 1 and may be raised to Dominion 10. Each candle added above the form's base costs progressively more:

Added candle number	Marginal cost	Cumulative cost
1st	7	7
2nd	14	21
3rd	21	42
4th	28	70
5th	35	105
6th	42	147

Added candle number	Marginal cost	Cumulative cost
7th	49	196
8th	56	252
9th	63	315

For `n` added candles:

```
cumulative cost = 7n(n + 1) / 2
```

The accelerating curve matters. Raising an already high starting dominion is often much cheaper than buying the same final score on a low-dominion form.

What initial dominion changes

Initial dominion contributes to:

- the maximum dominion ceiling;
- the chance that temple checks succeed;
- capital-only sacred recruitment through Holy Points;
- Pretender and Prophet statistics in friendly or hostile dominion;
- the speed at which scales tend to establish;
- resistance to hostile faith;
- survival against a dominion kill;
- several special national mechanics.

High dominion means more than "more candles." It improves several connected parts of the nation while consuming a steep share of the design budget.

Scale-point costs

Each favourable scale step costs 40 points. Each unfavourable step grants 40.

```
scale-point change = -40 x favourable steps + 40 x unfavourable steps
```

Temperature is measured relative to national preference during design. Only the first three clicks away from that preference grant points.

The ordinary design window is -2 to +2. National and Pretender scale-limit adjustments can pull that window in one direction. Province scales can reach -5 to +5 during play.

Scale-limit movement

A `+1 Growth Limit` does more than add one Growth option. It shifts the whole design window:

- Growth maximum rises by one;
- Death maximum in the opposite direction falls by one.

National and Pretender adjustments in the same direction overlap rather than automatically stacking without limit. Exact nation-form combinations should be checked in the design screen.

Awakening points

State	Point change	Ordinary arrival
Awake	+0	Present from the beginning
Dormant	+150	Approximately turns 10-13
Imprisoned	+350	Approximately turns 28-42

The official manual intentionally gives ranges rather than a guaranteed turn. It also says that Disciples awaken in about half the time of their Pretender. That wording does not define an exact Disciple range or a rounding rule.

Planning with an unknown distribution

The range is enough to build a robust opening, but not enough to calculate an expected arrival.

Design	Safe planning assumption	What must work before arrival
Awake	The god is available immediately	Its first several orders, expansion targets, and acceptable risks
Dormant	The nation may wait until the late end of turns 10-13	Expansion, research, and sacred use through the whole dormant window
Imprisoned	The nation may wait until the late end of turns 28-42	The first expansion cycle and a substantial part of the first war without the chassis or Incarnate effects
Disciple	Roughly half the Pretender delay, with no published exact rounding	The disciple nation must not depend on a single inferred half-turn

Do not substitute the midpoint for an average. The official range does not say that every turn is equally likely, and an arrival process with repeated rolls can be heavily weighted without changing its visible minimum and maximum. For practical design work:

1. budget the army and research plan to survive the latest official arrival;
2. prepare a useful first order for every plausible arrival turn;
3. treat an early arrival as extra tempo rather than as a requirement;
4. evaluate an Incarnate blessing as two armies: the pre-awakening army and the post-awakening army.

Older reverse-engineering notes propose repeated exploding-die checks rather than a uniform draw. A Dominions 6 community Pretender page, revised on 16 June 2026, now republishes the same model and attributes it to Loggy: `9 + d4!` for Dormant, `27 + d20!` for Imprisoned, and bases of 4 and 13 for the corresponding Disciple rolls. It says a new exploding roll is made each month and the result is compared with the current turn.

The newer page label does not create a new current-version test. The wording and constants can be traced to Loggy's older miscellaneous reverse-engineering notes and to copies published years before Dominions 6. The current page supplies neither raw 6.x outcomes nor an executable trace, and its usual displayed ranges of turns 11-14 and 29-42 are shifted from the revision-2 manual's approximate 10-13 and 28-42 wording. That may be a turn-label convention, an editorial carry-over, or a real version difference; the available sources do not decide which.

The exploding-die model remains a current community research hypothesis with historical provenance and is not promoted to a Dominions 6.36 rule. It is more specific than assuming a uniform draw and helps define a decisive reproduction, but it is not safe input for an exact probability calculator. R-014 stays queued until a sufficiently large current sample, a current engine-backed trace, or developer confirmation establishes both the distribution and the displayed-turn convention.

Total-budget worksheet

```
450
- form cost
- purchased magic
- added dominion
- favourable scales
+ unfavourable scales
+ awakening grant
= remainder
```

The final screen should be checked against the worksheet. Form-specific restrictions, national scale limits, bonus bless points, and mod changes can make a generic calculator incomplete.

Part III: Awakening, Time, and the Opening

Awake

An awake Pretender can contribute from turn one.

Possible opening jobs:

- expand personally;
- research;
- search;
- forge once research permits;
- cast early rituals;
- lead or bless an army;
- deter an early attack;
- establish a special site or dominion effect.

The opportunity cost is the 150 or 350 points not obtained from delay.

An awake design should specify its monthly orders. "Available" is not the same as "productive."

Awake-expander ledger

Record:

- provinces taken;
- turns saved relative to an ordinary expansion party;
- gold and commander-turns freed;
- wounds and afflictions;
- additional gear or research required;
- enemy counters revealed;
- time spent returning, healing, or waiting.

The correct comparison is not the expander's kill count. It is the territory and tempo created after subtracting its design cost and risk.

Dormant

Dormant grants 150 points and usually arrives near the end of the initial expansion phase.

Common uses:

- moderate Incarnate bless arriving before the first planned war;
- mid-game combat or ritual chassis;
- strong scales with a still-relevant physical god;
- path access not needed during the first ten turns.

Risks:

- an early war begins before arrival;
- the sacred plan requires Incarnate effects for expansion;
- the nation cannot exploit the purchased paths immediately on awakening;
- the arrival location or laboratory network is poorly prepared.

Imprisoned

Imprisoned grants 350 points and may remain absent until turns 28-42.

Common uses:

- high scales;
- broad or deep magic;
- large bless-point pools;
- late-game path access;
- a powerful Incarnate package deliberately deferred.

The design transfers power from the opening to the economy, blessing, or later magic. That transfer is only favourable if the nation survives and converts the points before the game's decisive wars.

The Incarnate trap

An imprisoned god can buy an Incarnate blessing, but the effect remains inactive while the god is imprisoned or dead. The sacred roster may fight for several dozen turns with only the non-Incarnate portion.

The design audit should split the bless into:

Phase	Available effects
Before awakening	Innate and ordinary non-Incarnate effects
God alive and present	Full bless, including Incarnate effects
God dead or absent under the effect's rule	Incarnate portion disabled

Timing comparison

Question	Awake	Dormant	Imprisoned
Helps turn-one expansion?	Yes, if capable	No	No
Incarnate bless active?	Yes while alive/present	Delayed	Heavily delayed

Question	Awake	Dormant	Imprisoned
Extra design points	0	150	350
Early personal research	Possible	None	None
Early personal risk	Highest	Deferred	Deferred longest
Best justification	Immediate actions worth more than 150 points	Mid-game arrival matches plan	Nation can carry the opening and exploit the large point grant

Arrival preparation

Before a delayed god awakens:

1. preserve a suitable laboratory;
2. reserve the needed gems;
3. complete required research;
4. forge planned equipment;
5. choose a safe operating province;
6. prepare priests and sacred armies if Incarnate effects matter;
7. identify the first three commander-turns after arrival.

An arrival without orders is delayed power followed by idle power.

Part IV: Dominion

Dominion in plain language

Dominion is religious control. Province ownership is military and administrative control. The two layers are independent.

A nation can:

- own a province under enemy dominion;
- spread dominion through provinces it does not own;
- conquer a continent without spreading its faith;
- lose by losing every friendly candle even while retaining forts and armies.

Friendly dominion is displayed as positive candles. Enemy dominion is effectively negative from the observing nation's perspective.

> Foundation rule: Armies take provinces. Religious infrastructure makes those provinces part of the god's world.

Sources of dominion spread

The manual gives the following sources:

Source	Checks
Pretender	One automatic increase plus two temple checks
Home province	One temple check

Source	Checks
Prophet	One temple check
Temple	One temple check
Disciple	One temple check
Claimed Throne	One to seven checks, depending on Throne

A check does not guarantee a candle. It attempts to create, increase, propagate, or contest dominion according to the local state.

Religious hosting order

The official turn sequence separates direct priest orders from ordinary passive spread:

Step	Religious operation	Consequence
6	Preaching	Priest orders adjust local dominion. Since version 6.13, commanders performing this order resolve in random order.
7	Heretic preaching	Heretics, insane commanders, and shattered-soul commanders reduce dominion.
8	Claim Thrones	Valid Throne claims resolve before movement and battle.
42	Dominion spread	Pretender, capital, Prophet, temple, Disciple, Throne, and sacrifice-generated spread resolves.
43	Dominion effects	Population death, insanity, temperature spread, and similar effects use the resulting religious state.
56	Elimination	A nation without provinces or dominion is removed.
57	Victory	The game checks whether a victory condition has been fulfilled.

This closes the ordinary R-015 model at the official-rules tier: the sources, check probabilities, local resolution rules, cross-water reroll, and hosting stage are all stated officially. The manual does not publish the random-number stream or the internal iteration order among simultaneous passive sources, so neither is inferred.

Maximum dominion

The maximum is:

```
maximum dominion =
initial Pretender dominion
+ floor(temples / (5 x players on team))
```

For a solo nation, every five temples raise the maximum by one. For a two-player team, every ten team temples do so.

Example:

```
initial dominion 3
12 temples
2 players on team

maximum = 3 + floor(12 / 10) = 4
```

The ceiling matters because it affects:

- maximum candle strength reached by ordinary temple spread;

- temple-check success chance;
- resistance in dominion conflict;
- the relay behaviour of strong friendly provinces.

Preaching uses a separate local cap and can exceed what a weak maximum would ordinarily establish.

Temple-check chance

The official chance that a temple check succeeds is:

```
50% + 5% x maximum dominion
```

Maximum dominion	Check chance
1	55%
3	65%
5	75%
7	85%
9	95%
10	100%

Temples have two network effects:

1. each adds another check;
2. each threshold of five per team member can raise the maximum, improving every ordinary check.

The value of a temple network is not linear around the threshold.

Resolving a successful check

Neutral province

A successful check adds one friendly candle.

Province with friendly dominion

At `U` friendly candles, the chance to add another candle locally is:

```
30% - 3% x U
```

If the local increase fails, the check propagates to a random neighbouring province.

High-candle provinces tend to relay pressure outward instead of endlessly concentrating it.

Friendly candles	Local increase chance
1	27%
3	21%
5	15%
7	9%
9	3%

Province with enemy dominion

At `E` enemy candles:

```
chance to reduce enemy dominion =
50% + 5% x maximum dominion - 5% x E
```

Maximum dominion	Enemy candles	Reduction chance
5	1	70%
5	5	50%
7	5	60%
9	8	55%

Dense hostile candles form a religious wall. High maximum dominion pushes against it more effectively.

Land and sea

When propagation randomly selects a neighbouring province across a land-sea boundary, the manual gives a 50% chance to reroll the destination. Faith crosses the boundary less readily than it spreads within the same environment.

Dominion as a network

Dominion spread has three behaviours:

1. creation in neutral provinces;
2. consolidation in weak friendly provinces;
3. propagation from strong friendly provinces.

This means a rear temple can influence a frontier through a chain of strong provinces, while a single weak or hostile province can absorb repeated checks.

Useful religious infrastructure is shaped by:

- temple count;
- maximum-dominion thresholds;
- adjacency;
- sea boundaries;
- hostile candle depth;
- local preaching;
- special dominion effects;
- vulnerability of temples to raids.

Preaching

Preaching acts only in the priest's province and does not use the ordinary maximum-dominion ceiling.

In neutral or friendly dominion:

```
success chance = 30% x effective Holy level
```

Against `E` enemy candles:

```
success chance =
30% x effective Holy level - 5% x E

minimum = 5%
```

A temple in the province adds 0.5 to effective Holy level for the chance and cap.

The maximum local dominion that preaching can establish is:

```
preaching cap = 2 x effective Holy level
```

Preaching examples

Priest	Temple?	Effective H	Neutral chance	Cap
H1	No	1.0	30%	2
H1	Yes	1.5	45%	3
H2	No	2.0	60%	4
H2	Yes	2.5	75%	5
H3	Yes	3.5	105%	7

Values above 100% should be treated as automatic for ordinary practical use, but exact engine handling remains a candidate for reproduction.

Inquisitors

An Inquisitor counts double Holy level when preaching in enemy dominion. In neutral or friendly dominion, ordinary Holy level is used.

An H2 Inquisitor in enemy dominion preaches as effective H4 before a possible temple bonus.

Heretics

A Heretic reduces dominion locally rather than establishing a rival faith.

```
chance to reduce = Heretic value x 20%
```

Heretics can erode friendly candles as well as enemy candles. Their position and allegiance require careful handling.

Blood sacrifice

An eligible priest in a temple may sacrifice blood slaves.

- maximum slaves sacrificed equals Holy level;
- each slave creates one temple check;
- the priest must have the national ability to sacrifice;
- the order consumes a priest-turn and slaves.

Blood sacrifice converts the blood economy directly into religious pressure. Its value rises when:

- the nation already hunts efficiently;
- dominion survival is threatened;
- a throne or special dominion effect depends on local candles;
- the temple network can project the additional checks;
- the sacrificed slaves are worth less than the military or ritual consequences prevented.

Dying dominion

Early and Late Age Mictlan use a special dying-dominion system.

According to the manual:

- home-province, Prophet, and temple spread do not operate normally;
- Pretender checks are only half as effective;
- blood sacrifice is the essential spread mechanism.

This changes temple construction from passive religious infrastructure into sacrifice stations. A Mictlan design that ignores blood-sacrifice logistics is structurally incomplete.

Prophets

A Prophet:

- becomes H3, or raises an already H3-or-higher commander by one;
- spreads dominion like a temple;
- gains +2 Attack, Defence, and Precision;
- receives dominion-dependent statistic changes.

Current community references also describe Prophets as automatically blessed, sacred, Morale 30, and upkeep-free, with a replacement delay after death. These details should be checked in 6.36 before being promoted to Official in this library.

Prophet roles

- battlefield-wide Divine Blessing if H3;
- mobile preaching;
- dominion source;
- Holy access beyond the ordinary roster;
- throne claiming when the other conditions are met;
- combat leadership or thug role on a suitable chassis.

Prophetising a fragile scout can gain cheap mobile H3. Prophetising a robust sacred commander can create a battle piece. The correct choice depends on whether Holy access, survivability, movement, stealth, or equipment matters most.

Thrones of Ascension

A claimed Throne:

- contributes dominion checks;
- may grant scales, blessings, sites, paths, gems, units, or other effects;
- contributes Ascension Points;
- changes the strategic value of its province.

The revision-2 manual says claimed Thrones spread one to seven checks depending on the Throne. Current community data commonly describes a claimed Throne as generating a number of guaranteed checks equal to its level. That exact success behaviour remains Test Pending.

Claiming normally requires:

- ownership of the province;
- a Pretender or Disciple, a Prophet, or an H3-or-higher priest;

- the Claim Throne order;
- a legal claimant when the order resolves at hosting step 8.

If a fort is present, a besieger cannot claim through its walls. The besieged owner may still claim. A Throne becomes unclaimed when another nation conquers its province and, where present, its fort.

Same-turn claim, loss, and victory

The official hosting sequence and the current ownership rule answer the central R-018 cases when read together. The claim is processed early, but victory is tested against the state that survives to the end of hosting.

Hosting point	Relevant change
8	A legal Claim Throne order establishes the claim.
10-27	Ritual attacks, assassinations, movement battles, and castle storming can kill the claimant or change control.
53	An unbesieged fort may reclaim its province under the official partial-ownership rule.
56	Elimination is checked.
57	The game checks the victory conditions.

The resulting state matrix is more useful than the vague instruction to "hold until hosting."

Same-turn result after a successful step-8 claim	State at the victory check
Claimant is killed later, but the nation retains the Throne	The claim remains; a claimant does not need to survive after the claim has resolved.
An unfortified Throne province is conquered	The Throne becomes unclaimed and its Ascension Points do not survive to step 57.
A fortified Throne is merely placed under siege	The defender still owns the fort and the Throne remains claimed.
The fortified Throne is stormed and conquered	The Throne becomes unclaimed before victory is checked.

This is a mixed Official plus Community-tested conclusion. The manual establishes steps 8 and 57 and the rules for full and partial province ownership. The current community Throne reference states that conquest of the province and fort, if present, unclaims the Throne. A published same-turn report independently records the claimant-death and province-loss branches. No official update through 6.36 changes that sequence.

R-018 is complete at that evidence tier. It does not settle every adjacent victory question. In particular, an exact simultaneous tie between different nations at the winning Ascension total still needs a current controlled reproduction before any tie-break rule is published as law.

Dominion effects on units

Ordinary troops

All units receive:

- +1 Morale in friendly dominion;
- -1 Morale in enemy dominion.

Pretender and Prophet

For each friendly candle, the Pretender and Prophet receive:

- +1 Strength;
- +0.5 Magic Resistance;
- +10% Hit Points.

Enemy candles reverse these changes. Hit Points do not fall below 10% through this effect.

Dominion changes whether a god or Prophet can safely take a fight. A combat report from Dominion 8 cannot be transferred unchanged to Dominion -4.

Scale convergence inside dominion

For each scale in a province, the official chance to move one step toward the god's selected scales is:

```
5% x local candles
+ 10% x absolute difference
```

Example:

```
local dominion = 6
current Order = -1
target Order = +2
difference = 3

chance = 5 x 6 + 10 x 3 = 60%
```

Current community documentation reports that a chance above 100% can move the scale two steps. The manual describes a one-step movement. The additional step requires controlled reproduction.

Dominion elimination

If a Pretender has no friendly dominion anywhere, the nation is eliminated.

The nation may still possess:

- provinces;
- armies;
- forts;
- a treasury;
- a living Pretender.

None prevents religious extinction.

Dominion-kill warning indicators

- no safe rear candle core;
- capital under deep enemy dominion;
- low maximum dominion;
- few temples;
- temple thresholds just below the next maximum increase;
- priests absent from threatened provinces;
- land-sea spread barriers;
- enemy blood sacrifice or Inquisitors;
- Pretender deaths that reduce dominion strength;
- simultaneous temple raids.

Part V: Scales

Scales in plain language

Scales describe the material and metaphysical tendencies of a god's dominion.

The six pairs are:

Positive end	Negative end	Principal systems
Order	Turmoil	Income, resources, recruitment, unrest recovery, events
Productivity	Sloth	Resources and income
Heat	Cold	Climate, income, supply, movement, fatigue environment
Growth	Death	Population, income, supply, aging, terrain at extremes
Fortune	Misfortune	Event quality, frequency, heroes
Magic	Drain	Research, MR, spell fatigue, starting research

"Positive" does not mean universally beneficial. Extreme positive scales carry penalties, and some nations exploit nominally negative scales.

Ordinary scale effects

The following values are the current unmodded 6.36 publication baseline. The Growth/Death income row uses the newer official Modding Manual default.

Scale step	Ordinary effect per step
Order	+3% income, +2% resources, +10% Recruitment Points, stronger unrest reduction, fewer events
Turmoil	Reverses Order's economic and recruitment effects; more events
Productivity	+3% income, +15% resources
Sloth	-3% income, -15% resources
Temperature away from preference	-5% income and -10% supplies per step
Growth	+0.2% monthly population, +10% supplies, +2% income
Death	Reverses Growth's ordinary effects
Fortune	+10 percentage points to good-event chance, +0.5% monthly hero chance, more events
Misfortune	-10 percentage points to good-event chance, -0.5% monthly hero chance, more events
Magic	Friendly mages +1 Research Ability, all units -0.5 MR rounded toward zero, -10% spell fatigue, +50 starting research
Drain	Reverse research, MR, fatigue, and starting-research effects

Default starting research is 150. Default monthly hero chance is 3%.

Resolved and remaining documentation conflicts

Rule	Revision-2 manual	Other current evidence	Publication treatment
Growth/Death income	1% per step	Modding Manual 6.34 default `#deathincome 2`; no official change through 6.36	Use 2%; resolved at official-documentation tier
Order/Turmoil resources	2% per step	No later official change; some unsupported older tables say 3%	Use 2%; resolved at official-documentation tier
Order/Turmoil events	Manual commonly states 2% in its scale table	Current community table says 3%	Reproduce
Fortune/Misfortune frequency	5% more events for either direction	Current community table agrees	Provisionally stable

The two resolved rows may be used in current calculators, while their integer rounding remains subject to R-008. The event-frequency discrepancy still requires better evidence.

Order and Turmoil

Order improves economic predictability, recruitment throughput, and unrest recovery while reducing events.

It gains value when:

- Recruitment Points bind troop production;
- the roster converts gold efficiently;
- populous provinces can be held;
- blood hunting or pillage creates recurring unrest;
- a stable economy matters more than event volume.

Turmoil grants design points and increases event frequency. It can be part of a coherent design when:

- the nation has Turmoil-dependent recruitment or freespawn;
- events are deliberately valued;
- the roster is not RP-limited;
- special dominion mechanics reward unrest or chaos;
- early direct power outweighs long-term economic loss.

Productivity and Sloth

Productivity is the clearest answer to resource-heavy recruitment.

It gains value with:

- heavy armour;
- high-resource sacreds;
- fort networks drawing from strong terrain;
- enough gold and RP to use the additional resources.

Sloth is less painful when:

- important troops have low resource cost;
- the nation relies on summons;
- gold, RP, Holy Points, or Commander Points bind first;
- forts cannot access enough potential resources for Productivity to matter.

The correct test is a queue, not an impression:

```
desired monthly recruit package
vs
gold, resources, RP, CP, and Holy Points
```

Temperature

Temperature choice is anchored to national preference, but actual provincial temperature also shifts with seasons, events, rituals, and competing dominion.

Official seasonal behaviour:

- summer usually adds one Heat;
- winter usually adds one Cold;
- caves and outer planes are unaffected;
- deep sea remains neutral;
- ordinary sea is limited to Heat or Cold 1;
- sea seasons apply differently from land.

Temperature affects:

- income and supply relative to national preference;
- snow, rain, river, and passability conditions;
- base encumbrance in severe climates;
- fire and cold battlefield interactions;
- extreme-scale population death.

The right design temperature may reflect an economic preference, a battlefield environment, a national mechanic, or a compromise between them.

Growth and Death

Growth compounds population, improves supply, and modifies income. It also reduces aging pressure.

It gains value when:

- the game is expected to last;
- provinces are populous;
- armies are supply-intensive;
- the roster uses local Recruitment Points;
- the nation does not destroy its own population.

Death grants design points and may support:

- undead or population-indifferent nations;
- a compressed early timing;
- national mechanics tied to death or corpses;
- maps where long-term civilian economy is unlikely to decide the game.

Death is not free merely because the capital roster is undead. Provinces may still supply gold, resources, tax trace, fort locations, and enemy denial.

Fortune and Misfortune

Fortune changes event quality and hero arrival chance. Both Fortune and Misfortune increase event frequency under the manual's ordinary rule.

The scale is sensitive to:

- event settings;
- map size and number of provinces held;
- national event lists;
- Turmoil;
- capital dependence;
- the value of heroes;
- tolerance for variance.

Fortune should not be valued only through expected gold. Events also provide or remove gems, population, scales, sites, commanders, troops, unrest, and strategic options.

Magic and Drain

Magic accelerates research and reduces spell fatigue while lowering MR. Drain does the reverse.

Magic gains value when:

- many national mages receive the research bonus;
- early breakpoints matter;
- battlefield casting is fatigue-sensitive;
- the nation can exploit lower enemy MR more than it suffers from its own.

Drain gains value when:

- design points fund a stronger immediate package;
- national researchers are efficient despite the penalty;
- high MR is unusually valuable;
- research speed or early magic matters less;
- the nation has researchers unaffected by the scale.

The spell-fatigue modifier applies locally. An army crossing into different scales may find the same script more or less sustainable.

Extreme scales

Scales at 4 or 5 carry additional effects.

Extreme	Additional effect
Order 4	-2 Research Ability
Order 5	-4 Research Ability
Productivity 4	+1d5 unrest per month
Productivity 5	+1d15 unrest per month
Heat or Cold 4	-0.4% population per month
Heat or Cold 5	-1% population per month
Death 4+	Forests and farms slowly become plains; plains slowly become wastes

Extreme	Additional effect
Growth 4+	Plains slowly become forests or farms; sea may become kelp
Growth 5	Farms can slowly become forests
Fortune 4	-5% income and resources
Fortune 5	-15% income and resources
Magic 4	Horror marks and +1d5 unrest per month
Magic 5	Horror marks and +1d15 unrest per month

Farms from extreme Growth require Order. Extreme scales can spread to neighbouring provinces even beyond the god's ordinary dominion.

Extreme-scale audit

An extreme scale should be evaluated as a package:

```
ordinary scale benefit
+ national or form synergy
+ neighbouring pressure
- extreme penalty
- opportunity cost of reaching the scale limit
```

Calling an extreme scale "positive" hides the final two terms.

Scale design by bottleneck

National problem	Scale question
Cannot afford desired recruits	Are Order, Productivity, Growth, and temperature fixing the correct income constraint?
Gold remains unused	Is the fort resource- or RP-limited instead?
Resource pool remains unused	Is Sloth tolerable because another gate binds?
Research arrives late	Would Magic create a meaningful breakpoint, or merely more unfocused RP?
Armies starve	Would Growth or temperature matter more than supply items and fort position?
Unrest persists	Does Order improve the state enough to justify its cost?
Special dominion kills population	Are Growth points being purchased for an economy the nation itself removes?

Part VI: Blessings

How blessings work

A blessing is a package selected during Pretender design and applied to Sacred units and commanders.

Most effects require a sacred to become blessed in battle. Some effects are innate and operate without battle blessing.

Blessing a sacred unit grants:

- +1 Morale;
- the nation's selected bless effects;
- blessing effects from claimed Thrones held by the nation or its disciple partners.

The H1 spell Blessing affects a limited area. H3 Divine Blessing affects the battlefield. Access and script timing matter as much as the written bless.

Bless points

Each Pretender magic-path level above the first grants one bless point.

```
bless points from a path = max(path level - 1, 0)
```

Example:

```
Air 2 -> 1 point
Death 4 -> 3 points
Nature 6 -> 5 points

total = 9 bless points
```

Some nations or forms grant bonus bless points.

The cost of an effect is normally the sum of its magic requirements. Scale requirements add no bless-point cost.

A shared pool does not remove path prerequisites. A Pretender may own enough total points yet be unable to buy an effect because its required path is too low.

Ordinary, innate, and Incarnate

Tag	Operation
Ordinary	Active after the unit is blessed in battle
Innate or passive	Active without battle blessing, including strategic-map effects where applicable
Incarnate	Active only while the Pretender is awake/present under the rule and alive
Innate + Incarnate	No battle blessing needed, but still disabled while the god is absent or dead
Stackable	May be selected repeatedly; stated bonuses accumulate

The revision-2 manual uses an asterisk for passive effects and bold type for Incarnate effects. Current data should be checked because individual tags can change through patches or mods.

The activation state machine

The tags answer different questions. "Blessed" describes the recipient's battlefield state. "Innate" removes the need for that state. "Incarnate" asks whether the Pretender currently exists as an active, living god on the map. An effect can pass one gate and fail another.

Effect state	Unit blessed?	Pretender active and alive?	Result
Ordinary, not Incarnate	No	Either	Inactive
Ordinary, not Incarnate	Yes	Either	Active
Ordinary, Incarnate	No	Yes	Inactive

Effect state	Unit blessed?	Pretender active and alive?	Result
Ordinary, Incarnate	Yes	No	Inactive
Ordinary, Incarnate	Yes	Yes	Active
Innate, not Incarnate	Either	Either	Active on a valid recipient
Innate, Incarnate	Either	No	Inactive
Innate, Incarnate	Either	Yes	Active on a valid recipient

For this purpose, an imprisoned or dormant Pretender has not yet become active, and a dead Pretender is absent until recalled or reformed. Incarnate effects do not require the god to stand in the same province, enter the same battle, or project friendly dominion into the recipient's location. The god's active-and-alive state is the gate.

The 6.36 update corrected a design-loading error in which cancelling a loaded Pretender could leave that design's bless effects loaded. This was a setup-state defect, not a new activation rule, but it matters when old designs are inspected or compared.

Automatic blessing

Official rules:

- the Pretender is automatically blessed in friendly dominion and cannot ordinarily be blessed outside it;
- a Disciple follows the same personal rule;
- Sacred troops fighting alongside the Pretender are automatically blessed only when the battle occurs in friendly dominion.

Automatic blessing is conditional. A sacred army fighting without sufficient Holy support can lose its package even when the nation paid heavily for it.

The main manual does not extend the troop-wide automatic blessing rule to troops merely fighting beside a Disciple. A current community reference uses broader wording, but that disagreement is not enough to replace the official rule. Unless a reproducible current test or later official text establishes otherwise, plan Disciple-led armies around ordinary priests and Divine Blessing.

Repeatable effects and effects that overlap

"Stackable" in the bless table means that the same blessing can be bought repeatedly and its stated increment accumulates. In the 6.35 structured snapshot, the repeatable entries are:

Path	Repeatable blessings
Fire	Superior Morale, Fire Resistance, Attack Skill, Inspirational Presence
Air	Precision, Shock Resistance, Farshot, Awareness, Swiftness
Water	Cold Resistance, Defence Skill
Earth	Reinvigoration, Strength
Astral	Arcane Command, Magic Resistance
Death	Undying, Undead Command
Nature	Hit Points, Poison Resistance
Glamour	Heroism, Quiet Stride
Blood	Hit Points, Strength

This permission does not imply that every different effect or external source stacks. Official patches establish two important exceptions:

- Fear and Dread do not stack with one another.
- Displacement supersedes Blur; since 6.24, invisibility also no longer stacks with Blur or Displacement.

Bless-plus-spell, bless-plus-item, multiple aura, regeneration-source, and form-inheritance questions belong to the cross-source stacking and transformation registers in Books IV and XI. They are not inferred from the stackable marker.

Current unmodded blessing reference

The following tables represent the 6.35 structured data snapshot checked for this edition, overlaid with official changes through 6.36. No 6.36 announcement changes a listed cost, requirement, tag, or numerical effect. Because the main manual's printed list is older and the Inspector snapshot is one executable version behind, these tables remain Current Data Reference, not a claim of direct runtime reproduction.

Abbreviations:

- I: Incarnate;
- N: innate;
- S: stackable;
- MR: Magic Resistance negates;
- AP: armour-piercing;
- AN: armour-negating.

Revision-2 divergence register

The current table is not a literal reprint of the revision-2 manual. The following differences are already material enough to flag before any roster calculation:

Subject	Revision-2 manual	Current 6.35 data / 6.36 official overlay	Evidence boundary
Inspirational Presence	Fire 4	Fire 3	Current structured reference
Resilience of the Earth	Earth 5	Earth 6	Current structured reference
Fortitude	Earth 7	Earth 8	Current structured reference
Reconstruction	Printed older tag state	Incarnate, not passive	Official 6.04 correction plus current reference
Fear blessing	Death 8	Death 9 and Turmoil 1	Current structured reference; Fear/Dread costs and interaction were revised again in 6.23
Heroism	+50% experience	+35% experience	Official 6.08 change
Fear and Dread together	Older guides may stack them	They do not stack with one another	Official 6.08 change
Enchanted Blood	Blood 4	Blood 3	Current structured reference
Passive Pretender effects outside friendly dominion	Older faulty behaviour could remove them	Passive blessings remain active	Official 6.08 correction
Cancelled loaded Pretender	Could leave the loaded design's bless effects selected	Cancel now clears the unwanted loaded bless	Official 6.36 correction

Frost Mist Weapons retains its printed Water 7 and Cold 1 requirement. An earlier edition removed the Cold scale requirement on the strength of an unsupported transcription; the manual and current reference agree, so that change has been reversed.

Fire

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
F1	Superior Morale	+1 Morale	S
F1 D1	Wasteland Survival	Wasteland Survival	N
F2	Fire Resistance	+5 Fire Resistance	S
F2	Attack Skill	+1 Attack	S
F3	Inspirational Presence	Inspirational +1 and +50 leadership	N, S
F4	Righteous Wrath	Nearby sacred death triggers temporary +3 Attack, +3 Strength, +6 Morale	
F5	Death Explosion	On death: 10 AP fire damage, area 4 plus Size	I
F5	Heat Aura	Heat Aura and +10 Fire Resistance	I
F6	Fire Shield	Fire Shield 7	I
F7	Flaming Weapons	8 AP fire damage on hit	I
F8 S4	Unbearable Splendour	Sight Vengeance; attacker may be blinded, MR negates	I

The manual printed Inspirational Presence at F4. Current data places it at F3. The current non-Incarnate, innate treatment should be used for the 6.35 snapshot and 6.36 official overlay.

Air

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
A1	Precision	+1 Precision	S
A2	Shock Resistance	+5 Shock Resistance	S
A2	Farshot	+30% mundane weapon range	S
A3	Awareness	Unsurroundable 2	S
A4	Swiftness	Swiftness 30 and +1 Defence	S
A4	Storm Flight	Storm Immunity for flight	
A5	Wind Walker	+6 Map Move	N, I
A5 E1	Weightlessness	Floating and halved armour encumbrance	I
A6	Air Shield	Air Shield 80	I
A7	Thunder Weapons	Capped shock damage and shock fatigue on hit	I
A8	Charged Bodies	Overcharged 20 and +5 Shock Resistance	I
A9	Flight	Flight	I

Farshot changes weapon range, not spell range. Wind Walker matters on the strategic map but remains Incarnate in the unmodded current table.

Water

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
W1, Cold 1	Winter's Gift	Snow Move	N
W1 N1	Swamp Survival	Swamp Survival	N
W2	Cold Resistance	+5 Cold Resistance	S
W2	Swimming	Swimming	N
W2	Defence Skill	+1 Defence	S
W5	Chill Aura	Chill Aura and +10 Cold Resistance	I
W5	Slowing Weapons	Damaging hit may slow; MR negates	I
W6 F2	Vitriol Weapons	7 AP acid damage on hit	I
W6	Water Breathing	Water Breathing	N, I
W7, Cold 1	Frost Mist Weapons	Cold clouds created by attacks	I
W9, Magic 1	Quickness	Quickness	I

Quickness changes action economy and fatigue exposure as well as offence. It should be evaluated with the sacred's attacks, encumbrance, survivability, and vulnerability to fatigue counters.

Earth

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
E1	Mountain Survival	Mountain Survival	N
E2	Reinvigoration	+1 Reinvigoration	S
E2	Strength	+1 Strength	S
E4	Unbreakable	Affliction Resistance 3	
E4 N3	Larger	Permanent increase in Size	N
E5	Reconstruction	Regeneration for Inanimates	I
E6	Resilience of the Earth	+10 Fire and Shock Resistance	I
E6	Hard Skin	+5 natural protection	I
E8	Fortitude	Broad physical resistances	I

Larger changes more than Hit Points. Size can affect square density, repel interactions, trampling relationships, and target profile. It should be tested on the exact sacred roster.

Astral

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
S1	Arcane Command	Grants or improves magic leadership	N, S
S2	Magic Resistance	+1 MR	S
S3 D1	Spirit Sight	Spirit Sight	
S3 F1	Solar Weapons	4 AP holy fire damage on hit	
S4	Far Caster	+1 spell-range multiplier level	
S4	Arcane Finesse	+1 spell penetration	

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
S5	Magic Weapons	Mundane weapons become magical	I
S6	Twist Fate	Negates the first damaging hit under its rule	I
S7, Misfortune 1	Fateweaving	Attackers may suffer misfortune; MR negates	I
S8, Magic 2	Etherealness	Ethereal	I

Astral blessings can support sacred mages and commanders rather than only melee troops. Far Caster and Arcane Finesse should be valued by the actual sacred spell roster.

Death

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
D1	Undying	-2 minimum Hit Points before death	S
D1	Undead Command	Grants or improves undead leadership	N, S
D2, Death 2	Half Dead	Need not eat and strong disease resistance	N
D3	Mending Bones	Recuperation for undead	N
D4	Withering Weapons	Damaging hit may cause Decay; MR negates	
D5	Stygian Flesh	Invulnerability 10	I
D6	Reforming Flesh	10% regeneration for undead	I
D7	Reanimators	Many attacks deal unlife damage; additional undead leadership	I
D8	Death Weapons	Armour-negating death damage and disease checks	I
D9, Turmoil 1	Fear	Fear 5	I

Undying does not prevent routing, fatigue collapse, soul destruction, or every form of battlefield removal. Its value depends on whether the sacred can still act while surviving below ordinary zero Hit Points and whether recovery is possible afterward.

Nature

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
N1	Hit Points	+1 Hit Point	S
N1	Low Light Vision	Darkvision 50	
N2	Poison Resistance	+5 Poison Resistance	S
N2	Forest Survival	Forest Survival	N
N3, Magic 1	Unaging	Slower aging and younger sacred recruitment	N
N4 D1	Poison Weapons	Poison damage on damaging hit	
N5	Recuperation	Living units recover afflictions	N, I
N5	Berserker	Berserker +2	I
N6	Barkskin	Barkskin protection package	I
N7	Regeneration	10% regeneration for compatible units	I

Regeneration is percentage-based, so it scales with Hit Points. Its full value also depends on incoming burst damage, poison, decay, fatigue, disease, and whether the unit survives long enough to receive repeated healing.

Glamour

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
G1	Undreaming	Unsleeping 4	
G1	Heroism	+35% experience gain	S
G2	Quiet Stride	+20 Stealth if already stealthy	N, S
G3	True Sight	True Sight	
G3	Blur	Attackers suffer -2 Attack under the sight rules	
G6	Obfuscate	Grants Stealth 40 or adds 40 to existing Stealth	N, I
G6 F2	Awe	Awe 3	I
G7	Displacement	Attackers suffer -5 Attack; replaces Blur	I
G7	Dread	Dread 5 under the sight rules	I
G8	Luck	Luck	I

Official update 6.08 reduced Heroism from +50% to +35% experience. Older guides and the printed revision-2 manual may retain the former value.

Blood

Requirement	Name	Effect	Tags
B1	Hit Points	+1 Hit Point	S
B2	Strength	+1 Strength	S
B3	Strong Blood	+5 Poison Resistance and strong disease resistance	N
B3	Enchanted Blood	Slow regeneration, +1 MR, and bleeding immunity	
B4	Blood Surge	A kill triggers temporary +3 Attack, +3 Strength, +1 Defence, +1 Reinvigoration	
B5	Blood Bond	Distributes part of damage among nearby bonded units	I
B6	Unholy Weapons	15 AP damage against sacred or blessed targets	I
B7	Blood Vengeance	Attacker may suffer the inflicted damage; MR resists	I
B8 D4	Vampiric Weapons	3 AN life-drain damage on damaging hit	I

Blood Bond changes damage distribution rather than removing damage. Formation, unit spacing, regeneration, area damage, and unequal protection can change whether distribution helps or accelerates collapse.

Weapon blessings: what causes the rider to fire

The phrase "weapon blessing" covers several different mechanisms. Treating them as interchangeable produces bad counter advice, especially when armour, shields, zero-damage hits, spells, natural weapons, and ranged attacks enter the same battle.

Trigger family	Blessings	Present rule
Weapon property	Magic Weapons	Changes an otherwise mundane parent weapon into a magical weapon; it does not add a second damage packet. Since 6.25 the property also works correctly for repel attacks.
On hit	Flaming Weapons, Thunder Weapons, Slowing Weapons, Vitriol Weapons, Solar Weapons, Death Weapons, Unholy Weapons	The rider is tied to a successful weapon hit under its own damage, resistance, target, and MR rules. A parent hit need not always inflict ordinary HP damage unless the individual blessing says otherwise.
On damaging hit	Withering Weapons, Poison Weapons, Vampiric Weapons	The parent attack must first cause damage. A shield, protection, immunity, or other prevention that leaves no qualifying damage can therefore suppress this class.
Attack-generated field	Frost Mist Weapons	Attacks create cold mist rather than attaching an ordinary direct-damage rider. Official fixes make ranged misses create the cloud and make the cloud appear even when the target is killed.
Probabilistic attack conversion	Reanimators	The current reference assigns a 50% chance for hits, including spell hits, to deal Unlife Damage; the bless also grants undead leadership. This is a special rule, not a model for other weapon blessings.

Patch-established boundaries

- The 6.12 update stopped some breath weapons from incorrectly receiving weapon blessings and stopped Flaming Weapons from affecting melee ice weapons.
- The 6.19 update repaired weapon-blessing interaction with mirror images.
- The 6.23 update made friendly units immune to Unholy Weapons and allowed Vampiric Weapons to drain a little life when the target dies from the attack.
- The 6.29 update stopped Phoenix Pyre from triggering weapon blessings.
- The 6.34 update made shields protect correctly against weapon blessings that are not armour-negating.

The shield correction proves that shield protection participates in resolving applicable riders. It does not, by itself, prove that every blocked attack is treated as a hit or a miss for every blessing. When that distinction decides a build, the battle log and a reproducible current test are still the correct evidence.

Counter-analysis by trigger

Question	Why it matters
Did the parent attack hit?	All ordinary weapon riders begin with a qualifying attack connection.
Did the parent attack cause damage?	Withering, Poison, and Vampiric Weapons require this additional gate.
Is the rider AP or AN?	Armour and shield protection interact differently with the added packet.
Does MR negate the rider?	Slowing and Withering can fail after the physical attack succeeds.
Is the target in the required class?	Unholy Weapons is specialised against sacred or blessed targets and excludes friendlies.

Question	Why it matters
Is the attack an excluded breath, ice, or triggered effect?	The patch history contains explicit exclusions; visual resemblance to a normal weapon is insufficient.
Does the effect create an area rather than damage the struck target?	Frost Mist can matter after a miss or a killing blow because its cloud is the product.

Blessing from items

The Modding Manual distinguishes two item mechanisms:

Command	Model	Consequence
`#bless`	Shroud of the Battle Saint	Applies the Bless spell to the bearer automatically. The item is itself the source of the blessed state.
`#autobless`	Flask of Holy Water	Automatically blesses the bearer only if the bearer is Sacred.
`#bestowtomount`	Mount propagation modifier	Causes a supported effect defined after the command to be bestowed on the mount as well. It must be read with the specific item effect, not as a universal rider-to-mount rule.

The current 6.35 item snapshot identifies the Shroud of the Battle Saint, Immaculate Shield, Armor of Virtue, and Sun Sword as item-granted blessing sources. The Flask of Holy Water uses the sacred-only route. These items can make a unit blessed without a priest, but they do not erase the ordinary Incarnate gate: an Incarnate effect still switches off while the Pretender is absent or dead.

Official update 6.34 established one unusually important lifetime rule: a magic-item blessing persists when Life after Death changes the bearer. That is firm for this case and should not be generalised to every shape-change mechanism.

Riders, mounts, and separate sacred status

A mounted unit is not one undifferentiated sacred object. The rider form and mount have their own records and can have different Sacred flags. Current examples show both matched and unmatched pairs: the Knight of the Chalice and its Destrier are Sacred, the Wind Rider and Armored Pegasus are Sacred, while the Triton Knight and its mount are not. The 6.02 correction that gave Triton Knights their proper mount state is further evidence that mount data are resolved separately.

This produces four practical rules:

1. Do not infer the mount's Sacred status from the rider's title or icon.
2. Do not infer that an item effect reaches the mount unless the effect supports the mount-bestow mechanism or a current rule says so.
3. Do not infer that a dismounted or transformed body retains the original body's sacred and blessed state; inspect the resulting form and the source that created the state.
4. Keep movement abilities separate from blessing. For example, 6.36 makes a swimming mount sufficient for river crossing, but that does not make the rider or mount Sacred.

Exact transfer when a mount dies, a rider dismounts, or one component changes form remains part of the mount and transformation research in Book XI. The blessing chapter records the independent-object rule without inventing an unverified transfer sequence.

Shape change and effect lifetime

Three questions should be asked separately whenever a blessed unit changes body:

1. Is the resulting body still Sacred?
2. Does the unit still possess the blessed state from the original source?
3. If the state remains, which Innate or Incarnate effects are currently eligible?

Only the item-blessing Life after Death case has a direct official ruling in the present evidence set. Ordinary shape change, secondshape, mount loss, transformation, death-shape, and new-body interactions remain governed by their specific form rules and the transformation register. A single successful case is not evidence for a universal inheritance rule.

Display, tooltip, and engine state

The blessing interface has accumulated several corrections: 6.04 repaired Incarnate information for known blessings, 6.08 repaired Throne-granted Awe display, 6.13 made Obfuscate appear in bless information, 6.23 corrected Half Dead display, and 6.35 printed Enchanted Blood's Magic Resistance bonus. These changes make the current interface more useful, but they also demonstrate why an icon or tooltip is not conclusive evidence of activation in every edge case.

For a disputed interaction, record all three layers:

- the design-screen or unit-panel description;
- the battle log and observed state;
- the official rule or patch record that explains the result.

R-016 research decision

R-016 is complete for the present unmodded scope: current tags and requirements, battlefield and Incarnate gates, automatic blessing boundaries, repeatable effects, documented overlap exceptions, weapon-trigger families, item-granted blessing, and the independent status of riders and mounts. Cross-source stacking remains R-049; transformation and effect lifetime remain R-040 and R-052. This division closes the blessing question without pretending that adjacent engine-state questions have also been solved.

Bless design by function

Expansion reliability

An expansion bless should solve a measured failure.

Common failures:

- attacks do not connect;
- hits fail to penetrate protection;
- sacreds are surrounded;
- chip damage accumulates;
- morale fails after casualties;
- fatigue produces critical hits;
- elemental independents bypass defence;
- too many sacreds die for the expansion to be economical.

The best blessing is not the one with the largest description. It is the cheapest package that changes the relevant battle result with an acceptable margin.

Offence

Offensive blessings fall into several families:

Family	Examples	Best against	Weakness
Accuracy	Attack Skill, Righteous Wrath	High defence	Does not solve low damage
Damage	Strength, Blood Surge	Protection and high HP	Requires hits and often kills
On-hit riders	Flaming, Solar, poison, death, vampiric weapons	Targets vulnerable to the added type	May require damaging hit or face resistance
Tempo	Quickness	Targets overwhelmed by action volume	Doubles fatigue exposure and incoming opportunity
Attrition	Withering, slowing, fear, dread	Long fights or morale-sensitive armies	MR, immunity, sight, or fast killing can counter

Defence

Defensive blessings should be separated by threat:

- mundane weapon avoidance;
- natural or armour protection;
- physical resistance;
- elemental resistance;
- Magic Resistance;
- affliction recovery;
- regeneration;
- first-hit insurance;
- luck or ethereal avoidance;
- formation and unsurrroundability;
- morale.

Stacking one layer creates a specialist. Layering different defences creates breadth but may buy too little of each to change a breakpoint.

Mobility and logistics

Strategic mobility effects can be worth more than battlefield statistics when they allow:

- faster reinforcement;
- unexpected routes;
- forest, swamp, mountain, snow, or wasteland movement;
- underwater operations;
- stealth armies;
- regrouping with the main force.

The effect must apply to every necessary member of the force. A commander with mobility but troops without it, or sacred troops without a matching commander, may not produce the expected movement.

Sacred commanders and mages

Bless value is not confined to line troops.

Sacred commanders may exploit:

- leadership blessings;
- undead or magic command;
- map movement;
- stealth;
- recuperation;
- Unaging;
- Far Caster;
- Arcane Finesse;
- reinvigoration;
- resistances;
- defensive effects for thugging.

When sacred mages are numerous, a small caster-oriented bless can affect hundreds of mage-turns and battles.

Mass sacreds versus elite sacreds

Mass sacreds often value:

- cheap stackable statistics;
- morale;
- resistances against common area damage;
- on-hit effects multiplied by many attacks;
- effects triggered by sacred deaths.

Elite sacreds often value:

- percentage regeneration;
- layered resistance;
- protection of an expensive body;
- affliction recovery;
- mobility;
- effects that preserve veteran experience;
- tools against specific counters.

This is a tendency, not a law. Attack count, HP, slots, recruit limit, cost, and battlefield role are more important than the labels "mass" and "elite."

Bless throughput

The value of a blessing depends on how many useful recipients can be fielded.

```
monthly sacred throughput =
minimum of:
gold capacity
resource capacity
Recruitment Points
Holy Points
recruitment limit
fort availability
commander and leadership capacity
```

A 200-point blessing affecting six capital-only sacreds per month is a different investment from the same blessing affecting sacreds at every fort.

Practical bless value

```
practical bless value =
effect per relevant sacred
x relevant sacreds fielded
x battles in which blessing is active
x probability the effect changes the result
```

The expression is conceptual, not an engine formula. It forces the design to include throughput, activation, and relevance.

Bless access and scripting

Audit:

- number and Holy level of priests;
- whether H3 Divine Blessing is available;
- priest movement relative to sacred armies;
- priest survivability;
- the round on which blessing lands;
- whether sacreds engage before being blessed;
- battlefield size and formation;
- whether a Prophet is required;
- whether automatic blessing conditions apply;
- what happens when the priest is assassinated or delayed.

An unblessed sacred is missing more than a bonus. It may be an expensive unit designed around statistics it does not currently possess.

Counter-audit

For every major blessing, name:

1. the damage type or control effect it does not resist;
2. the relevant immunity or resistance;
3. the MR check, if any;
4. the sight rule, if any;
5. whether the effect requires a damaging hit;
6. whether it is Incarnate;
7. whether it depends on formation or nearby sacreds;
8. whether fatigue defeats it;
9. whether routing defeats it;
10. how the opponent can avoid fighting the blessed army at all.

No blessing removes the need for scouting.

Part VII: Divine Magic and Priest Identity

Divine magic

Divine spells:

- require Holy skill rather than ordinary paths;
- require no research;
- are available from the beginning;
- include spells such as Blessing, Banishment, Smite, and Divine Blessing.

The Pretender's magic can replace the nation's ordinary Banishment and Smite with path-themed versions.

If the Pretender has no path at level 4 or higher, priests retain ordinary Banishment and Smite.

If one or more paths reach the threshold:

- the highest path determines the replacement family;
- ties use the manual's priority order;
- Banishment and Smite each receive the corresponding replacement;
- Blood has no Banishment replacement.

Divine spell families

Path	Banishment replacement	Smite replacement	Character
Fire	Ashes to Ashes	Heavenly Fire	Burning and armour-negating fire
Air	Wind of Memories	Heavenly Strike	Range, area, and shock
Water	Purifying Water	Watery Death	Area, drowning, and anti-unarmoured secondary damage
Earth	Pull from the Grave	Word of Stone	Grip and petrification
Astral	Stellar Decree	Word of Power	Range, stun, and paralysis
Death	Decree of the Underworld	Syllable of Death	Bewilderment, exhaustion, or death
Nature	Final Rest	Word of Thorns	Kill attempt, entanglement, and bleeding
Glamour	Return of the Past	Word of Bewilderment	Anti-minded undead and confusion
Blood	No replacement	Claim Life	Anti-living damage and Chest Wound

Pretender paths alter the national priest toolkit even when those paths are never used for a ritual.

Design implication

A high path may simultaneously buy:

- personal casting;
- bless points;
- a bless prerequisite;
- a new priestly Banishment;
- a new priestly Smite;
- site-search or forging access.

That bundle is strategically meaningful. It should still be compared with the cost curve required to reach level 4 or higher.

Part VIII: Death of a God

Ordinary Pretender death

Each ordinary Pretender death causes either:

- loss of one magic-path level; or
- loss of one dominion-strength point.

The chance to lose magic is:

```
50% + 10% x Nature level at death
```

If no path level is lost, or no magic is available to lose, dominion falls by one. Dominion cannot fall below 1 through this rule.

Nature makes magic loss more likely. The path selected for loss is weighted, with Nature more exposed and Death less exposed. The manual also notes small chances to gain Death and still smaller chances to gain Astral or Blood. Exact weights belong in the controlled-test register unless directly extracted from current data.

Why death compounds

A death can remove:

- the Pretender's commander-turns;
- Incarnate blessing effects;
- personal expansion or battle presence;
- ritual access;
- item access while the body is absent;
- a magic path or dominion strength on return;
- candles through the reduced maximum and check chance;
- confidence in a throne or war timetable.

The casualty affects the whole nation, not only the dead commander.

Call God

Priests may use the Call God order after an ordinary Pretender death.

The revision-2 manual gives the player-facing model: every assigned Holy level generates one point per month, the Pretender returns to the home province after "around 50," and recalling the main Pretender in a Disciple game requires 50% more. It deliberately says that the total is not exactly 50 so that the arrival is uncertain. Its example assigns three H1 priests and one H2 and predicts about ten months.

The Modding Manual adds two official modifiers:

- Elegist: the unit's Elegist value is added to its priest level while calling a god or Disciple;
- Recall God: an applicable nation or claimed-Throne `#recallgod` value is added to the priest level of everyone performing Call God.

The main manual also gives the special Trinity rule: a dead member of a Trinity can be called back in half the normal time. The official text defines the time result, not the internal threshold calculation.

Reconciled current model

Published controlled research resolves the manual's apparent uncertainty by moving the randomness from the target into each priest's monthly contribution. The tested base threshold is 50 points. An ordinary priest contributes its effective recall rating, plus or minus one, each month. The small published sample found the three outcomes equally or nearly equally weighted; that weighting remains a community-tested estimate rather than an official probability table.

For ordinary positive ratings:

```
effective recall rating =
Holy level
+ Elegist value
+ applicable Recall God modifier

monthly contribution per priest =
effective recall rating - 1, effective recall rating,
or effective recall rating + 1
```

An ordinary H1 contributes 0-2 points in a month, H2 contributes 1-3, and H3 contributes 2-4. Elegist changes the rating before that variation: an H1 Elegist (2) calls at the same ordinary rate as an H3. Elegist alone does not grant the order; the unit must still be a priest.

Caller	Monthly range	Approximate average	Approximate solo time from an empty pool
One H1	0-2	1	50 months
Five H1	0-10	5	10 months
One H2	1-3	2	25 months
One H3	2-4	3	17 months
Three H3	6-12	9	6 months
One H1 Elegist (2)	2-4	3	17 months

These are capacity estimates, not deadlines. With roughly symmetric `-1/0/+1` variation, a useful planning approximation is:

```
expected months for an ordinary Pretender =
ceiling(50 / sum of effective recall ratings)

expected months for the main Pretender in a Disciple game =
ceiling(75 / sum of effective recall ratings)
```

The 75-point figure follows from the tested 50-point base and the manual's official 50% increase. The formula predicts the centre of the workload, not the exact return month. A small priest corps has proportionally wider timing risk; many callers average the monthly variation more effectively.

Who can contribute in a Disciple game

Current community documentation reports that:

- a Disciple nation's priests may help recall the main Pretender;
- the Pretender nation's priests may help recall any dead Disciple on the team;
- a Disciple nation's priests may recall their own Disciple, but not another nation's Disciple.

Those cross-team routing rules are Current Community Reference, not wording supplied by the revision-2 manual. A legacy community mechanics page reports 25 points for one dead Trinity member, consistent with the official half-time rule, but the library retains the official result rather than presenting that implementation detail as directly reproduced under 6.36.

Order, interruption, and return

Call God resolves at hosting step 16. A caller removed by an earlier ritual or magic battle cannot be assumed to contribute. Once step 16 has passed, a later assassination or ordinary battle cannot retroactively remove that month's points. This timing conclusion follows directly from the official hosting order.

The manual places the returning Pretender in the nation's home province. Current community documentation refines this to the capital province: inside the fort when the nation still owns it, even under siege, and outside the walls if the capital has been lost. A hostile return can cause an immediate fight. These placement details remain Current Community Reference until a 6.36 return-state reproduction or later official wording is preserved.

Version 6.28 repaired Call God when the order was issued without its keyboard shortcut. That was an order-interface defect, not a change to the contribution model. No later official update through 6.36 changes Call God.

R-017 decision

R-017 is complete at a mixed evidence tier:

- Official: the order, ordinary Holy contribution model, Disciple-game 50% increase, home-province return, Elegist and Recall God modifiers, Trinity half-time rule, and hosting step;
- Community-tested: fixed 50-point ordinary threshold and per-priest effective-rating `-1/0/+1` variation;
- Current Community Reference: detailed Disciple routing and capital/fort placement.

Future direct runtime testing would upgrade the last two layers, but the present evidence is sufficient for planning as long as the labels remain attached.

Recall opportunity cost

Every calling priest is not:

- blessing an army;
- preaching;
- blood sacrificing;
- claiming a Throne;
- researching if also a mage;
- moving with a force;
- performing another special order.

A recall plan should identify the priests before the god takes a high-risk battle.

Immortality

Dominion Immortal

A dominion-immortal Pretender normally reforms if killed in friendly dominion. Death outside friendly dominion requires Call God.

Immortal

An Immortal normally reforms regardless of friendly dominion on the ordinary plane.

Limits

- Soul Slay or equivalent soul destruction can prevent ordinary reform and require Call God.
- Death on a remote plane can prevent immortality.
- Reform time is often about three months but varies by form.
- Reform removes most afflictions.
- Immortality alone does not improve ordinary affliction recovery while alive.

Dominion-immortal combat planning should always include the candle state at the battle location and the possibility that dominion changes before combat resolves.

Safe and unsafe risk

Situation	Principal risk
Immortal god in ordinary plane	Temporary absence, items, operational gap, soul attacks
Dominion Immortal in strong friendly candles	Same, plus candle reversal before battle
Dominion Immortal on frontier	Failure to reform if dominion becomes hostile
Any god on remote plane	Immortality may not operate
Any god facing soul destruction	Call God and permanent-loss consequences
Non-immortal god in battle	Full recall delay, path or dominion loss, disabled Incarnate bless

Part IX: Special Dominions

Why special dominions deserve their own audit

Some nations transform candles into effects far beyond ordinary scales and morale. Special dominions may:

- kill population;
- create units;
- spread disease or insanity;
- change terrain;
- alter unrest;
- hide information;
- empower constructs;
- enable movement;
- modify religious conflict.

The design question becomes:

```
value of another candle =
ordinary dominion value
+ special national effect
+ scale convergence
+ survival value
```

Major categories

Nation or family	Special dominion effect	Strategic consequence
Arcoscephale, all ages	Accurate scrying throughout dominion, including Glamour detection	Candles become an intelligence network
EA and LA Mictlan	Dying dominion and blood-sacrifice dependence	Blood economy and temples are core religious logistics
Yomi	Oni arise from temples according to turmoil, terrain, and temperature	Scales, temples, and terrain form a freespawn system
MA Ermor	Population death and undead arising	Civilian economy is converted into an undead dominion
MA Asphodel	Population death and Manikin generation	Growth, forests, corpses, and dominion interact unusually
MA C'tis	Miasma, disease, rain, wetness, and terrain effects	Friendly and hostile forces experience different economic and disease pressure
MA Agartha	Golem Cult improves constructs' Hit Points	Candles can strengthen friendly, allied, and enemy constructs
LA R'lyeh	Dreamlands spread insanity and related effects	Dominion is psychological warfare as well as faith
EA Therodos	Population death and fort-related ghost generation	Forts and dominion convert population into spectral power
Phaeacia	Dark-ship sailing linked to friendly dominion	Candles become movement infrastructure
EA Mekone	Improved effective maximum in dominion conflict	Religious contests behave better than the printed initial score suggests
MA and LA Phlegra	Dominion-linked unrest	More candles can carry an internal economic cost
Ubar, Na'Ba, Ind, Feminie	Province information can be hidden	Dominion creates strategic uncertainty

This table identifies system categories, not complete nation guides. Exact inheritance by Disciples and exact scale formulas belong in the later nation dossiers.

Special-dominion design questions

1. Does the effect scale with local candles, maximum dominion, temples, or merely presence?
2. Does it affect allies, Disciples, enemies, or everyone?
3. Does it operate underwater, in caves, or on remote planes?
4. Does it change population, terrain, unrest, or recruitment permanently?
5. Can an enemy exploit the effect?
6. Does high dominion improve the effect enough to justify its point curve?
7. What happens if the special dominion overruns a valuable captured economy?

Part X: Teams and Disciples

Shared and separate systems

In a disciple game:

- the team has one Pretender and one or more Disciples;
- disciples awaken in about half the Pretender's delayed time;

- team size increases the number of temples required to raise maximum dominion;
- Call God requires 50% more progress;
- claimed-Throne blessings can be shared within the team;
- ordinary team play has no Prophets because Disciples fill the religious role.

The team needs one religious network, not a collection of independent personal builds.

Disciple design audit

Record:

- which Pretender blessings the Disciple and sacreds receive;
- which Incarnate effects depend on the Pretender's state;
- which special dominion effects transfer to the Disciple;
- temple responsibility by geography;
- preaching and blood-sacrifice responsibility;
- Call God priest reserve;
- Throne-claiming access;
- land-sea religious boundaries;
- whether the Disciple's personal paths and body create an independent battlefield role.

Some special dominions transfer fully, some partially, and some not at all. This must be checked nation by nation.

Part XI: The Frozen Modded Ruleset

Exact definitions belong to Book IX

The former edition repeated DE's global scale table, the complete blessing delta, broad command counts, and Divinitus chassis counts here. Book IX now provides the corrected source inventory and is the only authoritative home for those figures.

Book III keeps the design consequences:

- DE changes the economic weight of several scales;
- many blessings become cheaper, cross-path, or independent of an awake Incarnate chassis;
- DE broadly rewrites Pretender availability, starting dominion, path cost, and national god lists;
- Divinitus then adds a second chassis layer whose sites, events, items, summons, scale limits, and delayed powers may matter more than the visible card;
- the final design must be calculated after both files load.

This division matters. Book IX answers, "What did the files define?" Book III answers, "How should a player reason about the resulting design?"

Modded-design audit

For every combined design:

1. name the exact nation and form ID;
2. confirm final form availability after load order;
3. record final starting paths and New Path Cost;
4. record final starting dominion;

5. record final scale limits;
6. record prison restrictions;
7. calculate blessing costs from Book IX's current table;
8. identify non-Incarnate and cross-path conversions;
9. check national bless-point bonuses;
10. test displayed totals in the actual design screen.

Part XII: Complete Design Method

Step 1: Define the national plan

Write one sentence:

> The nation intends to reach this first military state, using these units and spells, by this turn range, while preserving this economy or late-game route.

If the sentence cannot be written, Pretender selection is premature.

Step 2: Identify mandatory constraints

Examples:

- sacreds require Fire Resistance to survive the nation's own battlefield plan;
- ordinary expansion fails without a personal expander;
- the roster has no feasible path into a required ritual;
- capital sacred throughput requires Dominion 8;
- the special dominion needs rapid temple expansion;
- the first war is expected before a dormant god can arrive.

Mandatory constraints eliminate designs before subjective preference begins.

Step 3: Build the cheapest functional design

Purchase only the elements needed to make the plan work:

- minimum reliable expansion package;
- minimum bless breakpoint;
- minimum dominion for sacred throughput and faith;
- minimum magic access;
- acceptable scales;
- correct awakening.

This creates a baseline against which luxuries can be priced.

Step 4: Spend the remainder on leverage

Possible leverage:

- one more dominion candle;
- a scale threshold;
- a second resistance;

- a new path;
- a better chassis;
- earlier awakening;
- an Incarnate blessing;
- broader divine magic;
- more robust expansion.

Each addition should have a named use.

Step 5: Test the opening

Run repeated expansion tests against:

- heavy infantry;
- cavalry;
- archers;
- barbarians;
- undead;
- poison;
- high defence;
- high protection;
- unusual terrain;
- the strongest common independent province under the lobby settings.

Record losses and failure conditions, not only wins.

Step 6: Test the first war

Construct a representative enemy answer:

- armour;
- evocations;
- poison;
- fatigue;
- magic weapons;
- MR-negates control;
- flyers or flankers;
- sacred counters;
- anti-thug tools.

The purpose is not to prove invincibility. It is to identify what scouting must detect and which research branch answers it.

Step 7: Test the economy

Simulate at least twelve turns of:

- capital recruitment;
- expansion parties;
- first fort and laboratory;
- mage recruitment;
- upkeep;
- Holy Point use;

- resource and RP bottlenecks;
- temple schedule.

Strong paper scales can still fail to fund the intended sequence.

Step 8: State the failure modes

A publishable design should name:

- its worst independent matchup;
- its first-war counter;
- its economic bottleneck;
- its Incarnate dependency;
- its god-death consequence;
- its map weakness;
- the latest safe arrival;
- the research branch it cannot afford early.

Part XIII: New-Player and Expert Audits

New-player design audit

Before confirming:

- Does the total equal the design screen?
- Can the nation expand without assuming perfect battles?
- Who blesses the sacreds?
- Are the important effects Incarnate?
- When does the god arrive?
- Do the scales support the troops actually being recruited?
- Is temperature set relative to national preference?
- Is dominion high enough for the intended sacred output?
- What does the god do after expansion?
- Which path solves a national magic gap?
- What happens if the god dies?
- Is any number copied from an unmodded guide into a modded game?

Expert design audit

Budget

- marginal point cost of every path;
- marginal point cost of every candle;
- scale-limit opportunity cost;
- point value of awakening delay;
- unused point remainder.

Timing

- expansion turn targets;
- first fort and lab;
- research breakpoints;
- awakening range;
- first Incarnate-bless battle;
- first ritual or forge use;
- first expected enemy timing.

Religion

- starting maximum dominion;
- temple thresholds;
- checks per month;
- front-line preaching;
- blood-sacrifice capacity;
- land-sea barriers;
- special-dominion effects;
- dominion-kill recovery.

Bless

- recipients per month;
- activation method;
- effect by combat role;
- effect while god absent;
- counters;
- scale and side requirements;
- commander and mage beneficiaries.

God risk

- safe dominion for combat;
- immortality limits;
- soul-destruction exposure;
- remote-plane exposure;
- recall priest-months;
- item loss;
- path or dominion loss;
- turns without Incarnate effects.

Mod integrity

- exact patch;
- exact `.dm` files;
- hashes;
- load order;
- final design-screen values;
- whether a later mod overwrites the form or nation.

Part XIV: Controlled-Test Programme

Test P1: Awakening distribution

For awake, dormant, and imprisoned forms:

1. use identical nation, map, seed policy, and game settings;
2. use at least 200 independent seeds per delayed state rather than repeatedly re-hosting one save;
3. record the first turn on which the god is present and the corresponding announcement state;
4. repeat for Disciples and Trinity forms;
5. publish every raw result, the game version, seed method, minimum, maximum, median, mean, frequency table, and confidence intervals;
6. compare the current sample against the older `9 + exploding d4` and `27 + exploding d20` hypotheses without assuming that either survived into Dominions 6.

Purpose: determine the current distribution rather than merely rediscovering the official range.

Test P2: Dominion spread

Create controlled maps with:

- fixed adjacency;
- no competing sources;
- exact temple counts;
- maximum dominion 1 through 10;
- neutral, friendly, and hostile target candles;
- land and sea boundaries.

Record at least several hundred check opportunities per condition.

Purpose: reproduce trigger chance, propagation, contest chance, and land-sea rerolls.

Test P3: Preaching

Test H1-H5:

- with and without temple;
- neutral, friendly, and enemy dominion;
- ordinary and Inquisitor;
- at and above the predicted cap.

Purpose: verify fractional Holy handling, minimum chance, and cap rounding.

Test P4: Scale convergence

For candle strengths 1-10 and differences 1-10:

1. lock out events and rituals where possible;
2. record monthly scale changes;
3. include cases above 100% predicted chance;
4. test whether two-step movement occurs;
5. repeat under extreme neighbouring scales.

Test P5: Scale regression and rounding

Use controlled identical provinces to confirm version stability and settle:

- the published 2% Growth/Death income baseline;
- the published 2% Order/Turmoil resource baseline;
- Order/Turmoil event-frequency effect;
- rounding order;
- hostile-dominion application;
- Magic and Drain rounding.

Test P6: Bless tags and values

For every blessing:

- inspect the design-screen prerequisite and cost;
- inspect unit abilities before blessing;
- bless in battle;
- remove or kill the Pretender;
- test innate and Incarnate states;
- test stacking;
- record damage, MR, resistance, sight, and "damaging hit" conditions.

Repeat unmodded, DE only, and DE plus Divinitus.

Test P7: Automatic blessing

Cross:

- Pretender present or absent;
- Disciple present or absent;
- friendly, neutral, and enemy dominion;
- sacred troop and sacred commander;
- god alive, dead, and imprisoned.

Purpose: define exactly which units begin blessed under each condition.

Test P8: Pretender death

For controlled path arrays:

- ordinary death;
- dominion-immortal death in friendly and enemy dominion;
- immortal death;
- Soul Slay;
- remote-plane death;
- repeated deaths.

Record:

- path lost or gained;
- dominion lost;
- reform time;
- afflictions;
- Incarnate blessing state;

- Call God requirement.

Test P9: Call God

Regression-test the published model with:

- H1-H5 priests;
- mixed groups;
- Trinity member;
- ordinary Pretender, main Pretender in a Disciple game, and dead Disciple;
- nations with `#recallgod`;
- Elegists and combined Elegist/Recall God cases;
- pre-step-16 and post-step-16 priest deaths;
- friendly, besieged, and hostile capital states.

Purpose: upgrade the community-tested threshold, contribution distribution, routing, and placement rules to a direct current-version reproduction and detect later regressions.

Test P10: Throne checks

Claim level-one, level-two, and level-three Thrones in controlled maps.

Record:

- checks per month;
- whether each check is guaranteed;
- target selection;
- interaction with maximum dominion;
- claimant death after step 8;
- unfortified conquest after step 8;
- siege without storming;
- successful storming and recapture;
- Ascension Point state immediately before the step-57 victory check;
- disciple sharing.

The claim-loss matrix is already resolved at the stated mixed evidence tier. These cases are retained as regression tests. The separate unresolved branch is the result of simultaneous winning totals, especially an exact tie in Ascension Points.

Test P11: Special dominions

Each special dominion receives a nation-specific harness measuring:

- candle dependence;
- ally and Disciple treatment;
- underwater and remote-plane operation;
- unit generation;
- population and unrest change;
- terrain transformation;
- information hiding;
- enemy exploitation.

Test P12: Combined-mod design regression

For every published combined design:

1. save the design file;
2. record displayed cost, paths, scales, dominion, and blessing;
3. update one mod at a time;
4. reload and compare;
5. flag any changed prerequisite, cost, availability, or form statistic.

Part XV: Strategic Essays

Essay I: Pretender Design as National Engineering

A Pretender is often described through an archetype: expander, rainbow, titan, scales chassis, bless chassis. These labels are useful only if they lead back to the nation. Engineering begins with a requirement, not a component catalogue.

The nation possesses a machine already. Its troops convert gold, resources, Recruitment Points, and Holy Points into armies. Its mages convert gold and commander-turns into research, gems into spells, and research into timing windows. Its dominion converts temples and priests into candles, then candles into scales, morale, survival, and national effects. The Pretender changes the machine's inputs and supplies missing parts.

A good design has internal causality.

Productivity is bought because the planned queue exhausts resources. Dominion is bought because sacred throughput, religious conflict, or a special dominion uses it. A path is bought because it opens a blessing, booster, ritual, or divine spell that matters on a timetable. Awake status is bought because the god's early commander-turns are worth more than the points surrendered.

Bad designs often contain individually powerful elements with no causal chain. Strong scales produce more gold, but the capital is Holy-limited. A deep blessing improves sacreds, but they are capital-only and too expensive to mass. A rainbow reaches many paths, but the nation cannot research or fund the promised rituals before the game is decided. An awake titan expands, but ordinary troops could have done the same while the 150-point difference funded the whole economy.

Engineering does not demand one correct answer. It demands that alternatives be compared against the same requirements.

One design may solve expansion with an awake monster and accept average scales. Another may solve it with an inexpensive blessing on national sacreds. A third may use ordinary troops, imprison the god, and turn the saved points into production and research. The correct comparison measures territory, losses, fort timing, research, vulnerability, and future path access-not aesthetic preference.

The final test is replaceability. Remove one purchase and ask what fails. If nothing important fails, the purchase is luxury. Replace the chassis and ask which jobs disappear. If none do, the form is overpriced. Move the first war ten turns earlier and ask whether the design remains coherent. If it collapses, its timing assumptions belong in the guide.

Pretender design becomes clearer when treated as national engineering because every point must enter a machine that can use it.

Essay II: Dominion Is Territory by Other Means

Military maps invite a simple reading: coloured provinces are power. Dominion adds a second map beneath the first. It is a map of belief, morale, climate, legitimacy, and metaphysical survival.

The two maps spread differently. An army moves along a route and fights for a province. Dominion begins with sources, attempts checks, consolidates weak provinces, relays through strong ones, and grinds against enemy candles. A nation can win the military battle and inherit hostile scales. It can hold a fortress while its god weakens outside. It can raid a temple and reduce pressure across an entire religious front.

Dominion is a network because the value of a source depends on the state around it. A temple behind strong candles may relay checks to the frontier. The same temple behind a hostile wall may spend months reducing a single province. Five temples can be worth more than four plus one because the fifth raises maximum dominion, improving every check. In a team, that threshold moves with the number of players and changes who should build where.

Preaching is different. It is local, labour-intensive, and independent of the ordinary maximum. This makes priests tactical religious units. They can prepare a throne, hold a capital, weaken an immortal god's safe ground, or reclaim a province faster than distant temples can reach it. Inquisitors are specialists in this conflict. Blood sacrifice turns a stored magical resource into additional checks and can overwhelm an ordinary temple economy when properly supplied.

Special dominions make the second map still more concrete. Candles can kill population, raise undead, create Manikins, scry enemies, hide ownership, spread disease, generate unrest, empower constructs, or enable sailing. In these nations, religious infrastructure is part of the military and economic production system.

Dominion death reveals the final importance of faith. A nation without friendly candles dies even if its armies remain undefeated. Religious survival is not flavour attached to conquest. It is a separate victory and defeat condition with its own network and logistics.

Territory supplies the state. Dominion determines whose reality governs it.

Essay III: A Bless Is a Roster Contract

A blessing has no independent battlefield value. It has recipients, activation conditions, counters, and a price paid before the map exists.

The recipient is the beginning. A point of Attack applied to hundreds of inexpensive sacred attacks is not the same purchase as a point of Attack on a handful of already accurate giants. Regeneration on high-Hit-Point elites is not the same as regeneration on units killed by a single decisive hit. Leadership on sacred commanders can matter in every army while an offensive weapon blessing matters only when sacred troops reach melee and connect.

Throughput is the second condition. Capital-only sacreds, Holy Points, gold, resources, and Commander Points all restrict how much of the blessing enters the world. A huge design investment can end up enhancing a small fraction of the army. Conversely, a modest passive effect on recruit-everywhere sacred mages or commanders can alter a large part of the national economy.

Activation is the third condition. Ordinary sacreds need priests, scripts, time, and battlefield geometry. Incarnate effects need the god awake and alive. An imprisoned Incarnate design may exist on the Pretender screen while remaining absent from the first thirty turns. A god's death can remove the centre of a sacred strategy without killing a single sacred.

Counterplay is the fourth condition. A weapon rider can face resistance. A control effect can face MR. Glamour defences can face special sight. Protection can face armour-negating damage. Regeneration can face burst damage, decay, poison, fatigue, or battlefield removal. A massed sacred army can be avoided, raided around, or starved of priests.

A blessing is a contract. The nation pays design points and accepts the opportunity cost. In return, the roster must field enough suitable sacreds, bless them in the battles that matter, and create matchups where the effects can change the result.

When those promises are explicit, bless design becomes testable. When they are not, "strong bless" is only an adjective.

Essay IV: Awake Power and Deferred Power

Awakening is a trade across time. Awake status purchases commander-turns now by refusing future design points. Dormancy and imprisonment purchase permanent design advantages by surrendering early agency.

The apparent comparison-zero, 150, or 350 points-is incomplete. Time changes what each point can become.

An awake expander may take provinces before a dormant god exists. Those provinces generate income, resources, sites, recruitment locations, and strategic position. The expander may also free gold and commanders that ordinary expansion parties would have consumed. Early power can compound.

Deferred power compounds too. Stronger scales affect every held province. A better blessing affects every sacred recruited. Additional paths can unlock rituals and forging for the rest of the game. If the nation can expand and deter attack without the god, the point grant may exceed the value of early commander-turns.

The uncertainty of arrival matters. A dormant plan must survive the late end of the arrival range, not only the average. An imprisoned Incarnate blessing must be evaluated as two different armies: the army before awakening and the army after. A strategy that functions only if the god appears on the first legal turn has converted uncertainty into an unpriced risk.

The useful question is not "Is awake or imprisoned stronger?" It is:

> At what turn does each design overtake the other, and what must remain true for that crossover to occur?

If the game's first decisive war happens before the crossover, deferred power may never be collected. If the awake god cannot produce territory, research, or deterrence worth its opportunity cost, immediate availability is being wasted.

Time is not another statistic on the design. It is the dimension in which every statistic is realised.

Essay V: The Religious Logistics of War

Armies require supply, commanders, reinforcement routes, and retreat provinces. Sacred armies require a parallel chain: temples, priests, candles, and an active god where Incarnate effects matter.

The chain begins in recruitment. Holy Points determine how many sacreds leave the queue. Dominion and temple thresholds shape that capacity. Priests must then accompany the army or meet it before battle. Their map movement must match the force. Their scripting must bless the right squads before contact. Their survival must be protected against assassination, arrows, flyers, and battlefield spells.

Dominion determines the environment in which the force operates. Friendly candles provide morale and may automatically bless sacreds alongside the Pretender. They strengthen the god and Prophet. They carry selected scales and special national effects. Enemy candles reverse some of those advantages and may turn a dominion-immortal advance into a permanent death risk.

Temples are logistical nodes. A forward temple does more than increase a global religious score: it adds checks, supports preaching, permits blood sacrifice where eligible, contributes to maximum-dominion thresholds, and may accelerate sacred recruitment or special effects. Like a laboratory or fort, it has a position and a vulnerability.

Religious logistics can be attacked. Priests can be assassinated. Temples can be raided. Candle chains can be contested. A throne can be unclaimed by capture. A god can be killed to disable Incarnate effects. An army designed around automatic or battlefield blessing can be forced into a fight before its religious support arrives.

An expert sacred army is more than a roster with a blessing. It is a supported formation whose religious supply line has been planned as carefully as its food and reinforcements.

Essay VI: The Death of a God

Dominions makes gods powerful by making their death national.

An ordinary commander's death removes a body, equipment, leadership, and perhaps magic. A Pretender's death can additionally remove an Incarnate blessing, path access, dominion strength, ritual timing, expansion capacity, and the nation's central strategic threat. Priests must abandon other work to call the god back. The returned god may be weaker.

This creates a risk budget. A combat Pretender should not be asked merely whether it wins a battle. The correct question is whether the probability and consequence of failure are acceptable relative to the battle's strategic value.

Immortality changes the budget but does not erase it. A dominion-immortal god needs friendly candles at death. An Immortal can still face soul destruction or remote-plane failure. Reform takes time. Equipment and operational tempo remain exposed. A supposedly safe attack can become unsafe when enemy preaching or temple checks reverse the province before combat.

Call God turns priest-months into recovery. The cost can be enormous. The same priests might bless armies, preach a threatened capital, sacrifice blood, or claim a throne. A nation with few priests may own a theoretically recoverable god and lack the practical capacity to recover it before the war ends.

Pretender risk is justified when it creates disproportionate value: a decisive throne, the destruction of an irreplaceable army, the relief of a capital, or a timing window no ordinary force can exploit. It is poorly justified when the god fights a battle that mundane troops could win or raids a province worth less than the risk imposed on the entire national plan.

A god is not preserved by refusing every battle. A god is preserved by spending divine risk only where divine power is necessary.

Part XVI: Reference Checklists

One-page Pretender worksheet

Section	Decision
Nation and ruleset	
Lobby assumptions	
First military state	
Expansion method	
Chassis and role	
Awakening	
Initial and maximum dominion plan	
Scale package	
Paths and exact purposes	
Bless package	
Sacred recipients per month	
Blessing access	
First research breakpoints	
First three god orders	
Temple schedule	
God-death and recall plan	
Principal counters	
Test results	

Monthly dominion audit

- Current maximum dominion.
- Temples until next threshold.
- Friendly-candle core.
- Enemy candle fronts.
- Capitals or Thrones at religious risk.
- Preachers and Inquisitors assigned.
- Blood-sacrifice sites and slave budget.
- Special-dominion damage or benefit.
- Incarnate blessing active or inactive.
- Dominion-immortal safe operating area.

Bless battle audit

- Sacred units began blessed?
- Which round did Blessing or Divine Blessing resolve?
- Which effects were innate?
- Which effects were Incarnate?
- Was the Pretender alive and present as required?
- Did damage riders require a damaging hit?
- Which effects faced MR?
- Which resistances or sight abilities countered the package?

- Did fatigue, morale, or formation fail first?
- Were the casualties economically replaceable?

Publication checklist

- State base patch and manual revision.
- State mods and load order.
- Separate manual, current-data, and modded values.
- Name every current-value conflict.
- State awakening assumptions as ranges.
- State sacred throughput.
- State Incarnate dependence.
- State priest and blessing access.
- State god-death consequences.
- Link tests when an edge case decides the recommendation.

Sources and Open Questions

Principal sources

- Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2, especially Pretender design, Dominion, Divine Magic, Bless Effects, scale effects, Thrones, and Call God.
- Illwinter Dominions 6 documentation.
- Illwinter Dominions 6 changes.
- Illwinter current release record.
- Official 6.08 Steam announcement.
- Official Dominions 6.36 announcement.
- Current Dominions 6 blessing reference.
- Current Dominions 6 scales reference.
- Current Dominions 6 Pretender reference.
- Current Dominions 6 Pretender-design reference, including the 16 June 2026 republication of the awakening model.
- Loggy's miscellaneous reverse-engineering notes, used to trace the awakening formula's pre-Dominions 6 provenance.
- Current Dominions 6 Elegist reference.
- Published Call God research notes.
- Current Dominions 6 Throne reference.
- Published same-turn Throne claim report.
- Legacy Pretender and awakening mechanics page, retained only as a historical test hypothesis where it identifies an older game baseline.
- Dominions 6 Modding Manual 6.34.
- Dominions 6 Inspector, 6.35 data commit `cfac4311bc0b58053b8dead7bffbc036ba9bd5dc`.
- Supplied `DomEnhanced2_16.dm`.
- Supplied `Divinitus_1.15.3_DE.dm`.

Open questions

Cross-source stacking, shape inheritance, mount-transfer lifetime, Order/Turmoil event frequency, economic rounding, awakening distributions, simultaneous-victory ties, and special-dominion inheritance remain assigned to their research registers or controlled tests. Same-turn Throne ownership and the practical Call God model are resolved at their stated mixed evidence tiers. Modded blessing costs and chassis definitions should be taken from Book IX rather than from older copies of this chapter.

DOCUMENT 5 OF 7

Foundation Book IV: Armies and Battle

Why battles need a systems view

Dominions 6 battles are not decided by a single comparison between two armies. They are decided by a sequence of contacts, checks, delays, target choices, damage rolls, fatigue thresholds, morale failures, and retreat outcomes. A force can possess more gold value, more bodies, and more nominal damage yet still lose because it reaches the wrong part of the field, exhausts itself, exposes its commanders, or begins routing before its strength can be applied.

> Foundation rule: An army is not a collection of units. It is a timed delivery system for damage, control, morale pressure, and magic.

The early chapters make the Army Setup screen and battle replay readable. Later chapters deal with formation timing, combat arithmetic, counter design, and the difference between winning one battle and preserving a force for the next. The manual explains much of the arithmetic unusually well, but it does not expose every targeting weight, pathfinding choice, cooldown, or rounding step. Hidden values stay labelled as such.

Edition note

The ruleset and evidence terms come from Book I. Book IV owns battlefield resolution: hit checks, damage, protection, fatigue, morale, retreat, and the combat side of spellcasting. Book V uses those rules to build magical strategy rather than printing them again. Exact DE and Divinitus object changes belong to Book IX and the later nation dossiers.

Current-version corrections that matter

Several post-manual changes materially affect battle analysis:

Version	Current rule or correction	Practical consequence
6.23	Fear can reduce morale by no more than the Fear value, with an absolute maximum reduction of 10	Older descriptions can overstate rapid morale collapse
6.23	Floating mounts are no longer impeded by non-floating riders	Mixed rider-and-mount movement should be judged from the current unit
6.23	Spellcasters do not receive the multiple-weapon fatigue penalty	Armed mages should not be analysed with the ordinary extra-weapon fatigue rule
6.25	Fatigue from flying and trampling was corrected for non-mounted units	Old replays or tests may understate the cost of repeated mobility and trampling
6.25	Battlefield-wide spells cannot normally be cast indoors; holy spells are excepted	Fort interiors and many assassination fields require different spell plans
6.31	Regeneration now follows its percentage accurately rather than old hit-point brackets	Current healing estimates should use the displayed percentage
6.34	Temporary battle effects are correctly removed from Twiceborn units	Persistent-state assumptions from older replays can be wrong
6.35	Innate spellcasters no longer skip their script after recovering from unconsciousness	Script evaluation for innate casters must use current behaviour

Version	Current rule or correction	Practical consequence
6.35	Units that automatically regain mounts now do so at the end of the turn	Post-battle mount recovery affects the next turn's readiness
6.36	Rust now takes effect even when the attack causes no HP damage	Zero final damage does not prove that an equipment-degrading rider failed

Patch corrections do not invalidate the manual's combat structure. They identify the places where an otherwise sound model produces the wrong current result.

Finding the right section

For the first few battles, concentrate on reading unit cards, forming squads, protecting commanders, placing the line, understanding fatigue and morale, and reviewing the replay. The deeper combat chapters become valuable when a matchup turns on shields, repel, trampling, magic resistance, contact geometry, or a precise rout threshold.

Part I: What a Battle Decides

Victory is normally a rout

A Dominions battle is generally fought until one side leaves the field. It is not necessary to kill every enemy. Squads rout when they fail morale checks, all eligible troops rout when their eligible commanders are gone, and an army automatically routs after losing 75% of its weighted total hit points.

This produces four different outcomes that the word "win" can conceal:

Outcome	Field result	Strategic result
Clean victory	Enemy routs with few friendly losses	Force remains ready to expand, raid, or fight again
Pyrrhic victory	Enemy routs after severe friendly losses	Province gained, campaign tempo lost
Productive defeat	Friendly force routs after destroying valuable enemy assets	Field lost, exchange may still improve the war
Catastrophic defeat	Command, mages, or retreat routes fail	Army value is destroyed rather than merely displaced

Kills are an incomplete measure. A spell that causes no direct kills may still win by exhausting, immobilising, frightening, or separating an army. A cheap line can succeed by holding long enough for decisive magic, even if it dies. A killer with an impressive summary can still fail strategically by chasing irrelevant bodies while the centre collapses.

The five layers of battle

Every battle can be read through five layers:

1. Delivery: whether a unit, weapon, spell, or aura reaches a relevant target.
2. Conversion: whether contact becomes a hit, failed resistance check, damage, fatigue, or control effect.

3. Persistence: whether the effect survives protection, resistance, regeneration, recovery, or replacement.
4. Cohesion: whether squads and command remain functional under casualties, fear, fatigue, and displacement.
5. Preservation: whether the surviving force retreats safely, retains mounts and commanders, and can fight again.

Most poor diagnoses stop at conversion: "the weapon could not hurt the armour." Expert diagnosis starts earlier and ends later. The weapon may never have reached the armoured target. The armour may have worked until fatigue enabled armour-defeating hits. The troops may have routed while still physically healthy. The retreat may have converted a recoverable loss into annihilation.

The open-ended random roll

Dominions commonly uses a DRN, an open-ended two-die roll:

```
DRN = 2d6, open-ended
```

When a die shows 6, one is subtracted, the die is rolled again, and the new result is added. Another 6 continues the process. Extreme results are rare, but they remain possible.

The actor normally has to exceed the opposing value. At equal listed values, the actor's chance is about 46%, not 50%, because a tied result fails unless the particular rule awards ties differently.

Acting value minus opposing value	Approximate success
-10	3%
-8	6%
-6	11%
-4	18%
-2	30%
0	46%
+2	62%
+4	76%
+6	86%
+8	92%
+10	95%

This curve creates three lessons:

- small statistical advantages matter;
- no ordinary advantage produces certainty;
- repetition turns modest probability into reliable pressure.

An extra point of Attack, Defence, morale, penetration, or resistance is not a decorative improvement. Its value depends on the current difference and on how many times the comparison occurs.

Long battles

The ordinary expectation is that one force breaks well before the hard limit. When it does not:

Battle turn	Event
100	Twilight: battle enchantments and temporary magic effects end; berserk ends; Precision suffers -2; Glamour magic receives +1
150	Attacker routs; Darkness imposes -3 Attack, Defence, and Precision, or daylight replaces it in a night battle
170	Defender routs
200	All remaining units are killed

The attacker carries a long-battle clock. Stall plans, fatigue traps, regeneration contests, and endless summoning must be judged against role and side. A plan that "cannot lose" in ordinary exchanges can still lose to that clock.

Part II: Reading a Unit

A stat line is a conditional promise

A unit's displayed statistics describe what it can do before formation, fatigue, leadership, terrain, blesses, spells, injuries, and the enemy intervene. The useful question is not "Is this unit good?" It is:

> Under the expected battlefield conditions, which job can this unit perform repeatedly and at acceptable cost?

The first-pass unit card

For a first evaluation, record:

Field	Main question
Hit Points	How much damage can the body absorb, and how does HP weighting affect rout?
Size	How many fit in a square, what can be reached, displaced, mounted, or trampled?
Strength	How much melee damage, carrying capacity, siege force, and trample damage is available?
Attack	How reliably do directed melee attacks beat Defence?
Defence	How reliably are directed melee attacks avoided before harassment and fatigue?
Protection	How much physical damage is removed, and where are helmet and armour coverage weak?
Precision	How tightly do missiles and spells cluster around the target square?
Morale	How long does the squad remain coherent under losses and fear?
Magic Resistance	How well are binary magical effects resisted?
Encumbrance	How quickly do attacks and spellcasting degrade the unit?
Combat Speed	How quickly does the unit cross the field and finish movement cooldowns?
Map Move	How useful is the unit in the campaign rather than one isolated battle?
Resistances	Which elemental, poison, sleep, or other damage families are reduced?
Weapons	Reach, attack and defence modifiers, damage type, number of attacks, and special effects

Field	Main question
Armour and shield	Body and head protection, Defence penalties, Parry, and shield Protection
Abilities	The rules that may dominate the ordinary statistics

Build the effective line

The displayed line should be converted into an effective line for the planned battle:

```
effective Attack
= displayed Attack
+ weapon and spell modifiers
- fatigue penalty
- underwater or injury penalties
- multiple-weapon penalty

effective Defence
= displayed Defence
+ weapon and spell modifiers
- armour and shield penalties already represented where displayed
- fatigue penalty
- harassment
- rout penalty
```

The same method applies to morale, protection, speed, and resistance. A Defence 16 unit that expects to reach 60 fatigue and receive six rapid attacks is not a Defence 16 problem. A Protection 20 unit facing armour-negating shock is not a Protection 20 target. A Morale 15 squad led badly, mixed improperly, and placed in a sparse line may begin the battle far below the headline value.

Roles rather than tiers

Common battlefield roles include:

Role	Primary success condition	Common failure
Line holder	Occupies contact space long enough for the plan to mature	Dies or routs before support resolves
Damage dealer	Converts attacks into relevant damage quickly	Attacks the wrong defence layer or cannot reach
Flanker	Reaches exposed sides or rear	Targeting, zones of control, or congestion redirects it
Screen	Absorbs arrows, charges, spells, or first contact cheaply	Causes friendly obstruction or premature army rout
Missile unit	Applies damage or effects before melee contact	Range, Precision, shields, armour, or friendly fire
Tramper	Converts size, speed, and mass into repeated displacement and AP damage	Fatigue, high Defence, anti-large damage, or friendly congestion
Bodyguard	Prevents assassination or rear access to a commander	Too few, badly placed, or inappropriate against area effects
Buffer	Raises friendly effective statistics before contact	Casts too late, wrong targets, or is interrupted
Controller	Restricts movement, actions, morale, or targeting	Resistance, immunity, range, or poor spell selection
Finisher	Exploits fatigue, rout, or broken protection	Arrives before the target is softened
Summoner	Adds bodies, time, and replacement HP during battle	Exhausts, summons too slowly, or feeds rout weighting
Commander	Maintains leadership, formation, morale, and orders	Exposed command death collapses the army

A unit can occupy several roles, but every additional assumption increases the ways the plan can fail.

Cost must include the campaign

Gold, resources, Recruitment Points, Holy Points, Commander Points, fort access, mage turns, gems, and map mobility all belong in unit valuation. A body that is exceptionally efficient in one battle may still be a poor campaign unit if it is capital-limited, slow to recruit, unable to reach the front, or dependent on a scarce mage package.

Part III: Command, Squads, and Army Construction

Squads are the unit of morale and orders

A commander can lead up to five squads. Each squad receives its own formation, position, and order, and calculates morale separately. Dividing an army into squads is a tactical choice, not clerical organisation.

Splitting troops can:

- produce different target orders;
- stagger contact;
- protect specialised troops behind a screen;
- create flank or rear starting positions;
- prevent one local morale failure from routing every similar unit;
- allow a standard or inspirational commander to support the intended group.

Splitting also carries costs:

- leadership morale bonuses can fall when too many squads are assigned;
- small squads make special morale conditions more relevant;
- more scripts and positions create more opportunities for error;
- a commander's death can still remove every squad under that command from coherent control.

Leadership and squad morale

The manual defines leadership bands:

Base Leadership	Squad allowance before penalty	Morale effect
10	One squad already penalised	-1 with one squad; another -1 to all squads for each extra squad
50	Two squads	0 for one or two; -1 to all for each further squad
100	Three squads	+1 for up to three; each squad above three reduces the bonus by 1
150	Four squads	+2 for up to four; a fifth reduces all to +1
200	Five squads	+3 to all five

These morale effects use the commander's base leadership band. Experience can increase capacity without moving the commander into a better morale band.

Experience modifies leadership capacity:

Experience level	Normal leadership bonus	Poor leader bonus
1	+25	+5
2	+50	+10
3	+50	+10
4	+50	+10
5	+50	+10

This distinction matters when a veteran commander can physically hold a large force but still supplies the original weak morale environment.

Special leadership

Undead and demons require undead leadership. Magic beings require magic leadership. A unit that is both undead and magical uses undead leadership for command.

Mixing categories can reduce morale:

- one undisciplined unit makes the squad undisciplined and imposes -1 morale;
- mixing undead and living units imposes -1 morale;
- mixing demons with ordinary units imposes -1 morale.

An army can fit under the displayed numeric capacity while still being illegally or badly commanded.

Command redundancy

If every eligible commander is killed or routed, the troops rout. A large army under one fragile commander has a single structural hit point.

Command redundancy asks:

- How many eligible commanders can remain if the front commander dies?
- Are they protected from arrows, flyers, assassins, remote damage, and area effects?
- Are magical, undead, and ordinary troops each backed by the correct leadership?
- If a commander retreats, will its troops have a safe route?
- Does a redundant commander carry enough leadership to prevent an immediate secondary failure?

Redundancy is not obtained merely by adding an unrelated scout. The replacement must be eligible to command the affected units and must survive in a relevant position.

Standards, inspiration, and taskmasters

Squad morale can receive:

- home-province bonus;
- friendly-dominion bonus;
- leadership-band modifier;
- Inspiration;
- the highest applicable Standard;
- +1 while blessed.

Standards and Inspiration are not substitutes for correct formation and command. They improve the morale comparison after the triggering condition occurs. They do not prevent command death, excessive fatigue, paralysis, or an automatic 75% army rout.

Taskmasters are primarily relevant to slave leadership and the specific units they govern. A label such as "slave", "undisciplined", "mindless", or "magic being" must be read as an engine category with its own command implications, not as flavour text.

The command audit

Before every important battle:

1. Count squads under every commander.
2. Check the commander's base leadership band.
3. Check ordinary, magic, and undead capacity separately.
4. Remove harmful mixing unless it serves a deliberate purpose.
5. Confirm at least one practical command backup.
6. Protect the commanders whose loss triggers the widest collapse.
7. Verify that retreating commanders have friendly destinations.

Part IV: Formation, Density, and Placement

The square

A battlefield square normally holds ten size points. Three size-3 humans fit because nine size points are used. Formation Fighter permits greater density.

Density changes:

- the number of melee attacks that can be delivered from a square;
- vulnerability to area effects, trampling, clouds, and missiles;
- the amount of space occupied by the line;
- congestion behind the line;
- the rate at which replacements reach contact;
- missile hit probability through size points in the target square.

There is no universally best density. Dense troops convert frontage into attacks; sparse troops convert frontage into area coverage and reduced clustering.

Formation types

Formation	Shape	Requirement	Morale effect	Main use
Box	Compact block	Any disciplined squad	0	Depth, compact defence, concentrated movement
Line	One rank	Good commander	0	Maximum frontage and simultaneous contact
Double line	Two ranks	Good commander	0	Balance of frontage and replacement depth

Formation	Shape	Requirement	Morale effect	Main use
Sparse line	Line with empty squares	Good commander	-1	Wide screen, reduced clustering
Skirmish	Checkerboard	Any; forced for undisciplined	-1	Separation, missile or area-risk management

Skirmisher removes the -1 morale penalty from skirmish and sparse line. Tight Rein allows a commander's undisciplined units to use disciplined formations and specific orders.

Frontage and depth

A wide line places more weapons into early contact, which is valuable when:

- the squad wins individual exchanges;
- weapon reach or repel rewards simultaneous coverage;
- the plan needs to envelop a smaller formation;
- the enemy relies on a narrow, high-value centre.

Depth is valuable when:

- the front rank will die or fatigue;
- replacements must sustain a holding action;
- the force is protecting a compact magical core;
- the enemy uses flyers or rearward pressure;
- the formation must absorb displacement.

The trade is temporal. Width spends bodies early. Depth reserves bodies for later.

Placement is a timing instruction

The Army Setup position determines where a squad begins, not where it is guaranteed to fight. A rear squad on Attack Rear may meet a screening unit. A forward mage can still spend several actions preparing a spell. A fast unit behind a slow block can waste its speed in congestion.

Placement should answer:

- Which squad should make first contact?
- Which should still be unengaged on turns three, five, or ten?
- Which friendly square blocks another unit's path?
- Which commander is visible to flyers or missiles?
- Where will a summoned unit appear relative to the line?
- If the enemy deploys at the opposite extreme, does the timing still work?

Staggered contact

Staggering is created through position, speed, formation, and Hold orders. It can:

- let buffs resolve before the valuable line enters danger;
- make a cheap screen absorb the first charge;
- prevent every squad from suffering the same opening area spell;
- create fresh troops against an already fatigued enemy;
- keep a finisher away from the initial harassment.

It can also fail by feeding squads separately into a stronger enemy. A stagger is useful only if the earlier wave creates time or degradation that the later wave can exploit.

Formation checklist

- Does width or depth serve the unit's actual weapon and role?
- Does the chosen formation impose a morale penalty?
- Can the commander legally provide that formation?
- Is friendly congestion likely?
- Does density worsen the expected enemy counter?
- Will rear or flank placement expose command?
- Is the contact schedule robust to enemy deployment on either side?

Part V: Orders and Scripting

Squad orders

General squad orders include:

Order	Behaviour
None	The combat AI decides
Attack	Advance and fight toward the selected target category
Fire	Use missile weapons against the selected target category
Guard Commander	Remain near and protect the commander; eligible guards may appear in assassination battles
Hold and Attack	Hold for two rounds, firing if able, then attack
Hold and Fire	Hold for two rounds, then fire and move into range as required
Fire and Keep Distance	Fire while attempting to preserve distance
Retreat	Behave as routing and attempt to leave

The common target categories are:

- none or random;
- Archers;
- Cavalry or fast units;
- Fliers;
- Large Monsters, normally size 7 or greater and otherwise size 6;
- Closest;
- Rearmost.

Target orders express preference rather than a teleporting command. Zones of control, blocked paths, range, target availability, and the unit's current contact can prevent the preferred target from being reached.

"Rear" is not a destination

Attack Rear selects a rearward target according to the engine's targeting and pathing. It does not guarantee commander assassination. The squad can:

- collide with a screen;
- be caught by zones of control;
- choose a rear troop block rather than a commander;
- take a path altered by obstacles;
- lose its target and retarget.

Rear pressure is a system made from mobility, placement, survival, and target access. The order is one component.

Hold is exactly two rounds

Hold and Attack and Hold and Fire delay for two rounds. They do not create an indefinite wait. A plan requiring a longer delay must use starting distance, speed, obstacles, spell timing, or a different unit rather than assuming that repeated holding exists for squads.

Commander scripts

A commander can receive five specific orders followed by a general order.

Specific orders include:

- Hold one turn;
- Hold or Fire a weapon;
- Hold or Cast an AI-selected spell;
- Cast a named spell;
- Attack one turn;
- Fly Attack one turn.

General orders include:

- Stay Behind Troops;
- Attack;
- Cast Spells;
- Advance and Cast;
- Retreat.

If a named spell lacks the required gems or a valid target in range, the caster can fall back to an AI-selected spell. A script is a preferred branch, not an infallible playback.

Conservative gem use

Conservative gem use makes a mage spend gems sparingly and primarily on scripted spells. It can prevent waste in routine fights, but it can also withhold power from an unscripted emergency. The setting belongs in the battle plan:

- scripted gem expenditure;
- intended post-script behaviour;
- expected enemy strength;
- value of gems compared with the force at risk.

"Save gems" is not automatically conservative when the result is the loss of the mage carrying them.

Script construction

A robust script is built in this order:

1. State the battle objective. Hold, kill, rout, delay, break a siege, extract a raider, or destroy a specific asset.
2. State the enemy defence layers. Protection, Defence, shields, resistance, MR, regeneration, size, morale, mobility.
3. Assign answers. Each important defence layer needs a delivery mechanism.
4. Create the contact schedule. Decide which friendly element meets the enemy first.
5. Place enabling effects before dependent effects. Accuracy, resistance, mobility, protection, path boosts, and battlefield conditions often need sequencing.
6. Write failure branches. Named spell unavailable, target out of range, caster interrupted, screen destroyed, enemy deploys elsewhere.
7. Set gem policy.
8. Protect command and retreat.
9. Test both attacker and defender sides.

Timing templates

Screen and strike

- cheap or resistant screen forward;
- decisive troops delayed or placed behind;
- buffers script enabling effects;
- damage package begins as contact fixes the enemy.

Failure: the screen routs so early that morale or pathing disrupts the strike.

Armour break

- hold the line;
- apply armour-piercing, armour-negating, rust, Strength, or fatigue pressure;
- commit ordinary damage after the protection layer has been weakened.

Failure: the anti-armour component targets the wrong bodies or arrives after the line collapses.

Fatigue collapse

- survive early damage;
- impose heat, cold, shock, spell fatigue, trampling cost, repeated attack cost, or exhaustion;
- exploit falling Attack and Defence;
- finish unconscious targets.

Failure: the enemy kills faster than fatigue accumulates or possesses sufficient resistance and reinvigoration.

Morale break

- cause heavy losses or fear near selected squads;
- remove leadership or standards;

- force repeated checks;
- preserve enough mobile pressure to turn rout into strategic loss.

Failure: mindless, berserk, high-morale, or well-led troops ignore the intended pressure.

Rear disruption

- occupy the main line;
- send suitable mobile units around or over it;
- threaten fragile command and casters;
- prevent the rear force from being intercepted or stranded.

Failure: Attack Rear is treated as a guarantee rather than a pathfinding preference.

Script audit

- Are all named spells researched?
- Does each caster have the correct gems?
- Are path boosts active before the spell that requires them?
- Is the target likely to exist and be in range?
- Does the spell work underwater, indoors, in a storm, or in the current plane?
- What does the mage do after the fifth order?
- Will fatigue make the final scripted spell impossible or suicidal?
- Are duplicated battlefield enchantments wasting actions?
- Is every commander protected during preparation time?
- Does the plan survive an enemy Hold, flank deployment, or fast charge?

Part VI: Movement, Contact, and Time

Combat speed and cooldown

A move of one square costs roughly one point of combat speed; diagonal movement costs about 50% more. Units act individually. After moving or striking they receive a cooldown. A strike generally creates a long cooldown of about a round; movement creates a shorter cooldown influenced mainly by combat speed with some randomness.

When adjacent units are ready, the one whose cooldown finishes first attacks. Combat speed affects more than time to contact. It influences:

- path crossing;
- replacement into gaps;
- disengaged movement;
- how quickly a unit acts after a step;
- whether a fast unit can exploit a displaced or newly exposed square.

It does not multiply melee attacks as though every point were an attack-speed statistic.

Zones of control

An adjacent enemy creates a zone of control that normally halts movement. Routing units ignore zones of control.

Zones of control turn screens into spatial tools. A cheap body can stop or redirect a more valuable unit even if it cannot defeat that unit. Conversely, a fast flanker that touches the wrong enemy may lose its strategic role.

Displacement

A unit at least three size points larger than each displaced unit can enter an otherwise full square by displacing smaller occupants, at an additional cost of one combat-speed point. Non-routing tramplers avoid displacing friendly units because doing so would harm them.

Displacement can:

- break a neat line;
- expose units behind it;
- create congestion;
- change targeting and adjacency;
- move victims even when trample damage is avoided.

Obstacles and battlefield terrain

Obstacles, gates, walls, caves, water, storms, darkness, and indoor battlefields can alter legal movement and spell use. The manual establishes the large rules but not every pathfinding weight. Exact obstacle navigation belongs to map-specific observation and tests.

Treat battlefield terrain as a component of the script:

- Can the wide line physically deploy?
- Will large units fit through a gate?
- Can flyers operate under the current condition?
- Is the battle indoors, preventing most battlefield-wide magic?
- Does darkness penalise the army more than its opponent?
- Is the weather changing fire, cold, Precision, or storm-dependent abilities?

Part VII: Melee Resolution

The hit check

For a directed melee attack:

```
Attack roll = Attack + DRN - fatigue penalty
Defence roll = Defence + DRN - fatigue penalty
```

The attacker must exceed the defender. The defender wins ties.

Fatigue penalties are:

```
Defence penalty = floor(Fatigue / 10)
Attack penalty = floor(Fatigue / 20)
```

Defence collapses twice as quickly as Attack. This asymmetry is one reason fatigue turns stable lines into sudden massacres.

Damage and protection

After a hit:

```
Damage roll = Strength + weapon Damage + DRN
Protection roll = relevant Protection + DRN
+ shield Protection on a shield hit
```

Damage is inflicted only when the damage roll exceeds the protection roll.

The displayed damage figure for a weapon may already incorporate Strength and weapon rules in the interface. The formula explains resolution; it should not be used to add Strength twice to a value already presented as final damage.

Shields: avoidance and absorption

A shield has:

- Defence implications included in the unit's effective Defence;
- a Parry value;
- a Protection value.

If the attack beats Defence but not Defence plus Parry, it is a shield hit and shield Protection is added to the protection roll. If it also beats Defence plus Parry, it is a clean hit and the shield does not add Protection.

Shields create two defensive layers:

1. a wider band in which an attack strikes the shield;
2. added protection when that occurs.

They are not a flat chance to cancel all attacks.

Armour-defeating protection rolls

An unusually low protection die can produce an armour-defeating hit that bypasses 25% of protection:

Target state	Protection die results that qualify
Below 50 fatigue	2
50 or more fatigue	2-3
100 or more fatigue	2-4
Immobilised or unconscious	Treated as 100 fatigue

Protection remains valuable, but fatigue increases the tail risk that heavy armour is partly bypassed. This is another mechanism by which fatigue converts time into lethality.

Shield damage

Shield resistance is:

```
shield resistance = shield Protection + 5 if magical
```

Break force uses the incoming damage before ordinary protection:

- slashing attacks receive +50% for shield breaking;

- blunt attacks receive +25%;
- at three times resistance, the shield is damaged;
- at five times resistance, it breaks;
- a damaged shield hit again has a 25% chance to break.

A damaged shield loses 20% of its Protection; a broken shield loses 50%. Damaged magical shields repair after battle, but a broken magical shield is permanently destroyed. Mundane shields require spare provincial resources for repair.

Hit locations and reach

The ordinary hit-location distribution is:

Location	Chance
Torso	50%
Arms	20%
Legs	20%
Head	10%

Reach limits which locations can be struck:

- head requires attacker size plus weapon length at least target size;
- torso requires one less;
- arms require two less.

Some low-bodied monsters are easier to reach. An attacker significantly larger than the target shifts the normal distribution toward head hits: head rises to 20% and legs fall to 10%. For mounted attackers, mount size is used for this comparison.

Damage to an arm, leg, or non-essential head is capped at half the target's maximum HP during melee resolution. Location still matters greatly because affliction type and armour coverage depend on it.

Weapon damage types

Type	Effect
Blunt	+25% damage on head hits before protection; +25% shield-breaking force
Slashing	+25% damage after protection; +50% shield-breaking force; can sever a struck limb or head when the hit costs at least half maximum HP
Piercing	Reduces protection by 15%
Armour Piercing	Reduces protection by 50%
Piercing plus Armour Piercing	Total protection reduction of 65%
Armour Negating	Ignores ordinary protection entirely

Two-handed weapons add 125% of Strength rather than the ordinary Strength contribution to damage.

Weapons with several damage types can select among them according to the weapon definition. A label such as slash/pierce should not be analysed as if both protection modifications always apply simultaneously.

Underwater weapon penalties

Underwater:

- slashing and blunt attacks receive an Attack penalty equal to weapon length;
- piercing attacks receive no such penalty;
- mixed piercing weapons halve the penalty;
- flails receive another -1.

A weapon that works well on land can become a liability underwater even when the unit itself can breathe.

Multiple weapons and attacks

A unit wielding several ordinary weapons suffers an Attack penalty equal to the sum of their lengths. Ambidextrous offsets this penalty. Bonus and natural weapons do not create the ordinary multiple-weapon penalty.

Each additional wielded weapon after the first adds one Encumbrance. Current official rules exempt spellcasters from the multiple-weapon fatigue penalty, but not from every possible attack interaction of the weapons themselves.

Multiple attacks matter because they:

- create more hit checks;
- create more harassment;
- can threaten multiple units;
- trigger more defensive and strikeback effects;
- spend fatigue and expose the attacker to repel interactions.

Harassment

Every directed melee attack against a unit gives one point of harassment penalty. Each point reduces Defence by one. The penalty decays over time by a percentage rather than disappearing all at once.

- a weapon with multiple attacks gives harassment per attack;
- ranged and area-effect attacks do not;
- rider and mount are separate harassment targets.

Harassment is why a crowd of weak attackers can make a high-Defence elite vulnerable to the attack that matters. The weak attacks need not cause damage to create value.

The precise Dominions 6 decay function is not stated in the manual. A published Dominions 5 result multiplied the remaining penalty by 95% every 16/375 of a round, removing roughly 70% over a fully idle round. That old value is a useful regression-test hypothesis, not a Dominions 6 rule. Edition 27 leaves the current decay test pending.

Repel

When the defender's weapon is longer, it automatically attempts to repel the directed melee attack.

The sequence is:

1. a repel attack-and-defence comparison occurs;
2. if the repel attack would hit, the attacker makes a morale comparison;
3. failure aborts the attack;
4. success permits a repel damage roll;
5. if the repel causes any damage, it is capped at one and the original attack then continues.

The morale comparison is:

```
attacker = Morale + DRN - weapon-length difference
repeller = 10 + DRN + half the margin by which the repel attack won
```

The repelling unit acquires a lingering -2 repel penalty after repeated repel attempts; it decays with time. Size-6 or larger giants count their weapons as one length longer for repel.

Repel combines Attack, weapon length, morale, and tempo. A long weapon on an inaccurate, exhausted unit is not automatically good at repelling attacks.

Melee resolution order

The manual gives this useful order:

1. Determine target, including rider or mount.
2. Resolve early strikeback effects such as Awe or petrifying gaze; abort if the attacker becomes immobilised.
3. Resolve repel.
4. Resolve later strikeback effects such as Slimer, Sight Vengeance, or Horror Mark Attacker; abort if immobilised.
5. Resolve Attack against Defence.
6. Resolve damage against protection.
7. Resolve defensive abilities such as Mirror Image, Protective Force, Luck, or Mossbody.
8. Apply limb damage cap.
9. Apply redistribution such as Damage Reversal, Blood Bond, or Vengeance.
10. Deal damage, including shield consequences.

If damage redistribution kills the attacker at step nine, the attack is not retroactively cancelled.

Part VIII: Missiles and Ranged Delivery

Deviation

A projectile begins to deviate when range exceeds roughly half Precision minus two.

The manual gives:

```
deviation = range x 1.25 / Precision
```

Precision above 10 receives double value for the excess: Precision 12 is treated as 14 for this purpose.

The formula is best read as expected scatter around a targeted square rather than a direct chance to hit one individual.

The square hit check

After a projectile reaches a square, a target is selected with size weighting. The hit comparison is:

```
attacker = DRN + half the size points in the square + 2 if the weapon is magical
defender = DRN + twice shield Parry - Fatigue / 20
```

The attacker must exceed the defender.

This produces several non-obvious results:

- crowded squares are easier to hit;
- large bodies attract more hits within a square;
- shields are central missile defence;
- fatigue reduces missile defence;
- magical missiles gain accuracy at the square-hit stage.

Ranged damage

Missile damage then uses the ordinary damage-versus-protection structure. Many missiles add half Strength rather than full Strength. Crossbows and similar weapons often gain armour-piercing properties. Lightning is commonly armour negating; fire is commonly armour piercing. The actual weapon definition controls the result.

Missiles can hit friendly units. Screens, line width, range, and the timing of melee contact all affect friendly-fire risk.

Evaluating archery

Archery value is the product of:

```
number of shots
x probability of relevant square delivery
x probability of hitting a body
x probability of defeating protection
x strategic value of the target
```

"Many arrows" can be useful without many kills if they:

- damage shields;
- interrupt casters;
- inflict poison or elemental effects;
- remove fragile command;
- force the enemy into a resistant but less efficient composition.

They can also be almost irrelevant against the wrong armour and shield layer.

Ranged audit

- Is the target category likely to select the intended units?
- Is range beyond the accurate envelope?
- Are friendly troops about to enter the target squares?

- Are shields, Air Shield, protection, resistance, or mist negating the package?
- Does ammunition last long enough?
- Does Hold and Fire change the contact schedule usefully?
- Would a wider or sparser formation improve delivery or survival?

Part IX: Mounts, Trampling, and Size

Rider and mount are separate

Dominions 6 treats rider and mount as separate targets with separate HP, statistics, attacks, morale interactions, and afflictions. Area effects and lightning can hit both.

An evaluation of cavalry asks:

- what protects the rider;
- what protects the mount;
- which attacks each performs;
- what happens if one component routs or dies;
- whether equipment affects one or both;
- how replacement and mount recovery work after battle.

Hitting mounted units

The mount becomes more likely to be targeted when much larger than the rider:

Mount size advantage	Additional mount targeting rule
3	25%
4	50%
5 or more	75%

Otherwise:

- missiles have a 50% chance to target the mount;
- if mount size is at least reach plus two, the mount is targeted;
- otherwise mount chance is `30% + 10% x mount size - 10% x reach`, with a 10% minimum.

Trample always targets the mount. Area effects and lightning hit both components.

These targeting rules are official. The remaining mounted research question concerns carry, mixed-component movement, and the order in which every exceptional modifier is applied; it no longer treats ordinary target selection as wholly unknown.

Mounted combat

Both rider and mount can attack. A rider using a two-handed weapon while mounted receives -3 Attack. Skilled Rider improves the mount's morale and Defence; the amount of usable Defence is affected by mount armour Encumbrance.

Magic items on the rider do not automatically apply every effect to the mount. The item or effect must say so. Mount armour uses the barding slot where available.

Mounted morale

Fear can affect rider and mount. If the rider routs, the mount leaves with the rider. If only the mount breaks, the rider can be thrown and the mount routs. Falling damage is an open-ended armour-negating comparison based on size difference; chariots avoid ordinary falling damage.

A normal riderless mount routs. A mount with the relevant bravery can remain. The battle summary and replay should be inspected at component level because "cavalry loss" may mean a dead rider, lost mount, or temporary separation.

Mount recovery

A surviving rider without a mount can claim a matching riderless mount. Otherwise the rider returns home and can be recruited again at half cost while retaining identity, experience, and afflictions. Suitable intelligent mounts can return in a similar fashion.

Mounted commanders remain and can use Reclaim Mount or claim a suitable unit. Some units automatically regain mounts. As of 6.35, automatic recovery occurs at the end of the turn, ensuring the new turn begins mounted.

Trampling

A trampler entering a square displaces the smaller units to adjacent squares. Each victim checks:

```
Defence - floor(Fatigue / 10) against 3d6
```

On failure:

```
trample damage = 7 + trampler Size
```

The damage is armour piercing. An ethereal trampler deals half normal trample damage. A victim that passes the Defence check is still displaced and takes one damage. A trampled unit always takes at least one damage regardless of protection.

Trampling is simultaneously:

- movement;
- displacement;
- repeated Defence pressure;
- armour-piercing damage;
- fatigue expenditure;
- formation disruption.

Trample failure modes

Tramplers are vulnerable to:

- high Defence before fatigue;
- targets too large to trample;
- anti-large weapons and concentrated damage;
- cold, shock, and other fatigue pressure;
- poor morale;
- congestion around friendly troops;
- repeated trampling cost;
- mount targeting when the trampler is a mount.

Trampling weak units can look dominant while exhausting the trampler for the decisive contact.

Part X: Fatigue, Recovery, and Collapse

The hidden battle economy

Fatigue is a stock accumulated by actions and effects. It reduces combat performance before it causes unconsciousness:

```
Defence penalty = floor(Fatigue / 10)
Attack penalty = floor(Fatigue / 20)
```

At 50 fatigue, Defence has fallen by 5 and Attack by 2. At 90, the penalties are 9 and 4. A unit can remain upright while its original stat line has ceased to exist.

Gaining fatigue

Ordinary melee attacks add current Encumbrance. Spellcasting adds:

```
listed spell fatigue / (1 + path skill above minimum)
+ base Encumbrance
+ twice armour Encumbrance
```

The listed spell component is divided by excess path skill. The Encumbrance component is not.

Other sources include:

- flying and trampling;
- heat or cold effects;
- shock and fatigue damage;
- bleeding;
- special weapons, spells, and auras;
- extreme battlefield conditions.

Thresholds

Fatigue	Consequence
Every 10	-1 Defence
Every 20	-1 Attack
50+	More protection rolls can become armour defeating
100	Unit falls unconscious
Below 100 again	Unit can regain consciousness
200	Additional fatigue damage begins converting to HP damage

An unconscious unit recovers five fatigue per turn until it falls below 100. Reinvigoration and battle effects can accelerate recovery according to their rules. The manual does not fully specify ordinary recovery while a unit remains active.

The current community reference states that every active unit removes one fatigue per combat round and then adds its Reinvigoration. This is the best current working rule, but the page does not publish a version-matched frame-by-frame reproduction. Edition 27 therefore labels it current community reference, while the five-point unconscious rule remains official.

At 200 fatigue, each further 50 fatigue damage produces one HP damage. A smaller remainder produces a chance equal to two percent per fatigue point.

Fatigue as offence

Fatigue warfare can defeat protection without directly ignoring it:

1. Defence falls.
2. More attacks hit.
3. Armour-defeating protection results become more frequent.
4. The unit falls unconscious.
5. Further fatigue converts into damage.
6. The stationary target receives concentrated attacks.

This is why reinvigoration, low Encumbrance, resistance, and relief effects are offensive enablers as well as defensive statistics.

Fatigue budget

For a key unit, estimate:

```
starting fatigue
+ scripted action costs
+ expected contact costs
+ environmental and enemy pressure
- recovery
= fatigue at decisive turn
```

The number need not be exact to expose a bad plan. A mage expected to cast five expensive spells in heavy armour or a trampler expected to cross the field and overrun many squares may already be committed past useful performance.

Part XI: Morale, Fear, Rout, and Retreat

Squad morale

Squad morale begins from the members' average and receives applicable modifiers:

- +1 in the home province;
- +1 in friendly dominion;
- leadership-band modifier;
- Inspiration;
- the highest applicable Standard;
- +1 while blessed;
- temporary magic morale.

Magic morale can range from -10 to +1. Negative magic morale recovers gradually, approximately one point every two rounds; positive magic morale persists.

When squads check

A squad can check morale when:

- it suffers heavy losses since its last check and has at least 20% overall casualties;
- it has four or fewer members and any member is damaged that round;
- it is exposed to nearby Fear;
- Terror or a similar effect forces a check;
- the army has lost at least 50% of its weighted total HP, causing checks each turn thereafter.

At most one ordinary morale check occurs for a squad in a round.

For this purpose, a wound is a damage event that leaves a unit at no more than 80% of normal HP. Heavy losses are one wound per two squad members.

The morale comparison

The manual gives:

```
morale roll = squad Morale + DRN + survivor bonus from 0 to 5
fear roll = 14 + DRN
```

The squad routs when the fear roll is greater. Under this wording, a tie is safe.

The current community formula is:

```
survivor bonus = nearest whole number of
(5 x surviving proportion of the original squad)
```

That matches the manual's `0-5` description, but the published page does not supply a current raw test set and notes uncertainty for commanders. Edition 27 therefore records the formula as a current community reference, not an official or reproduced result. Boundary rounding and commander handling remain test pending.

Army-level rout

At 50% weighted army HP loss, surviving squads begin checking every turn. At 75%, the army automatically routs.

The army total weights some bodies differently:

Body type	HP weight
Ordinary unit	100%
Mount	25%
Province Defence	25%
Slave	50%

This weighting affects how a screen, summon, mount, or PD contingent contributes to army-wide collapse. It does not tell whether that body is tactically useful.

Fear

Fear can reduce magic morale and force squad or individual checks. Current official rules cap morale reduction at the Fear effect's value and at an absolute ten points.

Fear is strongest when combined with:

- existing casualties;
- command loss;
- fatigue;
- weak leadership;
- small squads;
- blocked or dangerous retreat.

It is weaker against mindless units, berserk behaviour, high morale, strong leadership, and effects that prevent or mitigate fear.

Frighten-like limited effects can reduce morale by no more than their stated amount and do not automatically create every broader Fear interaction. Exact effect text matters.

Routing units

A routing unit suffers -4 Defence and spends its activity moving toward a friendly battlefield edge. It ignores zones of control. Poison, burning, bleeding, and similar pending damage can still kill it after it leaves.

Mindless units do not rout normally. Without eligible leadership, they can become immobile, attack adjacent enemies, and have a one-third chance per turn to dissolve. Magic or undead troops without the required leadership rout.

Retreat destination

Each commander has a 75% chance to make a smart retreat. A commander in native terrain receives a second 50% chance after failure.

A smart commander:

- retreats into a friendly fort in the same province if available;
- otherwise chooses a random friendly adjacent province.

A failed smart retreat chooses a random adjacent province, including an enemy province. A unit retreating into enemy territory is killed.

Troops attempt to follow their commander with a morale check:

- squad morale bonus counts double;
- undisciplined units suffer -3;
- skirmish morale penalty applies.

Leaderless troops or troops that fail to follow make individual smart checks at 50%, with the native-terrain second chance still applying.

Retreat while defending a fort

Units retreating while defending their fort hide inside if the battle is won and they made a smart retreat. If the battle is lost, all such units are killed. Non-smart defenders are killed. Commanders are always smart in this special case, and lone units gain another 50% opportunity.

Preservation audit

Before committing:

- Which adjacent provinces are friendly?
- Is a friendly fort available?
- Are retreat provinces likely to be cut this turn?
- Are commanders native to the terrain?
- Are undisciplined troops likely to follow?
- Will poison, burning, or bleeding kill retreaters?
- Is a fort defence an all-or-nothing trap?
- Does a nominal victory preserve the force for the next operation?

Part XII: Resistances and Special Damage

Resistance

Elemental resistance works like an additional protection layer against its damage family, followed by percentage reduction. Each point corresponds to twice that percentage; resistance 50 gives immunity.

For elemental fatigue effects, resistance counts at double strength when reducing the fatigue component.

Resistance is not interchangeable with protection:

- armour negation can ignore protection but not the relevant resistance;
- poison resistance reduces initial poison application but not the later duration of poison already received;
- immunity thresholds and special interactions differ by damage family.

Fire and burning

Fire is commonly armour piercing. The chance to catch fire is:

```
pre-protection fire damage x 4%
```

Fire fatigue counts as one-third for this ignition calculation.

A burning unit suffers `(1dSize) / 2` damage, rounded up, each round: a size-8 unit rolls `1d8`, then halves the result. Fire Resistance 5 halves burning damage. The chance to extinguish is:

```
25% + Fire Resistance + 5% per Cold scale + 100% in rain
```

with a minimum of 1%. Fire vulnerability is negative resistance. Fire Resistance 10 or more, chill aura, Mistform, and Ethereal prevent burning.

Cold and freezing

A freezing unit suffers 2d6 additional fatigue each round until it thaws.

The thaw chance is:

```
25% + Cold Resistance + 5% per Heat scale
```

with a minimum of 1%. Cold Resistance 10 or more, heat aura, and Ethereal prevent freezing.

Fire and cold affect both damage and fatigue.

Bleeding

Profuse bleeding inflicts:

```
10 fatigue + 5% of maximum HP per round
```

The chance to stop is 10% plus regeneration. Underwater combat halves the chance that bleeding stops; it does not halve the listed damage.

Poison

Poison is stored and then applied over time, approximately ten percent of the remaining total per round as evenly as possible.

Poison also reduces Attack and Defence by 25% for each full maximum-HP dose currently stored, capped at 50%. The penalty falls as stored poison is consumed.

Poison Resistance reduces the initial amount. It does not shorten poison already received.

This delay makes poison strategically unusual:

- the victim may win the immediate exchange and die afterward;
- battle summaries can conceal post-contact lethality;
- retreating poison victims can be lost after leaving;
- regeneration and healing do not simply erase the stored schedule.

Shock and stun

Shock can stun. The chance is:

```
5% + half the percentage of maximum HP lost to the hit
```

Shock Resistance protects against shock damage and receives the elemental-resistance treatment against fatigue effects. Twist Fate and similar effects must be evaluated with current patch behaviour rather than old assumptions.

Acid and rust

Iron equipment can rust:

- rust chance is pre-protection acid damage times 4%;
- armour can be damaged based on damage before armour after shield interaction;
- rusty weapons have a chance to become damaged when used.

A damaged weapon suffers -2 damage, or -1 if blunt. Rust converts repeated minor exposure into declining equipment quality. Since 6.36, the rust effect can apply even when the attack causes no HP damage; inspect equipment state rather than using the health bar as a proxy for the secondary effect.

Life drain

Full life drain:

- heals half the damage;
- removes fatigue equal to twice the damage;
- can raise HP to 150% of maximum plus ten.

Weapons with partial life drain treat only the first five points of damage as drain; further damage is ordinary. Lifeless targets take only 25% of the post-protection drain result and do not heal the attacker. A lifeless attacker can still receive the ordinary benefit of its own life-draining attack.

Paralysis

Paralysis duration is:

```
(damage - Size) / 2
```

Repeated paralysis uses the larger duration and can add limited damage from the overlap. Size acts as a defence even when ordinary protection is not the main check.

False damage

Illusions and many Glamour effects cause false damage. It:

- can kill when real plus false damage reaches HP;
- causes no ordinary afflictions except death;
- is not healed by regeneration, life drain, or ordinary healing;
- does not trigger Damage Reversal, Blood Vengeance, or Blood Bond;
- dissipates at two per round if all enemy Glamour mages are dead.

Current official rules make false damage count toward HP-based rout. A force can be routed by damage that later disappears.

Clouds and auras

Cloud effects are armour negating and decay by roughly one level per round. Clouds of the same type do not ordinarily overlap; they spread and can increase level only within their limits. Heat and frost clouds cancel one another.

Monster auras commonly create level-one clouds that can accumulate to level two. Spells and items can create stronger clouds.

Clouds transform position and time into damage. The important questions are:

- who occupies the square;
- how long they remain;
- what resistance applies;
- whether the cloud moves, spreads, cancels, or decays;
- whether friendly troops are also exposed.

Part XIII: Afflictions, Regeneration, and Lasting Loss

Affliction chance

When a hit causes damage, the basic chance of an affliction equals the percentage of maximum HP lost to that blow. A hit taking 20% of maximum HP produces a 20% base chance. Damage beyond 100% can produce several affliction opportunities.

The chance that an affliction is major is:

```
affliction chance / 1.5
```

capped at 33%.

Regeneration reduces affliction risk. Since 6.31, regeneration follows its displayed percentage accurately rather than the older HP brackets.

Location pools

Location	Minor examples	Major examples
Any	Battle Fright, Profuse Bleeding	-
Head	Eye Loss, Mute	Dementia, Feebleminded, Blind
Chest	Chest Wound, Never-Healing Wound	Diseased
Arm	Weakened	Lost Arm
Leg	Limp	Crippled

Profuse Bleeding is temporary. Most other afflictions persist until an eligible healing mechanism succeeds.

Campaign consequences

Affliction valuation depends on the unit:

- lost limbs can remove weapons or slots;
- lost eyes impair Precision and combat;
- feeblemindedness can destroy a mage's strategic value;
- battle fright undermines command and morale;
- limp and cripple reduce map movement;
- disease creates ongoing attrition.

Troops with a limp can become crippled during long marches. Crippled troops can die while marching. An army that wins but accumulates movement injuries may cease to be an operational army.

Healing categories

Recuperation, healer abilities, immortality interactions, transformation, and specific sites or spells do not all heal the same afflictions under the same conditions. Undead and lifeless beings are commonly excluded from ordinary affliction healing. Item-caused afflictions can require removal of the item.

The safe method is to inspect the exact ability and target category rather than use "healing" as one universal mechanic.

Part XIV: Battle Magic within the Army

Scope

The complete spell, communion, ritual, and research system belongs in Foundation Book V. This part establishes the combat mechanics required to understand an army that includes mages.

Preparation and recovery

Most spells have a casting time of about one round:

- approximately half is preparation;
- approximately half is recovery.

Battle enchantments and gem-costing spells often take longer. If the caster is damaged during preparation, interruption chance is:

```
percentage of maximum HP lost + 25%
```

Combat Caster and Mindless halve this chance. Innate spellcasters require no preparation and ignore ordinary casting-time differences. As of 6.35, an innate caster that falls unconscious and later recovers continues its script correctly.

Spell accuracy

Spell delivery resembles missile delivery:

```
spell aiming Precision = caster Precision + spell Precision
```

Range, scatter, target-square density, area, and friendly position all matter. A spell with excellent listed damage can be a poor answer if it arrives late, lands unpredictably, or covers the wrong area.

Magic resistance

When "Magic resistance negates" applies:

```
caster penetration
= 11 + DRN + half additional skill above the spell requirement

target resistance
= Magic Resistance + DRN + half target skill in the spell path
```

The caster wins ties.

"Easily negates" gives the caster -4 penetration. "Hard to resist" gives +4.

Excess path skill and relevant boosters improve penetration, while path-skilled targets can receive extra resistance against effects in that path.

Spell fatigue

For a spell with listed fatigue:

```
path fatigue
= listed fatigue / (1 + caster skill - minimum required skill)

casting encumbrance
= base Encumbrance + 2 x armour Encumbrance
```

The Encumbrance cost is paid per cast and is not reduced by excess skill. Heavy armour can make a high-path mage collapse even when the printed spell cost appears manageable.

Battle enchantments

Battle enchantments can affect the whole battlefield or continuously alter the battle. They end when their caster dies. At Twilight, all battle enchantments and temporary magical effects are removed.

Current indoor rules prevent most battlefield-wide spells from being cast indoors; holy battlefield-wide spells are excepted. A fort-storming plan must distinguish gate, exterior, and interior conditions.

Magic as a package

A useful battlefield-magic package identifies:

Component	Question
Research	Is every required spell available now?
Access	Which mages can cast it without hypothetical boosters?
Gems	How many battles can the package sustain?
Timing	On which turn does each effect resolve?
Delivery	Which square or target category receives it?
Protection	How does the caster survive preparation?
Fatigue	What remains after the script?
Redundancy	What happens if one caster dies or is interrupted?
Counter	Which resistance, battlefield condition, or enemy script defeats it?

The fifth-order problem

After five specific orders, the general order governs. Many battle plans are excellent for five actions and incoherent thereafter. The post-script state must be designed:

- should the mage remain behind troops;
- advance to reach targets;
- continue casting;
- conserve gems;
- retreat after a task;
- avoid walking into melee?

The sixth action is often where a nominal support mage becomes an expensive casualty.

Part XV: Sieges, Storming, and Battle Context

Siege arithmetic

The wall-reduction formulas, repair modifiers, and supply progression belong to Book II and the field reference. Book IV begins where the battle problem starts: only the correct siege orders contribute, and reaching zero wall integrity makes storming available on the next relevant order.

Storm sequence

Storming occurs after any other battle in the province. A relieving or intercepting battle can weaken or destroy the besieger before the fort assault.

If a commander ordered to Storm Castle is killed before the storming battle, troops under that commander do not participate in the storm.

This creates a two-battle problem:

- preserve storm commanders through the exterior battle;
- retain enough force and scripting for the fort battle;
- account for changed gems, fatigue resets, casualties, and command structure;
- respect indoor restrictions.

Gates and constrained contact

Fort battles compress frontage and change pathing. Large formations can be delayed by gates, while concentrated area effects can gain value. Exact fort layouts vary and should be inspected in the replay or test game.

A storm script copied from an open field is suspect until it answers:

- which units pass through the gate first;
- where the command core begins;
- whether battlefield-wide magic is legal;
- how defenders exploit interior depth;
- where retreating defenders go.

Siege supply

A fort's storage is divided by the number of consecutive siege turns. Storage 300 yields 300, 150, 100, 75, then 60 supply in the first five months. Starvation and disease can weaken a garrison before the storm without changing its roster.

The battle card should include starvation, disease, fatigue-related afflictions, and any shortage of replacement equipment.

Part XVI: Counter Construction

Counters are layered

A counter should state which layer it attacks:

Enemy layer	Candidate answers
High Defence	Harassment, area effects, trampling, immobilisation, fatigue
High Protection	Armour piercing, armour negating, Strength, rust, fatigue, MR effects
Shields	High Attack for clean hits, shield breaking, area effects, armour negation
Regeneration	Burst damage, decay, disease where applicable, paralysis, control, morale
High MR	More penetration, non-MR damage, fatigue, mundane control
Elemental resistance	Different damage family, physical damage, MR effects, morale
Massed low-HP troops	Area damage, clouds, trampling, fear
Giants	Anti-large damage, repeated attacks, control, poison where relevant
Flyers and rear pressure	Bodyguards, rear screens, protected redundancy, anti-air or area control
Mages	Fast contact, missiles, interruption, assassins, battlefield conditions, resistance
Summon spam	Area damage, fatigue control, source elimination, long-battle clock
Fear	Morale, leadership, standards, mindless or berserk counters, source removal
Tramplers	Defence, size, fatigue, anti-large damage, spacing

The counter must then pass four tests:

1. Access: the nation can produce it in time.
2. Delivery: it reaches the intended target.
3. Scale: enough instances exist for the enemy force.
4. Survival: it remains functional until its work is done.

Avoid nominal counters

An armour-negating spell is not a counter to armour if:

- research is not complete;
- only one fragile caster can use it;
- the caster lacks range;
- the target resists or kills the caster first;
- the gem cost cannot be sustained;
- the spell AI selects something else;
- indoor conditions prohibit the package.

The correct unit of strategy is the delivered package, not the tooltip.

Counter-counter planning

After selecting the answer, ask how the opponent adapts:

- changes formation;
- adds resistance;
- changes deployment;
- attacks the caster;
- uses decoys;
- splits the army;
- changes battlefield conditions;
- refuses the battle.

An expert plan is not one unbeatable script. It is a branch with a tolerable response to the most likely counter.

Part XVII: Battle Replay as Evidence

Why the summary is insufficient

The summary reports numbers present, kills, and losses. It does not by itself explain:

- who made first contact;
- which spells were interrupted;
- where fatigue crossed a threshold;
- whether a shield or resistance worked;
- which squad failed morale first;
- why a target order redirected;
- whether a commander or mount died before the apparent collapse;
- which damage occurred after retreat.

Kills reward the last damaging event, not every enabling action.

First replay method

For a new player:

1. Pause at deployment.
2. Use F1 to inspect all units and commanders.
3. Use F2 to inspect weather and dominion.
4. Identify the first-contact squads.
5. Watch once at normal speed without chasing individuals.
6. Watch again with battle-log detail increased.
7. Select a key unit and use its combat log.
8. Record the first irreversible failure.

Useful replay controls include pause, speed changes, grid display, F1 unit list, F2 weather and dominion, and battle-log detail levels one through four.

The first irreversible failure

The decisive event is often earlier than the visible rout:

- a buff was interrupted;
- a screen made contact one round early;
- a commander stood inside an area effect;
- tramplers became exhausted on decoys;
- missiles stopped when melee geometry changed;
- an MR spell failed repeatedly;
- a squad's leadership penalty lowered its margin;
- a retreat province was enemy-controlled.

Finding the earliest event that made later failure likely produces a reusable lesson. Recording only the final kill does not.

Replay worksheet

Stage	Record
Deployment	Side, positions, formations, squad sizes, command
Conditions	Weather, scales, darkness, storm, indoor or underwater
Opening	First spells, first shots, first movement
Contact	Turn and location of each squad's contact
Degradation	Fatigue, poison, rust, afflictions, lost mounts, shield damage
Cohesion	First morale check, first rout, commander loss
Resolution	Automatic rout, long-battle event, or decisive destruction
Retreat	Destinations, post-retreat deaths, trapped units
Strategic result	Province, gems, mages, commanders, readiness next turn

Do not learn from one roll

Open-ended dice produce tails. A controlled comparison should be repeated enough times to distinguish a structural advantage from one improbable result. The goal is not to eliminate randomness. It is to learn whether the plan remains acceptable across it.

Part XVIII: Active Mod Ruleset

What the supplied files establish

The frozen combined ruleset loads:

1. `DomEnhanced2_16.dm`;
2. `Divinitus_1.15.3_DE.dm`.

Direct source counts demonstrate the scale of object-level battle changes.

Command family	DE 2.16	Divinitus 1.15.3 DE
New monsters	3,553	346
Selected existing monsters	4,227	373
New weapons	389	34
Selected existing weapons	142	0
Selected spells	2,816	17
New spell blocks	0	26
Attack edits	2,038	276
Defence edits	2,114	278
Protection edits	1,612	238
Morale edits	1,692	229
Encumbrance edits	1,186	163
Mount assignments	178	9
Skilled Rider edits	437	1
Trample assignments	39	12

Counts are syntactic occurrences, not numbers of distinct final objects. Repeated selections, copied statistics, inherited fields, and later load-order edits can change the effective count.

What the files do not establish

The supplied `.dm` files create and alter monsters, weapons, spells, items, sites, nations, blessings, and object abilities. They do not present a global rewrite of the engine's DRN, ordinary Attack-versus-Defence equation, ten-size-point square capacity, 75% army-rout rule, or general retreat algorithm.

Accordingly:

- the foundation mechanics remain the starting model;
- every unit, weapon, spell, mount, and Pretender must be read from the effective combined data;
- unmodded balance conclusions cannot be transferred merely because the core formula is unchanged;
- Divinitus loads second and can overwrite shared selections made by DE.

Modded battle-analysis rule

For a combined guide:

```
engine mechanic
+ effective DE object
+ later Divinitus overwrite
+ national availability
+ current patch correction
= claim that can be published
```

The name of an object is not enough. A DE or Divinitus version may share a familiar name while changing damage, paths, fatigue, attack count, resistances, abilities, or recruitment.

Foundation versus faction work

Book IV does not declare any specific modded faction or god optimal. It supplies the method used later:

1. extract the final combined roster;
2. classify roles;
3. calculate effective combat lines;
4. build packages;
5. test scripts;
6. record match-ups and counters.

Part XIX: Controlled-Test Programme

Test standard

Every test record should include:

- Dominions version;
- exact mod list and load order;
- map and province;
- attacker and defender;
- unit IDs and quantities;
- commander statistics and orders;
- formations and positions;
- gems and items;
- weather, scales, dominion, terrain, and indoor state;
- random seed if available;
- number of repetitions;
- result distribution;
- replay or log notes.

Change one important variable at a time.

Test 1: DRN tie direction

Purpose: verify tie behaviour in Attack, MR, and morale checks.

Method:

- create equal-value opposed cases;
- use the highest battle-log detail;
- record explicit equal totals;
- confirm which side wins each rule's tie.

Test 2: Harassment decay

Purpose: measure the hidden decay rate.

Method:

- expose one high-Defence unit to a known burst of harmless directed attacks;

- stop new attacks through controlled spacing;
- inspect Defence or logs over time;
- repeat across different initial penalties.
- compare the result with the historical Dominions 5 hypothesis of a 5% reduction every 16/375 of a round without assuming that value survived into Dominions 6.

Test 3: Cooldown and combat speed

Purpose: distinguish movement time, recovery, and attack cadence.

Method:

- compare otherwise identical units with controlled Combat Speed;
- record timestamps for steps and attacks;
- repeat with diagonal movement and no movement.

Test 4: Formation Fighter density

Purpose: document exact square capacity at several ability values and sizes.

Method:

- deploy uniform squads in each formation;
- count bodies per square;
- repeat with mixed sizes.

Test 5: Repel sequence

Purpose: confirm current repel bonuses, lingering penalty, giant length, and magic-weapon interaction.

Method:

- use non-damaging or highly protected targets;
- vary weapon length, Attack, morale, size, and interval between attacks;
- record repel rolls at log level four.

Test 6: Shield damage and repair

Purpose: verify current rounding and post-battle repair.

Method:

- strike known mundane and magical shields with controlled slash and blunt damage;
- record damaged and broken thresholds;
- vary available provincial resources;
- inspect the next turn.

Test 7: Mounted targeting

Purpose: reproduce target weights for rider, mount, reach, missiles, and area effects.

Method:

- use fixed rider size and several mount sizes;
- count hundreds of directed attacks;
- repeat with different weapon lengths and missiles.

Test 8: Trample fatigue

Purpose: measure current flying and trampling fatigue after the 6.25 correction.

Method:

- compare mounted and non-mounted tramplers;
- control Encumbrance, distance, number of victims, and resistance;
- record fatigue per displacement.

Test 9: Morale survivor bonus

Purpose: derive the manual's 0-5 survivor bonus.

Method:

- create squads at controlled original and remaining sizes;
- force identical checks;
- extract morale totals from detailed logs;
- test the current community hypothesis `round(5 x surviving proportion)` at every rounding boundary;
- test commanders separately from squads.

Test 10: Army HP rout weights

Purpose: verify mounts, slaves, and PD weighting in mixed armies.

Method:

- construct armies with one weighted category at a time;
- cause controlled casualties;
- record the first 50% checks and 75% automatic rout.

Test 11: Retreat intelligence

Purpose: confirm smart-retreat rates and priority.

Method:

- provide a fort, friendly province, and enemy province;
- repeat commander retreats in native and non-native terrain;
- separately test leaderless troops and undisciplined followers.

Test 12: Ordinary fatigue recovery

Purpose: resolve active-unit recovery not fully specified by the manual.

Method:

- give controlled fatigue without further actions;
- compare active, unconscious, reinvigorated, and spellcasting units;

- log fatigue every round.
- test the current community hypothesis of one point per active round plus Reinvigoration against the official five-point unconscious recovery.

Test 13: Regeneration and rounding

Purpose: reproduce the post-6.31 percentage rule.

Method:

- use several maximum HP values and regeneration percentages;
- inflict constant damage;
- record healing across many rounds.

Test 14: False damage and rout

Purpose: verify current HP-rout contribution and dissipation.

Method:

- apply only false damage;
- kill all hostile Glamour mages at controlled times;
- record morale triggers and two-per-round removal.

Test 15: Indoor battlefield magic

Purpose: catalogue which whole-field effects remain legal.

Method:

- attempt ordinary, holy, start-of-battle, innate, and item-created field effects in fort interiors and assassination maps;
- record script fallback and gem use.

Test 16: Modded regression suite

Purpose: detect future DE or Divinitus changes that invalidate published packages.

Method:

- preserve a small set of representative battles;
- rerun after each mod update;
- compare unit IDs, final fields, scripts, and outcomes;
- classify differences as source edits, load-order overwrites, or engine changes.

Part XX: Operational Checklists

Pre-battle audit

Objective

- What must the battle accomplish?
- Is taking the province enough?
- Which enemy assets matter most?
- What friendly losses are acceptable?

Command

- Are all troop categories legally led?
- Are squad-count morale penalties understood?
- Is there useful command redundancy?
- Are key commanders protected?

Formation

- Which squad contacts first?
- Is width, depth, or spacing appropriate?
- Are undisciplined restrictions active?
- Will friendly units obstruct one another?

Script

- Are spells researched and gems carried?
- Are targets in range?
- What happens after five orders?
- What happens if the named spell fails?
- Are indoor, underwater, storm, or darkness restrictions checked?

Defence layers

- What answers Protection?
- What answers Defence?
- What answers shields?
- What answers resistance and MR?
- What answers regeneration, size, flight, fear, or mindlessness?

Persistence

- When does fatigue become dangerous?
- Can the line survive until the decisive turn?
- Are poison, bleeding, clouds, or rust cumulative threats?

Preservation

- Where will the army retreat?
- Are routes friendly after simultaneous movement?
- Is the fort battle an annihilation risk?
- Can the force fight again next turn?

Post-battle audit

1. What was the first irreversible failure?
2. Did placement produce the intended contact order?

3. Which scripts completed?
4. Which spells were interrupted or replaced by AI choices?
5. When did key units cross 50 or 100 fatigue?
6. Which squad routed first and why?
7. Did command loss trigger a general collapse?
8. Did the counter attack the correct defence layer?
9. Which losses occurred during retreat or from delayed damage?
10. What is the smallest change likely to improve the result?

New-player minimum

Before ending a turn with an important army:

- assign every troop to a legal commander;
- separate units that need different orders;
- choose formations deliberately;
- protect commanders;
- check mage gems and scripts;
- inspect likely retreat provinces;
- view the replay even after an easy victory.

Part XXI: Essays

Essay I: Morale and the Shape of Defeat

Dominions gives armies bodies, weapons, armour, and magic, but it ends most battles through cohesion. This is not a cosmetic concession to realism. It is the mechanism that connects local violence to army-level outcomes.

A soldier's HP asks whether the body can continue. Squad morale asks whether a group still accepts the battle. Command asks whether that group remains part of an army. Army HP asks whether the whole force has absorbed so much destruction that continued resistance is no longer possible. Retreat then asks whether defeat remains recoverable.

These layers explain why two identical casualty totals can have different results. Ten losses spread among several large, well-led squads may be tolerable. The same losses concentrated in a small forward squad can trigger a rout, expose a flank, and place fear next to another squad. The second squad then checks under worse conditions. Once movement turns away from the enemy, Defence falls, zones of control no longer matter, and the enemy converts retreat into further damage.

Morale has geometry. A fear aura beside one squad is not the same as a global numerical debuff. A standard supports a particular command structure. A commander killed behind the line can matter more than a warrior killed at the front. A sparse formation's -1 seems modest until it moves an already marginal squad down the DRN curve.

The strategic conclusion is not as simple as "buy morale." The army needs a controlled way to fail. Squads can be divided so that one rout stays local. Command can be duplicated. Valuable troops can be kept from taking the first casualty threshold. Fear can be attacked at its source. Retreat provinces can be preserved so a rout displaces the army instead of destroying it.

The strongest armies are not those that never fail a morale check. Random rolls and extreme effects make that impossible. They are armies whose first failure does not automatically become total defeat.

Essay II: Fatigue, the Hidden Battle Economy

Gold buys the unit and resources equip it, but fatigue determines how long the purchased statistics remain real.

A fresh high-Defence unit can look nearly untouchable. Every ten fatigue removes one Defence. Directed attacks add harassment. At fifty fatigue, the same body suffers five less Defence and a broader range of armour-defeating protection results. At one hundred it falls unconscious. The transition is not gradual in battlefield effect: a stable formation can appear to hold, then collapse rapidly as many members cross the same thresholds.

Fatigue also binds ordinary troops and mages into one system. Heavy armour protects a caster from arrows but charges twice its armour Encumbrance on every spell. A trampler destroys light infantry but pays for movement and trampling. A berserker produces more offence but continues accumulating cost. Fire, cold, shock, bleeding, and spell effects can attack the fatigue stock even when direct HP damage is unimpressive.

This makes time a resource. A cheap screen may buy three rounds for buffs, or force the enemy to spend three rounds attacking and building Encumbrance fatigue. A resistant line does not need an immediate kill if every exchange makes the next one more favourable. Reinvigoration does more than extend endurance; it preserves Attack, Defence, casting, and the reliability of protection.

A proper comparison between two units includes their fatigue over time. "Who wins the first attack?" is often less important than "Who still has a functioning stat line on the tenth?"

Essay III: Formation Is the Management of Time

Formation appears spatial, but its principal strategic effect is temporal. It decides how many bodies enter contact now, how many wait, which square receives area damage, how long replacements take to arrive, and when a fast unit becomes trapped behind a slow one.

A line spends frontage early. It seeks simultaneous contact and converts many weapons into immediate checks. A box stores bodies behind the first rank. It may accept less initial damage output in exchange for depth and protection of the centre. A sparse line spreads risk and coverage but pays morale and density costs. A skirmish pattern gives each square room yet can allow enemies to penetrate or surround.

Placement adds another time instruction. Forward deployment advances the squad's personal clock. Hold adds two rounds. Combat speed changes travel and cooldown. The enemy's placement changes the actual meeting point. The resulting schedule determines whether a buff precedes contact, whether arrows receive three volleys or one, and whether a finisher arrives against fresh or fatigued targets.

This is why copying a formation without copying its purpose fails. "Put infantry in a line" is not a rule. A line is correct when early frontage is worth more than depth and clustering risk. "Put mages at the rear" is incomplete. The rear can be exposed to flyers, and excessive distance can place spells out of range.

Formation is best designed as a timeline: first contact, second contact, decisive effect, expected rout. The map is the clock face.

Essay IV: Protection Is a Probability Distribution

Protection is often treated as subtraction: damage fifteen against protection twenty should do nothing. Dominions instead rolls both sides, permits open-ended results, distinguishes body and head, applies weapon types, includes shield hits, and allows low protection rolls to become armour defeating.

Protection changes the damage distribution. It reduces ordinary damage and makes severe results rarer, but it does not create a hard wall. The tail can still contain clean shield bypasses, head hits, high damage rolls, armour-piercing reductions, and armour defeat caused by fatigue.

This perspective improves both defence and offence. Adding protection to an already protected unit may still matter if it removes many ordinary wounds and their affliction chances. Against that unit, a large number of weak attacks may be poor at direct damage but valuable for harassment and fatigue. A smaller number of armour-negating attacks may attack the correct layer but fail if their delivery is unreliable.

The important question becomes: which part of the distribution must change? If ordinary hits are killing the line, more protection or shields may work. If rare head hits kill expensive sacreds, helmet coverage, Luck, body count, or regeneration may matter. If fatigue is widening the armour-defeating tail, reinvigoration may preserve effective protection better than another armour point.

The defence layer is never just the number printed beside the shield icon.

Essay V: Scripting under Uncertainty

A Dominions script is neither direct control nor a prophecy. It is a commitment made before seeing exact enemy deployment and resolved through range, targets, pathing, fatigue, damage, and AI fallback.

This makes scripting a form of robust planning. A brittle script succeeds brilliantly in one anticipated battle and fails when the enemy deploys one formation-width away. A robust script may sacrifice theoretical perfection to retain useful behaviour across several plausible enemy plans.

Robustness begins with dependencies. If spell four requires spell one to boost a path, the caster must survive the preparation time, spend the correct fatigue, and still have a legal target. If a screen must hold for three rounds, its morale and matchup must support that duration. If a flier must kill commanders, the path must remain open and the flier must ignore irrelevant rear targets.

Failure branches should be written deliberately. When the target is absent, what will the AI cast? When the caster is interrupted, does the army still have resistance? When the enemy holds, do friendly damage spells fire into empty space or remain useful? After five orders, does the mage stay safe?

The ideal script is not the one with the most exact sequence. It is the one whose likely deviations remain acceptable.

Essay VI: Winning the Battle, Saving the Army

Field victory is one event in a campaign. The surviving commanders, mages, mounts, gems, afflictions, and retreat routes determine whether the event creates lasting advantage.

An army that wins with its commanders dead can become stranded or badly organised. A force that routs into friendly territory may remain a strategic asset. A cavalry army can retain riders while losing mounts and tempo. Poison and bleeding can kill units after their visible escape. A failed fort defence can annihilate every unit that had nowhere to retreat.

Preservation begins before battle. Friendly adjacent provinces are part of army design. Command redundancy protects against battlefield collapse and the reorganisation that follows. Gem expenditure should reflect the value at risk. A commander carrying a laboratory's worth of gems is a caster and a moving treasury.

There are moments when preservation should be sacrificed. Destroying a unique enemy global caster, breaking a throne defence, or exhausting the only relief army may justify severe losses. The decision should be explicit. "The replay said victory" is not a strategic valuation.

The useful post-battle question is: how much future action did this result purchase? Provinces, siege turns, mage survival, research continuity, and readiness belong in the answer.

Essay VII: Combined Arms as Counter Architecture

Combined arms is sometimes described as variety for its own sake. In Dominions it is better understood as a set of linked answers to layered defences.

A conventional line may hold space but fail against heavy armour. Mages may negate armour but require time and protection. Archers may interrupt the enemy's mages but fail against shields. Flyers may threaten command but need the centre fixed in place. Fear may rout ordinary troops but do little to mindless bodies. Each component covers a failure mode of another.

Combined arms works when every component follows the same timing plan. A screen that dies before the debuff resolves has not supported the mage. A flanker that arrives before the centre engages can be surrounded. An armour-breaking effect cast after the damage line routs is irrelevant.

Combined arms also imposes organisational costs: more commander types, more scripts, more recruitment gates, more research branches, and more ways to misdeploy. Variety becomes strength only when every component has a named job and a dependency it satisfies.

The aim is not maximum variety. We want the smallest useful combination: enough distinct mechanisms to answer the expected defences, all delivered on one coherent clock.

Sources and Open Questions

Principal sources

- Illwinter, Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2, especially the statistics, special abilities, Army Setup, Combat, afflictions, sieges, retreats, and Battle Magic sections.
- Illwinter, Dominions 6 Modding Manual, version 6.34.
- Illwinter Dominions 6 documentation.
- Illwinter Dominions 6 changes.
- Dominions 6 official Steam page.
- Supplied `DomEnhanced2_16.dm`.
- Supplied `Divinitus_1.15.3_DE.dm`.

Current community references are used to identify test questions and terminology, not to override the manual or current official corrections without evidence.

Open questions

The following still require controlled current-game tests:

- exact harassment decay;
- complete cooldown constants;
- Formation Fighter capacity at every value and mixed size;
- current-version reproduction of the survivor-bonus rounding boundaries and commander handling;
- frame-by-frame current-version confirmation of active-unit fatigue recovery outside the manual's explicit unconscious rule;
- some obstacle and targeting weights;
- full mounted carry and movement arithmetic;
- precise current rounding in shield damage, regeneration, paralysis, and several special effects;
- effective combined data for every DE and Divinitus object.

Until then, they remain research tasks rather than confident approximations.

DOCUMENT 6 OF 7

Foundation Book V: Magic

What magic asks of a nation

Magic is the system by which Dominions turns knowledge into force. Research changes what a nation can attempt. Paths determine who can attempt it. Gems, blood slaves, laboratories, turns, and mage actions determine whether the attempt is affordable. Formation, timing, fatigue, targets, resistance, and counters determine whether it works.

> Foundation rule: Magic is not a list of powerful spells. It is a conversion chain from mage-turns and magical income into effects delivered at the right place and time.

Book V follows that chain from research and path access through gems, battlefield packages, communions, rituals, globals, forging, and late-game magic. It is meant to answer both the beginner's question-"What can this mage actually do?"-and the harder one: "Can the nation deliver that effect repeatedly, in time, and against resistance?"

Edition note

Book I defines the common baseline and evidence labels. Book IV owns the arithmetic of battlefield resolution. Book V uses those results to deal with magical planning, while Book IX catalogues exact spell, item, site, and mage changes in the active mods.

Current-version corrections that matter

The printed manual remains the structural baseline, but current play must include later official changes:

Version	Current rule or correction	Practical consequence
6.25	Battlefield-wide spells cannot normally be cast indoors; holy spells are excepted	Fort interiors and many assassination fields need separate scripts
6.29	Several spell, item, ritual, and nation-specific errors were corrected	Old object data must not be treated as current merely because the engine formula is unchanged
6.30	Communion masters using conservative gem use no longer attempt inappropriate higher-level spells	Old reports of this spell-AI failure are historical
6.32	Spell AI became less likely to cast invisibility late in battle; several remote and single-target choices were improved	Script fallbacks and unscripted casting should be assessed on the current version
6.34	Domes can protect against Astral Disruption; ritual messages and several spell-AI choices were corrected	Strategic magic defence and report interpretation changed
6.35	Innate spellcasters resume their scripts after recovering from unconsciousness	Current innate-caster scripts are more reliable than older replays imply

Patch notes contain many object-specific balance changes. A current spell dossier needs current game data as well as the manual's rule text. This foundation preserves the rules needed to make sense of those objects.

Ways into the book

The shortest route runs through the conversion chain, paths and schools, research, gems, battlefield jobs, rituals, forging, and the first magic audit. Communions, domes, global contests, booster ladders, counter construction, and legendary spells can be added as the national game develops. The controlled tests are kept for questions that genuinely depend on hidden AI choices, rounding, or version-sensitive interactions.

Part I: Magic as a Conversion System

The complete chain

A magical effect normally depends on every link below:

```
mage recruitment
-> laboratory access
-> mage-turns assigned to research
-> required school level
-> required path access
-> gems, slaves, or items
-> a legal order or battle script
-> survival, range, target, and timing
-> penetration, damage, or control
-> strategic exploitation
```

A broken link invalidates the rest. Researching a decisive spell without a caster is stored knowledge without delivery. Forging a booster without the path needed to wear it is dead capital. Sending the correct mage without gems can reduce a battle plan to ordinary AI casting. Winning the resistance check after the line has routed is too late.

Six magical resources

Magic is paid for with more than gems:

Resource	What it purchases	Common failure
Research points	Access to schools and spells	Researching attractive levels with no operational deadline
Mage-turns	Research, rituals, forging, site searching, movement, and combat	Counting one mage as if all roles can be performed simultaneously
Paths	Eligibility, efficiency, range of effects, and forging access	Confusing national theoretical access with repeatable field access
Gems or slaves	Rituals, items, combat boosts, fatigue relief, and some summons	Treating the treasury as income rather than a finite stock
Laboratories	Research, rituals, forging, pooling, and logistics	Losing the network that turns sites and mages into national power
Time and position	Delivery before the strategic window closes	Finishing research after the war has already been decided

The strongest magical economy is not always the one with the most gems. It is the one that can turn its available paths, researchers, laboratories, and stocks into the required effects with the fewest broken dependencies.

Stock, flow, and capacity

The library's economic model applies directly:

- Stock: current gems, slaves, forged items, accumulated research, and prepared casters.
- Flow: monthly gem income, blood-hunting output, research points, and repeatable summon production.
- Capacity: laboratories, mage recruitment, path distribution, forge access, communion bodies, and ritual range.
- Position: where mages, labs, gems, armies, and legal targets are located.

Research is cumulative stock generated by a flow of mage-turns. A booster is stored path access. A global is a large stock expenditure converted into an ongoing flow or worldwide rule. A battle gem converts stock into immediate tempo.

The three horizons

Every research or forging decision belongs to a horizon:

Horizon	Typical question	Planning standard
Immediate	What can prevent defeat this turn or next?	Legal casters, carried gems, exact scripts, and battlefield timing
Campaign	What wins the next war or siege cycle?	Research breakpoint, item queue, summon mass, and lab movement
Strategic	What changes the nation's path access or world position?	Boosters, globals, remote movement, legendary spells, and unique artifacts

The common error is buying strategic possibility while losing the immediate war. The opposite error is repeatedly spending gems on emergency combat without building the research and access that end the emergency.

Part II: Paths, Schools, and Access

The nine paths

Dominions has nine ordinary paths of magical power:

Family	Path	Broad tendencies
Elemental	Fire	Heat, burning, direct damage, offensive enhancement, destructive globals
Elemental	Air	Lightning, storms, flight, precision, mobility, battlefield reach
Elemental	Water	Cold, quickness, underwater power, frost, fluid defence
Elemental	Earth	Protection, strength, fatigue control, constructs, forging
Sorcery	Astral	Resistance contests, communions, teleportation, information, global control
Sorcery	Death	Undead, decay, fear, souls, attrition, powerful summons
Sorcery	Nature	Life, poison, regeneration, animals, plants, supply, growth
Sorcery	Glamour	Illusion, false damage, concealment, bewilderment, perception
Neither	Blood	Blood slaves, sacrifice, demons, Sabbaths, corruption, high action cost

This table describes tendencies, not hard borders. Schools are thematic rather than perfectly rigorous, national spells break general expectations, and multi-path requirements deliberately combine toolsets.

Holy is separate. Divine spells depend on Holy skill rather than ordinary paths and research. Common divine magic is available from the beginning. Some Banishment and Smite replacements are determined by the Pretender's paths, as detailed in Book III.

The seven schools

School	Central study	Frequent output
Conjuration	Bringing beings or powers into the world	Summons, elemental or otherworldly forces, some searches
Alteration	Changing physical properties and conditions	Protection, strength, resistance, weather, transformation
Evocation	Projecting magical force	Direct battle damage, area attacks, battlefield destruction
Construction	Making items and artificial beings	Equipment, boosters, matrices, constructs, artifacts
Enchantment	Imbuing units, objects, land, or the world	Persistent buffs, domes, globals, battlefield enchantments
Thaumaturgy	Manipulating minds, souls, information, and space	Resistance-based control, remote vision, movement, sorcery
Blood Magic	Unlocking spells that use Blood magic	Demons, Sabbaths, sacrifice, blood rituals, world corruption

The Blood school is not the Blood path. The school is a research category; the path is a caster statistic. A spell can sit in Blood Magic and have multi-path requirements.

The three access gates

A mage can cast a spell only when:

1. the nation has researched the spell's school to the required level;
2. the mage meets every listed path requirement;
3. any required gems or blood slaves are available in the correct place.

Battle spells require carried resources before battle. Rituals draw automatically from the national treasury but require a friendly laboratory. Research level alone never grants a path to a mage.

Primary and secondary paths

Multi-path spells require every listed path. The first listed path is the primary path:

- only excess skill in the primary path improves the ordinary spell-fatigue divisor;
- resistance penetration uses excess skill in the spell path identified by the rule;
- dual-path spells and rituals consume gems of the primary path unless the spell specifies otherwise;
- forging a multi-path item charges each required gem type.

This makes ordering consequential. Two requirements with the same numbers are not necessarily interchangeable if the primary path differs.

Excess skill

Having more skill than the minimum can:

- reduce the listed fatigue cost;
- contribute to resistance penetration;
- increase the maximum gems usable in a ritual;
- enable stronger overcasting of a global;
- meet a higher item or spell threshold;
- improve path-derived indirect bonuses.

Higher skill gives more than access to extra icons. It increases endurance and sometimes contest strength. That value still needs to be weighed against the booster, communion, empowerment, or rare mage needed to reach it.

Acquiring and increasing paths

The principal methods are:

Method	New path from zero?	Duration	Main use
Native or random path	Yes	Permanent	National base access
Empowerment	Yes	Permanent	Opening a missing path or climbing without another route
Path booster item	No	While worn	Efficient repeatable threshold access
Battlefield path-boost spell	No	Battle	Combat thresholds and fatigue reduction
One combat gem	No	One spell	Temporary +1 and/or fatigue management
Communion/Sabbath/Chorus	No	Battle	Shared battlefield escalation
Grand Communion	No	One strategic casting	Add same-path strength to a global or dispel
Transformation or special effect	Sometimes	Object-specific	Must be verified separately

Only Empowerment is the general method that grants the first level of an absent path. A booster or Power of the Spheres requires at least level 1 already. A gem can raise a known path by one for one spell but cannot create it or raise it by more than one.

Empowerment costs

Official costs are:

```
first level in an absent path = 50 gems of that path
later increase = 15 x target level
```

Examples:

Change	Cost
F0 -> F1	50 Fire gems
F1 -> F2	30 Fire gems
F2 -> F3	45 Fire gems
F3 -> F4	60 Fire gems

Empowerment is expensive because it buys permanent access on one commander. It is justified when the new level unlocks a repeatable ladder: a booster, critical ritual, national summon, global, or item that creates further access. Empowering for a one-off effect should be compared with alchemy, a communion, recruiting a rarer mage, trading for an item, or choosing a different solution.

Indirect magic

Path knowledge grants side benefits:

Path	Level 1 and scaling benefits	Level 3	Level 4
Fire	+10 Leadership and +10 Magic Leadership per level; shorter life	+5 Fire Resistance	another +5 Fire Resistance
Air	+10 Magic Leadership per level	+5 Shock Resistance	another +5 Shock Resistance
Water	+10 Magic Leadership per level	+5 Cold Resistance	another +5 Cold Resistance
Earth	+10 Magic Leadership per level	+3 natural Protection	+1 Affliction Resistance
Astral	+20 Magic Leadership per level	-	+1 Magic Resistance
Death	+50 Undead Leadership per level	rarely dies from old age	+10 Morale
Nature	+10 Magic Leadership and +10 supplies per level; longer life	+5 Poison Resistance	another +5 Poison Resistance
Glamour	+10 Magic Leadership per level	false-damage regeneration 1 per combat round	True Sight
Blood	+10 Undead and +10 Magic Leadership per level	+5 Hit Points	another +5 Hit Points

Level-one benefits scale with the path level. Threshold benefits are cumulative. These effects can change command capacity, longevity, supplies, resistance, and survivability even when the mage never casts a spell from that path.

Part III: Research as Strategic Planning

The research formula

An ordinary magical researcher produces:

```
Research = 5 + (2 x total magic levels) +/- research bonuses or penalties
minimum = 1
```

Magic and Drain scales modify magical research. Dementia halves research ability. The displayed value should be treated as authoritative for the current object after all abilities, scales, afflictions, items, and mod edits.

Some special researchers do not follow the ordinary path requirement:

- philosophers can research without magical paths, gain from Sloth, and ignore Magic and Drain;
- Divine Insights supplies limited research, but no more such researchers in one laboratory contribute than the dominion candles in that province;
- nation- and object-specific abilities can add or alter research.

Research resolves early

Research is hosting step 2. A researcher contributes for the month even if killed later during hosting. This does not make exposed researchers safe; it means the current month's points can survive a later raid while the future research flow does not.

Research is a queue of responses

A weak plan says:

> "Research Evocation because the nation has Fire mages."

A useful plan says:

> "Reach the precise area-damage spell before the first war, with enough F2 casters and carried gems to cast it after the line has engaged, while retaining an Alteration branch if the opponent fields fire resistance."

Every breakpoint should record:

Field	Question
Deadline	On which turn or war must the spell exist?
Caster	How many mages can cast it without rare randoms?
Resource	What does one battle, ritual cycle, or item batch cost?
Delivery	What range, timing, formation, lab, or ritual range is needed?
Counter	What common defence defeats it?
Branch	What is researched if scouting disproves the original threat?
Afterlife	Does the school level remain useful after the first purpose?

Breakpoints, not school completion

Research should be measured by useful breakpoints rather than equal bars. A school level can unlock:

- a defensive self-buff that makes thugs viable;
- an army-wide resistance answer;
- an efficient battlefield damage spell;
- a site-search ritual;
- a national summon;
- a path booster;
- a dome;
- a remote attack;
- a global;
- an artifact tier.

The next level is valuable only through the spells or items the nation can actually use. High school level does not imply high path requirement; low-path utility can appear late and high-path effects can appear earlier.

Research portfolios

A robust research plan contains four functions:

1. Immediate survival: expansion, early war, resistance, protection, or fatigue tools.
2. Efficient repetition: spells many recruitable mages can cast.
3. Access development: boosters, summons, or rituals that widen the path graph.
4. Strategic leverage: movement, remote warfare, globals, artifacts, and legendary effects.

Overconcentration creates brittle excellence. Excessive breadth creates many half-finished answers. The correct portfolio is shaped by national mage distribution and the next opponent, not by a universal school order.

Research efficiency

Useful measures include:

```
RP per gold = monthly research / recruitment gold
RP per upkeep = monthly research / monthly upkeep
breakpoint time = remaining RP / current monthly RP
field opportunity cost = RP lost when researchers leave laboratories
```

These ratios answer different questions. Cheap research may have poor commander-point efficiency. A high-RP capital mage may be needed for battlefield duty. A sacred researcher may have low upkeep. A foreign or summoned mage may open a path worth far more than its raw RP.

Mage-turn accounting

One mage can normally perform only one monthly strategic job:

- research;
- forge;
- cast a ritual;
- empower;
- search manually;
- move;
- preach or perform another order;
- accompany an army.

The full cost of a ritual is:

```
gem or slave cost
+ one mage-turn
+ foregone alternative output
+ position and exposure
```

A "free" summon paid only in gems still consumes a caster's month. A cheap item can be expensive if the only qualified mage is the nation's research engine or unique global caster.

Legendary research

Level 9 of every school except Construction consists of legendary spells. Reaching level 9 does not automatically grant the entire level:

- one legendary spell is selected and researched at a time;
- the level can be researched repeatedly to learn additional legendary spells;

- the default limited-legendary setting restricts how quickly this catalogue is acquired;
- Construction 9 instead unlocks unique artifacts.

The decision is spell-specific. "Reach Thaumaturgy 9" is incomplete; the plan must name the first legendary spell, the caster and gems that make it real, and the reason its effect is worth delaying every other branch.

Research audit

At the start of a major plan:

1. list the next two wars and likely counters;
2. identify exact spell breakpoints;
3. count common, uncommon, and unique casters;
4. reserve the gems required for one decisive battle;
5. identify the item or summon ladder that changes access;
6. estimate turns to the breakpoint after fielding losses;
7. name the branch if the opponent changes plan;
8. avoid counting a Pretender or unique mage in two distant places.

Part IV: Gems, Slaves, and Magical Logistics

Gem production

Magic sites send gems to the national treasury when their province is connected through friendly territory to a province with a laboratory. Ownership alone is not enough. Raiding, isolation, or laboratory loss can interrupt collection without destroying the site.

The treasury records both current stock and monthly income. These must not be confused:

- income supports a sustainable rate;
- stock allows bursts, emergency defence, globals, artifacts, and path development;
- committed stock is already promised to a forge queue, ritual, or field army even if still visible in the total.

Blood slaves

Blood has no ordinary gem. Blood slaves are acquired principally through Blood Hunting and are physical units/resources that must be moved and pooled. Their economy includes:

- gold and commander points for hunters;
- unrest and population damage;
- patrol or tax consequences;
- laboratory and transport logistics;
- the opportunity cost of hunter mage-turns;
- battlefield and ritual consumption.

The correct comparison is not "slaves are free." It is the total provincial and organisational cost per useful blood effect. Book II gives the hunting and unrest foundation; this book treats the magical expenditure.

Pooling and distribution

The pool command gathers gems carried by commanders in a laboratory province into the national treasury. Direct transfer equips field mages. A reliable monthly process is:

1. pool slaves and unused gems at laboratories;
2. reserve strategic stocks;
3. issue ritual and forge orders;
4. assign exact battle loads;
5. leave an explicit contingency reserve;
6. check that moving armies carry neither too few nor treasury-sized excesses.

Carried gems are exposed to battle loss and may be unavailable to rituals. Treasury gems cannot help a mage in battle unless transferred before combat.

Combat gem rules

A mage may use gems in combat to:

- raise a known path by one for one spell;
- reduce a spell's fatigue;
- satisfy a spell's gem requirement.

Limits:

- a mage cannot spend more gems in one combat turn than the current skill in that path;
- gems cannot grant the first level of an absent path;
- gem use cannot increase the path by more than one;
- the computer controls optional fatigue spending;
- conservative gem use makes the mage spend sparingly and on scripted spells only.

"How many gems does the spell cost?" is only the beginning. The full question is:

```
required spell gems
+ any path-boost gem
+ optional fatigue gems selected by the AI
<= gems legally spendable this combat turn
```

Because current skill is part of the spending limit, a battlefield boost or communion may change what can be spent. Exact spell-AI decisions remain object- and situation-sensitive.

What the patch history proves about optional spending

Official corrections place firm limits on any exact table inherited from early reverse-engineering:

Version	Official correction	Consequence
6.12	Gems are no longer used when the mage is targeted by a remote attack ritual.	Remote-attack replays do not establish ordinary battle spending.
6.15	Communions sometimes used too many gems to reduce fatigue.	Older communion-spending thresholds are not current law.

Version	Official correction	Consequence
6.30	Communion masters on conservative gem use sometimes failed to try higher-level spells.	Conservative behaviour must be tested on 6.30 or later.

A pre-release code investigation reported several concrete decision thresholds: conservative casters reacted near 100 projected fatigue and a 30-fatigue addition; ordinary casters used lower 85 and 20 checks, had further 25/40 fatigue-per-divisor tests, and attempted to retain three gems. Those values are valuable test inputs because they predict distinct outcomes. They are not printed here as the current algorithm: the official 6.15 correction establishes that at least part of the old communion-gem behaviour changed after that investigation.

The safe rule for play is narrower. Carry the scripted minimum, allow for optional fatigue control, and reproduce a critical refusal boundary in the current version before building a battle plan around it.

A battle-gem budget

For each mage, record:

Field	Meaning
Scripted minimum	Resources required to execute the intended five orders
Likely AI spend	Additional gems that may be used to control fatigue
Emergency reserve	Gems retained for later rounds or a second battle
Capture exposure	Maximum acceptable value if the army is destroyed
Conservative setting	Whether unscripted or optional spending is restricted

Underloading produces failed scripts. Overloading converts a rout into a treasury loss. The right load depends on the value of the battle, expected duration, retreat route, and likelihood of a second engagement before resupply.

Gems as fatigue control

Many combat gems are spent not to meet the printed requirement but to keep the caster conscious. This can be decisive because fatigue changes:

- whether later scripted spells are attempted;
- the risk of unconsciousness;
- communion-slave survival;
- vulnerability to critical and armour-defeating hits;
- the number of useful casts before collapse.

The effect should be valued in additional useful actions, not only fatigue removed. A gem that permits the decisive fourth cast may be more valuable than one that merely makes an already won battle cleaner.

Alchemy

Any magically skilled commander in a friendly laboratory can use the Alchemy order:

```
2 non-Astral gems -> 1 Astral pearl
2 Astral pearls -> 1 gem of another type
```

Converting one non-Astral type to another through pearls is effectively 4:1. This is a severe exchange rate. It is rational when the receiving gem crosses a binding threshold: a decisive ritual, booster, dome, global, or emergency defence.

The ordinary conversion should not be confused with alchemical spells that convert gems into gold. The Modding Manual's Alchemy Bonus ability applies to the latter category, not automatically to the treasury's pearl conversion.

Gem valuation

The value of a gem depends on access and timing:

```
strategic gem value
= effect unlocked
x probability of timely delivery
x scarcity of substitutes
- opportunity cost
```

A Nature gem may be common nationally but priceless at the exact army that needs a resistance spell. Astral pearls are flexible but are also consumed by communions, teleportation, dispels, and powerful late rituals. A surplus path can fund a repeatable summon; an apparent shortage may be caused by idle forge queues rather than low income.

Reserve doctrine

Useful reserve categories are:

- battle reserve: one or more decisive engagements;
- counter reserve: domes, dispels, emergency movement, or resistance;
- access reserve: empowerment or a booster chain;
- strategic reserve: a named global, artifact, or legendary ritual;
- trade reserve: gems whose diplomatic value exceeds immediate conversion.

An unlabelled treasury is easily spent twice in planning.

Part V: The Anatomy of Battle Magic

Spell classes by battlefield job

A battle-magic package normally combines several jobs:

Job	Desired effect
Preparation	Path boosts, personal defence, reinvigoration, or communion formation
Protection	Resistances, armour, Luck, regeneration, mist, concealment, or anti-magic
Control	Immobilisation, confusion, sleep, fear, fatigue, displacement, or terrain conditions
Attrition	Repeated efficient damage or summons
Breakthrough	Large area, armour-negating, high-penetration, or battlefield-wide effect
Sustain	Fatigue relief, healing, replacement bodies, or continuous enchantment
Counter	Removal or neutralisation of the enemy's named mechanism

Job	Desired effect
Preservation	Escape, protection of commanders, or reduced gem exposure

No spell is "good" independently of delivery. A superb damage effect at the wrong range or damage type is a poor answer. A minor resistance buff applied before the relevant area attack can decide the battle.

The battle-resolution boundary

Book IV is the authoritative home for preparation, interruption, spell accuracy, Magic Resistance contests, casting fatigue, damage families, and the lifetime of battlefield enchantments. Reprinting those formulas here created two places that could drift after a patch.

For magical planning, the essential questions are:

1. Can the caster complete preparation before contact or interruption?
2. Will the spell reach the intended target at an acceptable risk to friendly troops?
3. Which defensive layer does it test: Protection, resistance, Magic Resistance, fatigue, morale, or position?
4. Can the caster afford the fatigue and repeat the effect?
5. Does the plan still work indoors or under a different battlefield condition?
6. Is the caster's survival part of maintaining the effect?

The exact arithmetic and current patch corrections are in Book IV, Part XIV. This chapter uses their result to build the package.

Scripting and spell AI

A five-order script is a preferred sequence, not complete control. A scripted spell may fail because:

- research or a path was misread;
- the required resource is absent;
- range or target is illegal;
- fatigue is too high;
- the caster was interrupted, stunned, or unconscious;
- the battlefield condition is wrong;
- a target no longer exists;
- the spell AI chooses a fallback after the script.

Robust scripts name their failure branches. If the critical buff is skipped, can the army still survive? If an enemy resistance appears, what does the mage cast after order five? If communion slaves drop below a threshold, which masters become illegal or exhausted?

Battlefield package worksheet

Layer	Question
Threat	What exact damage, control, or defence must be answered?
Preparation	Which boosts and communion orders occur first?
Screen	What buys the required casting time?
Main effect	Which repeated spell performs most work?

Layer	Question
Breakthrough	Which spell changes the battle state?
Sustain	How are fatigue and losses controlled?
Counter-counter	What happens against resistance, antimagic, flyers, or assassins?
Gem budget	What is the cost per expected battle and per war?
Retreat	Which casters and gems survive a failed plan?

Part VI: The Nine Paths in Practice

How to read a path

Each path should be evaluated through six questions:

1. What protection does it create?
2. What defence does it attack?
3. How does it control movement, fatigue, or cohesion?
4. What does it summon or forge?
5. How does it project power on the map?
6. Which other path covers its principal failure?

The summaries below are functional maps, not spell lists. National spells and the active mods can substantially alter them.

Fire

Fire commonly converts research and gems into immediate destructive tempo:

- direct and area fire damage;
- burning and Heat;
- offensive weapon or strength enhancement;
- Fire Resistance;
- battlefield-wide destructive conditions;
- gem-to-gold alchemy;
- late world effects tied to fire and heat.

Fire's strengths are efficient damage against dense, insufficiently resistant armies and the ability to turn an ordinary line into a more lethal one. Its weaknesses are resistance, friendly fire, fatigue, limited control, and the possibility that high damage is wasted on dispersed or expendable targets.

Fire packages need:

- a reason targets will remain clustered;
- screening or range;
- a non-fire answer;
- protection from their own area effects;
- a gem budget for high-impact casts.

Air

Air commonly supplies:

- armour-negating shock damage;
- precision and ranged support;
- storms and anti-flight conditions;
- flight and strategic mobility;
- concealment, mist, or displacement;
- strong remote reach.

Shock damage attacks a different defensive layer from ordinary physical damage. Storms can define the whole battlefield, but may also obstruct friendly flyers, missile plans, or spell requirements. Air mages are often high-value because the path combines battlefield damage with movement and information.

Air planning must distinguish:

- storm-compatible and storm-dependent effects;
- friendly flying requirements;
- shock-resistant targets;
- whether strategic movement resolves into a magic battle or later ordinary battle;
- whether a remote effect is blocked by a dome.

Water

Water commonly provides:

- Cold Resistance and cold damage;
- quickness and action-tempo changes;
- defence and fluid physical alteration;
- water-elemental and aquatic tools;
- underwater access;
- frost-based battlefield control.

Quickness multiplies both output and fatigue exposure. Cold effects are strongest when resistance and friendly exposure are managed. Water's ability to operate underwater can be strategically decisive because many ordinary armies and rituals have restrictions there.

Water packages should audit:

- fatigue after additional actions;
- friendly cold resistance;
- underwater legality;
- the difference between temporary battle acceleration and monthly map movement;
- whether the target's high Protection matters to the chosen cold effect.

Earth

Earth commonly supplies:

- Protection and natural armour;
- strength and physical enhancement;
- reinvigoration and fatigue control;
- armour damage or earth control;

- constructs and siege power;
- many foundational forging tools.

Earth often wins indirectly by making an army's existing bodies harder, stronger, and more sustainable. It is also central to path escalation because Construction and Earth forging frequently create the infrastructure for other schools.

Earth packages fail when:

- armour-negating or resistance-based effects bypass the added Protection;
- heavy armour raises casting encumbrance;
- slow preparation loses to early contact;
- transformed or buffed units still lack delivery;
- a forging plan consumes the only field-capable Earth mages.

Astral

Astral commonly provides:

- communions;
- Magic Resistance contests and penetration;
- antimagic and resistance support;
- teleportation and remote projection;
- information and detection;
- global control, dispels, and late strategic effects.

Astral's central advantage is leverage: many modest mages can combine, and high Astral can contest units or globals through exact arithmetic. Its central danger is that the same infrastructure can be fragile. Communion slaves can collapse; high-value casters can be exposed; Astral duels or hostile soul effects can punish path-heavy mages.

Astral planning requires:

- MR and penetration estimates;
- slave and master path ratios;
- pearl supply;
- protection of communion infrastructure;
- a clear distinction between battlefield communions and Grand Communion orders.

Death

Death commonly supplies:

- undead creation and command;
- skeleton-based battlefield attrition;
- fear, decay, disease, and fatigue;
- soul and death effects;
- powerful summons and transformed commanders;
- late rituals involving the dead and Titans.

Death can convert gems into bodies without ordinary upkeep assumptions, but those bodies may be Mindless, vulnerable to Banishment, or dependent on Undead Leadership. Reanimation and battlefield summoning can absorb time while decisive casters work.

Death packages should audit:

- priestly counters;
- Undead Leadership;
- battlefield turn limits;
- friendly morale and disease exposure;
- whether summoned bodies are an objective or only a screen;
- the risk profile of late summons whose minds or forms are uncertain.

Nature

Nature commonly supplies:

- regeneration, healing, and life enhancement;
- poison resistance and poison offence;
- entanglement and movement control;
- animals, plants, and living summons;
- supplies and longevity;
- growth- and dominion-linked world effects.

Nature often creates persistence rather than immediate lethality. Regeneration is strongest on sufficiently large and protected bodies; it is not a substitute for surviving the initial hit. Poison plans require protection for friendly units and enough battle duration for delayed damage to matter.

Nature packages should distinguish:

- healing from affliction removal;
- regeneration from one-time healing;
- supply generation from battlefield value;
- poison damage from immediate rout pressure;
- living summons from mindless or undead logistics.

Glamour

Glamour commonly supplies:

- illusions and false damage;
- concealment and misdirection;
- confusion, bewilderment, and perception attacks;
- defence through appearance rather than armour;
- remote or strategic deception;
- True Sight at high indirect path skill.

False damage can disable or rout without ordinary wounds, but it interacts differently with false-damage regeneration and True Sight. Glamour defence can be powerful until the opponent brings the correct perception or wide-area answer.

Glamour packages need:

- an answer to True Sight;
- a plan for Mindless or otherwise inappropriate targets;
- real damage or control when illusion is insufficient;
- awareness that late-battle spell AI and current patches affect invisibility choices;
- protection against area effects that do not care which apparent body is real.

Blood

Blood commonly supplies:

- demons and blood summons;
- Sabbaths;
- sacrifice and dominion interaction;
- severe single-target or battlefield effects;
- horror and corruption mechanics;
- world enchantments that punish ordinary magic.

Blood converts provincial population, unrest tolerance, patrols, hunters, laboratories, and transport into a magical economy. Its scale can be enormous, but its logistics are unusually visible and disruptive.

Blood packages should audit:

- slaves at the caster rather than only in the treasury;
- hunter, patrol, and laboratory capacity;
- Sabbath fatigue modifiers;
- living-only or underwater restrictions;
- enemy raids on hunting provinces;
- whether blood investment is delaying conventional research and defence.

Cross-path architecture

Paths become more useful when paired by function:

Need	First layer	Complementary layer
Armoured mass	Fire, Air, Death, or resistance-based attack	Earth or Nature screen
High MR elites	Physical or elemental pressure	Astral penetration only where efficient
Dense low-resistance army	Area elemental damage	Control that holds density
Fast rush	Early protection and control	Later breakthrough damage
Long attrition	Death or summons	Nature/Earth sustain and fatigue control
Remote threat	Air/Astral/Glamour movement or attack	Domes, scouts, and local response
Global war	Astral dispel and high ritual strength	Gem income, caster security, diplomacy

The purpose of a secondary path is not variety. It is to cover the principal failure of the first mechanism.

Part VII: Communions, Sabbaths, Choruses, and Grand Communions

What a battlefield communion does

A communion combines mages during battle to:

- raise every master's already-known paths;

- distribute each master's spell fatigue among that master and all friendly slaves;
- pass certain personal buffs from masters to slaves;
- concentrate the actions of many mages into stronger casting.

A valid communion requires at least one master effect and one slave effect. Astral uses Communion Master and Communion Slave. Blood uses Sabbath Master and Sabbath Slave. MA Man's Spellsingers can use Chorus Master and Chorus Slave.

These are separate communion types. One Astral Communion, one Sabbath, and one Chorus may coexist, each with its own masters, slaves, and bonuses. An Astral master does not gain the slaves of a simultaneous Sabbath.

The level bonus

A master gains `n` levels in every path the master already knows when the communion has at least `2^n` slaves:

Active slaves	Master bonus
1	+0
2-3	+1
4-7	+2
8-15	+3
16-31	+4
32-63	+5
64-127	+6

The first slave makes the communion valid but grants no level. Bonus levels do not create an absent path. If slave casualties reduce the total below a threshold, every master's bonus drops immediately.

The threshold structure makes "spare" slaves strategically useful. Four slaves produce +2, but the loss or unconsciousness of one reduces the group to three and +1. Five or six retain +2 after some attrition.

Participants in one spell

For a single master's spell, participants are:

- the master casting that spell;
- all friendly slaves in that communion.

Other masters are not participants in that cast. They gain the path bonus, but they do not share another master's fatigue as participants.

If there are four slaves and three masters, a spell cast by one master has five participants, not eight. Each master's separate spell creates its own fatigue event over that master plus the same slave pool.

Base fatigue distribution

For one master's spell:

```
base fatigue per participant
= spell fatigue after path calculations
/ number of participants
```

The slave's share is then modified by the slave's skill relative to the casting master in the relevant path:

Slave path relative to master	Slave fatigue modifier
higher than master	x 0.5
equal to master	x 1
lower, but at least half the master	x 2
lower than half the master	x 4

Skill gained from the communion and all other sources is included when calculating spell fatigue. Exact rounding at each step is assigned to controlled testing.

Worked comparison

Suppose one master and four slaves participate, so the divisor is five.

If the resolved spell fatigue before distribution is 100:

```
base participant share = 100 / 5 = 20
```

The caster receives the master share according to the communion rules. Each slave then receives:

Relative skill	Fatigue per slave before type-specific modifiers
Slave higher	10
Equal	20
Lower but at least half	40
Lower than half	80

Four weak slaves do not automatically make high-path casting safe. The path bonus can raise the master far above the slaves, turning the x4 bracket into the dominant risk.

Master count and slave load

Adding masters increases output but not the number of participants in each cast. If two masters cast 100-fatigue spells into the same four equal-path slaves:

- each event has five participants;
- each slave receives a share from the first cast;
- each slave receives another share from the second cast;
- total slave load approximately doubles.

The correct design ratio depends on:

- master casting frequency;
- spell fatigue after boosted skill;
- slave path relation;
- slave encumbrance and reinvigoration;
- buffs transmitted to slaves;

- expected battle length;
- whether slaves leave at unconsciousness;
- how many threshold casualties can be tolerated.

"Four slaves per master" is not an engine rule.

Slaves cannot act

While in the communion, slaves perform no independent actions. Their mage-turn in the battle is converted into:

- master path access;
- fatigue capacity;
- receipt of qualifying self-buffs;
- risk.

A slave's opportunity cost includes the spells that mage could otherwise have cast. High-path slaves may be safer fatigue sinks, but they can be too valuable to immobilise.

Shared personal buffs

Slaves benefit from self-buffs cast by communion masters when those spells are single-target, range 0 personal effects. This can create powerful shared protection, resistance, regeneration, reinvigoration, or other effects.

The important details are:

- the buff is produced by the particular master's cast;
- legal qualifying effects must be checked from current spell data;
- timing matters-slaves may already have received fatigue before the protection arrives;
- some buffs can be harmful to particular slave bodies;
- a master's personal path access and script determine what is transmitted.

Communion buffing is an army-design problem, not an arithmetic trick. Slave chassis, resistances, and encumbrance must suit the intended shared effects.

Collapse

The communion ends when no masters or no slaves remain.

If all masters die or flee, every slave suffers:

- approximately one combat round of stun;
- `3d50` fatigue damage.

This backlash can disable or kill an already exhausted slave block. Keeping the masters alive is part of keeping the slaves alive. Redundant masters can prevent sudden collapse, but every additional active master can also increase fatigue throughput.

The current patch boundary matters. Version 6.12 made removal from a communion clear the slave spell effect, and 6.29 corrected cases where communion backlash failed to occur. A replay from before those fixes cannot settle present collapse behaviour.

Automatic participation

Items such as matrices, Slave's Hearts, and Master's Athames can make bearers join automatically. The bearer:

- must be a mage, meaning at least one non-Holy magic path;
- need not have Astral or Blood;
- must still be analysed for item slot, cost, timing, and survivability.

Automatic participation can bring foreign paths into a communion without spending the first scripted round joining. It also creates fragile item dependencies and may expose expensive gear to battlefield loss.

Current communion correction ledger

Version	Official change	What to retest
6.12	Being thrown out removes the communion-slave effect.	Forced removal, form changes, and automatic slave items.
6.15	Excessive gem use for fatigue reduction was corrected.	Gem budgets for high-throughput master groups.
6.23	Spell AI confusion between different communion types was corrected.	Mixed Communion, Sabbath, and Chorus battles.
6.29	Missing communion backlash was corrected.	Last-master death, flight, and forced removal.
6.30	Conservative communion masters again try eligible higher-level spells.	Conservative scripts across a slave threshold.

The manual already settles the ordinary shared-buff rule: a single-target range-0 personal spell cast by a master can affect that master's slaves. An area-one spell centred on the caster is not the same category merely because it covers the caster's square. Automatic items on non-Astral mages, multi-form commanders, and forced participant removal remain current test work.

The three battlefield types

Type	Special rule
Communion	Spells take 25% longer to cast
Sabbath	Master suffers half fatigue; slaves suffer 20% extra fatigue
Chorus	Spells take 25% longer; a slave leaves on losing consciousness

The Sabbath improves master endurance by transferring a harsher burden to slaves. Chorus slaves avoid later damage once unconscious, but every departure can reduce the master's path bonus immediately.

Designing a safe communion

Proceed in this order:

1. name the highest-path spell each master must cast;
2. calculate master path after the intended slave threshold;
3. estimate spell fatigue at that path;
4. count participants for each cast;

5. place each slave in the relative-path multiplier bracket;
6. add type-specific Sabbath or casting-time effects;
7. estimate simultaneous master throughput;
8. include transmitted buffs and reinvigoration;
9. provide threshold redundancy;
10. protect masters from assassination, flyers, missiles, and early area damage;
11. write a useful plan for masters after the scripted sequence;
12. decide what a controlled collapse looks like.

Common communion failures

The threshold cliff

Exactly four slaves produce +2. One casualty produces only +1, invalidating later spells or sharply raising fatigue.

Weak-slave multiplication

Masters rise several path levels while slaves remain far below half the master. Every cast sends four times the base share to each weak slave.

Too many masters

The slave pool receives overlapping fatigue from many masters. The communion appears efficient because every master has high paths, then the shared battery collapses at once.

Harmful self-buffs

A master distributes an effect incompatible with slave physiology, resistance, or role.

Preparation without contact timing

The army needs several rounds to join, boost, and buff, but the enemy reaches the mages before the package activates.

No post-script policy

Masters complete five orders and begin casting high-fatigue or inappropriate spells into the same slave pool.

Master annihilation

All masters are placed together and die to one flanking or area effect, causing backlash.

Grand Communions are different

Grand Communion is a strategic monthly order used by certain nations. When one eligible mage casts or dispels a global, other eligible mages in the same context can use Grand Communion to add their relevant path skill to the power of the attempt.

It does not:

- create a battlefield communion;
- distribute battlefield fatigue;
- grant every path;
- make participating mages available for research or other orders that month.

For a Dispel, joining Astral skill adds directly to the attempt described by the manual's example. Grand Communions let a nation convert several mage-turns into ritual contest strength.

Communion audit

Before a battle:

- identify communion type;
- count slaves at every threshold;
- record each master's boosted paths;
- calculate every critical spell's participants and slave brackets;
- check shared self-buffs;
- set gem policy;
- separate or protect masters;
- decide how slaves recover;
- plan for one slave loss, one master loss, and early contact;
- test the exact package in the current ruleset.

Part VIII: Rituals and Strategic Magic

Ritual fundamentals

Rituals are map spells that take one entire monthly order. They normally require:

- a friendly laboratory;
- the researched school level;
- a caster with all required paths;
- sufficient gems or slaves in the national treasury;
- a legal target and range.

The treasury supplies ritual gems automatically. A field commander carrying gems elsewhere does not increase the national pool.

Hosting position

Important magic timing from the official hosting sequence:

Step	Resolution
2	Research
4	Empowerment
5	Forging
10	Magic rituals, in random caster order
11	Remote army attacks
12	Magic battles, including relevant teleports and movement

Step	Resolution
14	Site-search ritual results
28	Global enchantments take effect on the world
31	Item and monster special effects
62	Artifacts may become yearning

This timing has strategic consequences:

- current research can unlock knowledge before later events, but orders were submitted with the pre-host state;
- forging and empowerment complete before ordinary rituals;
- remote attacks and magic movement can precede ordinary movement battles;
- a global is cast at the ritual step but its world effect begins at step 28;
- a new global does not retroactively change movement battles or storming that already resolved in the same host;
- yearning occurs near the end of the turn.

Ritual order is random

Rituals at step 10 resolve in random caster order across relevant mages. Plans that require ritual A to precede ritual B in the same month are unsafe unless the engine or objects provide a specific guarantee.

This affects:

- opening and using gateways;
- competing globals;
- sequential remote attacks;
- global-slot contests;
- casting a protection before a hostile action;
- using a summon as a same-turn caster.

Range and legality

Ritual range is measured in provinces where shown. No listed range normally means a local ritual. Markers include:

- NUW: cannot be cast underwater;
- UW: can be cast only underwater.

Ritual-range abilities and sites can change reach. Range should be measured from the actual casting laboratory after movement orders, not from the capital or army being supported.

Local enchantments

Local enchantments affect a province and may persist. Many are linked to their caster:

- caster death ends the effect;
- most also end when the province is conquered;
- limited-duration enchantments can often be extended with extra gems;
- most gain one month per extra gem, while some gain three.

The shortcut `Shift+M` repeats a ritual monthly while the caster remains eligible and resources exist. Repetition is operationally convenient but can drain a treasury silently if the strategic need changes.

Anonymous and limited rituals

Some rituals are:

- Anonymous: caster or origin information is concealed by the effect's reporting rules;
- Limited: only one instance can affect the target province.

Anonymous is not synonymous with undetectable. Scouting, diplomatic inference, target selection, and repeated patterns can still reveal responsibility.

Ritual categories

Category	Strategic use	Main counter
Site search	Convert map ownership into gem income or special access	Raiding, lab isolation, opportunity cost
Summon	Convert gems and a mage-turn into units or commanders	Banishment, resistance, upkeep or leadership limits
Remote attack	Damage or invade a distant province	Domes, defence, decoys, retaliation
Magic movement	Relocate forces outside ordinary movement	Domes, traps, interception, wrong timing
Information	Reveal provinces, armies, sites, or magic	Concealment, misinformation, opportunity cost
Local enchantment	Protect or transform one province	Dispel, conquest, caster assassination
Economy	Produce gems, gold, units, scales, or other flow	Caster loss, global contest, raids
Global	Change rules across the world	Dispel, replacement, assassination, dominion pressure

Site-search rituals

Remote searches can:

- cover territory faster than manual movement;
- search dangerous provinces without exposing a mage;
- use otherwise idle path access;
- convert gems into future income.

They are investments, not automatic profit. The expected return depends on site frequency, province type, previous searches, ritual cost, and time remaining. A search that pays back in ten turns can be poor during an existential war and excellent during stable expansion.

Summoning

A summon should be valued by role:

Summon output	Main value
Combat bodies	Frontage, attrition, special attack, resistance, or siege
Commander	New path, leadership, forging, ritual, or thug chassis

Summon output	Main value
Sacred unit	Bless interaction and Holy Point independence where applicable
Undead or demon	Different upkeep and leadership system, specific counters
Elemental or temporary force	Immediate battlefield conversion

The cost includes the summoner's month. A mediocre combat unit can be a great summon if it opens a path, commands a new troop family, or relieves a commander-point bottleneck.

Remote attacks

Remote attacks resolve before ordinary movement battles. Their purposes include:

- stripping Province Defence;
- killing commanders or laboratories;
- testing a dome;
- exhausting defenders;
- cutting retreat routes;
- creating a magic battle before the main invasion;
- forcing the enemy to distribute defence.

A remote attack should be coordinated with the ordinary campaign. Damage without exploitation may only warn the target. Repeated attacks can also disclose path access and spending.

Magic movement

Teleportation and related movement create unusual timing. A movement ritual may produce a magic battle at step 12, before ordinary army movement. The arriving force must be self-contained:

- correct leadership;
- gems and slaves;
- a legal survival or retreat plan;
- enough force if the target is stronger than intelligence suggested;
- awareness of domes and redirection.

Strategic mobility is valuable because it compresses distance, but it can also separate mages from laboratories, armies, and friendly retreat provinces.

Repeat-ritual discipline

For every repeated ritual, record:

- monthly cost;
- assigned caster;
- cancellation condition;
- minimum reserve;
- target rotation;
- lab and range requirement;
- whether a new patch or mod changes the object.

Automation should preserve judgment, not replace it.

Part IX: Domes and Remote-Magic Defence

What a dome protects

Domes are local enchantments that interact with hostile ritual effects targeting the province. Their exact chance and consequence are object-specific. Some block, some redirect, and some retaliate.

They do not replace:

- scouts and intelligence;
- conventional defenders;
- protection against assassination;
- laboratory redundancy;
- dispersal of unique casters;
- diplomatic deterrence.

Major manual examples

Dome	Listed behaviour in the manual	Friendly-magic consequence
Dome of Solid Air	80% protection; destroyed when it fails	Blocks friendly targeted magic as well
Frost Dome	30% protection and a cold trap	Blocks friendly targeted magic as well
Forest Dome	30%; absorbed fire destroys it	Blocks friendly targeted magic as well
Dome of Misdirection	70%; redirects a ritual to a neighbouring province	Can redirect friendly targeted magic
Seven Seals	Perfect hostile protection until seven blocks crack it; caster-linked	Friendly Astral magic can pass
Dome of Arcane Warding	50% protection	Check current object text for exact scope

Strikeback or trap domes may retaliate without blocking. Against global enchantments, strikeback does not hit the global caster. As of 6.34, domes may also protect against Astral Disruption according to the official update.

Layering domes

When several domes exist, exact ordering and interaction must be tested for the current version and object set. Strategic evaluation should include:

- probability of at least one block;
- whether a failure destroys a dome;
- whether redirection can hit a friendly or valuable neighbour;
- whether friendly rituals are impeded;
- caster dependency;
- recurring gem and mage-turn cost;
- what the hostile caster learns from the result.

Do not multiply listed percentages without confirming resolution order and independence.

Dome strategy

A dome is best when it protects concentrated value:

- a capital research core;
- an artifact or global caster;
- a gateway;
- a throne;
- a major laboratory and gem stock;
- a predictable army staging province.

Concentration also makes the target predictable. A strong defence can invite repeated cheap probes, assassinations, ordinary invasion, or attacks on the dome caster.

Remote-defence audit

- Which provinces are worth enemy gems?
- Which hostile paths and ranges are known?
- Is the dome compatible with friendly rituals?
- Can the caster survive old age, raids, and assassinations?
- Is there a second laboratory or alternate staging point?
- What happens after one block, one failure, or redirection?
- Can the enemy simply attack the logistics outside the dome?

Part X: Global Enchantments and Dispel Wars

Global slots

Global enchantments are worldwide rituals. Game setup permits 3, 5, 7, or 9 global slots; five is the common default. The slot limit makes globals a shared political resource. Casting one changes not only the world but also what every other nation can maintain.

Casting cases

When a global is cast:

1. if the same named global already exists, the new casting attempts to replace it through the dispel contest;
2. if an empty slot exists and that name is absent, the new global occupies a slot;
3. if all slots are full and the name is different, the new global contests a randomly selected existing global, including possibly one cast by the same nation.

Global casting order among mages is random. A plan that assumes an open slot at the beginning of hosting may fail after other nations cast first.

Overcasting

The caster can add gems above the printed minimum. Ritual spending is capped by:

```
maximum ritual gems = caster path level x 100
```

The dispel strength of a global includes:

```
+1 per extra gem above minimum
+5 per caster path level above the spell requirement
+DRN
```

The challenger must beat the incumbent's result. The ordinary lesson is that one extra caster path level is worth five overcast gems in the contest, before considering other abilities or Grand Communion support.

Dispel

The common Dispel ritual directly challenges a selected global. The same comparison framework applies:

- extra gems add one each;
- excess relevant path adds five each;
- both sides receive a DRN;
- the higher result wins;
- the challenger must overcome the existing enchantment.

Because the roll is open-ended, no finite ordinary advantage is absolute. Large margins produce reliability, not certainty.

Caster dependency

Most globals end if the caster dies. Immortality does not preserve the enchantment through death while the body reforms. Some globals are also tied to an origin province and end if that province is conquered.

Counterplay includes:

- Dispel;
- same-name replacement;
- slot-pressure casting;
- assassination;
- remote attacks;
- old-age pressure;
- conquest of the origin;
- forcing the caster to take another risk;
- pushing out hostile dominion when the effect is dominion-limited.

A huge overcast protects against magical contest, not against a knife.

Protection against globals

Domes can protect units against many global effects in the same general way as local rituals. Strikeback domes do not retaliate against global casters. For globals restricted to or strengthened by dominion, removing hostile dominion from a province can function as protection.

The exact protected unit, province, and event scope is global-specific and should be read from current spell text.

Global categories

Category	Strategic effect
Gem engine	Creates monthly magical income
Economic engine	Changes gold, resources, supplies, or population
Battlefield rule	Adds storms, darkness, scales, or other conditions
Summoning or attack engine	Produces units or recurring hostile actions
Research or forging engine	Changes item cost, skill, or knowledge economy
Punishment global	Taxes rituals, forging, empowerment, or ordinary activity
Dominion global	Scales with or operates inside religious territory
Information or control global	Changes vision, detection, travel, or global slots

The printed benefit is only the first-order effect. A world storm, darkness, or ritual tax changes every rival's research choices and diplomacy.

Selected strategic examples

The following revision-2 manual values are a reference set; current object data must be checked before a live-game order:

Global	Requirement and base cost	Principal function
Eternal Pyre	Enchantment 6, F6, 80 Fire	+20 Fire gems per month; heat and darkness interaction at origin
Mother Oak	Alteration 5, N5, 50 Nature	+10 Nature gems per month
Well of Misery	Conjuration 8, D6, 80 Death	+21 Death gems per month and world growth interaction
Stellar Focus	Enchantment 7, S5, 60 Astral	+10 Astral pearls per month; world Drain and origin Magic effects
Gale Gate	Thaumaturgy 8, A5, 60 Air	+20 Air gems per month, stronger Air Elementals, hurricanes
Gates of Horn and Ivory	Thaumaturgy 7, G5, 60 Glamour	+15 Glamour gems per month and increased Glamour ritual range
Forge of the Ancients	Construction 6, E5, 80 Earth	Item cost reduction and Master Smith bonus
Perpetual Storm	Evocation 6, A5, 70 Air	Storms in battles, land-income and movement/range pressure
Burden of Time	Thaumaturgy 7, D7, 70 Death	Population, unrest, Death scales, and accelerated aging pressure
Eternal Twilight	Alteration 8, G8, 90 Glamour	Worldwide Magic/Twilight and economic pressure outside friendly dominion

Examples with more extreme late-game effects appear in Part XIII. These values are object data, not engine formulas; patches and active mods can change them.

Payback

For a pure gem global:

```
nominal payback time
= total gems spent / monthly gems produced
```

This is incomplete. A proper valuation adds:

- probability of being dispelled or losing the caster;
- value of the global slot;
- diplomacy and coalition response;
- same-path gem scarcity;
- caster and research opportunity cost;
- time remaining in the game;
- benefit from non-income side effects.

An 80-gem global producing 20 per month has a nominal four-month payback before overcast. It can still be poor if it provokes immediate war or exposes the only F6 caster.

Global diplomacy

Globals change incentives:

- a private gem engine is visible wealth;
- a world penalty creates a coalition even if its caster is hard to identify politically;
- a slot-filling global can block several nations' plans;
- a defensive overcast can signal a long-term commitment;
- an origin province becomes a public strategic target.

Before casting, assess:

1. who gains;
2. who loses;
3. who can dispel;
4. who can reach the caster or origin;
5. who benefits from helping either side;
6. what explanation or bargain is available.

Global-war audit

- Confirm the current spell object.
- Name the caster and backup.
- Calculate minimum, overcast, excess-path bonus, and maximum spend.
- Decide whether a Grand Communion applies.
- Verify slot state but assume other casts can precede it.
- Protect the caster and any origin province.
- Reserve a response to replacement or Dispel.
- Model diplomatic reaction.
- Set a minimum number of productive months.
- Do not place every strategic asset in the same protected province.

Part XI: Forging, Items, and Artifacts

Forging requirements

Forge Item requires:

- a mage in a friendly laboratory;
- the relevant Construction level;
- all item path requirements;
- the required gems;
- an appropriate item slot on the eventual bearer.

Forging resolves at hosting step 5. `Shift+0` repeats the selected item each month while requirements remain satisfied.

Construction tiers

Construction level	Item tier
1	Magical trinkets
3	Lesser magical items
5	Greater magical items
7	Very powerful magical items
9	Unique magical artifacts

Construction also contains spells and constructs. Its strategic value cannot be reduced to equipment alone.

Base item cost by path requirement

For each required path:

Required level	Base gems of that path
1	5
2	10
3	15
4	20
5	30
6	40
7	55
8	70

Multi-path items charge each path component. Current object data, national discounts, Forge Bonus, Forge of the Ancients, yearning, and mod commands can alter effective cost.

Item value

An item can provide:

- a path threshold;

- reinvigoration or resistance;
- protection, defence, attacks, or mobility;
- automatic communion membership;
- ritual range or special orders;
- leadership;
- monthly gem generation;
- survival or transformation;
- a chassis-specific thug or supercombatant package.

The correct unit of analysis is the package:

```
item gems
+ forge mage-turn
+ Construction research
+ bearer opportunity cost
+ risk of loss
```

A cheap item can be strategically expensive on the wrong bearer. A costly booster can be excellent if it unlocks a global or a new repeatable booster ladder.

Slots and package conflicts

Commanders have limited equipment slots. A booster competes with:

- protection;
- reinvigoration;
- a weapon or shield;
- penetration gear;
- mobility;
- anti-assassination equipment;
- another booster.

Path-access plans must be built on the actual chassis. "Wear three boosters" fails if they occupy the same miscellaneous, head, body, or hand slot.

Mounted units and unusual chassis can have different slot or item restrictions. Strength requirements and two-handed weapons can also invalidate theoretical loadouts.

National items

Some items are:

- restricted: only qualifying nations see and forge them, displayed with a dark blue forge background;
- discounted: available at reduced cost for particular nations, displayed in grey.

National items may alter a nation's access curve earlier than generic tables imply. They belong in every later nation dossier.

Forge bonuses

Forge Bonus and Master Smith are not identical:

- Master Smith raises paths for forging only;
- Forge Bonus reduces cost according to the ability or source;
- Forge of the Ancients gives a world-effect discount and Master Smith bonus to the caster's nation;
- national discounts and object-specific commands can also apply.

Exact stacking order and rounding among fixed and percentage effects are assigned to controlled tests. The displayed forge cost is the operational authority.

Forge of the Ancients

The revision-2 manual lists:

```
Construction 6
Earth 5
80 Earth gems
-20% item gem cost
Master Smith +1
```

This global changes both price and eligibility. Its strategic value is highest when:

- many item batches are planned;
- the +1 creates new forge thresholds;
- Construction research is already deep;
- the caster and global can be protected;
- the new efficiency will be realised before Dispel or war.

Artifacts

Construction 9 items are unique artifacts: only one copy of each can exist in the world. The default limited-unique-artifact rule limits each player to one unique artifact forged per turn.

Artifacts create:

- race conditions;
- intelligence from failed availability;
- concentration of power and loss risk;
- global strategic targets;
- an incentive to reach Construction 9 before others.

An artifact is more than an improved item. Its uniqueness changes timing and diplomacy.

Yearning

An artifact can become yearning, allowing it to be forged at half usual cost. Yearning can begin once at least one of these has occurred:

- any nation researches Construction 9;
- Forge of the Ancients is active;
- the Throne of Creation is claimed;
- the Throne of the Artificer is claimed.

Each condition increases the monthly yearning rate by 50 percentage points according to the manual. The check occurs at hosting step 62.

Yearning creates an information problem. Waiting can halve price but lose the artifact race. Forging immediately secures the object but pays full cost.

Booster reference

The following manual items form the core generic access map. Values are path requirements, not effective gem prices after bonuses.

Construction 5

Item	Forge requirement	Boost
Skull Staff	D2	+1 Death
Thistle Mace	N2	+1 Nature
Flame Helmet	F4	+1 Fire
Winged Helmet	A4	+1 Air
Gossamer Veil	G3	+1 Glamour
Robe of the Sea	W3	+1 Water
Armour of Souls	B5	+1 Blood
Earth Boots	E2	+1 Earth
Coin of Meteoritic Iron	S2E2	+1 Astral
Horn of Storms	A5	+1 Air
Brazen Vessel	B5	+1 Blood
Blood Stone	B3E2	+1 Earth
Armour of Twisting Thorns	B3N2	+1 Nature and +1 Blood

Construction 7

Item	Forge requirement	Boost
Staff of Elemental Mastery	F4W4 or A4E4 variant	+1 Fire, Air, Water, and Earth
Treelord's Staff	N5	+2 Nature
Blood Thorn	B3	+1 Blood
Starshine Skullcap	S2	+1 Astral
Skullface	D5	+1 Death
Robe of the Magi	A5B5	+1 all nine ordinary paths
Skull of Fire	F1D1	+1 Fire
Water Bracelet	W1	+1 Water
Ring of Wizardry	S7	+1 all nine ordinary paths
Ring of Sorcery	S6	+1 Astral, Death, Nature, and Glamour
Moonvine Bracelet	N3S1	+1 Nature
Mirage Crystal	G3E2	+1 Glamour

The table is a threshold map, not a recommendation to forge every item. It must be combined with slots, national paths, rare randoms, and active-mod data.

Booster ladders

A ladder begins with actual access and applies legal steps in order:

```
native path
-> low-tier booster
-> higher forge threshold
-> multi-path booster
-> summon or empowerment
-> global or legendary threshold
```

Example structure:

```
E2 mage
-> forge Earth Boots
-> operate as E3 while worn
-> cast or forge an E3 threshold
```

This does not create Earth on an E0 mage. It also does not allow one physical item to be worn simultaneously by two casters.

Forge queue

For each planned item:

Field	Record
Purpose	Exact spell, ritual, battle, or chassis unlocked
Qualified forger	Common, rare, unique, or Pretender
Research	Construction deadline
Cost	Displayed current cost after bonuses
Slot	Conflict with other equipment
Bearer	Where and when the item is needed
Reuse	Whether it returns to a laboratory or remains deployed
Loss risk	Capture, death, assassination, or artifact uniqueness

Part XII: Path Access and Bootstrapping

National access is a distribution

"The nation has Astral 3" can mean:

- every fort recruits S3;
- a capital-only mage has S3;
- a 10% random reaches S3;
- the Pretender alone has S3;
- a summon can eventually reach S3;
- one empowered commander reaches S3;
- a communion temporarily produces S3.

These are strategically different. Every nation dossier should separate:

- common repeatable paths;
- capital or terrain restrictions;
- random probability;
- foreign recruitment;
- summons;
- Pretender access;
- item-dependent access;
- communion-only combat access;
- empowerment.

The access graph

Represent each threshold as a node:

```
recruitable mage
-> booster forger
-> boosted ritual caster
-> summoned new-path commander
-> cross-path item
-> global or legendary caster
```

Every arrow needs:

- research;
- path;
- gems;
- a mage-turn;
- a slot or laboratory;
- correct load order under mods.

If any arrow depends on a rare random, calculate recruitment probability and delay rather than calling the ladder "reliable."

Probability of random access

For an independent probability `p` per recruitment, the chance of at least one success after `n` recruits is:

```
P(at least one) = 1 - (1 - p)^n
```

Examples:

Random chance	Recruits	Chance of at least one
10%	5	41%
10%	10	65%
10%	20	88%
20%	5	67%
20%	10	89%

This assumes independent rolls and the stated probability. Multi-pick random systems and linked randoms require their actual object definition.

Access quality

Evaluate a path threshold on:

Dimension	Question
Reliability	How often can the caster be obtained?
Scale	How many can be fielded?
Location	Capital, fort, terrain, summon site, or Pretender?
Timing	When do research and gems make it operational?
Sustainability	Can the effect be repeated each month or battle?
Replaceability	What happens if the caster dies?
Competing role	Is the caster also the only forger, researcher, or global anchor?

Empowerment as a bridge

Empowerment is most efficient when it creates an access loop. Examples:

- path 0 -> 1 permits a booster to function;
- a new cross-path combination forges a unique enabler;
- a permanent ritual caster summons replaceable mages;
- a global generates more of the gem type used;
- a new path makes an existing rare random unnecessary.

The fifty-gem first level is poor if it ends at level 1 with no useful threshold.

Pretender as access

A Pretender can:

- forge initial boosters;
- cast a national or global ritual;
- provide a missing cross-path;
- summon new-path commanders;
- establish a communion or item ladder.

This access is delayed by dormancy or imprisonment and endangered by death, Call God delay, and positional commitments. A Pretender path that exists only on the design screen is not operational until the chassis can reach a laboratory and spend the required turns.

Trading and diplomacy

Items and gems can move path access between nations:

- trade for a booster;
- hire another player to forge;
- exchange surplus gems for a binding shortage;
- coordinate a global or Dispel;
- use allied movement and laboratories where game rules permit.

Trade can be cheaper than empowerment, but it creates dependency and reveals strategic intent. A request for a Starshine Skullcap or Ring of Sorcery tells informed rivals which threshold may be approaching.

Hidden costs of path escalation

- rare mages stop researching;
- boosters occupy survival slots;
- a ladder concentrates unique items;
- the caster becomes an assassination target;
- alchemy destroys four gems for one off-path gem;
- the required global occupies a contested slot;
- the access arrives too late for the named war.

The correct endpoint is the cheapest timely and repeatable access, not the highest theoretical path.

Part XIII: Legendary and Late-Game Magic

The level-nine decision

Legendary research is a strategic commitment:

- level 9 has a large research cost;
- one spell is selected at a time;
- required paths are often rare;
- gem costs can consume several months of income;
- the spell can change global diplomacy;
- the caster becomes a critical asset.

The selection should answer:

1. What changes immediately after the spell is learned?
2. Is the caster already operational?
3. Are the gems reserved?
4. What is the counter?
5. Is a second legendary spell worth repeating the level?
6. Would another school's lower breakpoint win sooner?

Wish

The revision-2 manual lists Wish as:

```
Alteration 9
Astral 9
100 Astral pearls
```

Wish can produce extraordinary outcomes and can also harm the caster or nation. The manual suggests that wishing for gems or an artifact is safer than many ambitious requests.

Folklore is not enough to establish the accepted commands, aliases, random results, restricted units, or mod interactions. The library treats a complete Wish catalogue as test pending. The controlled suite records exact strings, messages, treasury changes, units, items, afflictions, horror marks, and repeat variation for each ruleset.

Nexus Gate

The manual lists Nexus Gate as:

```
Thaumaturgy 9
Astral 5, Earth 3
40 Astral pearls
```

It establishes a permanent gate to the Nexus. The network is shared and creates opportunities for rapid movement as well as exposure to other users and void-related danger. It cannot be evaluated as "forty pearls for movement" alone; it changes map topology.

Questions before opening it:

- who else can use the network;
- which laboratories and armies become connected;
- whether entry provinces can be held;
- what happens if an enemy learns or controls a node;
- which commanders can survive the destination.

Tartarian Gate

The manual lists Tartarian Gate as:

```
Conjuration 9
Death 7
7 Death gems
```

It releases a dead Titan or Monstrum from Tartarus. The body can be extraordinarily powerful, but the mind may be destroyed or otherwise impaired. The ritual's low printed gem cost is balanced by uncertainty, caster requirements, research, leadership, equipment, and remediation.

Tartarians should be classified after arrival:

- fully capable commander;
- impaired commander requiring healing or transformation;
- combat body;
- unusable or dangerous result.

The expected value depends on the nation's ability to repair minds, equip chassis, command units, and absorb failures.

Arcane Nexus

The revision-2 manual lists Arcane Nexus as:

```
Enchantment 9
Astral 8
150 Astral pearls
```

It gathers Astral pearls equal to one quarter of non-Astral, non-Blood gems spent on rituals, forging, and empowerment, along with its ambient collection described by the spell. It does not simply take a percentage of all magic income.

Arcane Nexus changes the world's incentives:

- rivals may delay forging and rituals;
- gem spending indirectly funds the caster;
- the caster becomes a coalition target;
- Dispel strength and overcast become geopolitical questions;
- Blood activity is comparatively less taxed by the stated collection rule.

Utterdark

The revision-2 manual lists Utterdark as:

```
Alteration 9
Death 9
100 Death gems
```

Its world darkness and severe income/resource reduction restructure military and economic play; caves and deep seas receive stated exemptions. Its value is relative. A nation prepared for darkness, nonliving armies, summons, or reduced conventional income may gain while ordinary gold-and-resource nations collapse.

The diplomatic effect is immediate: even nations not at war with the caster have reason to remove it.

Gift of Nature's Bounty

The manual's legendary Nature global improves income inside friendly dominion in proportion to candles and adds Growth. Its effect links:

- dominion strength;
- population economy;
- temple and preaching infrastructure;
- global protection;
- the ability to hold productive territory.

It does more than produce income. It turns religious map control into a fiscal multiplier.

Astral Corruption

The legendary Blood/Astral global punishes non-Blood rituals, forging, and empowerment with horror-related danger scaling with expenditure. It changes the comparative price of every magical action and can make ordinary path development lethal.

The caster should expect:

- coalition pressure;
- reduced rival forging and ritual tempo;
- greater relative value of Blood magic;
- attacks on the global caster;
- opponents shifting to armies, priests, or already forged assets.

Cataclysm and slot disruption

Some late rituals affect multiple globals, local enchantments, world magic, horror marks, or even the global-slot environment. Such effects should be treated as regime changes, not isolated spell casts.

Before using one:

- record which friendly enchantments will also be lost;
- estimate who benefits from a cleared global board;
- identify the order in which replacement globals can be cast later;
- protect against the new horror or magic environment;
- recognise that apparent neutrality can still favour one roster.

Late-game transition

A nation is not in the late game merely because it has researched level 9. A functional late-game magical state includes:

- several protected high-path casters;
- a deep treasury with named reserves;
- repeatable battlefield packages;
- remote response and movement;
- global defence;
- forged and summoned access;
- laboratories and retreat routes;
- intelligence about rival legendary choices.

Research without delivery is a catalogue. Delivery without preservation is a spectacle.

Part XIV: Countering Magic

Counter the chain

Every magical plan has dependencies. It can be attacked at:

```
research
-> caster
-> path boost
-> gems
-> lab
-> range
-> preparation
-> target
-> effect
-> persistence
```

The cheapest counter is often not the one printed opposite the damage type.

Counter layers

Enemy mechanism	Possible counter layers
Fire area damage	Fire Resistance, dispersion, faster contact, caster interruption, dome if remote
MR-based control	Higher MR, path skill, antimagic, fewer valuable targets, physical pressure
Communion	Kill or scatter masters, exhaust slaves, force threshold loss, early contact, extended battle
Skeleton spam	Priests, fatigue pressure, kill summoners, long-battle clock, commander targeting
Heavy buffs	Attack before activation, bypass Protection, remove caster-linked enchantment
Remote attack	Dome, decoy province, distributed labs, conventional defence, retaliation

Enemy mechanism	Possible counter layers
Global	Dispel, replacement, assassination, origin conquest, dominion removal, diplomacy
Artifact chassis	Disarm through killing bearer, fatigue, MR attack, battlefield control, assassination
Gem-heavy script	Cheap probes, sequential battles, retreat denial, treasury pressure

Resistance is not a complete counter

Resistance reduces one damage family. It does not necessarily answer:

- physical secondary effects;
- fatigue;
- control;
- armour-negating non-elemental damage;
- summons;
- morale pressure;
- battlefield conditions;
- a complementary second path.

A good counter preserves function after the opponent changes one spell.

Attack timing

Many magical packages are weakest:

- before research completes;
- while boosters are being forged;
- during the first preparation rounds;
- after gems are spent in a probe;
- when casters move away from laboratories;
- after a communion loses one threshold slave;
- when a global caster becomes publicly identifiable.

Tempo can be a stronger antimagic tool than Magic Resistance.

Targeting the organisation

Magic concentrates value in commanders. Countermeasures include:

- flyers or rear attacks;
- assassins;
- precision missiles;
- remote strikes;
- fast flanks;
- fear or morale pressure on ordinary mage chassis;
- cutting friendly retreat provinces;
- raiding laboratories and gem connections.

This must be balanced against decoys, bodyguards, traps, and expendable casters.

Gem denial

Force the enemy to spend resources inefficiently:

- attack twice before resupply;
- threaten multiple fronts;
- use cheap forces that look valuable enough to trigger scripted gems;
- retreat from the expected main battle where legal;
- raid gem-producing sites and laboratories;
- occupy the route that connects sites to labs.

Exact spell-AI gem thresholds are not fully public, so sacrificial-probe doctrine must be tested rather than treated as automatic.

Counter-counter planning

Every package should answer:

> If the opponent knows the plan, what is the cheapest adjustment that defeats it?

Then add one response:

- alternative damage;
- different formation;
- a faster script;
- a lower-gem mode;
- extra slave redundancy;
- a second route;
- conventional troops that exploit the magical counter.

The aim is not an uncounterable spell. It is a package whose counters create exploitable costs.

Part XV: Active Mod Ruleset

Keep the engine and object layers separate

Book IX owns the exact spell, item, site, mage, and command inventories for DE 2.16 followed by Divinitus 1.15.3 DE. Those files can change schools, paths, costs, range, area, effects, boosters, research, forging, ritual mastery, and gem income on thousands of individual objects. An unmodded spell table cannot safely be copied into the combined game.

The object edits do not automatically replace the engine's general research process, communion participant rules, ritual timing, laboratory requirements, global-slot process, or ordinary alchemy. Those rules remain the starting point until an exact command, patch correction, or controlled test changes them.

Resolving modded magic

For every important spell or item:

1. identify the unmodded object;
2. apply every DE selection or copy in source order;

3. apply Divinitus afterward;
4. resolve linked units, effects, weapons, sites, and shapes;
5. record final school, paths, cost, range, area, effect, and restrictions;
6. verify in game;
7. test AI, communion, and edge behaviour if strategically important.

The published explanation can remain readable, but its source record must retain the full provenance.

Part XVI: Controlled-Test Programme

Test standard

Every test records:

- game version;
- ruleset and load order;
- map and province;
- research and global settings;
- exact commander and object IDs where available;
- paths, items, gems, fatigue, and scripts;
- screenshots or turn files;
- number of repetitions;
- observed distribution;
- conclusion and remaining uncertainty.

One replay can demonstrate possibility. It rarely establishes probability or exact rounding.

Test 1: Research arithmetic

Create researchers with known total paths, bonuses, Magic/Drain, Dementia, philosopher status, and Divine Insights. Verify displayed and contributed RP, minimum 1, halving order, and dominion-candle caps.

Test 2: Research hosting timing

Have researchers contribute and then die at later hosting steps. Confirm current-month contribution and future loss. Test laboratory loss and site-income connectivity separately.

Test 3: Combat gem spending

For paths 1-4, script spells requiring zero, one, and several gems. Vary fatigue, conservative use, communion bonus, and carried stock. Record maximum gems spent per combat turn and AI fatigue spending.

Include boundary cases around the historical projected-fatigue checks of `85/20` and `100/30`, the reported `25/40` fatigue-per-divisor checks, and stocks of three versus four spare gems. These are regression predicates, not expected current rules. Run the same scripts outside a communion, inside one, and while targeted by a remote attack ritual so the 6.12, 6.15, and 6.30 corrections are isolated.

Test 4: Spell-fatigue rounding

Use listed fatigue values not divisible by the excess-skill divisor. Vary base and armour Encumbrance. Record fatigue after each cast and locate every rounding step.

Test 5: Penetration

Use fixed caster path, excess skill, target MR, and target same-path skill. Run enough trials for baseline, easy, and hard resistance. Confirm tie direction and half-skill rounding.

Test 6: Communion thresholds

Run 1, 2, 3, 4, 7, 8, and 9 slaves. Remove one slave during battle and record immediate master path changes and spell legality.

Test 7: Communion fatigue

Vary:

- equal-path slaves;
- higher-path slaves;
- lower but half-path slaves;
- below-half slaves;
- one or several masters;
- odd fatigue totals;
- reinvigoration;
- Communion, Sabbath, and Chorus.

Record master and every slave after each spell.

Test 8: Communion self-buffs

Cast range-0 single-target buffs before and after joining. Use several masters and incompatible slave types. Record exactly which effects pass, timing, stacking, and harmful interactions.

Test 9: Communion collapse

Kill or rout all masters at different slave-fatigue levels. Measure stun and `3d50` fatigue distribution. Separately eliminate all slaves and compare.

Include a forced-removal case to reproduce the 6.12 effect cleanup and confirm the 6.29 backlash correction.

Test 10: Automatic communion items

Test matrices, hearts, and athames on:

- non-Astral mages;
- non-Blood mages;
- priests with and without another path;
- innate casters;

- multi-form commanders.

Verify joining time, type, and slot behaviour.

Test 11: Ritual order

Construct same-turn rituals whose results reveal order. Repeat across nations and casters. Test dependencies involving summons, gateways, domes, and competing globals.

Test 12: Dome interaction

For each dome:

- friendly and hostile remote spells;
- anonymous and limited rituals;
- global unit effects;
- Astral Disruption;
- multiple layered domes;
- redirection at map edges;
- caster death and province capture.

Test 13: Global contest

Vary extra gems, excess path, same-name replacement, full slots, and Grand Communion. Confirm challenger tie behaviour, random incumbent selection, and self-replacement risk.

Test 14: Forge-cost stacking

Combine national discounts, fixed and percentage Forge Bonus, Master Smith, Forge of the Ancients, yearning, and multi-path items. Record eligibility and displayed cost at each step.

Test 15: Booster access

Verify that boosters fail at path 0 and activate at path 1. Test multi-path and all-path boosters, forms, item loss, and battlefield boost interactions.

Test 16: Artifact race and yearning

Trigger each yearning condition alone and in combination. Record monthly checks, half-cost display, simultaneous forging, unique-item failure, and limited-unique-artifact settings.

Test 17: Legendary research

Under limited and unlimited settings, record:

- first level-9 completion;
- spell-selection interface;
- repeated level-9 cost;
- simultaneous schools;
- Construction 9 differences.

Test 18: Wish

For every ruleset:

1. prepare an S9 caster and turn backup;
2. enter exact candidate strings;
3. record message, treasury, units, items, afflictions, horror marks, and caster status;
4. test aliases separately;
5. repeat random outcomes;
6. inspect mod restrictions such as `NO_WISH`.

Priority requests include gems, gold, slaves, artifact/artefact, weapon, power, strength, experience, dominion, population, exact unit names, commander or hero, and dangerous wishes.

Test 19: Indoor magic

Repeat battlefield-wide, ordinary area, personal, holy, and innate spells in open fields, caves, fort interiors, and assassination arenas. Confirm current 6.36 legality and AI fallback.

Test 20: Combined-mod regression

Build fixed battle and ritual fixtures for:

- school and requirement changes;
- damage, area, range, and fatigue;
- boosters and forge costs;
- communions and `#masterrit`;
- sites and gem income;
- Divinitus overwrites after DE.

Re-run whenever either file changes.

Part XVII: Operational Checklists

First magic audit

For a new nation:

1. list every recruitable mage and path distribution;
2. separate common, capital-only, terrain, foreign, sacred, and random access;
3. record research per gold, commander point, and upkeep;
4. identify the first battlefield protection, damage, and control breakpoints;
5. list generic and national boosters;
6. identify summon-based path expansion;
7. map gem income and unsearched paths;
8. name the first war's battle package;
9. set battle and strategic reserves;
10. identify the Pretender's unique magical jobs.

Research-turn checklist

- Did scouting change the next threat?
- What exact breakpoint is being bought?
- Which common mage casts it?
- Are the necessary gems already available?
- Is a critical forger or ritualist still counted as a researcher?
- Does one additional school level produce a usable spell?
- Is the plan overdependent on one rare random?
- What is the branch if war begins early?

Battle-magic checklist

- legal research and path;
- carried gems or slaves;
- current skill and per-turn spend limit;
- fatigue after excess skill and Encumbrance;
- range and likely target;
- battlefield indoor or underwater status;
- resistance and friendly exposure;
- preparation and interruption risk;
- communion threshold and slave load;
- orders after script completion;
- retreat and gem preservation.

Ritual checklist

- laboratory;
- treasury stock after other commitments;
- caster path and maximum ritual spend;
- range and UW/NUW legality;
- hosting order;
- dome risk;
- anonymous or limited status;
- repeat-order cancellation condition;
- caster and origin protection;
- exploitation after success.

Forging checklist

- current Construction;
- current object and mod overwrite;
- actual qualified forger;
- displayed cost;
- national, global, bonus, and yearning modifiers;
- item slot;
- bearer and delivery location;
- forge mage-turn;
- alternative booster or trade;
- loss risk.

Global checklist

- empty-slot uncertainty;
- minimum and overcast;
- excess-path bonus;
- Grand Communion;
- caster and origin;
- Dispel opposition;
- same-name contest;
- diplomatic coalition;
- payback time;
- world effect begins at step 28.

Post-battle magic audit

After every important replay:

- Which scripted spell first failed or changed target?
- Did contact occur before the package activated?
- How many gems were consumed and why?
- Which casters were interrupted?
- What was master and slave fatigue after each major cast?
- Did resistance, Protection, dispersion, or summons decide conversion?
- Did the army exploit the effect?
- Which caster, item, or gem stock was permanently lost?
- What single change most improves the next battle?

Part XVIII: Essays

Essay I: Research as a Response Tree

Research is often imagined as a ladder: climb one school, take the strongest spell at each level, then begin another. That image is convenient and strategically misleading. A ladder has only one direction. A real research plan is a response tree whose branches depend on enemy armies, geography, Pretender timing, gems, and the distribution of national mages.

The root is the nation's repeatable access. If most forts can recruit E2 mages, an Earth spell cast by E2 is not one option among many; it is a scalable transformation of the roster. If S3 appears only on a rare random, the same research level may provide a spectacular but unreliable trick. Research points do not distinguish between them. Strategy must.

The branches are deadlines. A spell that finishes two turns after an invasion is not an answer to that invasion. A defensive level reached one turn early may preserve laboratories and researchers, increasing every later branch. This is why research value cannot be reduced to spell efficiency. Timing changes the quantity of future research that exists.

Scouting prunes the tree. Fire Resistance becomes urgent against mass fire damage and largely idle against an enemy who changes to poison or fatigue. A wide portfolio protects against uncertainty, but each unfinished branch delays every completed answer. The best plan is neither a straight rush nor equal investment. It maintains one main branch and one affordable pivot.

Access development creates new branches. A Construction level can forge a booster; the booster permits a summon; the summon carries a new path; that path unlocks a ritual. The original research may produce far more than its first item. A high-level spell with no caster is the opposite: knowledge with no route into the world.

An expert research screen should be read as a decision map. Every allocated point says which future is being prepared for and which is being delayed. The useful question is not "Which school is best?" It is "Which branch leaves the nation with a timely answer and the strongest next choice?"

Essay II: Gems as Stored Time

A gem is condensed magical power, but strategically it is also stored time. It represents a site found, territory held, a connection maintained to a laboratory, and several turns during which the resource was not spent elsewhere.

This explains why equal gem costs are not equal. Five gems from a path producing twenty each month are a small slice of current flow. Five gems in an absent or scarce path may represent alchemy at four to one, diplomatic trade, or the entire stock accumulated since expansion. The spell interface displays cost; it does not display replacement time.

Combat converts stored time into immediate tempo. A path-boosting gem can bring a spell forward by one threshold. Fatigue spending can buy an additional useful cast before unconsciousness. A battlefield enchantment can make one battle occur under conditions that would otherwise require an entirely different army. The gem is efficient when the time purchased now is worth more than the time stored for later.

Forging converts gems into persistent access. A booster may be moved between mages, reused across wars, and become the first rung of a larger ladder. A summon converts them into a body or commander. A global converts a large stock into continuing flow or a new worldwide rule. These forms have different exposure: items can be captured, summons can die, and globals depend on casters and contested slots.

The gem treasury is also a calendar. A reserve for Dispel protects future turns. A forge queue promises gems to a coming threshold. Battle loads prepay the chance to survive an invasion. If every gem remains in one unlabelled total, future plans are silently sold to the first attractive order.

The mature question is not whether to spend or save. It is which future action the stock is preserving, and whether the current crisis is more valuable than that future. Hoarding without a named endpoint is wasted time. Spending without an opportunity-cost ledger is borrowed defeat.

Essay III: From Mage to Army

A nation does not possess battlefield magic merely because its mage can cast a spell. The effect becomes military power only when it is delivered through an army structure.

The first requirement is time. Buffs, communion formation, and battlefield enchantments occupy preparation rounds. The line must hold without routing or pushing the fight outside spell range. Formation is part of the magical plan. A cheap screen may be the piece that makes an expensive spell work.

The second requirement is scale. One powerful caster can influence a battle, but repeatable mages define doctrine. If every fort supplies the required path, losses can be replaced and several armies can carry the package. If the Pretender or one rare random is essential, the effect is a strategic reserve, not standard army equipment.

The third requirement is conversion. Protection must answer the actual damage family. Evocations need legal targets and acceptable friendly exposure. Resistance spells must activate before the hostile effect. Summoned bodies must appear where their frontage and morale matter. A spell cast successfully but converted into irrelevant damage has consumed time and perhaps gems without becoming force.

The fourth requirement is exploitation. Immobilising an enemy matters if missiles, flankers, or heavy infantry can use the delay. Darkness matters if the friendly roster functions better inside it. A storm matters if it disables more hostile systems than friendly ones. Magic is strongest when it changes the exchange in favour of bodies already prepared to exploit it.

The final requirement is preservation. Mages, boosters, slaves, and gems are campaign assets. A victorious army that loses its magical core may not fight again. The full magical package includes retreat routes, commander protection, spare laboratories, and a resupply plan.

Turning a mage into part of an army is an organisational job. The spell is only one component. Screen, formation, script, gem load, counter, and post-battle survival complete the weapon.

Essay IV: Communions Without Myths

Communions attract rules of thumb because their exact arithmetic feels cumbersome. "Use four slaves," "one master per four," or "communions share buffs" are memorable. None is a sufficient design rule.

Four slaves do create +2 paths, but they also stand on a cliff. One loss reduces every master to +1. Whether they survive depends on the spell's fatigue, the master's boosted path, each slave's relative path, the number of masters casting, the communion type, and shared buffs. The visible slave count is only the beginning of the calculation.

The participant definition corrects another common assumption. Other masters do not help divide one master's spell. One casting master and all slaves participate. Adding masters increases the number of fatigue events sent into the same pool, so an impressive casting roster can make the communion less stable.

The path comparison is equally important. Communion bonuses lift the master. If weak slaves remain below half that boosted skill, their fatigue share is multiplied by four. A spell that looks cheap after the master's excess-skill reduction can still crush every slave when repeated by several masters.

Shared self-buffs are the creative centre of communion design. A master can transmit qualifying personal protection, resistance, regeneration, or other effects to the slave block. This can turn fragile researchers into a durable magical battery. It can also distribute an incompatible effect and kill them faster. The chassis matters as much as the paths.

The communion is best understood as a power grid. Slaves provide capacity, masters draw and transform it, thresholds govern voltage, and every spell creates load. Redundancy, compatible components, controlled demand, and protected control nodes make a grid reliable. A copied ratio does not.

Essay V: Rituals and Geopolitics

Battle spells act inside one encounter. Rituals act on a map shared with other players and intentions. A remote attack, dome, teleport, or global is both a mechanical action and a political signal.

Range compresses geography. A nation with remote search and attack can turn distant laboratories into forward influence. Magic movement can ignore ordinary fronts. Domes create protected capitals and staging provinces. None abolishes position: every effect still begins from a caster, laboratory, origin, range, or gateway that can be scouted and attacked.

Hosting order makes this influence simultaneous. Rituals resolve in random caster order. Remote attacks and magic battles precede ordinary movement. Globals take world effect after several military phases. The strategic map visible when orders are submitted is not the map on which every effect resolves.

An anonymous ritual conceals information but does not remove inference. Nations observe who has the path, range, motive, and gem economy. A repeated attack can unite several targets against the suspected caster. A global publicly changes every nation's incentives even if its direct benefit is private.

Protection also redistributes violence. A dome over the capital encourages enemies to raid gem sites, assassinate the dome caster, probe the percentage, redirect magic, or invade conventionally. Successful defence changes the cheapest hostile route; it does not end hostility.

Ritual planning must include the diplomatic aftermath. The effect, its likely attribution, the victims' alternatives, and the means of exploiting it all belong in the order. Strategic magic is geopolitics carried out through the hosting sequence.

Essay VI: Globals as Political Economy

A global enchantment is often evaluated by payback: cost divided by monthly income. This is necessary for gem engines and radically incomplete.

The global occupies a scarce public slot. It announces a caster with high path access and a treasury capable of overcasting. It may reveal an origin province. It changes which rivals gain from cooperation, Dispel, assassination, or slot pressure. Its true cost includes the coalition it creates.

World penalties demonstrate the point most clearly. Darkness, storms, aging, ritual corruption, or income collapse do not harm every roster equally. The caster has presumably prepared summons, resistances, dominion, or alternative income. Other nations assess not the absolute harm but the caster's relative gain. A spell that reduces everyone by half can be overwhelmingly aggressive if one nation loses only a quarter.

Gem globals also alter politics. Private income increases future Dispel and forging capacity. A rival may reasonably spend more than the global's nominal value to stop it compounding. The caster's payback calculation must include the chance that the global survives, not only its monthly output.

Overcasting buys resistance to one form of attack. It does not prevent assassination, old age, origin conquest, or a random full-slot replacement attempt. Every additional gem increases magical security while concentrating more value behind the same mortal dependency.

The strongest global plan is a state programme: caster security, reserve gems, dome and mundane defence, diplomatic preparation, origin protection, and a schedule for exploiting the new world. The enchantment is the public institution; the protected network behind it is the state that keeps it alive.

Essay VII: The Level-Nine Decision

Level-nine research is seductive because it promises the largest effects in the game. The cost is not only the research points shown on the bar. It is every lower branch delayed while the nation climbs, every mage-turn required to create the caster, and every gem reserved instead of winning earlier battles.

Legendary selection makes the trade sharper. Most schools do not grant a complete catalogue at level 9; one spell is selected at a time. The first choice needs a named caster, treasury, target, counter, and operational date.

Some legendary spells transform the map. Nexus Gate changes connectivity. Others transform magical economy: Arcane Nexus taxes world expenditure, and Astral Corruption punishes ordinary magical action. Utterdark or similar world effects change the value of entire rosters. Wish can cross conventional boundaries but carries uncertainty that must be tested rather than romanticised.

The best legendary spell is relative to preparation. Tartarian Gate is stronger for a nation that can repair, equip, and lead its results. A dominion-scaled economic global is stronger for a nation already winning religious territory. A punishment global is stronger when the caster's own economy is exempt or prepared.

Counterpressure begins before the cast. Rivals can observe research direction, boosters, rare path mages, pearl hoarding, and Construction races. A path to level 9 may invite attack precisely because its future is frightening. Reaching the threshold requires surviving the signal.

The level-nine decision should be worked backwards from the world it creates. Describe the position one turn after success, four turns after success, and after the obvious coalition response. If those positions are not favourable, the legendary spell is not yet a plan. It is only a possibility.

Sources and Open Questions

Principal sources

- Illwinter, Dominions 6 Manual, revision 2, especially Magic, paths and schools, battle magic, rituals, global enchantments, communions, gems, research, legendary spells, items, Divine Magic, alchemy, and the spell and item appendices.
- Illwinter, Dominions 6 Modding Manual, version 6.34.
- Illwinter Dominions 6 documentation.
- Illwinter Dominions 6 changes.
- Official Dominions 6.30 announcement.
- Supplied `DomEnhanced2_16.dm`.
- Supplied `Divinitus_1.15.3_DE.dm`.
- Loggy's reverse-engineering notes, used only to define historical combat-gem threshold tests; the notes predate official 6.15 and 6.30 corrections.
- Naaira's communion guide, used for current player doctrine and examples, while the manual and patch ledger own the rules.

Community references are used to discover disputed questions and test candidates, not to override current official rules without reproducible evidence.

Open questions

Current-game tests or resolved object data are still needed for:

- exact current optional combat-gem AI thresholds and all target-selection weights after 6.15 and 6.30;
- every rounding step in spell fatigue, penetration, communions, forging, and ritual contests;
- complete ordering and independence of layered domes;
- every current object value altered after the revision-2 manual;
- exact Wish vocabulary, aliases, random distributions, and restrictions;
- all effective DE and Divinitus spell, item, site, mage, and summon records;
- automatic-item, forced-removal, multi-form, mod-specific communion, Grand Communion, and forge interactions;
- simultaneous artifact and global edge cases.

Book IX now owns the exact mod command scope; this list is limited to behaviours that still need engine evidence.

DOCUMENT 7 OF 7

Foundation Book VI: Strategy and Campaign Conduct

From systems to campaign

Dominions is won on the map, but the map is only the visible surface of the contest. Armies occupy provinces; research changes what those armies can survive; laboratories turn gems into reach; scouts turn uncertainty into decisions; forts turn territory into replacement capacity; diplomacy changes how many fronts must be defended; and Thrones determine when strength becomes victory.

> Foundation rule: Strategy is the conversion of limited resources into a position that can force, survive, or prevent the next decisive event.

A nation does not win by collecting the largest abstract total of gold, gems, research, or territory. It wins by making those resources matter before rivals can answer, then turning the advantage into enough claimed Ascension Points. Every recommendation in Book VI has a context and a deadline.

Book VI is where the earlier rules meet the map. It assumes the mechanical foundations instead of teaching their formulas again. A spy revealing income is a rule. Recruiting one before the first war is advice whose value depends on access, cost, geography, and the information already available.

Edition note

The shared ruleset and evidence language remain in Book I. Books II-V own the detailed economy, religious, combat, and magic rules. Book VI brings them together for expansion, intelligence, logistics, diplomacy, defeat, and victory conversion. Book IX supplies exact modded changes whenever a campaign plan depends on DE or Divinitus.

Current-version corrections and additions that matter

Dominions 6 introduced strategic systems and interface changes that make some older-series advice incomplete:

Current feature or correction	Strategic consequence
Optional hidden maps require exploration	Map knowledge is acquired rather than assumed; scouts can reveal routes as well as armies
Maps may contain multiple planes	Adjacency, sanctuary, invasion routes, and throne access can cross a plane boundary
Formal diplomacy supports binding NAPs with humans and AI	Treaty terms may be enforced by the engine, but the game setting and agreed social doctrine still matter
Raid is movement followed by pillaging, without an automatic return	Pillager units now seize and damage the destination rather than performing an abstract round trip
Scrying inside dominion can detect glamoured units	Glamour conceals information but does not guarantee operational surprise
Thrones become visibly lit after being claimed	Claimed victory progress is easier to read from the map
Many globals depend on an origin province that must be held	Strategic enchantment defence includes territorial defence

Current feature or correction	Strategic consequence
Score graphs incorporate more sources accurately	Threat estimates using graphs are stronger than in early releases, though still incomplete
AI builds forts, recruits better national troops, and plans high-level rituals, globals, and dispels	Old descriptions of a purely passive or magically incapable AI are obsolete
Magic-phase movers can be included in moving-army setup	Teleporting and ordinary elements can be prepared as one operation
Cataclysm is harder to counter	Late games with Cataclysm enabled must treat the victory threshold as a moving clock
Large games host faster and allied site information was corrected in 6.34	Operational coordination is more reliable than in affected older versions

Object balance still changes through patches. A current nation plan must be rebuilt when its roster, spell access, Pretender options, or mod layer changes, even if the campaign principles remain valid.

Using the campaign sections

Expansion, scouting, borders, research signals, war planning, sieges, Thrones, and the turn checklist form the main route. Raiding, remote warfare, deterrence, coalition politics, recovery, and after-action review become more useful once those basics are familiar. The single-player chapter explains what AI games teach well and where multiplayer creates a different strategic problem.

Part I: Strategy as Conversion

Position, force, and deadline

A strategic position has three parts:

1. Assets: provinces, forts, laboratories, temples, armies, mages, gems, research, Pretender, and diplomatic relationships.
2. Access: which assets can affect which places and at what time.
3. Deadline: the next event that changes the value of the position.

Deadlines include an enemy research breakpoint, a dormant Pretender awakening, a fort cracking, a treaty expiring, a global taking effect, a claim-capable priest reaching a Throne, or the arrival of Cataclysm. The same assets can be sufficient before a deadline and worthless after it.

This yields a practical model:

```
strategic value
= usable assets
x probability of correct delivery
x value before the deadline
- exposure and opportunity cost
```

This is not an engine formula. It is a way to compare plans. A large army has little current value if it cannot cross the terrain in time. A research lead has little war value if the mages carrying it are trapped in a sieged capital. A cheap raider has high value if it pulls an expensive counter-mage away from the decisive front.

The six conversions

Most campaigns turn on six conversions:

Conversion	Example	Failure mode
Economy into capacity	Gold builds forts and recruits mages	Infrastructure delays necessary defence
Capacity into knowledge	Mages spend turns researching	The nation researches effects it cannot field
Knowledge into force	Mages, gems, troops, and scripts form an army package	A spell list is mistaken for a deployable force
Force into position	Armies take routes, labs, forts, sites, and Thrones	Victories occur in strategically empty provinces
Position into constraint	Raids, forts, threats, and treaties narrow enemy choices	Gains are too diffuse to force a response
Constraint into victory	The nation cracks, storms, and claims enough Thrones	Dominance is enjoyed but never converted

Strong play moves deliberately from one conversion to the next. Weak play often becomes trapped between them: rich but unable to recruit, researched but unable to cast, victorious but unable to siege, or dominant but unable to claim.

Tempo and initiative

Tempo is the amount of useful change achieved before an opponent can respond. Initiative is the ability to present threats that determine where and how the opponent must spend the next turn.

Tempo is not speed alone. A fast raid that loses a unique commander may surrender more future tempo than it gains. A month spent combining armies may be correct if the merged force can remove a capital and every smaller force would bounce.

Initiative is strongest when threats are:

- credible: enough force or hidden capacity exists to execute them;
- multiple: the defender cannot cover every target;
- asymmetric: the attacker spends less than the defender must reserve;
- timed: the threats mature together;
- convertible: at least one successful branch leads to a fort, lab, army destruction, or Throne.

The objective is not perpetual aggression. It is the ability to decide which problem becomes urgent.

The strategic horizons

Horizon	Typical distance	Central question
Turn	Current hosting cycle	Which orders can fail, collide, or become illegal?
Operation	Several turns	Which target can be isolated, reached, cracked, and exploited?
War	Research and reinforcement cycle	Which exchange rate and breakpoint can the enemy not sustain?
Game	Victory threshold	Which route produces enough claimed Ascension Points?

Good decisions align all four. A tactically excellent battle can damage the operation by consuming gems needed for the storm. A successful operation can damage the war if it exposes two unforted borders. A winning war can lose the game if another nation claims the last required Throne.

The cost of attention

Dominions has an unpriced resource: player attention. Every additional raider, scout network, forge route, blood-hunting transfer, communion, or diplomatic promise creates orders that must be checked. A system that is theoretically optimal but routinely misordered has a lower practical value than a robust system.

Attention costs grow sharply in war because each turn adds:

- battle reports and script diagnosis;
- enemy movement estimates;
- gem and item transfers;
- recruitment replacement;
- route and retreat checks;
- diplomacy;
- throne arithmetic.

Simple habits such as renaming commanders, marking armies, keeping standard scripts, using repeatable gem loads, and following a fixed turn audit are strategic tools. They lower the chance that a mature position dies to an omitted order.

Part II: Expansion

What expansion is for

Expansion is the first time a Pretender design and national roster are turned into territory. The result is more than a province count. Good expansion produces:

- gold and resource flow;
- room and population for forts;
- magic sites and independent recruits;
- defensible boundaries;
- routes toward or around Thrones;
- enough surviving troops and commanders to discourage an early war;
- an infrastructure schedule that does not stop recruitment.

A player can finish the first year with many poor, exposed provinces and a hollow army. Another can hold slightly fewer provinces but own two strong fort sites, a narrow border, and intact expansion parties. The second position may be stronger.

Expansion testing

Expansion should be tested under the actual game assumptions:

Variable	Why it must match
Nation and age	Starting army, roster, independent composition, and resources differ

Variable	Why it must match
Pretender and awakening	An awake expander changes routes, risk, and recruitment
Scales and dominion	Gold, resources, supplies, bless, and Pretender safety change
Independent strength	Required party size and acceptable targets change
Map or map type	Terrain, connectivity, caves, water, and start density change
Active mods and load order	Costs, units, blessings, spells, and Pretenders may differ
House rules	Expansion diplomacy, mercenaries, and early attack restrictions may differ

A useful test protocol is:

1. Create the intended ruleset and game settings.
2. Record the Pretender design.
3. Play through turn 12, including realistic recruitment, Province Defence, site searching, and fort construction.
4. Record every fight, loss, province type, treasury level, fort start, and remaining army.
5. Repeat on several starts.
6. Change only one major element at a time.
7. Keep the reliable build, not the one with the luckiest maximum.

The community practice of testing to turn 12 is valuable because one in-game year includes route variation, attrition, winter or summer conditions, and the first infrastructure decision. A benchmark is meaningful only if its accounting includes what the real game will buy. Tests that omit PD, forts, researchers, or required temples create an imaginary expansion economy.

The first expansion audit

Before the first attack:

- What troop or Pretender package is the expansion engine?
- Which independent types can it defeat cheaply?
- Which types can kill it through lances, high damage, mass missiles, magic, poison, fear, or surround penalties?
- Does it need a bless, prophet, priest, mage, screen, or specific formation?
- How many losses can be replaced without delaying the second party?
- What is the retreat route?
- Which adjacent province improves capital recruitment through resources?
- Which route reveals the most map or claims the most valuable boundary?

The first attack should normally be selected after scouting reports arrive. Independent armies do not change merely because the estimate changes; the report contains uncertainty. The correct response to uncertain numbers is margin, not false precision.

Expansion party archetypes

Archetype	Strength	Main risk
Armoured line	Absorbs low-damage infantry and missiles	High-damage barbarians, lances, fatigue, slow killing
Defence or glamour line	Avoids many ordinary attacks	Surround penalties, high attack, area damage, magic weapons

Archetype	Strength	Main risk
Missile mass	Damages before contact and exploits low protection	Shields, armour, weather, ammunition, fast contact
Lance or impact force	Powerful first contact	Wasted charge, attrition after impact, missile exposure
Giant or elite squad	High individual durability and damage	Low numbers, surrounding, expensive casualties
Sacred party	Bless creates an efficient specialist package	Holy-point limits, priest dependency, wrong matchup
Awake monster	Independent commander with rapid early tempo	Irreplaceable loss, hostile dominion, fatigue, specialist independents
Awake Titan	Expansion plus later slots and strategic magic	Complex scripting, afflictions, insufficient early damage
Thug pair or small commander team	Mobile, low troop demand, scalable later	Gem or bless dependency, counter matchups
Mage-supported troops	Solves hard types and reduces attrition	Lost research, stray death, gem consumption, script failure

These are roles, not strict categories. A sacred giant line may belong to three at once. The purpose is to identify why the party wins and which target will break it.

Target selection

Target value has at least five dimensions:

1. Win probability.
2. Expected permanent loss.
3. Economic value.
4. Positional value.
5. Information value.

The weakest visible province is not automatically the best target. A resource-rich cap-ring forest can unlock a second party. A low-income mountain may secure a choke point or later fort. A province on the wrong side of the intended boundary may create a diplomatic dispute. A throne province may reveal valuable effects but contain mage support far beyond ordinary independents.

An expansion route should prefer:

- targets the party counters;
- cap-ring terrain that improves recruitment;
- rich farmlands and high population for economy and forts;
- strategic connectors and plane gates;
- provinces that cut off a safe interior;
- independent mages or special recruits;
- routes that can be reinforced rather than isolated.

Minimum force and acceptable loss

The ideal party is not the smallest one that can win once. It is the smallest one that wins with enough reliability and survivors to keep tempo. A party that takes a province with 55% probability is not efficient merely because it is cheap.

Expansion losses have compounding cost:

- replacement gold and resources;
- commander turns spent collecting troops;
- delayed second and third parties;
- lost veteran experience;
- exposed routes;
- weaker deterrence at first contact.

Overbuilding also compounds. A single enormous party may win every fight but captures only one province per turn. Two parties with safe matchups normally create more map tempo, reveal more land, and deny more provinces.

Use three margins:

- combat margin: enough strength to survive report error and random battle outcomes;
- attrition margin: enough survivors to take the next scheduled target;
- strategic margin: enough reserve or recruitment that one bad fight does not collapse the opening.

Routing and branch points

An expansion party should rarely be sent to the far edge without a return plan. Every route should mark:

- the next two intended targets;
- a branch if the preferred target is too dangerous;
- a rendezvous province for reinforcements;
- the future border;
- the nearest fort site;
- the path home or toward a threatened neighbour.

Interior provinces can be deliberately left for a later party if the outer route encloses them safely. This increases frontier speed without surrendering the eventual income. The risk is that an unscouted connector, cave, water route, or rival cuts into the pocket.

First contact

First contact turns expansion into diplomacy. The first border message should settle practical facts before fear fills the gap:

- which provinces each side believes are natural claims;
- whether a disputed province contains a Throne, special site, or critical route;
- whether formal or social NAPs are in use;
- how countdowns are counted;
- whether scouts and stealth units are permitted;
- how accidental bumps will be handled.

The best border is not always equal by province count. A stable border that preserves a rich interior can be worth conceding one weak province. A narrow, fortifiable line is often stronger than a long geometrically "fair" boundary.

When expansion ends

Independent expansion ends when profitable unclaimed targets disappear or when continuing exposes the nation to an unacceptable first-war position. The transition signs are:

- neighbouring expansion parties can collide;
- taking the next province creates a disputed salient;
- armies must combine to take Thrones or hard independents;
- forts and researchers now return more than another marginal army;
- opponents have reached military breakpoints;
- the nation must choose a first-war target or defensive posture.

The correct transition does not stop all growth. Thrones, underwater access, caves, remote provinces, and independent pockets may remain. It changes the dominant problem from beating known neutral defenders to acting under human opposition.

Part III: Scouting, Intelligence, and Uncertainty

Information is a resource

Information changes which orders are rational. It does not directly kill troops, but it prevents armies from attacking the wrong counter, reveals undefended infrastructure, identifies a throne rush, and allows gems to be carried only where necessary.

The value of information depends on:

- accuracy: how close the report is to reality;
- coverage: how much of the relevant map or force is observed;
- timeliness: whether it arrives before orders are due;
- interpretation: whether the player understands what the evidence implies;
- denial: whether the opponent can be kept from obtaining the same advantage.

Old information decays. A capital report from six turns ago still identifies fort and terrain, but not the current army, research package, gem reserve, or commander movement.

Official information channels

Observer or condition	Information provided
Scout in province	Owner, military estimate, fort construction, province history, current temperature and neighbour temperature
Priest in province	Scout information plus dominion strength and owner
Spy in province	Scout information plus income, supplies, known sites, unrest, PD, and more accurate military information
Friendly dominion	Owner, income, temperature, neighbour dominion
Scrying	Owner, highly accurate military information, income, supplies, sites, PD, history, temperature, dominion, forts, and unrest
Province ownership	Full provincial information, with map-name exploration distance depending on age
Adjacent ownership	Neighbour owner, temperature, and unreliable military information
Spy in an enemy capital	Access to enemy score-graph data even when score graphs are disabled

These channels overlap but are not interchangeable. A scout can see construction; a spy can estimate state capacity; scrying can penetrate heavily patrolled areas without risking a physical scout. Dominion vision is broad but does not reveal every military fact.

The intelligence cycle

Use a five-step cycle:

1. Question: what decision must be made?
2. Collection: which scout, spy, scry, battle probe, graph, or diplomatic inquiry can answer it?
3. Assessment: which facts are observed, inferred, stale, or possibly deceptive?
4. Action: what order changes because of the result?
5. Review: after hosting, which assumption was correct and which source failed?

"Scout the enemy" is too broad. Better questions include:

- Can the border fort be cracked in one turn?
- Which province contains the enemy's research mass?
- Does the army have poison resistance, magic weapons, or battlefield mobility?
- Which commander is likely carrying gems?
- How many Ascension Points can the nation claim within three turns?
- Which route is outside ordinary reinforcement range?

Collection without a decision produces clutter.

Reading partial evidence

No single clue proves a full plan. Combine indicators:

Indicator	Possible meaning	Alternative explanation
Research graph rises sharply	Research infrastructure matured	Site, event, Pretender, or graph uncertainty
Gem income appears high	Wide site-search coverage or rich territory	Throne income, globals, events, or hidden alchemy
Army disappears from border	Withdrawal or magic-movement staging	Glamour, stealth, transfer, or report failure
Construction mages stop researching	Forge cycle or army deployment	Rituals, site searching, illness, lab loss
H3 unit moves toward a front	Throne claim preparation	Bless support, preaching, or ordinary movement
Large cheap-unit recruitment	Siege preparation or mass screen	Patrol, freespawn organisation, or replacement
NAPs requested on several borders	Consolidation for war elsewhere	Genuine insecurity or throne preparation

An estimate should carry a confidence statement: observed, likely, possible, or unknown. This prevents one attractive story from becoming the only story.

Scouting density

A useful network has layers:

- border screen: current armies, construction, and route changes;
- operational depth: forts, labs, reinforcement roads, and reserve armies;
- strategic nodes: capitals, Thrones, globals' origin provinces, blood centres, major laboratories;

- rear warning: stealth raiders, plane gates, underwater exits, and indirect routes.

One scout on each border province is not a network. Scouts should leapfrog or overlap so the loss of one does not blind an entire front. Spare scouts can travel with armies to loot gear, hold transferred gems, or preserve observation after a province changes hands.

Patrol and concealment

Official detection compares:

```
Patrol Strength + 2d25 open-ended
versus
Stealth Strength + 2d25 open-ended
```

Stealth strength is based on the commander and is reduced by troops in the party. Patrol strength combines unit contributions, is reduced by unrest, and gains from PD at 15 or more. Flying, map movement, Precision, Patrol Bonus, commander status, Mindless, and Undisciplined affect individual patrol contribution.

The complete manual arithmetic is:

```
Stealth Strength
= leader Stealth
- 1 per stealth troop with Stealth below 50
- 0.5 per stealth troop with Stealth 50 or more

individual Patrol Strength
= (Precision + Map Move) / 20 + Patrol Bonus
use Map Move 30 if the unit flies

province Patrol Strength
= sum of individual contributions
- min(Unrest, 100) / 2
+ max(Province Defence - 14, 0)
```

Commander contributions are doubled. The manual halves the contribution of Mindless and Undisciplined units; this official wording controls where community pages describe a different Undisciplined adjustment. The displayed patrol number may be rounded, so exact work should preserve the underlying fractions.

Let `D = Patrol Strength - Stealth Strength`. Enumerating both open-ended 2d25 rolls gives the following chance of detection:

D below stealth	Chance	D above stealth	Chance
-60	0.1%	+60	99.9%
-55	0.2%	+55	99.8%
-50	0.4%	+50	99.6%
-45	0.7%	+45	99.2%
-40	1.2%	+40	98.7%
-35	2.0%	+35	97.7%
-30	3.6%	+30	96.0%
-25	6.3%	+25	93.0%
-20	10.6%	+20	88.3%
-15	17.1%	+15	81.3%
-10	25.9%	+10	72.1%

D below stealth	Chance	D above stealth	Chance
-5	36.7%	+5	61.0%
0	48.8%	0	48.8%

Equal strengths do not give 50% because detection requires the patrol total to be greater; a tied opposed total leaves the stealth party hidden. These figures are official plus derived: the formula is the manual's, and the table is a direct enumeration rather than a fitted sample.

Consequences:

- detection is probabilistic, not guaranteed;
- repeated exposure raises cumulative risk;
- adding troops makes many stealth parties easier to detect;
- high unrest weakens patrols;
- PD 15+ changes a province from a token garrison into part of an intelligence screen;
- a discovered stealth force fights the outside defenders, while ordinary fort defenders not patrolling remain inside.

Movement and patrol timing also matters. Move and Patrol lets an arriving army fight outside a friendly fort, but it does not have time to search for stealth units during that same turn. The order becomes ordinary Patrol on the following turn.

Information denial and deception

Denial measures include:

- killing or patrolling out scouts;
- avoiding unnecessary army concentration near observed borders;
- moving gems and items at the last practical moment;
- hiding capable commanders among ordinary researchers;
- keeping several plausible research branches;
- protecting capital and throne interiors from spies;
- using domes, stealth, glamour, or magic movement where appropriate;
- displaying false or incomplete threats.

Deception should create a plausible wrong decision. A visible army near an irrelevant Throne matters only if the enemy must reserve a force against it. A false weak border is useful only if the actual counter can arrive. Deception that requires the opponent to act irrationally is hope.

Battle probes and pings

A probe can reveal:

- troop and commander identities;
- positions, formations, and orders;
- bless effects;
- scripted spells;
- carried gems through observed casting;
- throne independent mages and their spell repertoire;
- fort or field context.

The cost includes the probing commander, information given to the opponent, possible treaty implications, and the chance that the probe changes the target before the real attack. A retreat script does not guarantee survival when routes are hostile, a commander is trapped, or combat reaches it too quickly.

Score graphs

Graphs are strategic indicators, not inventories. They can show trends in provinces, forts, income, research, army size, dominion, or resources according to game settings. Current versions incorporate more event-derived changes accurately, and a spy in an enemy capital can expose that enemy's graph information even if ordinary graphs are disabled.

Graphs should answer comparative questions:

- Who is compounding fastest?
- Who suffered a sudden army or territory loss?
- Whose research curve implies a breakpoint?
- Which apparent victim remains economically dangerous?
- Which leader can reach a throne threshold?

Graphs cannot show scripts, exact counters, hidden gem stock, diplomatic obligations, or the quality of units behind an army-size number.

Since version 6.35, victory reveals all score graphs and the hidden map to the players who remain until the game ends. Elimination still reveals neither, so a defeated player removed before the final result does not receive the same post-game intelligence. This is a review and learning tool, not information available for the decisions that produced the victory.

Part IV: Map Structure, Borders, and Infrastructure

Strategic geography

Every province has at least four geographic meanings:

- economic: income, population, resources, supplies, and sites;
- network: which provinces and planes it connects;
- military: terrain, movement cost, fort and battlefield context;
- political: border, Throne, buffer, treaty claim, or coalition route.

A low-income connector may be more valuable than a rich dead end. A cave entrance, water crossing, or plane gate can create an invasion route that ordinary border counting misses.

Interior lines and exterior pressure

A nation has interior lines when its forces can move between threatened fronts faster than enemies can coordinate around the outside. Forts, roads, labs, central terrain, sailing, flight, and magic movement strengthen interior lines. Long tendrils, mountain or swamp barriers, and isolated underwater pockets weaken them.

Interior lines permit one reserve to answer several threats, but simultaneous hosting limits reaction. A reserve must be placed where its legal next-turn destinations are known before the enemy commits. "It can respond eventually" is not the same as "it can intercept next turn."

Exterior pressure becomes decisive when several enemies attack different nodes at once. Diplomacy is part of geography: a neutral border can shorten the defended perimeter more effectively than any fort.

Border shapes

Shape	Advantage	Risk
Narrow choke	Easy to fortify and scout	One lost node may open the interior
Broad line	Many routes for offence	High scouting and reserve demand
Salient	Threatens several enemy provinces	Can be cut off from reinforcement
Pocket	Safe later expansion and recruitment	Hidden routes or rivals may steal it
Corridor	Connects separated holdings	Vulnerable to a single raid or fort
Island or underwater enclave	Difficult for some rivals to reach	Limited exits and specialised counters
Plane gate network	Strategic mobility and surprise	Gate provinces become decisive nodes

The strongest border is the one the nation can actually observe, reinforce, and politically maintain.

Fort placement

Fort decisions should be evaluated across five roles:

1. Recruitment: population, resources, terrain recruits, and national restrictions.
2. Research: repeatable mage production and safe laboratories.
3. Control: sealing routes and forcing enemies into sieges.
4. Logistics: resupply, gem pooling, forging, ritual origins, and army assembly.
5. Victory: protecting Thrones and claim-capable commanders.

An early fort that produces the key mage may be worth more than a richer province. A border fort with no recruitable value may still impose a siege clock. A fort adjacent to a resource-hungry capital can reduce the capital's resource draw and should be tested before construction.

Laboratories as strategic nodes

Labs do more than recruit mages:

- collect site income into the national treasury;
- permit research, forging, rituals, and empowerment;
- pool and transfer gems;
- support magic movement and remote operations;
- allow rapid equipment changes;
- become targets for raiders and teleporters.

A forward lab increases force projection but also exposes stored gems and mages. A laboratory network should include redundancy. If one captured lab disconnects the whole front from gem supply and ritual access, the network has a single point of failure.

Temples and religious infrastructure

Temples:

- generate temple checks;
- support sacred and priest recruitment where national rules allow;
- raise maximum dominion according to the temple rule;
- enable Blood Sacrifice where available;
- protect dominion and help make Pretenders safer;
- turn Throne and border provinces into religious anchors.

Temple value rises near enemy dominion, special dominions, Thrones, and awakening or immortality operations. A temple is also visible intent. Building one in a disputed province can be read as territorial commitment.

Province Defence as delay and information

PD should be bought for a purpose:

- defeating scout captures or tiny raiders;
- adding patrol strength at 15+;
- forcing larger raids and revealing their composition;
- joining an outside field battle;
- buying time for a counter-raider;
- exploiting unusually strong national PD;
- maintaining a low-cost tripwire.

PD is not a substitute for a mobile defence because the buyer cannot move it, preserve it through retreat, or customise it like a field army. Excessive uniform PD converts liquid gold into local strength that an enemy can bypass or counter once.

Map annotation

A serious strategic map should mark:

- every known Throne and Ascension Point value;
- claimed and unclaimed status;
- forts under construction and their completion turns;
- laboratories, temples, and major sites;
- routes by movement class;
- water, river, mountain-pass, cave, and plane restrictions;
- likely enemy research and army positions;
- treaty borders and expiry dates;
- rally points, gem depots, and retreat routes;
- provinces whose loss breaks a corridor or global origin.

The map should show commitments as well as ownership.

Part V: Research as a Strategic Response Tree

From queue to campaign plan

Book V establishes the mechanics of research. Strategy asks when each breakpoint must enter the field. A research plan should contain:

- a main line that creates the nation's preferred army package;
- an expansion line if early magic materially changes neutral conquest;
- a defensive branch for the most likely early invader;
- a mobility or raiding branch;
- a forging and access branch;
- a late-game transition;
- an explicit rule for when to pivot.

A fixed queue ignores evidence. Constantly changing schools wastes accumulated progress and never reaches a threshold. The solution is a response tree with preselected branch points.

Breakpoint records

For each important level, record:

Field	Question
Effect	What new battle, ritual, item, or summon becomes possible?
Caster	Which repeatable or unique commander delivers it?
Resources	Which gems, slaves, items, communion bodies, or labs are required?
Scale	Can one army use it, or every army?
Deadline	On which turn or before which enemy event must it arrive?
Counter	What obvious answer reduces its value?
Pivot	Which adjacent research provides the next answer?

The result is useful operational knowledge, not a list of admired spells.

Research signals

Research is partly observable through graphs, deployed spells, forged gear, summoned units, and mage movement. A rapid rush can surprise once; repeated use reveals the level. Rivals can then infer adjacent capabilities.

Information denial methods include:

- delaying public use until the decisive battle;
- researching a cheap supporting branch after the main threshold;
- fielding a lower-level package that conceals the real peak;
- avoiding recognisable booster staging at exposed labs;
- maintaining several mages capable of different path packages.

The cost of secrecy must be real. Refusing to use a completed answer and losing territory to preserve surprise is normally poor conversion.

Timing attacks as temporary advantage

A timing attack begins when relative power is temporarily highest. Common windows include:

- an awake expander surviving expansion while neighbours' imprisoned designs remain absent;
- a dormant Pretender awakening;
- a mass bless reaching sustainable sacred recruitment;
- a key battlefield enchantment or resistance spell;
- the first reliable communion;
- a Construction level that produces thugs or path boosters;
- a summon mass reaching operational scale;
- a mobility ritual opening unexpected targets;
- a hostile global changing the world's exchange rates;
- an opponent exhausting gems or elite recruitment in another war.

The attack needs preparation before the breakpoint:

- troops and commanders recruited;
- gems moved;
- items forged;
- scouts positioned;
- treaty countdown started;
- routes cleared;
- siege strength assembled.

Research finishing is the last dependency, not the first planning step.

Portfolio depth

A nation with one exceptional package can force opponents to buy one exceptional counter. Portfolio depth adds a second axis:

- physical protection plus elemental resistance;
- battlefield army plus mobile raiders;
- troops plus MR-negates control;
- field strength plus remote attacks;
- glamour or stealth plus conventional pressure;
- army wipes plus fort-cracking capacity.

The purpose is not variety for its own sake. Each branch should punish the answer to another branch. If all packages fail to the same resistance, mobility, or commander kill, the portfolio is visually diverse but strategically narrow.

Research under invasion

When invaded, divide research into:

- survival threshold: the cheapest completed answer that prevents immediate collapse;
- stabilisation threshold: the package that can win or deter field battles;
- reversal threshold: mobility, summons, or scale that turns defence into counteroffence.

Do not abandon a nearly complete decisive level for a weaker emergency spell without calculating completion time. Do not continue a grand late-game rush while the laboratories generating it are about to fall. The correct pivot is measured in turns, legal casters, and delivery-not anxiety.

Part VI: Movement, Logistics, and Force Projection

The official movement model

Army movement is limited by the slowest unit. Only commanders move independently; troops require leadership. Ground movement is calculated in half-steps: leaving the origin and entering the destination each have a terrain cost.

Terrain	Ground half-step cost
Plains	3
Forest	5
Waste	5
Highlands	6
Swamp	7
Sea	5
Cave	4
Cave Forest	6
Crystal Cave	6
Drip Cave	7

Modifiers include:

- entering or leaving a province with enemy non-stealthy forces: +4;
- enemy stealthy forces: +3;
- snow: +1;
- road: -2, with a minimum cost of 2;
- matching survival ability: -2 for the relevant terrain.

Forest Survival also helps in Cave Forest, Mountain Survival in Crystal Cave, and Swamp Survival in Drip Cave. Flying normally costs 3 per half-step, 5 in caves, and +1 for enemy presence.

Common Map Move parameters provide a scale:

Example	Map Move
Heavy infantry	8
Light infantry	14
Light cavalry	20
Unicorn	26
Slow flier	14
Ordinary flier	20
Fast flier	26

Commanders normally receive +2 to the general parameter. Object values and special abilities still control the actual unit.

Barriers and army composition

Rivers require Cold +1 on both sides unless the army can fly, float, swim, or otherwise cross amphibiously. Mountain passes require Heat +1 on both sides unless the army flies, floats, or has Mountain Survival.

For special movement, every troop in the relevant army normally needs the required ability. Sailing and granted water breathing have their own exceptions. One slow, non-surviving, or non-amphibious squad can invalidate the intended route for the whole commander.

Version 6.36 establishes three current exceptions or extensions worth recording in route plans:

- a swimming mount is sufficient for its mounted unit to cross a river;
- Perpetual Storm increases movement cost in caves and underwater provinces as well as the previously affected environments;
- Gift of Water Breathing can protect against Lost Land.

Each statement is narrow. A suitable mount does not grant swimming to unrelated troops, and protection from one underwater disaster does not prove general underwater legality.

Every movement order should be checked against the actual slowest and least capable component, not the commander icon or the majority of the force.

Friendly, hostile, and intercepting movement

Friendly movement resolves before hostile movement. In contested situations:

- more than two sides may fight sequential battles in a determined entry order;
- allied defenders fight in sequence, with defender order random;
- hostile armies attempting to swap provinces may meet in either province or miss and exchange positions;
- relative army size and terrain influence interception;
- entering a friendly fortified province normally places the army inside the fort;
- Move and Patrol is required to arrive and fight outside.

An arrow remaining on the map does not prove that a movement order is still legal. If conditions change before hosting-such as a river, pass, leadership, or destination issue-the unit may remain in place.

Published collision algorithm: test hypothesis

A current community movement page publishes a more detailed reverse-engineered procedure for a directly adjacent one-step swap:

1. calculate a chassis value for the moving commanders and squads on each side;
2. compare each side's value with a separate random result from 0 to 349; if both values fall below their rolls, the armies pass and exchange provinces;
3. otherwise, each side rolls an open-ended die with its chassis value as the die size and adds one tenth of that chassis value;
4. the lower result is stopped, so the battle occurs in that side's starting province; a reported tie rule favours the side from the higher-numbered origin province.

The same page says this collision check applies to adjacent single-step swaps, while multi-province movement can pass through. It also opens by warning that the movement article needs more accurate information and publishes no 6.36 save set. Edition 27 therefore records the procedure as a source-traced hypothesis for S4, not as the rule players should assume without qualification.

Operational reach

Operational reach is the set of provinces that a force can influence within a deadline. It includes:

- ordinary legal movement;
- sailing, flight, stealth, amphibious movement, and plane access;
- magic-phase movement;
- reinforcement and gem routes;
- the ability to survive after arrival;
- the ability to retreat.

A province "in range" of a teleporting thug may still be strategically unsafe if it has no laboratory for escape, no friendly retreat route, or a counter-mage can arrive in the same phase. Reach must include extraction.

The logistics chain

Every serious army consumes:

- troops and replacements;
- commanders and appropriate leadership;
- food and supplies;
- gems and blood slaves;
- forged items;
- research-capable mage turns;
- scouts and reports;
- retreat routes;
- siege time.

A logistics chain can be represented as:

```
recruitment fort
-> rally and command
-> route and supply
-> forward lab or gem mule
-> battle package
-> replacement and retreat
```

The chain is only as strong as its most exposed node. A frontier army with no replacement commander can become immobile after one assassination. A communion with no additional slaves may win once and disappear. A giant force without supplies can accumulate fatigue and disease before the decisive battle.

Gem logistics

Gems are national stock in laboratories but physical carried resources in battle. A campaign needs:

- a load standard for each mage role;
- reserve gems for multiple battles;
- mules or a forward lab for reloads;

- a method to prevent optional gem use from draining the storm budget;
- decoys and bodyguards against assassinations;
- an evacuation plan if the lab is threatened.

Late-game throne operations may require several battles in one hosting cycle: magic-phase attacks, move-phase relief or interception, and a storm. The same script and carried stock may have to survive all of them.

Supply and attrition

Supply is a campaign constraint, not a seasonal footnote. It affects:

- the size and route of living armies;
- how long a siege force can remain concentrated;
- the safety of capital or cave interiors;
- the usefulness of supply items and Nature magic;
- whether an opponent can force disease without winning a battle.

Book II contains the exact supply and starvation rules. At campaign level, the important point is that besieged storage falls as the siege continues and repeated starvation can lead to disease. A defender may gain time while quietly losing irreplaceable mages.

Reserves

A reserve is not an army without orders. It is a force positioned to alter several likely enemy branches.

Good reserves:

- sit on a lab or movement hub;
- have compatible movement;
- carry counters rather than generic excess;
- can protect a Throne, fort, or retreat route;
- are hidden or ambiguous when possible;
- remain cheap enough that holding them back does not lose the main front.

The reserve's deterrent value depends on what the opponent believes it can reach. Scouting and information denial can change the value of the same force.

Part VII: Raiding and Counter-Raiding

What a raid is

Strategically, a raid is a limited force sent to take or threaten assets without joining the main battle. Its purpose may be:

- provincial income denial;
- capture of sites, labs, and temples;
- interruption of recruitment or gem collection;
- destruction of PD and patrollers;
- cutting retreat or reinforcement routes;
- forcing expensive defenders away from the main front;
- creating unrest or population loss;

- revealing counter capabilities;
- surrounding a fort;
- changing throne access.

The ordinary Raid order is a specific mechanic, not a synonym for every small attack. Officially, only a commander with Pillager can issue it, the army must have Map Move 20 or more, and only Pillager units contribute to the pillage at half strength. The force moves to the province, wins any battle, and then pillages. It does not automatically return.

Pillaging

Pillaging:

- kills population;
- raises unrest;
- reduces supplies;
- yields temporary gold and food.

Fast and large units pillage better, and some unit types such as barbarians or fear-causing forces are particularly effective. The resulting supplies last one month. Pillaging converts long-term provincial value into short-term campaign resources and damage.

This is often rational in enemy land and often self-defeating in territory intended for immediate annexation. A player should distinguish:

- seizure: capture intact value;
- denial: prevent the enemy using it;
- destruction: reduce future value for everyone;
- foraging: support a force for one more month.

Exact-output hypotheses

Older code-analysis notes proposed a base unit pillage strength of `floor((Strength + Combat Speed + 10 x Fear) / 2)`, with a special Combat Speed value for flyers, followed by population, fort, exploding-die, unrest, casualty, food, and gold checks. The same notes gave a separate Raid catch sequence and reduced contribution rules.

Those formulas are precise enough to reproduce but not safe enough to publish as 6.36 law. The notes predate later Raid interface fixes, do not include a current raw outcome set, and Illwinter's current public description deliberately states only that Raid is move plus pillage with no return. Edition 27 keeps the proposed unit-strength expression and its downstream branches as S6 predicates. Until S6 is run, compare raiders by legal order access, mobility, Pillager bodies, expected battle strength, and the official half-strength contribution rather than a promised gold figure.

Raider classes

Raider	Strength	Typical answer
Cheap commander with small troop squad	Low cost, repeatable	Modest PD, local troops, fast commander
Stealth army	Hidden approach and broad threat	Patrol network, scrying, chokepoints
Light thug	Defeats PD and weak local troops	Counter-thug, mage, specialised PD

Raider	Strength	Typical answer
Heavy thug	Beats larger troop-only responses	Magic weapons, fatigue, control, tailored damage
Supercombatant	Threatens armies and critical nodes	Layered specialist response, army magic, denial
Flying or sailing force	Crosses ordinary front geometry	Coverage of landing nodes, mobile reserve
Magic-phase attacker	Arrives before ordinary movement	Dome, trap, counter-teleporter, protected nodes
Assassin or seducer network	Removes command and specialist mages	Bodyguards, decoys, patrols, redundant command
Remote army or spell	Projects force without exposing a route	Domes, dispersed assets, retaliation

Raider value depends on the defender's replacement cost. A ten-gem thug that forces a twenty-gem counter to remain idle can be valuable even before taking a province. The same thug is poor if it walks into a cheap armour-piercing weapon and transfers its equipment to the enemy.

Raider efficiency

Evaluate a raider by:

```
value denied
+ response cost imposed
+ positional gain
+ information gained
- expected permanent loss
- attention and opportunity cost
```

The captured province's income is only one term. Cutting a laboratory may strand ritual mages. Taking a corridor can kill retreats. Threatening three provinces can make the enemy divide an army. Conversely, repeatedly trading expensive raiders for low-income provinces can lose the gem war while the map colour appears active.

Raider design

A raider needs:

- a target class;
- sufficient movement;
- enough offence to end the fight;
- enough defence to survive that target;
- fatigue stability;
- morale or mindlessness appropriate to the task;
- a retreat or escape plan;
- a price ceiling.

Thugs should layer different defences rather than maximise one statistic. Protection alone eventually fails to armour-defeating results, high damage, fatigue, or armour-piercing and armour-negating attacks. Defence alone fails under repeated attacks and surrounding. Regeneration alone fails to burst damage or conditions that prevent recovery.

Minimalism is central. Every additional item must change a relevant matchup or survival probability. Decorative gear increases the reward for the counter-thug.

Creating a raiding front

A raiding front works when several threats mature together:

1. Scouts identify low-PD, high-value, and weakly connected provinces.
2. Raiders enter from different routes.
3. The main army threatens a fort or decisive battle.
4. Remote or magic-phase attacks threaten the reserve.
5. Captured provinces cut retreat and reinforcement paths.
6. Raiders withdraw, regroup, or join a siege before tailored answers arrive.

One raider is a puzzle. Several raiders plus a main army are a resource-allocation crisis.

Counter-raiding as a system

Counter-raiding should not chase every loss with the main army. Build layers:

Layer	Function
Scouts and scrying	Identify raider type, movement, and equipment
PD tripwires	Defeat the smallest raids and reveal larger ones
Patrol nodes	Restrict stealth routes and protect critical labs
Local recruits	Reclaim undefended provinces cheaply
Mobile counters	Catch or threaten expensive raiders
Magic-phase response	Intercept forces that ordinary movement cannot catch
Fort network	Preserve recruitment and force raiders to stop
Strategic reserve	Prevent several raids from becoming a capital or Throne attack

The defender should calculate which provinces are worth defending. A poor border province may be allowed to change hands while the counter waits at the lab, Throne, or route the raider actually needs.

Counter-thugs

A counter-thug is usually cheaper and more specialised than the target. It may need only:

- a weapon that bypasses the target's principal defence;
- sufficient attack or precision to connect;
- resistance to the target's damage;
- enough speed or magic movement to catch it;
- a scout or spare commander to loot gear.

Specialisation creates efficiency but reduces general usefulness. Do not send the counter at a different chassis merely because both are called thugs.

Raid recovery

After losing provinces:

1. Preserve the force that can defeat the raider.
2. Identify its legal next destinations.
3. Protect the high-value nodes among them.

4. Retake empty provinces with cheap commanders.
5. Rebuild a continuous retreat and supply route.
6. Do not overinvest in PD everywhere after one frightening loss.
7. Use the revealed gear and script to construct the cheapest repeatable answer.

The aim is to reduce future response cost. A defender who spends a major mage and ten gems on every raid may technically win each battle and still lose the campaign.

Part VIII: War Planning, Timing, and Decision

Reasons to go to war

War is justified when it improves the route to victory more than the alternatives. Common reasons include:

- an opponent can be defeated before its breakpoint;
- a critical Throne, fort, gate, or path recruit is accessible;
- a neighbour is committed elsewhere;
- a hostile position will become unanswerable if left alone;
- a treaty network creates a temporary safe front;
- defensive war is already unavoidable and initiative can be seized;
- the war prevents an imminent victory.

"The neighbour is weak" is incomplete. The relevant questions are what can be taken, how long it takes, who benefits, and what other nations can do during the commitment.

War aims

Define the minimum successful outcome:

- destroy a specific army;
- seize a border fort or capital;
- capture or neutralise a Throne;
- remove a global origin;
- secure a corridor or plane gate;
- force a treaty or transfer;
- eliminate the nation;
- delay it while another operation succeeds.

Unlimited conquest causes strategic drift. A war that has achieved its aim may be ended or frozen before the winner's armies become trapped in low-value territory.

The invasion ledger

Before ending a NAP or submitting attack orders, record:

Requirement	Minimum answer
Enemy strength	Main army, mobile reserve, Pretender, known thugs, magic phase

Requirement	Minimum answer
Friendly package	Troops, mages, scripts, gems, counters, leadership
Target sequence	Border battle, fort, lab, Throne, capital
Siege	Expected wall strength, reduction per turn, defence and relief
Logistics	Route, supplies, reload, reinforcements, replacement commanders
Diplomacy	Legal attack date, other borders, coalition reaction
Research	Current package and next breakpoint
Failure branch	Retreat route, fallback fort, diplomatic exit
Victory conversion	Claim unit, AP count, post-capture defence

If the plan ends at "win the battle," it is tactical preparation rather than a campaign.

Back-planning the attack date

The attack date should be derived backwards:

```
desired decisive battle
<- arrival turn
<- treaty expiry
<- final recruitment and rally
<- item and gem preparation
<- research completion
<- scouting confirmation
```

Because hosting is simultaneous, a force one province away may arrive into a different position than expected. Every route needs a branch for enemy movement, interception, or a changed barrier.

Concentration and dispersion

Concentration wins difficult battles and cracks forts. Dispersion captures provinces and imposes attention. The campaign should alternate:

1. disperse for expansion or raiding;
2. concentrate for the decisive army or siege;
3. disperse after victory to cut retreats and take infrastructure;
4. reconcentrate before the opponent's new package arrives.

Permanent doomstacks waste map tempo. Permanent dispersion invites defeat in detail.

Forcing battles

An opponent can often decline an unfavourable field battle. Force commitment by threatening:

- a capital;
- a high-output mage fort;
- a Throne;
- a laboratory with rare commanders;
- a global origin;
- a corridor whose loss traps an army;
- multiple forts whose siege clocks mature together.

The best target is sometimes the one the enemy must defend, not the one with the most immediate income.

Gem burning

Battle magic consumes carried resources. A weak or sacrificial force may trigger expensive scripts before the decisive battle. This can be achieved through:

- magic-phase attacks before move-phase combat;
- sequential allied or multi-party battles;
- remote attacks;
- probes against an army expected to storm;
- assassinations that cause individual gem use.

Gem burning is not free. The probe may die, reveal information, or fail to trigger the intended spells. Conservative gem-use settings and spell AI affect results. The attacker should compare the expected hostile gems consumed with the permanent cost of the probe.

Deterrence

Deterrence depends on credible punishment. It can come from:

- a visible army;
- hidden teleporters or thugs;
- a known battlefield wipe;
- a treaty partner;
- a fort that imposes delay;
- the ability to raid an attacker's undefended rear;
- a Pretender whose commitment changes the battle;
- the diplomatic cost of creating a runaway elsewhere.

Purely hidden capacity may not deter because the opponent does not know it exists. Selective disclosure-one demonstration, a truthful warning, or visible staging-can preserve peace more cheaply than actual battle.

Ending wars

A rational peace assessment asks:

- Has the original aim been achieved?
- Which side's reinforcement and research curve is improving?
- Are forts about to crack?
- Can either party win the game elsewhere?
- Are new enemies entering?
- What border can actually be held?
- Which terms are enforceable?

Continuing from anger is a strategic expenditure. Reputation and justice matter in multiplayer, but they should be pursued through explicit objectives rather than unbounded attrition.

Part IX: Thugs, Supercombatants, Assassins, and Remote Force

Campaign roles

Single commanders and remote effects should be classified by what they change:

Asset	Campaign role
Light thug	PD raiding, province recovery, bottleneck pressure
Heavy thug	Defeat troop-heavy, mage-light forces
Supercombatant	Threaten armies, capitals, or decisive nodes
Army thug	Hold, kill elites, or add concentrated damage inside a line
Counter-thug	Trade cheaply into a known chassis
Assassin	Remove commanders, priests, mages, or gem carriers
Seducer or corrupter	Remove or acquire commanders through a special duel
Remote attacker	Damage, probe, distract, or burn gems without ordinary movement
Magic-phase mover	Intercept, surprise, reinforce, or open a storm operation

The label does not guarantee performance. A heavy thug against troops may die instantly to the first prepared mage. A supercombatant without the correct resistance may be a very expensive target.

The defensive onion

Durable commanders combine layers:

- avoidance: defence, glamour, awe, ethereal, displacement;
- mitigation: protection, invulnerability, resistances;
- recovery: regeneration, life drain, recuperation;
- control resistance: MR, mindlessness, morale, elemental and status immunity;
- endurance: reinvigoration, low encumbrance, fatigue management;
- offence: enough killing speed to avoid the turn limit and cumulative random failure;
- escape: returning, immortality, retreat, stealth, or magic movement.

Every layer must be checked against the intended target and the likely counter. The DRN makes absolute safety rare.

Assassin rules

An assassin selects a random enemy commander in the province. Each assigned bodyguard has a base 50% chance of being present, modified by Bodyguard and Patience. The target is unprepared and does not use its ordinary battle script. Province context may add guards or bystanders.

An assassin cannot normally operate into or out of a besieged fort without Scale Walls, flight, teleportation, or equivalent access. Similar access restrictions apply to related orders such as seduction or infiltration. Mounted targets are often dismounted; when the assassin wins, the mount may also be killed.

Strategic consequences:

- commander redundancy reduces assassination leverage;
- bodyguards must be assigned before the attack;
- decoy commanders dilute random targeting;
- vital H3 claimants and communion masters require special protection;
- killing a leader may immobilise troops even if the army survives;
- assassinations inside a throne fort can disrupt both battle and claim timing.

Remote operations

Remote force can:

- kill or afflict armies;
- summon attackers;
- change weather or scales;
- attack commanders;
- scry;
- damage walls;
- move units or armies;
- establish or protect local enchantments.

Remote operations should be combined with a physical exploitation plan. Damaging an army without contesting its fort or route may merely spend gems. A remote that removes PD immediately before a fast raider arrives converts more cleanly.

Domes reduce probability or redirect certain hostile rituals, but no dome is universal. Current official notes state that domes may protect against Astral Disruption. Exact layering and object interaction must be verified for the current spell set.

Counter construction

Build answers from the enemy's dependency:

- high protection -> armour-piercing or armour-negating damage, fatigue, control;
- high defence -> area effects, multiple attacks, attack boosts, unavoidable effects;
- regeneration -> burst, decay, disease, or prevention of recovery;
- ethereal or glamour -> magic weapons and appropriate perception;
- elemental damage -> specific resistance;
- life drain -> lifeless targets or denial of contact;
- Phoenix Pyre -> fatigue and soul or battlefield control;
- high MR -> non-MR effects or penetration investment;
- magic movement -> protected nodes, domes, traps, distributed assets;
- stealth -> patrol, scrying, route control;
- item dependency -> counter-thug and looting plan.

The cheapest sufficient answer is normally superior to building a more expensive mirror.

Part X: Sieges and Fort Operations

Siege arithmetic

Book II owns the wall-reduction formula and repair modifiers; Book IV owns the storm battle. Strategy begins with the operational consequence: only commanders ordered to Maintain Siege and their eligible forces work on the walls. A commander preaching, forging, or performing another order is not also reducing the fort.

The siege clock

A fort creates delay by requiring:

1. entry into the province;
2. one or more turns of wall reduction;
3. a legal Storm Fortress order after walls reach zero;
4. victory in the storm battle;
5. occupation, repair, and exploitation.

Each added turn permits:

- relief movement;
- remote attacks;
- recruitment elsewhere;
- diplomatic intervention;
- research completion;
- throne counterattacks.

Siege strength is tempo. An army that wins the field but needs six months to crack the fort may lose the strategic race to one that brought specialised siege bodies.

Information asymmetry

The defender sees wall condition. The besieger receives qualitative messages:

Message	Approximate wall state
Lightly damaged	High remaining integrity
Moderately damaged	About 51-85% remaining
Severely damaged	About 11-50% remaining
Critically damaged	About 1-10% remaining

"Work is going very slowly" indicates less than roughly 15% of wall integrity was removed that turn according to the community reference. Because the besieger lacks exact totals, plans should include a safety margin and scouting of likely repair bodies.

Inside and outside

At a friendly fort:

- Defend places the commander and troops inside;
- Patrol keeps them outside and able to fight field battles;
- an arriving ordinary move normally enters the fort;
- Move and Patrol arrives outside.

Version 6.35 adds one narrow escape route: a commander with teleport movement can move out of a besieged fort. This does not release an ordinary army, legalise every teleport ritual, or change the movement phase for other units. The order-entry exception is recorded in Book X's siege orders, while Book I retains the hosting sequence.

This distinction determines whether a unit joins a relief battle, remains protected, contributes to wall repair, or can be attacked by the besieger.

Relief, break siege, and storm

A relief battle occurs before a scheduled storm. If relief succeeds, the storm does not occur. If relief fails, the besieger may still have to storm with losses, fatigue, expended gems, or altered scripts.

The defender can also Break Siege. A retreating defender may return inside the fort or move to an adjacent friendly province; where both are available, the manual gives a 50/50 selection. Fort context and later battles can change the ultimate retreat result.

When storming:

- the gate creates a narrow and dangerous battle context;
- intrinsic fort guards aid the defender;
- if a storming commander dies before the gate battle, its squads do not participate;
- besieged commanders that retreat from the storm die;
- relief and storm may force one attacker script through several battles;
- battlefield-wide magic may be restricted indoors under the current indoor rule.

Starvation and trapped value

Besieged recruitment stops. Provincial income is divided between besieger and defender according to the siege rules, while site gems continue to the besieged side if a laboratory can connect them to the treasury. Declining fort supply can starve and eventually disease the garrison.

The defender should classify trapped units:

- irreplaceable mages that justify early relief;
- cheap repair bodies that justify delay;
- troops suitable for a break-siege battle;
- claim-capable priests on a Throne;
- stealth or special-access units able to leave;
- Pretender or immortal assets with separate risk.

Saving the fort while permanently diseasing the research core may be a strategic loss.

One-turn cracks

A one-turn crack denies the defender most of the siege clock. It is especially important in throne operations. Calculate:

- fort wall strength;
- expected defending repair;
- flying and siege bonuses;
- Mindless, Animal, and Undisciplined penalties;
- remote wall damage;
- loss of siege contribution if commanders fight or perform other orders;

- possible Iron Walls or equivalent increases.

The one-turn crack force must also fight. Siege bodies that contribute enormous reduction but collapse in relief can become a liability unless protected.

Multi-fort operations

Besieging several forts at once can exceed the defender's relief capacity. The attacker should stagger clocks so:

- at least one fort becomes stormable each turn;
- the main army can move between decisive storms;
- raiders cut reinforcement routes;
- enough force remains on each fort to prevent repair;
- gem reserves survive repeated battles.

The defender should repair, reinforce, and sally selectively. Preserving a key mage fort or Throne can justify abandoning a peripheral castle.

Part XI: Diplomacy, Treaties, and Reputation

Diplomacy changes force ratios

A treaty can remove an entire front from the immediate defence problem. A trade can create a path booster that research cannot. Intelligence from an ally can prevent a surprise. A coalition can turn a leading nation's local superiority into global inferiority.

Diplomacy is an exchange of:

- time;
- information;
- territorial certainty;
- resources and items;
- military access;
- threats and commitments;
- reputation.

The resource is not the message. It is the changed set of legal and expected actions.

Formal and social NAPs

Dominions 6 can use formal in-game diplomacy. Depending on settings, a formal NAP may be binding: the game blocks offensive actions that violate it. Games can also use nonbinding settings or social treaties negotiated outside the engine.

These systems should not be silently mixed:

Doctrine	Authority	Main benefit	Main risk
Strict formal NAP	Game engine	Clear mechanical enforcement	Edge cases may permit conduct players consider hostile

Doctrine	Authority	Main benefit	Main risk
Written social NAP	Agreed text and host rules	Can cover remotes, stealth, globals, access, and victory	Requires shared interpretation and reputation
Hybrid	Formal pact plus written additions	Enforcement plus broader expectations	Conflicts between engine legality and social meaning
No NAP	No non-aggression commitment	Maximum freedom and fewer countdown disputes	Higher uncertainty and defence cost

Before a game begins, players should know which doctrine governs conflicts.

Binding diplomacy

Illwinter describes formal diplomacy as optional, with binding NAPs available for humans and AI and a setting that makes them nonbinding. The command-line help exposes the corresponding `--weakdiplo` and `--nodiplo` settings. This establishes three engine baselines: binding, nonbinding, and absent. It does not turn an organised game's social customs into engine rules.

The official correction history supplies the safest current exception ledger:

Version	Official NAP or allied-territory rule
6.01	NAPs do not govern arena battles; global-enchantment attacks no longer respect NAPs.
6.03	A besieged force may break free from its fort during a NAP.
6.04	A defect involving movement bumps during a NAP was corrected.
6.12	Players can bump forces covered by a NAP; a besieger counts as bordering the besieged player for diplomacy.
6.13	An army may move into NAP-protected forces that are besieging its own fort.
6.19	An expiring NAP continues counting down after a nation dies; modders gained `#napbreakrit` for spells.
6.29	The Wait order became legal in allied territory.
6.30	Expiring NAPs were corrected in disciple games.

This ledger proves that a binding pact is not a blanket ban on every hostile-looking interaction. It also shows why an old anecdote can be wrong after a patch. The complete action matrix-ordinary movement, magic movement, anonymous and attributed rituals, stealth incidents, province transfers, sieges, and every disciple case under all three settings-still requires S12.

Minimum treaty terms

A useful NAP states:

- the parties;
- whether it is formal, social, or both;
- the notice period;
- exactly how turns are counted;
- the first legal turn for hostile orders and for hostile contact;
- treatment of scouts and stealth armies;
- remotes, assassinations, seduction, heretics, disease spreaders, and unrest effects;
- dominion and temple pressure;
- province trades and accidental bumps;

- harmful globals;
- third-party access;
- whether imminent victory suspends the pact;
- how mistakes are repaired.

Without these terms, both parties may act in good faith under incompatible definitions.

Countdown arithmetic

Community conventions differ. One explicit convention treats an N-turn NAP ended on turn T as permitting contact on turn T+N. Under that convention, ending NAP3 on turn 10 permits attack orders on turn 12 that make contact during hosting into turn 13. Other groups count differently.

Never rely on the label alone. State the first legal order-submission turn and the first legal contact turn in plain numbers.

Treaty edge cases

Potential disputes include:

- a scout being discovered;
- a stealth army positioned before expiry;
- an accidental movement bump;
- a remote attack with uncertain attribution;
- a harmful global;
- selling a corridor to a third party;
- cutting off agreed spoils;
- dominion pressure;
- independent or event armies taking border provinces;
- a throne rush while formal NAPs remain binding.

Engine legality does not settle social legitimacy unless the group agreed that it would. A written doctrine protects both strategic freedom and the community from avoidable arguments.

Trade

Trades can exchange:

- gems and blood slaves;
- forged items;
- provinces;
- mercenary noncompetition;
- intelligence;
- ritual or global contributions;
- military access;
- coordinated timing.

Good trade messages specify item, gem type, quantity, delivery turn, sender, recipient, and contingency if forging or delivery becomes impossible. Trades are generally treated as binding in community practice because simultaneous turns expose one party to opportunistic default.

Assess the strategic effect, not only nominal gem equality. A five-gem booster that opens a new path can be worth far more than five surplus gems. A trade that enables an enemy's throne rush may be profitable and fatal.

Reputation

Reputation changes future transaction costs. Reliable players receive information, trades, and treaties with less suspicion. Deceptive or rules-lawyering play may win one exchange while forcing expensive hostility in later games.

Reputation is not a demand for passivity. A treaty can be ended, a rival can be threatened, and a surprise attack after legal expiry is ordinary strategy. The core distinction is between hard bargaining within clear terms and exploiting ambiguity that the other party reasonably believed was settled.

Threat communication

A useful threat states:

- the behaviour that must change;
- the consequence;
- the deadline;
- an achievable off-ramp.

Vague outrage does not deter. Impossible demands turn the threat into a declaration of war. Excessive detail can reveal exact capacity. The objective is credible constraint with minimal disclosure.

Coalition politics

Coalitions form around relative threat. Indicators that create coalitions include:

- rapid province, fort, research, or gem growth;
- oppressive globals;
- visible throne progress;
- elimination of neighbours;
- treaty networks that appear permanent;
- unique late-game access;
- refusal to communicate.

A leader can reduce coalition pressure by:

- leaving other players with meaningful autonomy;
- sharing limited intelligence or trade;
- avoiding unnecessary worldwide harm;
- framing war aims as bounded;
- preventing a rival from appearing harmless while compounding;
- keeping the true throne conversion window short.

Coalition management is not concealment of all strength. If the position is obviously dominant, implausible denials destroy credibility.

Part XII: Thrones, Cataclysm, and Endgame Conversion

Victory by Ascension Points

By default, Thrones of Ascension provide the victory structure. A Throne's level equals its Ascension Point value:

Throne level	Ascension Points	General defence
1	1	Stronger than ordinary independents but often early-accessible
2	2	Substantial army and magic support
3	3	Extremely strong defence, often including Pretender-class commanders

The host sets the total points present and the number required. Conquer-all is an alternative, but throne settings define most campaign deadlines.

Finding and identifying Thrones

The presence of a Throne becomes visible when the province is observed through ordinary means such as scouting, dominion, or neighbouring ownership. Exact identity requires stronger information, such as a spy or direct control, according to the current community reference. When a Pretender awakens, unrevealed Thrones are sensed; an awake Pretender receives this information on turn 2.

Throne identity matters because effects vary widely: gems, gold, scales, bless changes, recruitment, research access, unrest, dominion spread, or world events. Treat community tables as object references to verify against current game data before committing a design.

Claiming

A Throne can be claimed by:

- the Pretender;
- the Prophet;
- a priest with Holy 3 or more.

The nation must own the province. If a fort exists, a besieger cannot claim through the walls, while the besieged owner can still claim. Claiming is a turn action and resolves during hosting at the throne-claim step. Conquest makes the Throne unclaimed until a legal claimant acts.

Book III owns the exact same-turn state matrix. For campaign planning, remember the operational result: killing a claimant after the step-8 claim does not undo it; conquering an unfortified Throne or successfully storming its fort removes the claim before the step-57 victory check; a siege that has not taken the fort does not. Once the claim resolves, counterplay must attack the ownership state and not only the claimant.

A claimed Throne:

- supplies Ascension Points;
- spreads dominion through its throne checks;
- activates its claimed effects;
- visibly lights on the map.

The campaign must include the claimant. A victorious army without an H3, Pretender, or Disciple is at least one turn farther from victory.

Throne arithmetic

Every turn, record for each living nation:

- claimed points;
- unclaimed controlled points;
- points under siege;
- points reachable within one ordinary move;
- points reachable in the magic phase;
- claim-capable units in range;
- forts that can be cracked in one turn;
- points required to win.

Also record the maximum plausible claim, not only current points. A nation on five of eight required points that controls an unclaimed three-point Throne can win with one claim order.

The throne-rush sequence

A common fortified one-Throne rush follows this timing:

Turn	Attacker	Defender and bystanders
T+0 orders	Move enough army and siege power onto the Throne	Detect approach, reinforce, remote, or prepare relief
T+1 orders	Walls are cracked; order storm; move H3 or Pretender into position	Break siege, relieve, attack other attacker Thrones, burn gems
T+2 orders	After successful storm, claim	Last chance is normally to remove another claimed Throne or prevent the claim
T+3 hosting	Claim resolves and victory occurs if threshold is met	Counter must already have changed the AP total or ownership

Exact battle sequence, magic movement, wall state, and claim position can alter this schedule. The important lesson is that bystanders do not have "several turns" merely because the fort has not yet fallen. A one-turn crack compresses the coalition's response into one hosting cycle.

Requirements for a credible rush

The attacker needs:

- enough siege power to crack on schedule;
- enough combat power for relief, sequential battles, and the storm;
- scripts that function across those battle contexts;
- gems for repeated combat;
- resilience against remotes and assassins;
- claimant access;
- defence of existing claimed Thrones;
- secrecy or deception;
- a response to Iron Walls and emergency reinforcement.

A throne rush is an operation, not a large army walking toward a victory icon.

Defending against a rush

Defence can attack any dependency:

- reinforce or increase wall strength;
- kill the siege bodies;
- force extra battles to consume gems;
- assassinate commanders or the claimant;
- use magic-phase attacks before relief and storm;
- break siege;
- capture or unclaim one of the attacker's existing Thrones;
- cut the claimant's route;
- form a coalition and share exact timing;
- exploit binding-NAP limitations through pre-agreed victory clauses.

Counterattacking another claimed Throne may be more reliable than saving the target. Victory arithmetic, not pride of ownership, decides.

Information warfare

Surprise is especially valuable because every visible turn permits specialised counter-scripts and coalition formation. Methods include:

- stealthy elements staged near or on the target;
- flying, sailing, underwater, or plane routes;
- magic-phase mage delivery;
- high Map Move and movement items;
- false army displays and secondary throne threats;
- ordinary wars used as cover;
- keeping the H3 claimant separate until required.

The attacker must balance concealment against siege. Stealth forces on the fort do not contribute while sneaking. The operation needs a turn when hidden potential becomes actual wall reduction.

Defence of owned Thrones

Throne defence should be layered:

- fort and wall strength;
- enough repair to defeat casual siege;
- patrols and anti-assassin measures;
- a claimant or priest plan;
- a mobile relief force;
- remote and magic-phase support;
- gem reserves;
- alternate victory arithmetic if one Throne falls.

Not every Throne requires the same force. Concentrate on the points whose loss changes the victory threshold, the routes opponents can reach, and the forts vulnerable to one-turn cracking.

Cataclysm

If enabled, Cataclysm begins after the configured turn. Horrors attack and destroy Thrones. Each destroyed Throne reduces the Ascension Points required to win, so the threshold moves as the world collapses. Current official changes make Cataclysm harder to counter.

The manual states that if no one owns a Throne when the last is destroyed, the horrors win. Current community reference describes all Thrones destroyed as a draw; this wording conflict must be reproduced under current 6.36 before being stated more narrowly. Operationally, neither result is a player victory.

Cataclysm strategy:

- track turns to arrival;
- fort and defend key Thrones;
- prepare to kill or dislodge horrors;
- recalculate required points after every destruction;
- avoid plans that mature after the relevant Thrones cease to exist;
- treat every surviving point as increasingly decisive.

Cataclysm is more than late-game flavour. It shrinks the objective map.

Part XIII: Recovery, Elastic Defence, and Defeat Management

A lost battle is not automatically a lost war

After a major defeat, the strategic position contains several different losses:

- force loss: troops, mages, Pretender, items, and gems;
- capacity loss: forts, laboratories, sacred recruitment, and researchers;
- position loss: routes, sites, Thrones, dominion, and borders;
- information loss: scouts, known enemy scripts, and hidden alternatives;
- diplomatic loss: confidence, allies, and deterrence;
- tempo loss: the opponent chooses the next urgent event.

Recovery begins by separating them. A nation may have lost its main army but retained every mage fort and a superior research curve. Another may win the field but lose its only laboratory and retreat corridor. Battle animation does not rank these consequences.

The first post-defeat turn

Perform this audit before issuing revenge orders:

1. Count surviving mages, commanders, items, and gem stocks.
2. Identify where every routed force went.
3. Check leadership and whether troops are stranded.
4. Mark the enemy's legal next destinations.
5. Protect the capital, key mage forts, labs, Thrones, and corridors.
6. Determine whether the enemy can crack each fort in one turn.
7. Read the replay for spent hostile gems, fatigue, casualties, and revealed scripts.

8. Ask neighbours for information, trade, pressure, or coalition action.
9. Select the cheapest research or recruitment stabiliser.
10. Preserve a retreat path for the next battle.

The instinct to recreate the destroyed army exactly is often wrong. The opponent has already demonstrated an answer to it.

Elastic defence

Elastic defence exchanges low-value territory for time while preserving the force needed for a counterstroke. It uses:

- forts as delay;
- scouts to track the attacker;
- PD and cheap units as tripwires;
- raiders against the attacker's rear;
- mobile reserves;
- selective relief;
- research completed behind the line;
- diplomacy that makes further advance expensive.

The defence is not passive. It forces the attacker to choose between:

- concentrating and losing provinces to raids;
- dispersing and risking defeat;
- storming and spending gems;
- waiting and allowing research or coalition response.

What to hold

Rank provinces:

Priority	Examples
Existential	Capital, last candle sources, victory-critical Throne
Capacity	Major mage fort, rare recruit site, blood centre, global origin
Network	Corridor, plane gate, only lab chain, retreat hub
Economic	Rich province, strong gem site
Disposable	Poor border land that does not open the interior

The list changes with the position. A one-income cave can be existential if it is the only route to a plane or underwater enclave.

Preserving cadres

Troops are often easier to replace than:

- high-path mages;
- experienced communion leaders;
- H3 priests;
- item carriers;
- rare randoms;

- prophet;
- Pretender;
- specialised commanders.

A small surviving cadre can rebuild a battlefield package if given forts and time. Protect command redundancy, retreat routes, and extraction items. Do not place every rare path in the same army unless the battle is truly decisive.

Counteroffence

The attacker is most exposed when:

- concentrated on a fort;
- low on gems after several battles;
- beyond reinforcement range;
- dependent on one lab;
- holding provinces with token PD;
- using a revealed script;
- committed under expiring treaties elsewhere.

Counteroffence does not require retaking every lost province. It may destroy the siege army, cut its retreat, take its staging lab, threaten its capital, or force a peace by opening a second front.

Negotiating from weakness

A weakened nation still possesses:

- information;
- remaining army or raiders;
- forts that consume time;
- gems and items;
- a vote in coalition politics;
- the ability to make another nation the beneficiary of its collapse.

Useful offers are concrete: a stable border, a province transfer, gem payment, joint war, intelligence, or permission to disengage. Empty threats weaken reputation; credible kingmaking threats can change the attacker's calculation but may also unite the table against the speaker.

Elimination, handover, and meaningful play

When recovery is impossible, distinguish:

- a nation still capable of affecting victory;
- a position that can be handed to a substitute;
- an agreed concession under host rules;
- a player leaving without setting AI or notifying the host.

Long multiplayer games depend on continuity. A defeated player should follow the game's substitution, AI, and concession rules rather than silently stale. The host's master password can set a dropped player to AI, but it also grants access to positions and should be controlled accordingly.

Part XIV: Single-Player Strategy and the AI

What the AI receives

Difficulty modifies AI bonuses to gold, resources, recruitment points, and magic income:

Difficulty	Bonus or penalty
Easy	-30%
Normal	0%
Difficult	+30%
Mighty	+60%
Master	+100%
Impossible	+150%

These modifiers do not increase commander recruitment rate or Holy Points. The AI also has omniscient knowledge of province ownership, which removes one information problem human players face.

Current AI capabilities

Dominions 6 AI is improved over earlier descriptions. It:

- builds forts;
- recruits better national troops;
- plans high-level rituals;
- uses global enchantments;
- attempts Dispels;
- participates in formal diplomacy.

Current patches also corrected behaviours such as trying rituals without a laboratory, researching when unable, and preaching with non-priests. The AI still operates through programmed evaluation rather than human political judgment and long-form deception.

Version 6.35 also improved the AI's protection of important mages. This should be read as a narrower targeting and preservation improvement, not as evidence that the AI now values mage-turns, research concentration, retreat routes, or political risk with human reliability.

Learning games

A useful first learning environment uses:

- a small or medium map;
- one plane unless plane travel is the lesson;
- Normal AI before large economic bonuses;
- ordinary independent strength;
- visible score graphs;

- Thrones as the victory condition;
- a nation with understandable troops and broad enough magic;
- no mods for the first rules-learning game.

Then add difficulty or complexity one variable at a time. High AI bonuses teach crisis management but can hide whether the player's economy and expansion are fundamentally sound.

Productive self-imposed constraints

To learn transferable strategy:

- do not rely on repeated reloads except for controlled testing;
- avoid exploiting a predictable movement loop indefinitely;
- track Throne arithmetic even when the AI does not punish mistakes;
- practise scouts, reserves, forts, and gem budgets as if facing humans;
- watch important battles and diagnose mechanisms;
- use formal diplomacy if it is part of the intended multiplayer environment;
- compare turn-12 expansion across repeated starts.

The objective of practice is not only to beat the AI. It is to create habits that survive a human opponent.

What AI games teach well

- interface and turn execution;
- national recruitment and expansion;
- battle scripting;
- economy and infrastructure;
- research pacing;
- siege and movement rules;
- army composition against varied rosters;
- surviving numerical pressure;
- late-game spell and global operation.

What requires multiplayer experience

- credible deception;
- negotiated borders;
- reputation;
- coalition timing;
- adaptive counter-research;
- human throne-rush detection;
- trades built around path scarcity;
- restraint and threat communication;
- opponents deliberately burning gems or hiding scripts.

Single-player mastery is a foundation, not a complete substitute for diplomacy and adversarial uncertainty.

Part XV: Turn Discipline and Multiplayer Operations

The strategic turn order

The complete engine hosting sequence appears in Book I. A player-facing strategic turn should be reviewed in this order:

1. Victory: Can anyone win during the coming hosting?
2. Messages: Battles, events, rituals, construction, diplomacy, and throne changes.
3. Map change: Ownership, forts, labs, dominion, routes, and enemy movement.
4. Threats: Every hostile force's legal destinations and phase.
5. Battles: Replay decisive and surprising results.
6. Research: Completion, caster access, and pivot.
7. Economy: Treasury, upkeep, recruitment queues, forts, and PD.
8. Magic: Rituals, forging, site search, gem movement, globals, and domes.
9. Armies: Leadership, squads, scripts, supplies, movement, and retreats.
10. Diplomacy: Treaties, countdowns, trades, warnings, and coalition information.
11. Verification: Illegal arrows, idle commanders, empty labs, unclaimed Thrones, and unsubmitted turn.

Victory comes first because every other optimisation is irrelevant if the game ends.

Commander roles and naming

Names should expose function:

- `RCH F2A1` for a researcher's relevant paths;
- `FORGE E3` for a forge specialist;
- `ARMY N` for a field group;
- `CLAIM H3` for a throne claimant;
- `RAID A` for a raider;
- `MULE 20F` for carried gems;
- `SCOUT EAST` for coverage;
- `NAP3 T24` in notes for a treaty deadline.

The exact scheme matters less than consistency. A late-game turn should not require reopening every commander to remember why it exists.

Army package records

For each major army, record:

- commander roster and redundancy;
- troop roles and formations;
- five-order scripts;
- expected unscripted behaviour;
- gem load and optional spending policy;
- communion or Sabbath structure;
- target matchups;
- known counters;

- movement class;
- supply;
- retreat provinces;
- siege contribution;
- next reinforcement.

This converts battle preparation into a repeatable system and makes after-action review possible.

Diplomacy records

Keep:

- exact treaty text;
- agreement turn;
- expiry notice turn;
- first legal order and contact turns;
- trades owed and delivered;
- disputed province settlement;
- promises to third parties;
- public and private victory commitments according to house rules.

Memory becomes unreliable over games lasting months. Written terms protect strategy and relationships.

Submitting safely

Before ending the turn:

- use the warning system but do not assume it catches every strategic error;
- confirm commanders who must remain hidden are Sneaking, not moving normally;
- confirm an army entering its own fort uses Move and Patrol if it must fight outside;
- confirm all special-movement troops qualify;
- confirm rivers and passes are open;
- confirm claimant and siege orders;
- confirm commanders expected to reduce walls are maintaining siege;
- confirm gems and slaves are on the correct bodies;
- confirm no forge, ritual, or research order unintentionally replaced a military task;
- save and submit according to server practice.

Stales, extensions, and substitutes

House rules should define:

- when extensions are granted;
- how requests are made;
- what counts as repeated staling;
- when a substitute may be found;
- when the host may set AI;
- how concessions are handled;
- whether private information can be shared with a substitute.

Reliable scheduling is part of multiplayer skill. A brilliant plan that repeatedly stales damages the game more than an imperfect plan submitted on time.

Part XVI: The Active Modded Ruleset

What carries across

Book IX defines the exact combined ruleset and its load order. The durable strategic ideas still include simultaneous planning, movement timing, information, concentration, siege clocks, treaty clarity, Throne arithmetic, conversion, logistics, and attention. Their numbers and available tools may change, so their application must be recalculated.

Recruitment, sacred throughput, paths, Pretenders, blessings, spells, items, summons, sites, siege bodies, national mechanics, and AI priorities may all differ. An unmodded expansion party, research queue, thug kit, or counter is evidence for a method, not a ready-made combined-mod plan.

The strategic rule

> Mod compatibility is part of force estimation. If load order changes an object that a plan depends on, the plan is a different plan even when its name remains the same.

Combined strategy test

Every nation package will later require four snapshots:

1. unmodded;
2. DE only;
3. Divinitus only where applicable;
4. DE then Divinitus.

Diff the roster, Pretenders, paths, blessings, spells, items, sites, summons, and strategic special abilities. Then repeat expansion, research, battle, raid, and throne tests.

Part XVII: Controlled Strategy Tests

Test record format

Every controlled test should record:

- game version;
- exact map and settings;
- nation and age;
- Pretender design;
- active mods, hashes, and load order;
- turn;
- province and terrain;
- units, commanders, items, gems, orders, and scripts;
- expected result;
- actual messages and replays;
- repetition count;
- conclusion and confidence.

Strategy tests differ from formula tests because the objective is often robustness. Record distributions and failure types rather than only the best result.

S1: Expansion reliability

Run the intended opening to turn 12 on at least ten starts.

Record:

- provinces and forts;
- treasury and income;
- army survivors;
- commander and mage production;
- PD spending;
- target types;
- defeats and causes;
- ability to fight a first war.

Compare median and worst credible outcomes, not only maximum provinces.

S2: Expansion matchup matrix

Create representative independent provinces for:

- militia and ordinary infantry;
- archers;
- barbarians and high-damage infantry;
- light and heavy cavalry;
- tribes;
- giants or elephants;
- undead;
- Amazons and mage-supported defenders;
- Throne defenders.

Test party size, formation, script, bless, attrition, and retreat.

S3: Map movement boundaries

Test armies at exact Map Move limits across:

- every surface terrain;
- snow;
- roads;
- friendly and enemy presence;
- survival abilities;
- rivers and mountain passes;
- caves;
- flying;
- mixed armies.

Record when the arrow remains but movement fails.

S4: Hostile swaps and interception

On several terrains and army-size ratios, order hostile armies to swap provinces.

Record:

- battle province;
- whether they miss;
- sequential-battle order;
- retreat results;
- effect of stealth and allied forces.

Run direct one-step swaps separately from multi-province movement. For the direct set, preserve army chassis values and compare miss rate and battle location with the published 0-349 and open-ended chassis-die hypothesis.

S5: Patrol detection

At controlled Stealth and Patrol strengths, repeat detection trials with:

- zero and high unrest;
- PD below and above 15;
- commanders and ordinary units;
- flying, Mindless, and Undisciplined patrollers;
- stealth troops with ordinary and +50 or greater stealth.

Compare observed rates with the official opposed open-ended rolls.

The main 6.36 table is already closed by direct enumeration. This suite now checks exceptional contributors, displayed rounding, invisible units, global bonuses, and any difference between the manual's halving rule and community descriptions of Undisciplined patrol strength.

S6: Raid and pillage

Verify:

- the Map Move 20 requirement;
- Pillager commander legality;
- which units contribute;
- half-strength contribution;
- sequence after battle;
- population, unrest, supplies, gold, and food;
- one-month supply duration;
- interaction with forts and retreat.

Add boundary cases around the historical `floor((Strength + Combat Speed + 10 x Fear) / 2)` unit-strength hypothesis, the proposed flyer substitution, population-to-strength failure boundary, and enemy-fort failure. Record raw outcomes rather than accepting the old downstream gold and casualty formulas.

S7: Intelligence channels

For the same province, compare:

- neighbour report;

- scout;
- priest;
- spy;
- dominion;
- scrying;
- ownership.

Record every displayed field, error range, glamour detection, and update timing.

S8: Siege arithmetic

Test Strength values around square and rounding boundaries with:

- flying;
- Mindless;
- Animal;
- Undisciplined;
- combinations;
- siege and castle-defence bonuses;
- intrinsic fort guards.

Verify reduction, repair, qualitative messages, and the effect of non-siege orders.

S9: Relief and storm order

Create a cracked fort with:

- outside relief;
- Break Siege;
- magic-phase reinforcements;
- a scheduled storm;
- multiple allied attackers;
- commander deaths before the gate.

Record battle sequence, scripts, gem consumption, participant squads, and retreat.

S10: Fort starvation

Record supplies and disease risk for at least ten siege turns with:

- ordinary living units;
- survival abilities;
- supply items and spells;
- commanders and mounts;
- large and small forts.

Verify the printed declining supply sequence and two-turn disease condition.

S11: Assassination and bodyguards

Repeat assassination against:

- zero to five bodyguards;
- different Bodyguard and Patience values;

- mounted targets;
- fort interior and exterior;
- besieged forts;
- special-access assassins;
- multiple decoy commanders.

Record target distribution, bodyguard presence, surprise context, mount survival, and retreat.

S12: Formal NAP edge cases

Under binding and nonbinding settings, test:

- direct movement attack;
- magic-phase attack;
- remote damage;
- assassination and seduction;
- stealth positioning;
- accidental bumps;
- independent recapture;
- harmful globals;
- throne-rush response.

Distinguish engine blocking, warnings, legal execution, and social doctrine.

Repeat the matrix with diplomacy binding, nonbinding through `--weakdiplo`, and absent through `--nodiplo`. Preserve the exact version and separate engine legality from any social rule used by the game.

S13: Throne claim timing

Treat the established claim-loss matrix as a regression target and test claims by:

- Pretender;
- Disciple;
- H3;
- H2 boosted or transformed by relevant effects;
- besieged owner;
- besieger;
- claimant arriving by ordinary and magic movement;
- simultaneous capture and claim attempts.

Record hosting messages, claimant survival, full or partial ownership, fort state, AP immediately before victory, and dominion spread. A current test should reproduce claimant death, unfortified conquest, siege without storming, and successful storming separately. Exact simultaneous winning-AP ties remain an unresolved adjacent branch.

S14: One-turn throne operation

Build a T+0 to T+3 scenario with:

- one-turn wall crack;
- relief;
- remotes;
- assassins;

- claimant movement;
- counterattack on an owned Throne.

Repeat with different event and movement branches to validate the operational timeline.

S15: Cataclysm

In 6.36, record:

- first Cataclysm turn;
- horror target selection;
- fort interaction;
- throne destruction;
- required AP after each destruction;
- final result when all Thrones disappear;
- effect of current countermeasures.

This test resolves the manual/community wording conflict.

S16: AI difficulty economy

Use identical nations and provinces at each difficulty.

Measure:

- gold;
- resources;
- recruitment points;
- magic income;
- commander recruitment;
- Holy Points;
- fort timing;
- ritual, global, and Dispel behaviour.

Confirm which modifiers apply and which do not.

S17: Raider response exchange

For each standard thug or stealth package:

1. price the raider in gold, gems, and mage-turns;
2. price each defender;
3. run repeated battles;
4. include capture and looting;
5. measure provinces taken before interception;
6. compare attention and map impact.

The output is a campaign exchange table, not only a duel result.

S18: Recovery scenario

Begin from a saved position after a main-army loss. Compare:

- immediate reconstruction;

- fort-based elastic defence;
- raiding counteroffence;
- emergency research pivot;
- negotiated peace.

Measure survival of capacity, territory after six turns, research, gem stock, and opponent advance.

S19: Information-deception scenario

Present opponents with:

- visible false mass;
- hidden magic movers;
- multiple target routes;
- manipulated gem loads;
- staged claimants.

Record which observations actually change rational defence. Reject deception that works only because the defender ignores available evidence.

S20: Combined-mod campaign regression

For the frozen DE + Divinitus load order, repeat:

- turn-12 expansion;
- key movement;
- first-war package;
- representative raider and counter;
- siege arithmetic;
- throne operation;
- AI practice game.

Any difference must be linked to a mod command or recorded as test-only evidence.

Part XVIII: Operational Checklists

New-game settings

- Patch and manual revision recorded.
- Map, planes, and start density understood.
- Independent strength recorded.
- Research and magic-site settings recorded.
- Throne levels, total points, required points, and Cataclysm recorded.
- Score-graph settings recorded.
- Diplomacy mode and NAP doctrine recorded.
- Story events and special rules recorded.
- Mods, hashes, and load order recorded.
- Extension, substitution, and concession rules recorded.

Turn-12 expansion audit

- Provinces, forts, and claimed routes.
- Income, treasury, upkeep, and resources.
- Surviving expansion parties.
- Capital recruitment unlocked.
- Researchers and site search.
- First fort start or reason for delay.
- Known neighbours and border settlements.
- Thrones located and inspected.
- First-war deterrence.
- Opening variance across tests.

Pre-war audit

- War aim and stopping condition.
- Legal treaty date.
- Enemy main army and reserve.
- Known research, paths, Pretender, and counters.
- Friendly package, scripts, gems, and replacements.
- Siege strength and fort sequence.
- Scout coverage and deception plan.
- Other borders and coalition reaction.
- Failure route and peace terms.
- Throne conversion.

Army departure

- Every troop has legal leadership.
- Slowest movement and survival checked.
- Rivers, passes, caves, water, and planes checked.
- Supply checked.
- Scripts and formations checked.
- Gems and slaves checked.
- Bodyguards checked.
- Spare commander and retreat route checked.
- Siege contribution checked.
- Claimant included if required.

Raider

- Target class and likely PD.
- Legal route and movement.
- Counter locations.
- Minimal equipment.
- Fatigue stability.
- Retreat or escape.
- Replacement cost.
- Captured province exploitation.
- Loot carrier.
- Recall condition.

Counter-raider

- Exact raider observed or inferred.
- Cheapest relevant counter.
- Interception destinations.
- High-value nodes covered.
- Empty provinces reclaimed cheaply.
- Gear-looting plan.
- Main army not distracted unnecessarily.
- PD raised only where it changes the matchup.

Siege attacker

- Wall strength and one-turn crack estimate.
- Repair estimate.
- Maintain Siege orders.
- Relief routes.
- Sequential battle and gem budget.
- Storm script suitable for gate and indoor context.
- Commander survival and redundancy.
- Supplies.
- Claimant and post-storm defence.

Siege defender

- Wall condition.
- Repair bodies.
- Interior supply and disease.
- Break Siege package.
- Outside relief and phase timing.
- Remote and assassination options.
- Irreplaceable cadre extraction.
- Alternate fort or Throne defence.
- Counterattack on attacker's strategic assets.

Diplomacy

- Exact parties and terms.
- Formal, social, or hybrid.
- Notice and first legal turns.
- Scout, stealth, remote, dominion, global, and access terms.
- Trade quantities and delivery.
- Victory emergency clause.
- Mistake procedure.
- Written record.

Throne watch

- Current and plausible AP for every nation.
- Controlled but unclaimed Thrones.

- Claim-capable units and movement.
- One-turn-crack forts.
- Magic-phase access.
- Existing claimed-Throne defence.
- Cataclysm threshold.
- Coalition contacts.
- Counterattack targets.

Recovery

- Surviving cadres, gems, and items.
- Enemy next destinations.
- Existential, capacity, network, economic, and disposable provinces.
- Cheap stabilisation research.
- Fort and retreat line.
- Raider counteroffence.
- Diplomatic options.
- New army package rather than blind replacement.

Final submission

- No immediate opponent victory.
- All messages read.
- All decisive replays watched.
- Treasury and queues checked.
- Research allocated.
- Forts, labs, temples, and PD intentional.
- Rituals and forging intentional.
- Gems, items, and troops transferred.
- Movement remains legal.
- Siege, patrol, sneak, defend, and claim orders correct.
- Treaty and trade obligations fulfilled.
- Turn saved and submitted.

Part XIX: Essays

Essay I: The Expansion Problem

Expansion is often measured by a turn-12 province count because the number is visible, easy to compare, and strongly connected to early income. It is useful and incomplete. The real expansion problem is to acquire enough valuable and defensible territory while preserving the capacity to survive first contact.

The opening begins before the map appears. Pretender design decides whether an awake monster supplies a second army, a bless turns sacreds into a specialist expansion force, or scales finance ordinary troops and early infrastructure. These choices do not buy abstract power. They buy particular expansion matchups at particular times. An awake monster that clears militia but dies to the first heavy cavalry province has not solved expansion; it has created a route constraint with catastrophic failure.

The first skill is classification. Independents are not a ladder from small to large. They are a collection of damage, armour, morale, missile, lance, formation, and magic problems. Heavy national infantry may walk through ordinary weapons and bleed out against barbarians. High-defence sacreds may dominate low-attack infantry and collapse when surrounded. Archers may erase unarmoured tribes but waste months against shielded heavy troops. A party becomes reliable when its player knows what it is designed to fight.

The second skill is routing. Each province changes future options. A cap-ring forest can release resources into capital recruitment. Rich farmland can finance a fort. A choke point can define a border. A route around an interior pocket can reserve easy provinces for a third party. Province value is not just the income shown this turn; it is the chain of recruitment, movement, and diplomacy that ownership makes possible.

The third skill is force sizing. Too little force creates losses whose true cost includes replacement, delayed parties, commander transport, and deterrence. Too much force concentrates strength that can conquer only one province per month. The efficient party is not the mathematical minimum that can win under average rolls. It carries enough margin to survive uncertain reports, unlucky combat, and the next target.

The fourth skill is transition. Independent expansion offers largely static opponents. Human contact introduces adaptation, deception, and simultaneous movement. A nation that continues driving small parties outward after borders are settled may present each one for defeat. A nation that combines too early may surrender unclaimed land. The transition occurs when the next neutral gain is worth less than the fort, research, reserve, or diplomatic stability it delays.

Expansion testing works because it turns these judgments into experience before the game begins. The test must include realistic PD, recruitment, site search, and infrastructure or it rewards a position that cannot exist in the real campaign. Repetition matters more than one ideal map. The goal is a procedure that produces a resilient median and an acceptable bad start.

The final measure is the first-war position. Territory is valuable when it has become income, resources, forts, mages, sites, routes, and political claims. Expansion is complete only when the nation can defend or exploit what it has taken.

Essay II: Information as a Resource

Information has no treasury icon, yet it changes the value of every other resource. Ten gems carried into the correct battle are a weapon; ten gems carried by a mage who is intercepted by the wrong counter are loot. A fort one turn from cracking is a crisis if observed and a surprise defeat if not. A Throne held by an opponent is ordinary territory until its claim changes the victory arithmetic.

Dominions distributes information unevenly. Ownership gives one view, adjacency another, scouts another, spies another, dominion another, and scrying another. Score graphs show trends without scripts or stocks. Battle replays reveal exact deployed tools but only after contact. Diplomacy supplies claims whose reliability must be judged. The strategic task is not to obtain perfect knowledge. It is to combine imperfect channels before the decision deadline.

This begins with questions. "What does the enemy have?" has no practical stopping point. "Can the border fort be cracked next turn?" directs collection toward army size, siege bodies, wall modifiers, and nearby movement. "Can the army survive Foul Vapors?" directs attention toward Nature paths, research evidence, poison resistance, and gem carriers. Intelligence has value when it changes an order.

Uncertainty must remain visible. A missing army may have withdrawn, hidden through glamour, moved through another route, or prepared a magic-phase attack. A research spike may indicate a new threshold, an event, or simply accumulated infrastructure. Experts are not those who always guess correctly. They assign confidence, retain alternative explanations, and choose orders that remain tolerable under several branches.

Denial is the other half. Patrolling out scouts reduces enemy coverage. Concealing item transfers delays counter construction. Holding a magic mover on a central lab creates several possible targets. Hiding everything also sacrifices deterrence: an enemy cannot fear a capability it does not believe exists. Selective revelation can preserve a border while the decisive package stays concealed.

Deception is useful only when it changes rational allocation. A false army near an irrelevant province is theatre. A displayed force near one Throne while a stealth and magic-movement package can reach another may force the defender to split. The false story must fit observed paths, movement, and incentives. Good opponents do not need certainty to respond; they need a threat whose expected cost is high enough.

Information also imposes attention costs. A hundred unlabelled scouts and reports can make a position harder to understand rather than easier. Networks need roles: border screen, operational depth, strategic nodes, and rear warning. Reports need dates. Old observations must be marked stale. The player must know which provinces going dark matter.

The final advantage is learning speed. Each battle answers questions about scripts, gem use, target selection, and counters. A player who reviews those answers converts losses into future efficiency. A player who watches only whether the green bar won receives almost no information from the same event.

Information is not omniscience. It is the reduction of expensive surprise.

Essay III: Raiding and Counter-Raiding

Raiding is often described as taking low-defence provinces with small forces. Its deeper purpose is to create an unfavourable allocation problem. A raider costs less than the force that must remain available to stop it, threatens more provinces than the defender can cover, and moves while the main army creates a separate emergency.

The provincial income is only the simplest return. A raider can cut a reinforcement route, stop a lab from pooling gems, interrupt recruitment, isolate a fort, remove a temple, expose retreat into hostile land, or force a combat mage away from the field army. These gains are positional and temporal. A poor province can be the most valuable raid if it breaks a corridor on the decisive turn.

Raider design begins with a target class. A small troop squad may defeat token PD. A light thug may defeat stronger PD and ordinary local recruits. A heavy thug may punish troop-only responses. A stealth army may bypass the line. A teleporter may strike a lab before normal movement. Each class has a ceiling. Calling every geared commander a thug hides the question that matters: what can it beat at its price?

Minimalism creates the favourable exchange. A protection item that changes the PD matchup can be efficient. A fifth defensive item that does not change the likely counter turns the unit into loot. Equipment keeps its value only while the carrier survives; when captured, the swing includes the attacker's loss and the defender's gain. Expected target value, escape probability, and available counters should set the item budget.

Counter-raiding fails when the defender treats every lost province as equally urgent. Chasing a fast raider with the main army abandons the decisive front. Raising heavy PD everywhere can cost more than the raids. Sending an expensive mage after incomplete information can donate another asset.

A layered defence is cheaper. Scouts predict routes. PD tripwires defeat the smallest attacks and reveal larger ones. Forts preserve recruitment. Local commanders retake empty land. Mobile specialists cover labs, Thrones, and junctions. Magic-phase counters threaten raiders that ordinary armies cannot catch. The strategic reserve does not chase; it occupies a node from which several valuable provinces are protected.

The defender should also attack the raid's support. A stealth force may need a commander route, a laboratory for magic escape, or a predictable safe province. A thug may depend on one irreplaceable item factory. A remote attacker may expose a high-path caster and gem stock. Counter-raiding becomes counteroffence when it removes the infrastructure that makes repeated raids possible.

Raiding succeeds when it is connected to the campaign. Provinces taken at random are noise. Provinces taken while a fort is being cracked can prevent relief. A raider that forces the only counter-mage away may let the main army win. A raid that captures a Throne can change the victory threshold without destroying an army.

The mature contest is not province against province. It is response cost against threat cost, repeated until one side can no longer cover the map.

Essay IV: Siege as a Strategic Clock

A fort does not make a province invulnerable. It buys time, preserves an interior, and changes the sequence required to convert field victory into ownership. That sequence is the siege clock.

The attacker first has to reach the province and defeat whatever remains outside. Wall reduction then compares Strength-squared contribution against repair. Only armies maintaining the siege contribute. Once walls reach zero, the attacker must issue a storm order and win the gate battle. Relief can occur first. The same mages may fight several times, spend gems, lose commanders, and enter the storm with a script designed for a different battlefield.

Each turn of delay creates room to act. The defender can finish research, move relief, cast remotes, recruit elsewhere, negotiate assistance, or counterattack another Throne. The attacker pays upkeep, supply, attention, and exposure. A fort's value is not only its wall number. It is also the number of hostile deadlines that pass while the walls remain.

Siege strength converts troop composition into tempo. High-Strength and flying units can reduce enormous walls quickly. Mindless, Animal, and Undisciplined penalties can make a visually vast army unexpectedly slow. An army optimised only for field battle may spend months outside a cheap fort. A smaller army with specialised siege bodies may convert victories before the political situation changes.

The defender also converts bodies into time. Cheap units can repair. Intrinsic guards strengthen the storm. Mages inside remain able to research or prepare while the fort holds, but declining supplies create an attrition clock in the opposite direction. A capital packed with irreplaceable living mages cannot wait indefinitely if starvation and disease begin.

Relief creates the siege's most dangerous turn. If the defender breaks the besieger outside, the storm is cancelled. If relief fails, it may still consume attack gems and kill siege commanders before the gate. The attacker must decide whether one script can survive several combats and whether gem loads cover the full chain. The defender must decide whether the relief force is buying victory, delay, or merely a cheap gem burn.

Throne forts expose the clock's endgame importance. A one-turn crack can reduce coalition reaction to a single cycle. A force that requires two turns may allow every surviving nation to move, forge, assassinate, and attack the rusher's existing points. Wall strength is then not local defence; it is world reaction time.

Siege strategy should be planned backwards from the storm and forward from the relief. How many turns can the larger game afford? Which assets are trapped? What counterstroke becomes possible during delay? A fort has fulfilled its role when the time it creates is converted, even if the walls eventually fall.

Essay V: Timing Attacks and Power Spikes

Power is relative and temporary. A nation may have a stronger endgame and still die before reaching it. Another may dominate the first year with an awake expander and lose once opponents acquire armour-negating magic. Strategy identifies the interval when a package produces more usable force than rivals can answer and converts that interval before it closes.

A power spike can come from awakening, research, recruitment scale, a forged booster, a summon, a global, a treaty expiry, or an opponent's losses. The visible event is rarely sufficient by itself. Completing a battlefield enchantment does nothing if troops have not assembled, gems remain in the capital, and mages need three turns to walk to the front.

Preparation must begin before research completes. Recruit the line that the spell will protect. Forge the boosters that create legal casters. Place scouts on the target. Begin the NAP countdown. Move siege bodies and claimants. Accumulate enough gems for the operation and the response. The spike begins when the whole package can act, not when one school reaches a number.

Relative timing also includes counters. A mass protection spell may dominate mundane armies for several turns and become ordinary once armour-piercing evocations or battlefield control appear. A sacred rush may exploit neighbours who spent design points on scales and imprisonment, then face awake gods and deeper research later. The attack's deadline is the earliest likely answer, not the player's preferred calendar.

Good timing attacks produce a conversion that persists after the window. They take forts, destroy irreplaceable cadres, seize Thrones, or force treaties. Merely winning peripheral battles allows the defender to survive until the counter arrives. The objective should be the asset whose loss prevents recovery.

There is also a defensive spike. A nation under attack may be two turns from a cheap resistance spell, a communion threshold, or an awakened Pretender. Elastic defence can surrender land to preserve those turns. The invader's strongest play is often to force the decisive battle before the threshold; the defender's strongest is to make every route consume time.

Not every spike should be used for war. Visible capacity can deter and create favourable treaties. A global or research lead can improve economy more safely than conquest. The comparison is between what the window can gain through attack and what it can compound through peace.

The essential habit is to date power. "This army is strong" is not a plan. "This package can crack the border fort on turn 25, before the likely counter on turn 28, and hold the captured lab" is strategic reasoning.

Essay VI: The Diplomacy of Threat

Diplomacy in Dominions is not separate from military power. It determines how much power must be held idle, where armies can move, which gems become accessible through trade, and how quickly a leader faces a coalition. The central diplomatic object is the credible threat.

A threat has capacity, communication, and an off-ramp. Capacity means the stated consequence can actually occur. Communication means the target understands the condition and deadline. The off-ramp gives the target a cheaper action than defiance. Without capacity, the threat is noise. Without clarity, it produces fear without control. Without an achievable exit, it becomes war.

NAPs formalise some of this uncertainty. Dominions 6 can mechanically enforce them, but engine enforcement cannot answer every social question. Remotes, stealth staging, dominion pressure, harmful globals, third-party access, and victory emergencies create conduct that may be legal in code and unacceptable under a group's expectations. Clear doctrine prevents disagreement from becoming the most destructive event in a months-long game.

Treaties purchase time. That time should have a named use: research, a war on another front, fort construction, recovery, or a throne operation. A NAP with no purpose can allow a stronger neighbour to compound more efficiently than the beneficiary. Long commitments also reduce the table's ability to respond to victory. Their duration must be compared with plausible throne windows.

Reputation is stored diplomatic capacity. A player known to deliver trades and follow written countdowns can create agreements with fewer guarantees. A player known for exploiting ambiguity forces neighbours to hold armies and refuse valuable exchanges. Betrayal may occasionally be strategically decisive, but its full price includes future games and coalition response, not only the current province.

Leaders face a different problem. Strength attracts balancing. Oppressive globals, rapid eliminations, hidden throne progress, or permanent treaty blocs can make every other nation safer by cooperating. A leader should convert strength quickly enough that the coalition cannot form, or behave in ways that keep rivals divided without making promises that destroy credibility.

Weaker nations possess leverage because their collapse redistributes territory, Thrones, and fronts. They can offer information, gems, access, or coordinated resistance. They can also choose which rival benefits from conquest. This is not unlimited power, but it means diplomacy does not end when the army graph falls.

The diplomacy of threat is ultimately the management of expected futures. Every treaty, warning, trade, and coalition message changes what other players believe will happen if they choose one branch. The most efficient military victory is the one a credible threat secures without spending the army.

Essay VII: Recovery and Elastic Defence

Defeat creates a dangerous illusion of total collapse. The missing army is immediately visible; surviving research, forts, gems, diplomatic value, and enemy exposure are less vivid. Recovery begins by measuring what remains.

The first objective is capacity. Territory can be retaken if forts still recruit the mages that define the nation. Troops can be rebuilt if command survives. Gems can become a new counter if laboratories remain. A panicked counterattack that loses the surviving cadre turns a reversible battle loss into structural defeat.

Elastic defence uses space to buy the time needed for a different exchange. Poor provinces are allowed to fall. PD reveals movement. Forts interrupt advance. Scouts identify whether the attacker concentrates or disperses. Raiders enter the rear. A research pivot matures behind the line. The defender chooses a shorter perimeter while the attacker acquires a longer supply and reinforcement problem.

This approach works because field victory creates commitments. The attacker must siege or bypass forts, protect captured labs, cover retreats, and decide how much force to leave behind. If it concentrates, raiders can recover provinces. If it disperses, a surviving reserve can defeat pieces. If it storms repeatedly, gems and commanders are exposed. The defender's purpose is to make every further gain cost more time than the attacker budgeted.

Recovery also changes diplomacy. Neighbours may fear the attacker more after a major victory. Exact reports of the winning army, its spent gems, and revealed scripts are valuable coalition information. A weakened nation can offer access or intelligence that a bystander could not obtain alone. The diplomatic position may improve while the military graph worsens.

The counterstroke should target dependency rather than colour. Destroy the army's lab, cut its retreat, assassinate the leader carrying most troops, relieve the key mage fort, or take a Throne elsewhere. Retaking every low-value province can wait. The goal is to remove the opponent's initiative.

Some positions cannot recover. The same discipline still matters. A final defence can delay a throne leader, transfer useful information under the rules, or create time for a substitute. Silent staling damages the competitive structure and removes strategic choices from everyone.

Elastic defence is not an excuse for indecision. It is a controlled exchange of land for the one resource a defeated nation most needs: a future turn in which the answer exists.

Essay VIII: The Throne Race

Thrones transform Dominions from a war of unlimited conquest into a contest of conversion. A nation does not need to defeat every army or own most provinces. It needs to own and claim the configured number of Ascension Points at the relevant hosting step.

This makes arithmetic a strategic skill. Current claimed points are only the visible baseline. Controlled but unclaimed Thrones, H3 movement, one-turn-crack forts, magic-phase reach, and Cataclysm can change the threshold within several turns. A nation that appears three points short may already control a three-point Throne. A nation at the threshold can be stopped by unclaiming one existing point before the new claim resolves.

Throne defence differs from ordinary border defence. A Throne province has discontinuous value because losing the wrong one can end the game. Its fort walls measure coalition reaction time. A one-turn crack may leave only one cycle for remote attacks, relief, claimant assassination, or a counterattack on another Throne.

The attacker must prepare for more than the storm. Bystanders who ignored a conventional war may unite when victory becomes visible. Magic-phase probes can consume gems before the relief and gate battle. Assassins can remove the claimant or commanders whose squads are needed to storm. Existing Thrones become counterattack targets. The winning operation needs redundancy, secrecy, siege, combat, claimant access, and defence at once.

The defender should resist local fixation. Saving the targeted Throne may be impossible. Cracking one of the attacker's owned Throne forts can change the arithmetic faster. Killing the claimant can buy a turn. Cutting a route can strand H3 access after the army wins. Coalition members should assign tasks by reach rather than all sending armies toward the same province too late.

Diplomacy changes near victory. Many communities treat an imminent throne win as superseding ordinary NAP expectations; formal binding systems may still constrain actions unless a victory clause was agreed. Games should resolve this before play, because a rule intended to create peace can otherwise make a legal response impossible.

Cataclysm adds a moving target. As Thrones disappear, required points decline and surviving points gain value. A long plan can become irrelevant between order and resolution. Endgame arithmetic must be recalculated every turn.

The throne race rewards preparation disguised as ordinary strength. The best rush becomes obvious only when the response window is already closing.

Essay IX: Why the AI Behaves as It Does

The Dominions AI plays the same fundamental economy, recruitment, movement, battle, magic, and victory systems, but it does not possess human political reasoning. It receives programmed priorities, complete province-ownership knowledge, and difficulty bonuses rather than intuition or social memory.

This distinction explains both pressure and predictability. At high difficulty, large bonuses to gold, resources, recruitment points, and magic income can create armies and magical output that a human position could not match from the same land. The AI can build forts, recruit national troops, cast high-level rituals and globals, and Dispel. It is not passive. Its threat comes from production and broad action.

What it lacks is the full human model of intention. A human may conceal a research spike, accept a poor local exchange to win a Throne elsewhere, or maintain a treaty because reputation across future games matters. Human coalitions can distribute tasks and share exact enemy scripts. The AI's decisions are bounded by the behaviours its evaluation can express.

Patch corrections matter. An old report that the AI repeatedly attempts rituals without a lab or assigns non-priests to preach no longer describes current 6.36 behaviour where those errors have been corrected. AI strategy must be evaluated by version rather than inherited folklore.

Difficulty also changes what a practice game teaches. Impossible pressure trains emergency defence and efficient battle magic, but its economic ratios are not a fair benchmark for human expansion. Normal difficulty better exposes whether the player's first fort, recruitment, and research produce a sound state. Both have value when their purpose is explicit.

Players can defeat predictable behaviour through loops that teach little. Better practice keeps scouts, legal Throne arithmetic, layered defence, gem budgets, and realistic no-reload consequences. The aim is to rehearse a full national campaign, not only discover one weakness in target selection.

The AI is best understood as an active strategic environment with asymmetric advantages and bounded judgment. It is capable enough to punish weak fundamentals and broad enough to expose players to many spells and rosters. It is not a substitute for the social, deceptive, and adaptive layer of multiplayer.

Sources and Open Questions

Principal sources

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Community doctrine and test references

- Naaira's Expansion Guide, used for the repeat-to-turn-12 expansion-testing method.
- Cybertron2's Guide to Expansion, Part 1, used for current Dominions 6 expansion-role and mage-support discussion.
- Cybertron2's Guide to Expansion, Part 3, used for frontage and expansion analysis.
- Building Thugs and Supercombatants, used for contemporary role, efficiency, defensive-layer, and counter-thug doctrine.
- NAPS: a rundown and two formal doctrines, used to document community ambiguity and explicit treaty conventions.
- Siege, used for community-documented messages and operational edge cases that remain assigned to tests.
- Owl's Mini-Guide to Throne Rushes, used for the T+0 to T+3 operational model and coalition-response doctrine.
- Dominions 6 Thrones, used as a current community object reference and to identify Cataclysm and identity questions requiring current-game verification.

Community sources supply doctrine, hypotheses, and test candidates. They do not override the current manual or official update notes. Where a community page is inherited from Dominions 5, only system-level reasoning consistent with Dominions 6 is retained, and exact claims remain marked for reproduction.

Open questions

Current-game tests or resolved data are still needed for:

- exact movement-interception probability and battle location in hostile swaps;
- full rounding and combination rules for movement and siege modifiers;
- current patrol-detection distributions under every unit modifier;
- all Raid and pillage output functions;
- exact bodyguard, Patience, surprise, and mounted-assassination distributions;
- every binding-NAP edge case under all diplomacy settings;
- complete current Throne identity and object-effect data;
- final Cataclysm outcome wording and current horror interaction;
- AI decision weights, target priorities, and diplomacy evaluation;
- current effective strategy objects under the DE 2.16 then Divinitus 1.15.3 DE layer;
- nation-specific expansion, research, war, raid, and throne packages.

These remain explicit research tasks. Nation dossiers can still use the campaign method as long as their local assumptions are stated.